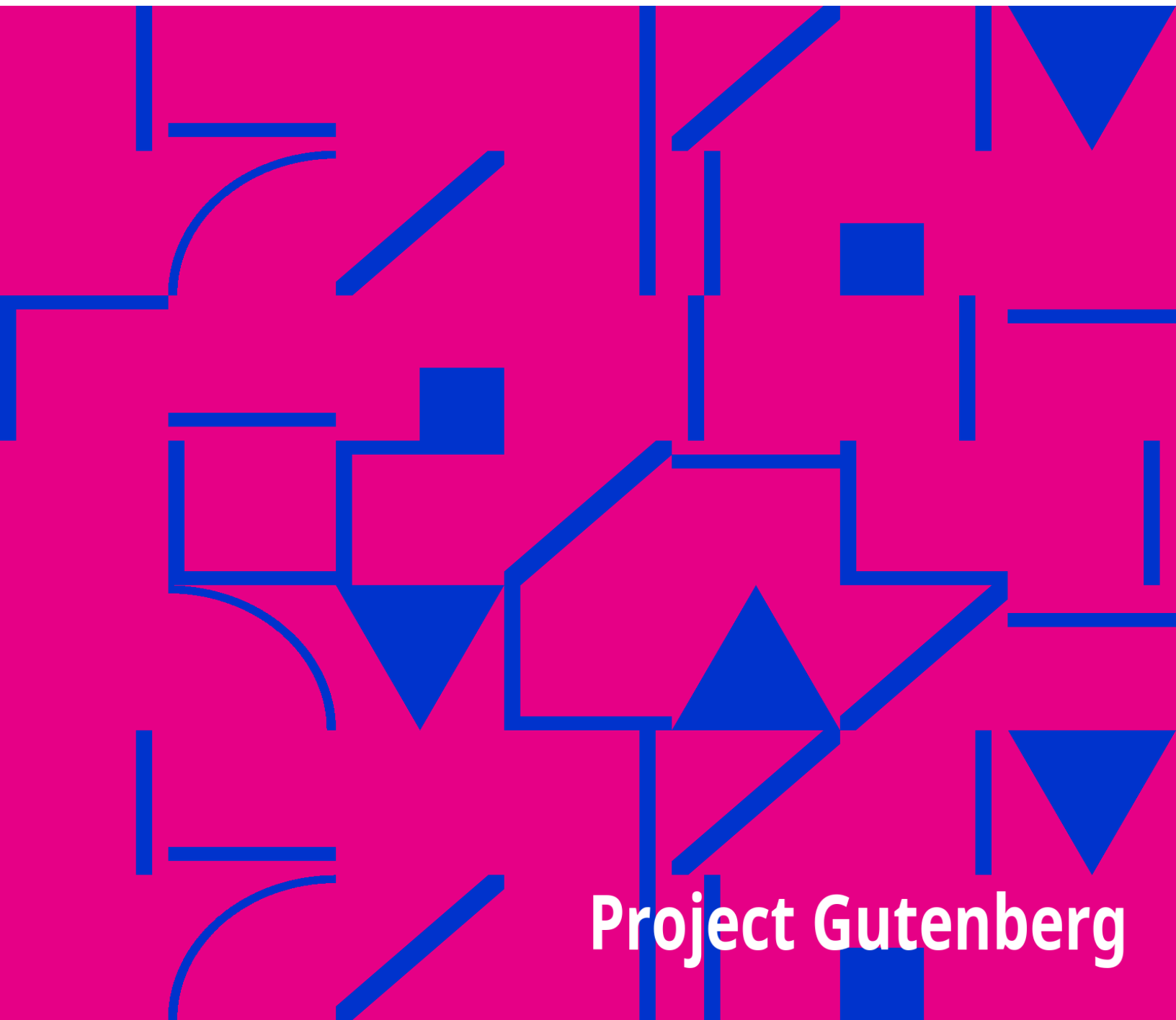


Yr Ynys Unyg; or, The lonely island

a narrative for young people

Julia de Winton

The background of the lower half of the cover is a vibrant pink. It is decorated with a complex, abstract pattern of blue geometric shapes and lines. These include straight lines of various lengths and orientations, right-angled turns, squares, triangles, and curved segments. The pattern is dense and non-repeating, creating a modern, architectural feel.

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK YR YNYS
UNYG; OR, THE LONELY ISLAND ***



YR YNYS UNYG;

OR,

THE LONELY ISLAND:

A NARRATIVE

FOR

YOUNG PEOPLE.

"Beseech you, be merry: we have cause
Of joy: for our escape
Is much beyond our loss: our hint of woe
Is common: every day, some sailor's wife,
The masters of some merchant, and the merchant
Have just our theme of woe: but for the miracle,
I mean our preservation, few in millions
Can speak like us: then wisely, good sir, weigh
Our sorrow with our comfort."—*Tempest*.

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1852.

Transcriber's Note

Archaic and dialect spellings remain as printed.
Punctuation has been normalised. Significant
errors have been noted at the end of the text. A
table of contents has been provided below:

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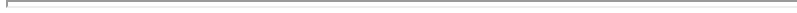
INTRODUCTION.

DEAR FRIEND,

I enclose you the manuscript of which you have so long desired possession. You have permission to do what you like with it, on one condition, which is, that you alter all the names, and expunge anything like personality therein; for, as you are aware (with two exceptions) each character mentioned in the story is now alive, and so few years have elapsed since the events recorded took place that it would not be at all difficult for a stranger to recognize the heroes and heroines therein mentioned. Having settled that business, I now proceed to say, that as the narrative begins very abruptly, you will find it necessary to have some little personal account of the parties concerned, which I will lose no time in giving you. The mother of the party you know so well I need say nothing further of her than that she was about 27 when these events occurred; what her age is now, I must be excused telling, inasmuch as it has nothing to do with the story, and it is her own concern, and it will too certainly expose the time of the narrative and other things she wished left in obscurity. Mrs. E., the little mother, as she is called by every one, was the second in command. A greater contrast to her cousin could not exist. Short, and rather stout, she trotted by the side of her companion, as the little hippopotamus by the side of the giraffe. Both their eyes were dark, but the mother's were soft, and the little mother's so brilliant when she fixed her eyes on you, you must tell what you thought, as they penetrated into the heart. Her broad forehead showed the prevalence of the intellectual powers, and the reliance on her own sense and judgment. To be sure some people called her very masculine, and it is true that, when equipped in her riding gear, and ready to get into her second home (the saddle), she certainly slaps her tiny boots with her whip, walks round her horse, examines his legs, and questions her groom as to the throwing out of curbs, and other mysteries, known as stable lore. The horse has his nose twitched that she may get into the saddle before the usual kicking scene commences; once there, he may do what he likes, she is part of her horse, and enjoys his gambols as much

as himself. When in female garments, though somewhat brusque in manners and blunt in speech, she is a true woman, and as feminine in heart as the fairest and most delicate among the sex. Madame, the governess, must occupy our attention the next. She was the kindest, best, most loving guardian over her flock, and seemed to have but one unhappiness in the world, and that was her utter inability to keep in order and understand one rebellious pupil among them. But I will not tell tales out of school. Sybil and Serena were the mother's young sisters, 13 and 14 years of age, innocent, gay, and happy creatures, blessed with beauty and sense above the common lot. Gertrude, or Gatty, was the child of an old and valued friend. She was about 12, with the wit, the quickness, the sense of 20, and I had almost said the size, for so large a proportion of flesh, blood, and bones rarely fall to the lot of male or female at that age. She was alternately the soul of fun and merriment or the plague and torment of every one about her. She had the judgment of mature age and the nonsense of the greatest baby in her. The mother alone obtained unlimited obedience from her. I am afraid I have discovered the "unruly one," but all the characters shall speak for themselves. The mother's own children were three in number. Oscar, a fine tall active boy, with a grave quick demeanour, but the open brow and frank sweet smile won him the love of every one. Lilly, the little girl, was about 6, a little, loving, winning thing, with eyes like violets, and long dark rich curls floating all round her, from the middle of which was uplifted a little rosy face, almost perfect in its childish beauty. Felix, the youngest boy and child, was a little, delicate, spoilt fellow, whose face seemed made up of naught but eyes and eyelashes. They were all three quick and clever children; and it was partly for the improvement of the little boy's health the voyage took place, the incidents of which are mentioned in this book. Zoë and Winifred were two little nieces. The former a grave, little, quiet picture of a sweet Madonna, and the latter a little, sparkling, merry pet, with the quick action and grace of a fairy. Madame does not know it, or think we guess it, but Winny is certainly her pet. Mrs. Hargrave, the lady's maid, and Jenny, the little pet nurse, concluded the females; while a fine, tall, handsome, athletic gamekeeper formed their only male attendant. Now, having said my say, I leave you; but you must be answerable for the faults of this journal if you will publish it; nothing could be more irregular and hasty than its compilation. With this burden on your shoulders, dear friend, believe me, thine in all pity and affection,

A FRIEND.



CHAPTER I.

On the 3rd of May, 183—, we embarked on board our pretty yacht, "La Luna," the crew of which included all the party mentioned in the preceding pages, besides those necessary to work her. These consisted of a captain, two mates, a boatswain, fourteen seamen, a cook, a steward, and my son's gamekeeper. Captain MacNab was a remarkably nice, active, bluff, plain-spoken man. It was easy to be seen that he was not too much pleased at commanding a company composed so entirely of women and children; neither do I think he would have undertaken the charge had we not expected Sir Walter Mayton, my children's guardian, and Mr. B., their tutor, to make part of the live stock. The former was prevented accompanying us by domestic matters; the latter from his father's death. But we made arrangements for both to join us at Madeira, for it was not deemed advisable to wait the month it would take Mr. B. to settle his father's affairs and provide a home for his sisters. The weather was so beautiful it was thought we could easily spend a month in the Mediterranean, previously to extending our voyage across the Atlantic; besides I was anxious to see the promised roses restored to my little son's face, and, without being foolhardy or presumptuous, I could not entertain the least idea of danger. Our first mate, Mr. Skead, was not only extremely skilful, but the nicest merriest person on board, being quite as ready to be the boys' play-fellow as they could be to have him. Mr. Austin was the second mate, a grave religious person, who kindly acted chaplain for us. Of the seamen I need say nothing, but that they were all picked men. Alas, when I recall that day, and see so vividly before me all their rough but honest manly faces, and remember the close intimacy that, being sharers in one common home, participators in all things alike, engendered, I cannot but mourn over each face as I recall it to memory. In the few months we were together each seemed a part of the family, and in the sudden severing of our lives and fates mournful thoughts will arise as to what can have been the fate of those in whom we were so interested. But I must not anticipate, and, moreover, my task is a long one,

and I have no time to spare lingering over the past. Our cook was a black man, called Benjie, which rather disturbed the peace of the little girls. They could not think the white rolls were really made by his black hands, and only his extreme good nature and willing activity caused them to be in any degree reconciled to having a black man for a cook. He was a very good one however, and willingly would we, many years after, have hailed his black face and white teeth with the joy of a dear friend. Smart, the gamekeeper, was a fine, tall, handsome man, of Gloucester make and tongue; he was quite a character in his way, and the contrast between his fear of the sea, his illness at the least gale, his utter ignorance of anything nautical was very great, when we thought of his courage, strength, and skill on shore, in his own vocation. Under his care he had two large dogs, half blood hounds half St. Bernard, their names were Bernard and Cwmro. But I must describe our vessel:—La Luna had been built expressly for her present purpose, in the river Clyde; she was of nearly 200 tons burden, three-masted, beautiful and elegant in her appearance, and nothing could exceed the convenience and comfort, combined with strength, with which she was fitted up; we had a deck house, surrounded with windows, so that we were shaded from sun and sheltered from breeze, and could see in every direction each pursuing his or her favourite occupation, and yet losing none of the beauties and wonders of the ocean; near the deck house were two berths, one for Captain MacNab, the other for Mr. Austin; down stairs we had a saloon, the length of which was the width of the vessel, and about twelve feet across; on the upper end a smaller saloon, or drawing room, the sofas of which made up four berths; the three girls used this room, and it opened into the stern cabin, where Jenny and the three younger girls slept, and through which the rudder came; at the other end was a double cabin, which served for my cousin and me, opening into the bath room, beyond that was the boys' cabin, and on the left hand side of the stern cabin was Mrs. Tollair's cabin; in the other part of the vessel were four other cabins, a steward's or servant's room, besides the seamen's berths, here also were two very excellent deck cabins for our two gentlemen whenever they joined us. We had fitted up the whole of the saloon with bookcases, of which one was devoted to the children's school books, drawing materials, and everything of that sort they might require. Our travels were at present not only indefinite as to time, but equally so as to place. We had a piano and a small hand organ, which could be carried on deck.

It would be impossible to convey any idea of the bustle, the noise, the confusion, the pleasure, the novelty that possessed everybody and everything the few days before we sailed. The leave-takings were the most painful, for having the care of so many who left the nearest and dearest ties behind them, on a voyage, the singularity of which invested it with a certain degree of mysterious danger, the nature of which no one could define, and which I now for the first time felt. All this gave a degree of sadness to the feelings of the whole party as we watched the English coast fading from our sight. I sat on the deck until a late hour recalling the happy and cheerful "God speed you" that my mother gave us, the more grave and solemn farewell of my father, whose foreboding mind looked farther than ours did. And then I recalled the parents of those with me; the hearty and oft-expressed wish of Gatty's father, high in honours and public esteem, to accompany us, the tearful farewell of her mother, dear Winny's merry and light-hearted mother, while her father bid her remember, during her long absence, the lessons of goodness and high principle he was always so anxious to inculcate in her. My brother and sister-in-law had been prevented coming to wish Zoë farewell, on account of the illness of one of her brothers. I could not but think this as well, for her mother's delicate nerves could never have borne the parting from a child so beloved, and Zoë's leave to come would have been rescinded at the last moment. Poor child! I know not whether to wish it better to have been so or not. Dear uncle P. came to wish his daughter, my cousin, good bye, and to promise once more a father's and mother's care over her two little children during her absence. I could not help being amused at his sometimes expressing a wish to go with us, and the next minute scolding us for doing anything so mad. Well, we were off! the last adieus were said, the last looks given, the last words spoken. We were off! The die is cast, and it seemed strange to me that now and only now did fearful doubts, and vain regrets, and sad forebodings oppress my heart, and take possession of my mind. With striking vividness I recalled how, mainly to please myself and amuse my mind, I had projected and finally carried out this expedition; how I had covered my own private wishes and thoughts under the plea of the good it would do my little boy, the benefit it was to all young people to enlarge their minds by travelling and experience, the novelty of the adventure, and the sort of certain uncertainty which was to attend our steps and ways during the next eight months, thus giving the charm of novelty and singularity to the whole

scheme. I know not how long I should have dwelt on these circumstances, had not the children come to wish me their wonted good night. Schillie declared I had moped enough, the girls were eager that together we should take our last view of England, for the breeze that carried us now so fast through the water bid fair to take us soon out of sight of land. The young soon lose the painful feelings of parting; besides, they were so delighted at being really off, they had been so fearful lest anything should occur to prevent one or all going, so as to destroy the *unity*, if I may so call it, of the party, that unmitigated pleasure alone pervaded them. This buoyancy of their feelings had as yet prevented any symptoms of illness, and I don't think there was a pale face amongst the party, save the little invalid and Smart, the gamekeeper. He sat silent and amazed between his two dogs, and, could we have analyzed his feelings, I have no doubt we should have been privy to most curious and contradictory ideas. Qualms were coming over him of various kinds, equally foreign to his nature. Probably, for the first time, he was experiencing fear and sickness at the same moment, and quite unable to understand the symptoms of either. The boys had not yet found out what made their dear Smart so dull and unlike himself, when they were so joyous and delighted. We all rose up, and went together to watch the fading land. Various exclamations proved how much our thoughts dwelt on that beloved shore, and long after my short sight had deemed it passed from view did my dear girls exclaim, "they yet saw it; there were still lights." But Captain MacNab wanted his deck to himself, so with cheerful good nights, the moon being up, we descended to take our first meal on board, and use those narrow couches at which we were so much amused, and which the children had been longing to try from the moment they came on board. Such a noisy tea never was, interrupted now and then by a lurching of the vessel, which was such a new thing to us that all started, some in fear, some in fun, and some, I must own, with other feelings not very agreeable. The oddity of having nothing steady on our swinging table, the laughing at the pale looks that flitted across the faces of others, the grave determination with which little Winny declared "that now she was really a sailor, she would only eat ship biscuit," caused intense merriment. But ere tea was over one or two of our party disappeared, and when twelve o'clock arrived Captain MacNab had La Luna all to himself and his men, for the feminine crew were deep in slumber, caused by the, to them, unusual motion of the sea, and the unwonted excitement of the day.

CHAPTER II.

May 4.—The next morning there were many defaulters, myself amongst the number. In lieu of the laughter and joy of the preceding evening, there were groans, and moans, and beseechings for tea or a drink of water. Sybil, Gatty, and Serena all rose valiantly; Gatty scornfully repudiating the possibility of being ill. But it was in vain, "the loftiest spirit was lowliest laid." The little girls rather courted the notion. Being ill in bed of course precluded the idea of lessons, with which a certain portion of every day had been threatened, and as they lay in bed thus they discoursed:—

Zoë.—"I really do not think it will be pleasant if we are to be like this all the time."

Lilly.—"Oh, Zoë, I am so snug, I have got a nice book to read, and there will be no playing on the piano to-day."

Winny.—"Oh! I am very sorry for that. If I did not feel so funny, I should like to go and play very much. But I am glad we are to have no French. Jenny says Madame is very ill indeed, and I think I heard her groan once."

Zoë.—"Groan, did you? then she must be very bad. I don't wish her to groan much, but I don't mind if she is sick always from ten until two. You know mother promised we should do no lessons after two. Here is Jenny. Why, Jenny, what is the matter with you?"

Jenny.—"Indeed, Miss, I don't know; but just as I was fastening Miss Sybil's dress, I felt so queer, and I was so ashamed, I was obliged to sit down before all the young ladies."

All the little girls at once exclaimed, "Ah, Jenny, Jenny, you know you are sea-sick." "No, indeed, young ladies," exclaimed Jenny, vehemently, "I am sure it is no such thing; but Master Felix would have some cold beef with Worcester sauce for his breakfast, and that gave me a turn, it has such a

strong smell." But ere Jenny had well got the words out of her mouth, nature asserted her rights, and after an undeniable fit, she reeled off to bed, and was a victim for three days. Hargrave, my maid, being of a stolid, determined, sort of stoical character, announced her intention of not giving way; and though a victim, or rather martyr, she never suffered a sign to appear, or neglected one thing that she was asked to do, or showed the smallest feeling on the occasion beyond a general sense of dissatisfaction at all things connected with the sea. But of all our sufferers none equalled my poor cousin. Not a word was to be got out of her, but short pithy anathemas against everybody that came near her, everybody that spoke to her, every lurch the ship made, every noise overhead; an expression of pity caused an explosion of wrath, a hope that she was better a wish that she was dead, and an offer of assistance a command to be gone out of her sight. Neither of the boys suffered in the least. And now the increased motion of the vessel, the noise overhead, and various other signs told us that the lovely smooth ocean, on whose bosom we had trusted ourselves, for some cause unknown to us was considerably disturbed, internally or externally. It was impossible for any land-lubbers to stand; it was equally impossible to eat in the form prescribed by the rules of polite society, food being snatched at a venture, and not always arriving at the mouth for which it was originally intended. One or two were pitched out of their cots, and a murmuring of fear that this should be a tempest, and that we were going to be wrecked, caused a message to be sent to Captain MacNab to know whereabouts we were, for no one liked to be first to acknowledge fear or expose our ignorance to the Captain, who had good-humouredly rallied some on what they would do and say in case of bad weather. Therefore the question of whereabouts are we seemed a very safe one, likely to obtain the real news we wanted without exposing our fears to the captain. In answer, we received a message to say we were near the Bay of Biscay and as there was a very pretty sea, we should do well to come up and look at it. "Come up and look at it?" that showed at once that no shipwreck was in contemplation. But how to get up? that was the question. The message, however, was dispatched round to the different berths, with the additional one, "that the mother was going immediately," that being my title amongst the young ones, and the little mother being the title of my cousin.

On deck we were received by the captain, who welcomed us with much pleasure, an undisguised twinkle in his eyes betraying a little inkling into the purport of our message. To our amazement, he and the sailors seemed quite at their ease, walking as steadily as if the vessel was a rock, and as immoveable as the pyramids. But what a sea! I looked up and saw high grey mountains on all sides, and ere I could decide whether they were moveable or my sight deceptive, they had disappeared, and, from a height that seemed awful, we looked down upon a troubled, rolling, restless mass of waters, each wave seeming to buffet its neighbour with an angry determination to put it down. In the midst of all this chaos, one monster wave rose superior to all the rest, and rolling forward with giant strength and resistless impetuosity, threatened instant destruction to the vessel. A cry, a terrific roll, a shudder through the vessel, and again we were in the valley of waters; and during the comparative lull the captain roared in my ear, "Is it not a pretty sea, Madam?"

We can now laugh at our fears, and the awe-struck faces we all presented, but it was many hours ere some of us recovered ourselves, and for this show of timidity Gatty scolded Sybil.

Gatty.—"How can you be such a goose, Sybil? Why, you are trembling now."

Sybil.—"No, I am only a little cold; but you know, Gatty, that was such an awful wave, if we had stretched our necks ever so high we could not see to the top."

Gatty.—"Well, and what did that matter? It was a glorious wave, a magnificent fellow, I dare say a tenth wave. If we had been walking on the sea shore we should have counted and known."

Sybil.—"But I could not tell how we were ever to get to the top. I thought we must certainly go through it, or it would go over us."

Gatty (laughing).—"Serena, do come here, Sybil is talking such splendid stuff, and, moreover, she is frightened out of her wits, and I do believe wishes herself at home."

Serena.—"Oh dear! I am so ill; going on deck has quite upset me, and I am worse than I was."

Gatty.—"Now, whatever you do, don't go and be so foolish, Serena. I shall have no pleasure at all if Sybil is frightened and you are ill. Get up, and eat a lot of roast beef with heaps of mustard and you will be quite well."

A little small voice called to Gatty, and also asked for beef and mustard. "I am sure, quite sure, Gatty," said the little speaker, Winny, "it will do me a great deal of good." "Ah," said Lilly, "I wish I was out of this place. Do, mother, ask the captain to stop and put me down somewhere." This little idea caused infinite amusement. Time, however, went on, and cured us all. We had lovely weather, and began to keep regular hours, and have allotted times of the day for different things. All attending, whatever might be our occupations, to the captain's summons; for when anything new was to be seen, any wonders of the ocean, any curious bird resting its weary wings on the only haven in sight—our little vessel, any furling of sails, or any change, so did the good-natured captain send for us, and we joyfully obeyed the summons, listening to all his wondrous tales, watching the rolling of the porpoises, and the wondrous colours of the sea. As we approached a hotter climate, everything became, in our eyes, objects of new and strange interest. In this manner we reached Gibraltar, and landed for the first time, having been thirteen days at sea.

CHAPTER III.

May 16.—GIBRALTAR.—I, for one, was very glad to land, for somehow on board ship one never seemed to be able to finish one's toilette with the degree of niceness necessary, a lurch of the ship very often caused an utter derangement, a rolling sea made it a matter of great difficulty even to wash one's face, and as for tidying the hair that had been given up, and those who did not wear caps enclosed their rough curls in nets. We therefore migrated to the principal hotel, leaving the two boys, at their own request, on board, under the care of Jenny and Smart. The three elder girls were to wait on each other, and each take a little girl in their charge, while Hargrave waited on the three elderly ladies. We were objects of great curiosity, and many people supposed our party to consist of a school. They were more surprised at hearing that La Luna belonged to the school. The visitors on board of her became innumerable, causing the good-natured captain a world of trouble. Every day he came and reported himself, as he called it, to his commanding officer, meaning myself and brought an account of the boys, or one with him; and it was most curious to see this great rough captain take each little girl up in his arms and kiss her quite gently, always expressing a hope to each that they were not getting too fond of the land, but would soon return to their ocean home, as he was quite dull without them. Whatever misgivings he might have had on starting, they had all given way to an interest and affection for us all, that made it quite a pleasure to us to communicate with him.

We took advantage of our first landing to write letters home, which, having been preserved with sorrowful care, have now become agreeable memorials of our adventures, and may be interesting, as their own letters will best explain the individual character of each of those who were now on their way towards adventures strange as unexpected. The letters of the elder portion of our party contained but a description of Gibraltar, which is well known to most people. Sybil's letter was as follows:—

"Gibraltar, May 16, 18—

"MY DEAREST MAMMA AND SISTERS,

"Here we are safe on dry land again, and who would have believed a fortnight ago that we should have been so glad to get out of our dear La Luna. But we don't make half such good sailors as we expected; and how Em would have laughed could she have seen all the queer looks and sad faces which possessed the merry party she had so lately seen. But here we are really on dry land, and at Gibraltar, at the summit of all our present hopes, and charmed enough to make us forget all the horrors of the sea, and even think we could undergo them twenty times for such a sight. We came into the harbour last night, and landed as soon as we could collect our wits, and mother collect us; Madame has been at Gibraltar before, and so ought to have had the use of hers, but knowing her propensity to lose her way, we made Hargrave look after her, while we three elder girls each took a little child. Both the mothers looked after our things. The boys and Jenny were left behind. So we landed just before gun fire, passing through the long rows of houses, which looked so strange to our wondering eyes, piled one above the other, and as we were passed and stared at by numbers of odd queer-looking people, we quite fancied ourselves in a dream, or realizing the Arabian Nights. At last we halted at our hotel. Our sailors deposited our boxes, and seemed to wish us good night with sorrow. We had a famous tea, if I may so call such an odd mixture of eatables, and went to bed, hardly believing we could be in Gibraltar. This morning we were awoke by some little voices round our beds—'Oh, auntie, dear auntie, do get up; this is such a lovely place, and so odd. There are such rocks, and oh, auntie, such queer people. I saw a man in a turban, and there is a black man in the house, and ——' 'Hush, little nieces, how are aunties to get up, if you chatter so? rather help us to dress, that we may see the wonderful things too.' We found our two mothers in the pretty drawing room. Three large windows looked out upon the busy town and blue sea below. The little mother was out in the balcony, in a perfect ecstasy of delight. A call to breakfast was obeyed, though we could hardly eat, the chicks jumping up every minute to look at something new and strange going on below, and the aunties quite wishing that they might commit such a breach of decorum. We were startled out of all propriety at last by a well-known voice sounding under the windows, and a remonstrance which drew us all there. Looking down, we beheld

Felix seated on the top of a most extraordinary vehicle, the driver of which he had superseded, and was trying to persuade the lumbering old horse to get on. Smart was behind vainly endeavouring to persuade his young master to come down. A glance at the drawing-room windows effected what Smart's entreaties had failed to do, and the young pickle was soon at high breakfast, and had demolished a pretty considerable quantity ere his steady elder brother appeared.

"We have just returned from our first expedition so charmed, even our excited imaginations came not up to the beautiful reality. The town is a very curious one. A long street composes the principal part. Almost all the houses are painted black, with flat roofs. The shops open to the street. But the rock itself! My dearest sisters, you cannot imagine anything so exquisite as the tiers upon tiers, the masses of granite or marble rising one above another until one's eyes ached in counting them. I think if our party are always as wild as the fresh air, the beautiful scenery, and the new sensations caused to day, our mother will repent her responsibility. Even the quiet Zoë was roused, and her exclamations were as rapturous as Winny's. Felix's feats of climbing were frightful; we were never quite sure where to look for him. If Smart had not kept his eye on him, and threatened him with sundry punishments, I don't know in what mischief he would not have been. He is much more afraid of Smart than he is of his mother. Lilly's head was full of some classic stories which she had picked up somewhere, the scene of which she was quite sure was in Gibraltar, and each auntie in turn came in for a bit of the story, which might have created a sensation at any other time or in any other scene but this. So you may imagine us now, all so happy, so weary, so enchanted, so sleepy, but wide-awake enough to be able to send the dear party at home a bit of our pleasure, and the wish that they were all with us to delight also in such scenes. I don't think the mother will ever get us all away. We have quite forgotten our pretty La Luna; indeed she is at present as little thought of as her great prototype in broad daylight. So I will now say good-bye, hoping you will set down all deficiencies and incoherences in this long dispatch to the new and delightful feelings such a place and such a new pleasure have produced in our wondering heads. But in Gibraltar as at home, you must believe me ever, dearest mamma, your dutiful and affectionate daughter, and dearest sisters, your loving and affectionate sister,

"SYBIL."

My eldest son's letter to his grandpapa was as follows:

"DEAR GRANDPAPA,

"I like the sea quite as well as I expected; but I would rather go out shooting at home. I hope mamma, however, will allow us to go to the Cape or Canada. Smart says he should like to shoot a bear, and I wish to kill an elephant. In the Bay of Biscay we had a rolling sea. The captain told us the waves were 30 feet high; the wind was very great, and blew from the South-West; but the captain did not seem afraid, he laughed and liked it, so I thought it better not to be afraid either. But Smart was very ill, and said, whenever we spoke to him, 'Oh! I wish I was at home with my old woman.' Felix told him he was a coward and afraid; but he said, 'I ain't afeard, but I be going to die, I be sure.' The dogs are very happy and so is the cow; we feed her every day, and she knows us quite well; she has not been sea-sick, or the dogs, or Felix and I, or the captain and sailors, but I think everybody else has. Pray give my love to grandmamma and my aunts. I am tired of this long letter, and I think you will be also. I remain, your dutiful and affectionate grandson,

"OSCAR."

Gatty's letter was to her sister:—

"MY DEAREST LIFFY,

"This is such glorious fun; but I am so hot. I declare if I stay here much longer I shall flow away, and nothing be left of me but a rivulet. I eat oranges all day long. We have a basket full put by our bedsides at night, and I never leave one by breakfast time if I can help it. It is a horrid nuisance being so sick at sea. I really thought in the Bay of Biscay that I should make a fool of myself and wish I was at home again. I don't like this place much, one is so stewed; there is not a shadow, all seems baked hard as pie-crust twice done. I like being on the sea better now I have got over being ill; there is a breeze to cool one, besides it is so jolly having nothing to do but watch the waves and the wind and learn to mind the helm. I have made great friends with all the sailors, and they are very nice fellows, all but one crabbed old Scotchman, who says, when he sees us on deck, 'ladies should

always stay down stairs.' I crawled up stairs in the Bay of Biscay, because they said it was such a glorious sea, and, at first, I thought we were in a vast quarry of bright blue marble, all the broken edges being crested with brilliant white spar. Suddenly we seemed to go over all, all my quarry disappeared, and I was as near as possible going headlong down the companion ladder, and if I had how they would have laughed. The captain said the ship was on an angle of twenty degrees, what that means I cannot precisely say, but leave you to find out. I can only tell you I thought we were topsy-turvy very often, and I hope we shall not experience any more angles of that kind again. Sybil was awfully frightened, and as white as a sheet. Serena was too ill to care whether the ship was in angles or out. Felix is such a jolly boy, and likes the winds roaring and the waves foaming, and he struts and blusters about as if he was six feet two, and stout in proportion, instead of being a shrimp of the smallest dimensions. He is getting a colour though, and his mother looks at him quite happy. Winny is such an innocent little donkey, so quaint and matter-of-factish.

"I suppose you don't care to hear about Gibraltar, you will get a much better account in some Gazetteer than I can give you; I hate descriptions. However, I'll look in our Gazetteer, and tell you if it is true. All right, very good account. So now I will finish. I hope we shall go across the Atlantic. The little mother is as cross as a bear; but, as she cannot be so always, we are looking out for a change of weather. You know I never can make civil speeches, so please say everything proper for me, including my best of loves to papa and mamma. Ever, old girl, believe me your most affectionate sister,

"GATTY."

CHAPTER IV.

I think the three letters I have given you will sufficiently explain the feelings of our party. We now retraced our steps, though I should have much liked to stop at Lisbon to see the celebrated Cintra.

We, to fulfil the promises made to our gentlemen, were now obliged to make the best of our way to Madeira. This we accomplished within two days of the time we had promised to meet them. But alas! instead of having to welcome them, we received letters, stating that their joining our party must be again postponed, from circumstances needless to mention, and that we must either cruise about for another month or fix some spot where they could meet us at the expiration of that time. Having now become a nautical character, I may be excused saying "that I was quite taken aback." What to do, where to go, or how to manage, I knew not. But to proceed. After a variety of consultations, a vast quantity of advice from all sides, we, backed by our captain's wishes, and rendered rampant by the stretch we had given our hitherto home-clipped wings, decided that we would cross the Atlantic. So great a change had taken place in the captain's mind regarding ourselves that I am not quite sure he mourned at all for the defalcation of our male escort. He had us all to himself now; and, in recommending us the trip across the Atlantic, he reminded me that my brother was stationed at Rio Janeiro, being captain in H.M.S. C——, and that we might cruise up towards North America, and pick up the gentlemen, who, coming from England in the fast-sailing packet boats, would not be more than a fortnight or three weeks at most on the voyage. Of course all the children were wild to go. Remaining in the Mediterranean was voted dull and stupid. How charming to go to America, to see things much more uncommon, much more curious. Everybody could and did see the Mediterranean; it was quite a common yacht excursion. Besides, as I overheard Gatty say to her companions, "Just think, Girls, what a bore it would have been, if, in a month or two's time, our mother should have got tired of the sea, or the little mother continued, every time we have a gale, to get sea sick, they would

have ordered us homewards, without consulting our wishes, and at the end of three months we should have been in stupid England again."

Sybil.—"Stupid England!"

Gatty.—"Stupid England. I did not say stupid England, did I?"

Sybil (much shocked).—"Yes, Gertrude, you did."

Gatty.—"Then, Sybil, I am very sorry. England is anything but stupid. It's a glorious place. It's a delectable place. It's a place that if any one dared to say a word against it, I really think I should feel very much inclined to——"

Sybil.—"Well! What?"

Gatty (softly).—"Why, I should like to knock them down; only don't mention my ideas. Madame will bother me, and say it is unladylike; and perhaps she will give me Theresa Tidy's maxims to do into French as a punishment."

Serena.—"Then we won't tell on any account; such a fate would be so horrible. But I agree with you that it would be dreadfully stupid to go home in three months. Now, if once we get to America, we shall have so much to see and do that the winter would come on, and mother would never trust all us precious people across the Atlantic in bad weather, so we shall have to winter in New York perhaps."

Gatty.—"How jolly! won't I 'guess' and 'reckon' every minute; and won't I fire up if I hear anyone abuse our monarchical and loyal constitution."

Sybil.—"What grand words, Gatty. Where did you pick them up?"

Serena.—"Oh, Gatty is so loyal, that I think she will be quite ready to do that which we promised not to mention a little while ago, if——"

Gatty.—"Hush, hush, Serena, you will get me into a scrape. Don't you know everything is heard in this horrid—no, no, not horrid—sweet, charming, dear, darling La Luna. You know what I mean, so hold your tongue."

Therefore, across the Atlantic, accordingly, we pursued our merry course, previously writing letters to detail our plans, to describe our pleasures of all

kinds, and to appoint a place of meeting.

What can express the delicious pleasure of the sea in a tropical climate. The soft trade wind blowing us gently but swiftly through the water, fanning every limb, and filling every vein with the very meat, drink, and clothing of air; everything around, above, below bathed in brightest purest sunshine; the still life, consequent upon the heat, which pervaded the vessel, each person enjoying the unwonted luxury of enforced idleness in their own way; the very barque herself seeming to sleep on her silent course through the parting water; and as I raised myself from the couch where I had lain down to read, I could not help being struck with the pretty picture the vessel presented. My cousin was reclining not far from me; her book had fallen from her listless hand, her bright searching eyes, so restless in their intelligent activity when open, were closed, her flushed face shewed she slept. Madame was quietly pacing up and down, shaded from the sun by a great parasol; to her the heat was soothing and agreeable, for she had lived much in India, and it agreed with her better than cold winds and chilling frosts. The three girls were not far off; the two elder ones making pretence to read, but looking more inclined to snooze, while the restless Gatty utterly prevented their pursuing either occupation. From them came the only sounds in the vessel, and they consisted of peevish expostulation, requests to be left alone, now and then a more energetic appeal, a threat to complain to the higher powers, promises to be quiet and still, and this scene at last resolved itself into a promise from Sybil to tell a story, if the restless individual would only be quiet. Immediately a reinforcement offered itself to the party in the shape of Zoë and Winny. A pretty little group of four eager listeners and one inspired narrator soon disposed themselves in the unstudied grace of childhood, and the soft voice was heard in regular cadence, now lively, now solemn, now pathetic, and again elevated according to the interest and pathos of her story. Oscar, in his sailor's dress, with his fair bright curls, his animated blue eyes, added to their picture. But in the distance lay the prettiest group; tired and heated with the noisy play of childhood, the mischievous and excited Felix lay fast asleep with his arms round the neck of one of the dogs, as if he was determined the dog should not play if he could not; but the watchful eye of Bernard shewed that he was merely still for his little master's sake, and that he even looked with a distrustful eye at the measured pacing of Madame, fearing that her slight

movement would disturb the profound repose into which his charge had fallen. With her long curls sweeping half over the other dog, and half over herself, lay the tired little Lilly, so mixed with the other two that Cwmro did not seem to think it necessary to keep guard while his companion watched so faithfully, and nothing could exceed the depth of repose and stillness into which they seemed plunged; and in finishing this picture I will end my chapter, for our days glided quietly and deliciously, a time often looked back upon by us as the sweetest and calmest we ever passed, and was only too short in its duration.

CHAPTER V.

There fell upon us a dead calm. The heat was insufferable; the sky was too blue to be looked at; the sea too dazzling to be gazed on; the sun too scorching to be endured. We turned night into day, without mending matters much. Gatty ran about, hot and panting, searching for a cool hole, while she declared that the ship was a great pie, which the sun had undertaken to bake, and that we were all the unfortunate pigeons destined to be stewed therein. "Then," said the matter-of-fact little Winny, "we must put all our feet together, and stick them up in the middle." One day, when we happened to be in that indescribable state—a sort of half consciousness of what was passing around—scarcely knowing whether we were dreaming or waking, we heard a knock at the door, and the hot but smiling face of our captain shewed itself. He was immediately assailed with innumerable questions. Was the heat going? Was the wind rising? When were we to go on? Why did he not whistle for a breeze? Where could we get out of the way of the sun? Was it possible to get into a shade? Could he give us anything to cool us? What would happen if we all went on being baked in this manner? In fact, the purport of his visit to the saloon at such an unusual hour was all but lost sight of in the midst of these queries when I asked him if anything was the matter. "I only wish to look at your barometer; something has happened to mine," was his reply. So amidst an uproar of young voices, with pullings, tuggings, and caresses, for he was a prodigious favourite, he accomplished his object. I was surprised to see such an expression of concern cross his countenance as he gazed at it, and questioning him thereon, he answered, "Why, Madam, I find both the barometers tell the same tale; therefore, what I imagined was owing to a fault in mine, I must now impute to some extraordinary change in the weather."

Gatty.—"I hope then it will be hard frost."

Felix.—"Or a storm, Gatty. I want the wind to blow, and the waves to be mountains high."

Lilly (yawning).—"I wish something would blow, and I wish I had two little slave girls to fan me as they do in India."

Zoë.—"I don't think I should; they would be so hot themselves, poor things, I should be quite sorry all the time."

Oscar.—"I vote for a hard frost, like Gatty, then we should have such splendid skating on the sea."

Serena.—"But, supposing (which I believe is no supposition, but a fact) that the sea freezes in waves, we could not then skate."

Gatty.—"Oh, don't talk any more of ice and frost, it makes one hotter still to think of the contrast."

I proceeded to enquire of the captain what change he expected.

Capt.—"Madam, it must be a storm of some kind; I have been becalmed very often, but I never endured such profound stillness and heat as there have been now for some days past. Dear little souls, I quite feel for the young people, Madam."

Mother.—"But, captain, is it likely to be a bad storm, or will there be any danger?"

Capt.—"You are all such good sailors that I am not at all afraid of telling you the truth. Indeed," looking smilingly on the surrounding faces, "I am thinking some of you will be glad to hear we are likely to have a hurricane!"

The babble on this announcement was tremendous. Gatty and Felix shook hands on the spot, and congratulated each other on the probable fulfilment of their secret wishes. Madame turned deadly pale, and sunk into a seat. My cousin tossed up her head, and said "anything is better than this confounded heat." I trembled; the two little girls clasped each other's hands half in fear, half in excitement; Sybil and Serena both looked pleased; and Oscar besought me to allow him to be on deck the whole time, that he might see the hurricane.

Capt. (seeing my alarm).—"You may be sure, Madam, I would not joke if I thought there was any danger. I have been in Chinese typhoons, hurricanes

in the Tropics, and storms in the Atlantic, where one would imagine heaven and earth were coming together, and under the blessing of God" (here our captain bowed his head) "I apprehend nothing, Madam, but what care and skill can overcome."

Mother.—"But your face expressed great concern when you looked at the barometer; and, besides, you mentioned the heat and calm as greater than you ever before experienced."

Capt. (half hesitating).—"That is true, Madam, but I am such an ass, I cannot hide the impulse of the moment."

Mother.—"But, tell me, is this the impulse of the moment? Do you not fear a more than ordinary severe hurricane? Remember, you have praised us so much for being such good sailors, and so obedient to orders, that you must put us to the proof; and the more you take us into your confidence, the more well-behaved you will find us."

A number of voices, "Yes do, dear captain, tell us everything. Are we going to have a grand storm? Will there be ice and snow? Shall we have thunder and lightning? Will the waves be one hundred feet high? Do you think the masts will be blown away? Tell us that it will be a magnificent storm, whatever you do," said Gatty, winding up the noise.

Capt. (very much perplexed and anxiously).—"Dear little souls. Ma'am, it does my heart good to hear them. They ought all to have been born sailors, and bred to the sea into the bargain. Yes, my darlings, you shall have a grand storm, no doubt you shall have all your wish, whatever I can do for you, my little angels," and the good captain looked quite benignly at them all, giving great energetic kisses back for all the light rosy ones imprinted on his great Scotch face.

My cousin laughed as she turned to me and said, "Good as the captain is, I hope he is not really going to spoil those children and conjure up a prodigious storm for their amusement. Now brats, get out of the way, and let us have a little common sense. You think we shall have a storm, captain?"

Capt.—"I fear so, Madam; that is, I don't fear," apologetically turning to the young ones, "but I have no doubt we shall have a storm."

Schillie.—"Then you would advise my betaking myself to bed, I suppose, immediately."

Capt.—"No, Ma'am, no, for I cannot judge when we shall have it, not these twenty-four hours yet."

Schillie.—"But, pray, have you any advice to give us against the storm does come. When a horse kicks, I am well aware that the rider has solely to think of sticking on; but, I confess, storms and their consequences are quite out of my way."

Capt.—"Indeed, Madam, I should be greatly obliged if you would undertake to keep everybody quiet below, the children especially: if they come running up after me, dear little souls. I shall be thinking too much of them to mind my ship."

Schillie.—"Then I will take particular good care they are kept out of your way. I have no mind to lose my life for a parcel of spoilt animals. But, otherwise, you think there is no danger?"

Capt.—"Why she is a good boat, a very good boat; I fear nothing as long as we have room."

Gatty.—"Room, captain, what sort of room?"

Capt.—"Sea room, begging your pardon, Miss. I quite forgot you would not understand me."

Gatty now pouted in mortification that her intended laugh at the captain should be construed into ignorance on her part of what he meant, and the colloquy was broken up by the captain being sent for. We crawled on deck, as a matter of duty, panting and exhausted with doing nothing. Though we had bright blue sky above us, and the glittering sea around us, I never shall forget the brazen, hard, heated look that everything appeared to possess. The sky seemed to be gradually turning into brass, the ship looking like brass, we feeling like brass. It was horrible; and it was with no slight pleasure I heard a moaning wind rise slowly in the night, freshening into a gale by morning. Ere twenty-four hours had passed, with bare poles we were driven through the water just as a child's walnut shell might be tossed on a rough ocean. Here, there, and everywhere the sea rose, each wave with

a crest to it madly buffeting and fighting with the others, yet each apparently bent on attacking the vessel, freighted with such precious lives. The wind whistled and roared until every other sound was lost. We could hear it gathering in the distance, then collecting, as it were, strength, rage, and speed as it advanced, it poured all its wrath and fury upon what appeared to us, the only victim with which it had to deal. The noble vessel bent, as it were, her graceful head in deprecation of such furious rage and turmoil, and shivering from bow to stern, would again rise lightly and proudly, as if appalled, but yet indignant at the rough usage she was receiving; yet far above the rattling wind the pealing thunder rolled with majestic sound, while the incessant lightning showed us the mad waves in all their forms. From time to time the captain sent us kind messages. We got used to the noise, uproar, and shocks; but, nevertheless, we could perceive the gale increased instead of abating. We bore it well for twelve hours, not a murmur, not a fear was expressed; but, after a shock, so tremendous that the vessel trembled to her inmost timber, a faint shriek was heard from Madame, this was echoed from the deck, it seemed to strike the ship motionless. As our breath returned to us, slowly and labouringly did she rise, heavy and waterlogged; how unlike the buoyant creature she had been a few moments before. Alas! that fatal cry was not without its signification; a sea had struck her, and in sweeping off seven men, had filled the ship with water, and carried away rudder, deck-house, and everything. Then, indeed, fear took possession of our minds. Amidst the roaring of the wind, the earnest and solemn prayers of Madame might be heard, as she sat in the gloom of the cabin, with ashen face and clasped hands, while the wailing sobs of the little girls came mingled with subdued cries from the elder ones. The two boys sat with faces uplifted, and their large eyes distended in fear and awe, as if their wild wishes had caused this awful tempest. The servants, unable to bear their fears alone, were seated in a distant part of the saloon, the wringing hands of the one and the deep groans of the other testifying the anguish and terror of their minds. Unawed by the dreadful turmoil above and the painful scene around her, Schillie alone seemed fearless and unmoved; steadying herself by the cabin door, she stood erect, and, as she looked at each of us, the calm undaunted expression of her countenance seemed to impart to us the courage her words would have given could we have heard them.

The heavy rolling of the ship became each moment more apparent; the timbers creaked and groaned; as if satisfied with the mischief it had done, the wind ceased its wild uproar, and, during the temporary calm that succeeded, we learned the loss of the seven men, hurled at once into eternity, the wreck of all on deck, and the fatal consequences still more likely to ensue from the sea we had shipped. The pumps were manned immediately, and a temporary rudder made from one of the spars. So little did the captain hide our danger from us that he accepted the offer for those that could to help at the pumps; this enabled him to spare two men for the rudder and other work he thought necessary.

Madame remained below with the children, beseeching for that aid which is equally necessary on sea or shore, and Hargrave, being helpless from fear and despair, remained with her. Wrapping ourselves up in warm close garments, we took our places, two at one and two at another pump, to help the men; and we had the exquisite gratification of finding that our labours were successful, for once more La Luna rode lightly on the waters, and our captain, in the broadest Scotch, which he always used when agitated, expressed his heartfelt happiness, while he let out, in broken exclamations of thankfulness, the fear he had entertained that her waterlogged condition might have proceeded from the starting of some of her timbers; and, indeed, the shocks and buffets she had received from the angry waves, with the straining and pitching, made us, inexperienced mariners as were, wonder, more than once, that she was not riven into a thousand pieces. Many were the fond words and endearing epithets bestowed on the brave La Luna by the good captain while he apostrophized her, as if endued with life and consciousness, beseeching her to hold on yet awhile, by all the good angels in heaven, by the mighty powers of the deep, by the love she bore to those within her, by the affection they bore to her, by the value of their lives, by the preciousness of the little innocent children, by the hopes she had given them of her strength and goodness; while he promised her in return every good thing on sea or in sky, fair breezes, bright sun, and ever-flowing sheet, with the devoted love and affection of all on board.

Towards evening, the moaning wind again rose in furious gusts, and we were recalled from the calm into which we had been sunk by the sudden and awful death that had befallen so many of our companions (a feeling only to be felt at sea) to a repetition of all we had undergone before, save in

that one instance. In the language of scripture, "we strake sail, and so were driven." The sky was as pitch, the waves furious, the wind awful. Night and day passed without thought or heed. Working at the pumps had done us all good, diverting our minds from the loss we had sustained, and preventing us from dwelling on the perils surrounding us. But now we had nothing to do, and we experienced, in its full force, that heart-sickness consequent upon hope deferred. Hours sped on, yet still the ship was driven like a mad thing through the water. Bruised and sore, from the various falls and shocks we hourly received, hungry and faint from inability to get the food so necessary for our exhausted frames, death seemed our inevitable doom.

CHAPTER VI.

At the end of the seventh day, we were startled by the cry "Land ho! Land, Land." We exclaimed, "we are saved, we are saved!" and, for a moment, there was deep silence, an instructive feeling of gratitude prompted in each breast, young and old, a spontaneous prayer of thanksgiving to the mighty Being in whose hands we were, who was at once our Father and our God. The first powerful impulse obeyed, we had leisure to think of each other. I kissed the little ones, but said nothing. Madame was loud in her rejoicings and thanksgivings, the servants outrageous in their frantic joy, but the dread fear of the past days, the fury of the still existing storm, kept the elder girls yet in a state of subdued feeling. Dashing the tears from her eyes, and assuming an indifferent manner, Schillie said, "Madame, spare your rejoicings until we land; and you howlers," turning to the maids, "keep your noise for a fitting occasion. I imagine," looking at the rest of the party, "our condition is rendered more dangerous by the probability of being driven on shore; when, instead of going to the bottom, like Christians, with whole skins, we shall be dashed to pieces on the rocks, and washed up in little bits."

Felix.—"I hope some of my little bits will get near mama's little bits, and then I shall not care."

Oscar.—"Mother, may I creep up and ask Smart what the captain thinks about the land?"

All.—"Yes, do, do, dear boy."

"Mind you are careful, my darling boy," said the anxious Mother.

The captain came down himself with the boy, and corroborated Schillie's idea, that land was dangerous if the gale continued. "But, thank God," said he, bowing his head, "the gale is breaking; may I see you all down before my eyes, if I am deceived in thinking we shall have fine weather in a few

hours; but," continued he, looking round with concern, "what pale faces, what suffering and misery you have undergone. I am a'most done myself," the large tears rolling down his pale shrunken cheeks, "and, but for the lives under my care, I must have given way long ere this. Ye have need to pray yet for succour; we are aye in a mickle mess, shortened in our hands, with work for twenty men, it is not to be expected as nature 'll stand it out. The men are fairly done, and, but for that likely Smart, I ken we should be in a far worse state. I am thinking, leddies, a spell at the pump will no harm you, and gie us a better chance of our lives, while the men get a bit snack. Another six hours will make or mar us; but it's no me as will disguise from any one that she's sprung a leak. All the straining and strammashing she has gone through would have foundered some score of fine boats, but she is a good one, aye, a grand one. So weel ye just come?"

We were awfully startled at the announcement of a leak, but followed him as well as we were able. Lashed to the pumps, we again worked hard, but not as before to reap a reward of our labours in seeing the pumps become dry. At the end of two hours, when we had worked turn and turn about, the captain told us that the water did not gain on us, yet the pumps must be kept going night and day to keep her afloat. How grieved we were to see our kind-hearted merry Smart, who had always looked such a fine handsome specimen of an English gamekeeper, worn down to a shadow, his fine fresh colour gone, his cheeks shrunk and withered, his bright eyes and frank smile vanished, and a care-worn, haggard, gaunt man in his stead. The two dogs were near him, looking famished and subdued. But throughout the whole time, during our greatest danger, he had never forgotten the cow; he remembered how necessary the milk was to the health of his little master, and he had fenced and guarded her stall with sails and straw-bands to prevent her being knocked about; nevertheless, with all his care, she looked pitiable, and was galled and bruised in many places.

Gradually the leaden darkness over our heads seemed to be stealing away, a low moaning sound succeeded to the hollow blasts and whistling hurricane that had been making us their sport. Instead of the violent pitching and tossing that had been our fate for so many days, with the fearful careening over of the labouring ship, we were now going slowly up and down with the swelling rolling waves. Gradually and distinctly the land, that had been viewed some hours before, became more visible, and we beheld what

seemed to us a small irregular island, rising very abruptly to the right, and of great height, but shelving off to the left; and, as we approached nearer, we could perceive long breakers dashing for a great distance over the lower part, leading us to imagine that it extended some miles into the sea. Our captain edged off as well as he could, with his crippled rudder and the troubled sea with which he had to contend, because night was coming on. Though the wind was quite subdued, and the sea becoming each hour more calm, the night was an anxious one, and weary enough to some of us, for the pumps could not be left a moment.

The harassing time the young ones had passed made me anxious that they should obtain that rest so long desired, while the age and delicate health of Madame rendered her almost as necessary an object of care; but the maids with my cousin and myself did our duty with the rest in our endeavours to keep the ship afloat.

We were rewarded in the morning by, oh! joyful and beautiful sight, the unclouded and glorious rising of the sun. Months seemed to have passed since we had seen his beautiful face, and the genial warmth and bright beams imparted a glow to every eye and every heart. The cock, so long silent and almost dead with salt water, faintly crowed, the dogs barked, and the cow lowed. When dumb animals thus endeavoured to express their joy and thankfulness, could we be silent? Oh no, words were not wanting to add to nature's hymn, happy and joyful sounds were heard on all sides, and those who could not help it wept the happiness they found themselves unable to express in words.

CHAPTER VII.

In us was exemplified the old adage, "that man is but the creature of circumstances." Who could have foretold that in two short weeks we should think so differently, and yet in that fortnight of dark anxiety, undefined dread and forebodings, more distressing than reality itself, we had seemed to live years of misery. The bodily sufferings we had endured from the heat and burning fever of the scorching sun seemed as nothing in comparison with the horrors we afterwards underwent, and it was almost impossible to imagine that we had ever deprecated the bright beams or complained of the genial warmth now so grateful to our feelings.

What happiness it was to hear the joyous voices of the young ones, as each, in their different manner, expressed their delight at the beautiful change. The gentle Zoë clasped her hands with excited joy; Felix flew into his dear Smart's arms, exclaiming "that the sun was shining most stunningly;" Oscar came softly behind me, and with one arm round my neck, whispered "Dear mama, surely we are saved now;" Lilly and Winny ran from one end of the vessel to the other, singing, in clear ringing voices, the morning hymn; while each and all gazed on the surrounding scene with happiness and delight, worn out as we were with aching arms, blistered hands, and utter weariness, we could not be insensible to the beauty of the little island we were now approaching.

It was seemingly so long since we had seen land that even if it had been a barren rock, we should have hailed it with delight. Yet, with all our love for La Luna, with all our experience of her goodness, beauty, strength, and worth, not a heart beat on board of her, I fear, that did not pant to be on shore. It seemed as if this little island had risen out of the sea for the sole purpose of affording us the rest and peace our shattered condition and worn-out frames demanded. And yet it was curious and half alarming to see this little spot of earth rising so lonely and yet so beautiful in the middle of the sea: like an emerald gem on the vast extent of water it lay calm and alone,

no other land in sight, no other object to divide our attention with it. The nearer we approached, the more we became absorbed in our inspection. It grew larger, it appeared higher, we distinguished cliffs or rocks, we noticed ravines, and beheld small bays. The roaring of the breakers was distinctly heard, and the rolling billows, collecting foam as they advanced, seemed to spend their force against the reef of rocks, while they lightly and gently swept on towards the little island, breaking so softly on the sanded shore that they seemed to regard it as a favoured child, whose solitary condition demanded protection and indulgence. Slowly and heavily the laden ship advanced; suddenly we seemed, as it were, to pass a corner of the island, and came upon a view so lovely in its quiet beauty, so unexpected in its richness and colour, so delightful in its homelike appearance, that one cry of admiration burst from all. How exquisite! How lovely! What rocks! What trees! Look, look, a gushing stream, a lovely waterfall! I see birds, bright birds, and beauteous flowers, I am sure! What colours! What a lovely bay! What blue water! What golden sands! Was ever such a scene beheld before by mortal eyes! Such and many more were the exclamations heard on all sides. There hung, in vast variety, gigantic trees, stretching their huge limbs in every direction on the face of the cliff, as if clinging for support. Every here and there verdant spots appeared, like mossy resting places for the weary climber, from whence hung creeping plants, wonderful to us for their size and beauty. In the right side of the bay, the cliffs seemed suddenly rent asunder, and through the opening gleamed a silvery thread, which, advancing to the edge, fell in a rich stream of water from rock to rock, dispersing into a thousand sparkling dancing rills, sometimes lost, then again bursting forth, now shadowed by a huge old tree, then deepening into a quiet smiling pool, until at last tossed, tumbled, and thrown from a descent of a hundred feet, it reunited its troubled waters on the sand, and flowed in tranquil beauty to the sea. The cliffs shelved up higher almost immediately beyond the waterfall, and rounding abruptly on either side towards the sea, they formed a bay or harbour, scarcely half a mile from point to point, though it must have been some miles round it. High on the right hand, which in fact was the sort of corner we had passed, rose abruptly from the sea a gigantic rock separated from the mainland; it had an archway, apparently hollowed by the sea, quite through it, and was curiously picturesque and strange to view. On the left, the bay was also sheltered by rocks, filled with caves and hollow places, but none separated

from the mainland. Our captain had been occupied taking soundings ever since we had neared the land, and amidst all our exclamations arose regularly the man's deep voice, proclaiming the depth of the line, with a melodious cadence peculiar to the cry.

CHAPTER VIII.

But not even that sound or the nearness of our approach to land prepared us for a sudden grating noise, a shock, a succession of bumps that finally left nearly everybody on their faces and the ship perfectly motionless and fast on a sand bank. Those who soonest recovered themselves were greeted by the captain with cheering voice and hearty shakes of the hand. Wiping the numerous drops of anxiety from his brow, he congratulated us on what seemed the climax of our misfortunes.

"All right, all right," he exclaimed, "capitally done; I hardly hoped we should manage it so well. Cheer up, cheer up, my darling," picking up poor little Winny, whose bleeding nose shewed how suddenly the shock had upset her, "we are all safe now. There is the bonny island ready to receive us, and the pratty ship has borne us safe and sound, as far as she weel could, and now she is safe on a soft sand bank, and no harm to speak on. Another few hours, and we wadna hae had hands to shake or mou's to praise God for all his mercies." In answer to my appealing look, he continued, "She could not have floated long, Madam, the pumps are clogged and useless. Every hour was increasing the weight of water. With all my wisdom and knowledge, I could not have saved you had not a merciful providence raised up this picture of 'the fair havens,' like as is mentioned in the holy scriptures, and I bid ye welcome with my auld heart singing for joy. Never mind your bit knock my hinny. Here's a pratty home and a lovely garden come up from the ocean depths to shield and shelter ye; and ye shall have bonny fruits and flowers to pleasure ye, after the strife and turmoil you have been undergoing. But, aye, leddies, what a grand boat this is. I'd wager my mither's silver tea-urn none could have done so weel; she has borne and sheltered us to the last minute, and now she lays us gently and saftly on a nice sand bank, and we may step ashore with the ease and pleasure of grand folk. Oh, she's a darling."

Oscar.—"But she did not lay us so softly, I came down with such force that I am quite sore now."

Capt.—"But, my darling, you would not expect a ship to be so gentle in her manners as your own lady mother. Na, na, she did as weel as she could, and that's better than the best, I'll engage."

Winny (half angry).—"But she made my nose bleed with her great bumps."

Capt.—"And did she not do it on purpose, my precious lamb? How could she have settled herself so fast and high without making a bed for herself in the sand; she's as knowledgeable as a Christian, and there's no denying of it. Most lumbering vessels would have bumped a hole in their bottoms, but I'll be bound she has not rasped an inch of her keel. Here she lays us, and bids us, while she lies doon to rest, to take a snack ashore, and be thankful for a' the mercies showered on our unworthy heads. Good Mr. Austin is gone fra us, Madam, but surely there remains some amongst us to lift the song of praise and glory."



Every heart responded to the good captain's words, and the crippled crew, more alive than we were to the danger we had escaped, flocked from each part of the vessel to join us. The startled birds, unused to human sounds,

rose in clouds as the energetic and outpouring spirit of praise rose in the air, fervent in its expression, heartfelt in its depth and feeling.

And then our good captain manned the only boat left us, and calling upon me to choose any three other companions I liked, bid me come and take possession of the fair island in the name of the Queen. Calling Schillie, Serena, and Oscar, with the two poor dogs, we got into the boat; in a few minutes we approached, we landed, and seeing the showers of tears that rushed to our eyes, the captain considerately shoved off, and ere we had well dried them, clinging arms and soft voices hung round us, and welcomed us to this land of loveliness and beauty. A very short time elapsed ere we were all on shore, and would have wandered from tree to tree and rock to rock in pleasure too delicious to be described, had not the considerate kindness and untiring exertions of our good captain made us anxious to assist him as well as we could. Everybody was called into requisition, even the volatile Felix and the indolent Lilly were chidden into useful activity, and bestirred themselves to the best of their little powers, on being promised the reward of sleeping on shore. It was nearly noon when we landed, but, in spite of the heat, we worked untiringly, having, first of all, fixed on a dry and sheltered corner on which to have a tent pitched. Under the captain's judicious management, the sailors soon erected a large and commodious apartment, into which we put couches and cushions to serve as beds; a smaller tent, a few feet below us, was prepared for the captain, the boys, and Smart. A large fire was kindled ere night approached to keep off wild beasts, or scare any other unknown enemies. On a shelving rock, against which the waves gently broke, we had our first meal, one never to be forgotten by me, for the many mixed feelings with which it was partaken. All hearts were too full to say much. The overwrought mind of the captain showed itself in his profound silence, while slowly and at intervals a single large tear rolled down his cheeks. Madame swallowed as many tears as tea. Schillie gulped down her food in convulsive starts while she spoke only in short sentences to the dogs, sharply reproving them for nothing. Sybil and Serena both wept quietly, and ever and anon cast fond and anxious but furtive glances at their two mothers. Gatty shewed the workings of her mind by the innumerable holes she was tearing in her poor handkerchief, while she earnestly begged the little girls to eat more, and called them stupid little apes when they did not. They, poor children, would

have been joyful and happy, for the feelings of childhood chase each other like clouds on an April day, but the unwonted sight of the kind captain's tears, the uncontrollable feelings that possessed the elder party, gave an awe to the whole proceeding. Oscar and Felix ate and drank to their heart's content, relieving their feelings by occasional visits to Smart, who sat at a little distance with some of the sailors. Such a state of feeling could not last. Our meal ended abruptly, and ere the lingering glory of the sun had wholly left the sky, all the worn frames and overtaxed hearts sought the repose so necessary for them, and, save two faithful watches by the fire, deep sleep fell on all the party.

CHAPTER IX.

I awoke in the morning, hardly at first comprehending where I was. On rising, I found myself alone, no sound broke the stillness, no sight met my eyes to assist me in restoring my still dreaming thoughts. After passing some moments in endeavouring to recollect myself, I opened the door of the tent. High and dry on a sanded bank lay La Luna, almost on her beam ends, while active figures were busily employed in her. The little boat had just left her laden with a heavy cargo. Smart and the two maids were apparently waiting to receive what she brought, and assist in unloading her. Scattered in numerous and pretty groups along the shore were all my loved companions. I slowly and mechanically counted them, as if I feared from the unwonted stillness some were missing; but they were all there; I thanked God, and sat down to recover myself. One of the dogs barked, and I saw my cousin run forward to silence him. The little girls were feeding the ducks and chickens, at least two were, while the third was wandering close to the waves at some distance. The boys were one rubbing the cow down, the other feeding her with fresh grass, for which she eagerly pursued him. Schillie walked slowly to the water's edge, and began to make ducks and drakes, as it is called, with a stone, apparently trying to hit a dark object that was moving in the water. The dogs were going in after the stones, when a shout from the vessel roused her. Pointing to the black object, of which now there appeared many, vehement signs were made to her to forbear. The noise reached the ears of all, and they came each from their separate occupations to know what was the matter, and I also walked from the tent for the same purpose. The moment I was perceived they all uttered joyful cries, and ran towards me, expressing their pleasure that I was at last awake; and I then learnt that the cause of their great silence was a wish to leave my repose as undisturbed as possible. I thanked them all, and was greatly relieved; and now there was no end to the gabble, which nearly made us forget the cause which had first broken the stillness.

But Smart came, sent by the captain's orders, to tell us not to throw more stones, or allow the dogs to go into the water, as the odd black things we saw were sharks. Some of the party were aghast, and some delighted at the notion of being on such familiar terms with creatures of whom we had only before read. We sent a message back to the captain to come to breakfast, which had been prepared under a vast plane tree, whose huge branches afforded us delightful shelter. He soon arrived, and greeted us all, in famous spirits. He shook our hands until they ached, he kissed the children a dozen times, and he talked broader Scotch than we had ever heard him do yet; also, he drank about fifteen cups of tea. We all did ample justice to our breakfast; and I was glad to see poor Madame quite merry, roused by the mirth and noise of the children.

Gatty.—"What a jolly island this is."

Oscar.—"Yes. Should you like to live here?"

Gatty.—"I'll be Robinson Crusoe, and you shall be my Man Friday."

Winny.—"You must be Mrs. Robinson Crusoe, Gatty, because you are a woman."

Mother.—"Then I suppose we had better go away, and leave you two here."

Oscar.—"Oh no! don't do that, but we will go and live at the top of that rock, and make believe to be Crusoe and Friday; only, Gatty, if I let you be Crusoe, you must let me have a gun, and I must not sit at your feet, and have to read, because I can do that already quite well. The best thing will be for us both to be Crusoe, and have no Friday at all, because I shall have to black myself."

Sybil.—"And I know that won't please you at all, you little Eton dandy, with your smart waistcoat, white tie, and shining boots."

Oscar.—"Why you know, aunt Sib, we are no longer sailors now. We must dress as shore-going folks. Besides, we don't know if there may not be company here."

Madame (turning quite pale).—"Oh dear! Do you think there are any savages likely to be near us. I have such a dread of them."

Capt. (laughing).—"Why, Ma'am, from all I could see of this island, there isn't much room for them and us, and there cannot be many of them at any rate. If there are, they will show themselves soon."

Schillie.—"I would advise an exploring excursion, that we may see who has possession of this island besides ourselves. It would be as well to know if we have foes, either man or beasts. I know one person," with a slight glance at me, "who will be as fidgety as she is high if her mind's not at rest. She'll see a savage in every bush, a tiger behind every stone, and sharks walking on the sand swallowing brats like pills. It did not seem very large, captain, though we can hardly tell now, walled in as we are by these great cliffs."

Capt..—"I think your advice very sensible, Madam. It will ease my mind too, very much, to know that you are exposed to no danger while I am busy overhauling the ship. Here comes Mr. Skead, and we'll take his opinion. Ah! good Mr. Austin, you're a sair miss."

This apostrophe to the memory of our kind good mate was heartily responded to by all. Amongst others who were lost in that fatal night was the old Scotch sailor; but the subject was so painful to us, we never recurred to it, if possible. We could not recover the shock of such a fatal parting from our late companions.

We gave Mr. Skead some breakfast, and then entered into a discussion of plans, in which every one took a part. The captain declared that *La Luna* must be overhauled, that all her cargo must be taken out, and that he had work for fifty men, and had but ten to do it, himself and Mr. Skead making twelve, Smart and Benjie fourteen. And yet every voice pronounced, "we must go and explore." The good captain was sorely puzzled, and in his perplexity talked Scotch to an unintelligible degree. Every day was of consequence until he had discovered what injury the ship had received. We, on our parts, declared it was impossible to sleep or rest in peace while we were subjected to any unknown enemy rushing out upon us.

Schillie.—"Good lack! What a noise. Pray be quiet for a moment, and listen to common sense. Why should the captain go exploring at all. Let him remain with his men and ship, and give us Smart and some guns, and we will go and explore."

A dead silence followed this announcement of Schillie's. At last, exclaimed Gatty, "It will be capital fun." "So it will," said Sybil. "Most delightful," said Serena. "I want so much to climb up those cliffs," said Zoë. "I want to gather flowers," said Winny. "I want to kill a lion," said Oscar. "I wish to climb up a cocoa-nut tree, and get mama some cocoa-nut milk," said Felix. "And I," said Lilly, "want to stay here and pick up shells. Oh, mama, such shells, I never, never, never saw such lovely——" here I put my hand on her little mouth, while Madame exclaimed, "My dearest children, my darling girls, are you mad. What, go up those frightful rocks, exposed to the dangers of wild beasts, get torn and scratched amongst the forest, scorched and burnt by the sun. My dear young ladies, believe me, I cannot permit such indecorum." Blank looks followed, while I, taking Madame's hand; said in a deprecating tone, "You know, dear Madame, we are in peculiar circumstances, and we must all do our duty in the small circle to which we are now reduced. As it is so necessary that the captain should examine the ship, and as we cannot help in that, I think we may as well try our talents in exploring. I think you will have no objection to the girls going if the two mothers go also."

Madame.—"Oh! my dear Madam, think not of it. Remember how precious your life is. Think what would become of us should anything occur to either of you. I feel quite incapable of filling your place; and a thousand unseen dangers are preferable to your leaving us for a moment."

Mother.—"Thank you very much, Madame, for your very kind interest. Be assured I will do nothing rashly. What do you say, captain?"

Capt.—"Why I must say, Madam, every day I live with you ladies adds to my wonderment. You are no ladies, but brave fine warriors, and nothing will daunt you. There is not a man in the world has such a soul as she has," pointing to Schillie. "I'll wager my mither's silver punch bowl that she's afraid of nothing. You can fire a gun, no doubt, Ma'am?"

Oscar.—"Yes, to be sure, and a pistol too, and she can load them also."

Capt. (gazing at her with great admiration).—"Well then, she's as good as another man. There will be Smart and her, and as you must go quietly, they will be quite enough."

The three girls exclaimed, "But we want to go, captain; we don't fear anything, and we will be very brave. If you show us how to fire off a gun, we will do it."

Schillie.—"Pooh, pooh, girls. I should like to know what peace and quiet there would be with you three magpies after us."

Mother.—"I don't see the advantage of going quietly; though I hope we shall do so peaceably. I think the larger the party the better; and I therefore propose that Hargrave and Jenny cook the dinner wanted here, and by that means Benjie can be spared, who will be very useful, as he is acquainted with the bush and all the things about these places of which we are ignorant. Therefore, let Smart and Benjie go first, you next, then the three girls and Oscar and I will bring up the rear."

Schillie was about making a remonstrance, when we were interrupted by a burst of weeping, most outrageous in its noise; and, between sobs and passion, Felix blurted forth his indignation and disappointment at not being included in the party. Taking him up from the ground, where he had thrown himself in his passion, the good captain tried to console him—"Come now, come, my little man, don't fret so. Don't you know we want you here. How could the dear little girls and the good old lady do without such a grand protector as you."

Felix (blubbing).—"I hate taking care of girls, they do such silly work, and I won't take care of Madame; and if lions and tigers come, they may kill them themselves, for I won't do it for any of them."

Even the too indulgent Mother could not help laughing at the absurdity of such a frit killing tigers and lions, looking not much bigger than an impudent monkey. Fresh tears followed the universal laughter. "Well then, my man," continued the captain, "you shall come on board with me. I want a very clever active hand to help me."

Felix.—"I hate the ship, and I won't go on board. She is a nasty creature, and nearly drowned us all."

This impudence was too much for the captain, so he put him down with an ejaculation, "Ech! but you're a fashious bairn;" and how long he might have continued to roar we know not, but between his tears his eye suddenly

caught sight of the cow, who, either intoxicated by all the fresh sweet grass she had eaten, or having risen in particularly good spirits, was indulging in a series of antics, equally ludicrous and unbecoming in such a sober creature. With the tears rolling down his cheeks, he clapped his hands and shouted with glee. Smart took advantage of the favourable moment, and said, in a commanding voice, "Sir, I'll thank you to catch us some fish to-day; they are jumping in buckets-full, and we shall want some supper agin we return."

This restored the smiles, and, with rod in hand, away he went in happiest spirits; and ere we were ready to depart, such was the change in the state of his feelings, that he privately confided to his brother, he thought him a great muff to go toiling up the rocks instead of stopping with him to catch the fish that were jumping about, almost asking to be taken out.

The captain gave us many orders and directions, charged Smart and Benjie with innumerable cautions, and finally dismissed us with hearty good wishes and fervent hopes for our safe return. Madame was too much agitated to speak, and could only wave her adieus. Jenny and Hargrave, who were assisting in our preparations, each in their own way expressed their feelings. The former declaring she would be glad of a quiet day to get through a lot of washing, the latter grumbling that the young ladies would spoil their clothes and get them torn, while both had indistinct visions of snakes and dragons snapping us up, lions and tigers leaving only our bones as sad memorials, savages or monsters running away with us! Fortified by these ideas, we emerged from the tent, properly equipped, and then had to take leave of the little girls. Their notions all tended towards the pleasurable kind, and had we been in a civilized place, spectators might have imagined we were starting for a good day's shopping in London or elsewhere, provided they had interpreted the young ladies' wishes as toys and not real live creatures. "I'll thank you to bring me a monkey and some grapes," said Felix. "I also wish for a monkey," said Winny. "No, no, Winny," said Zoë, "don't have a monkey, they smell so. Let us have each a parrot." "Oh yes, yes, a parrot. Bring Zoë a green one and me a blue one," said Winny, "A blue one, you stupid girl," said Oscar, "there never was a blue one in all the world." "Then I will have a yellow one; red parrots are so common and vulgar," Lilly said, "but whatever you do, mind and bring us some cocoanuts." We promised to do our best, and started, not in the order I proposed,

but with Benjie in the rear. Hard work it was, and many times did we stop, pretending to admire the view, watching the dear ones below, answering their signals, but only with an object to gain breath for fresh exertions. It took us quite an hour and a half to get to the top, during which we frightened innumerable quantities of birds, and disturbed a vast number of lizards. The latter alarmed some of us very much, and they turned their large serious odd eyes upon us as if in wonderment at our appearance, gliding so imperceptibly from our sight, that it seemed as if they dissolved in air. Once at the top, we sat down to rest and eat, for, by the captain's advice, we determined not to stir during the hot part of the day. We of course had the dogs with us, but they were kept to heel by Smart, to avoid rousing any enemy. After cooling ourselves, and recovering our breath, we had leisure to examine the exquisite beauty of everything around us. Anything like the trees with the foliage of every shade of green, and creepers with stems as thick as the trees in our country could not be imagined. Whatever fears the girls might have had, they seemed all to have vanished; and they sat talking and laughing with the same glee and unconcern as if they had been in the garden at home. During the noise they were making, we had not perceived that Benjie had left us. Presently he returned with a vine clinging round him, covered with ripe luscious grapes. We were enchanted, and had only one drawback, that we could not send any one below. Madame would have enjoyed them so much, and it was so hot on the shore, compared to the breeze we were enjoying. Benjie, comprehending our words, said, "Hi, Benjie, cook that for them, hi, Benjie, first-rate good cook, and send a pye-grape down to Miss Winny." Miss Winny was his pet, because when the little girls with more openness and candour than civility, expressed their horror of a black cook, Winny had endeavoured to soften the matter as much as possible, declaring that even if he had a black face he had whiter teeth than anybody else, and she was sure that if he could he would have washed himself long ago, "Besides," she ended, "he is so kind and gentle, that I am sure his mind and soul are white." Benjie understood quite enough to make him Winny's slave for life.

He soon returned to us with some enormous gourds. The girls jumped up in delight, and Gatty seizing hold of one, attempted to carry it—suddenly she uttered a shriek, dropped her gourd, and ran behind us all; a large green lizard peeped out of a hole in the gourd, and peering about for a few

moments, finally crawled out, followed by innumerable little ones, who disappeared like magic in the grass. Nothing would induce Gatty to touch the gourd again, Benjie soon scooped one out, and, putting green leaves inside, filled it with grapes, and, covering the hole with some strong shiny green leaves, gathered from a tree close by, he gave a shout, using his favourite word "Hi!" Not only did the sky become dark with the clouds of birds which arose at that unearthly cry, but various noises in the bushes made us huddle together in fear and alarm. However, it effected his object, and we could see them eagerly, and apparently in alarm, looking up from below. Benjie showed every tooth in his head, and, swinging his gourd round and round, he sent it bounding down from point to point, until it fell as if on purpose, nearer to little Winny than any of the other spectators. Nevertheless, as might be expected, Benjie's "pie-grape" was somewhat damaged in its descent. We, however, sent them some more, and a note inside one, to say we were all merry and well, and greeted them right lovingly.

It was now time to move on, Smart took Oscar up and seated him on his shoulders, saying, "Now, Sir, keep watch up there, and if you see anything coming just let me know, and, particklarly, a beere, Sir, I have a notion I should like to kill a beere ere I die." Oscar promised faithfully, and added, "But I shall not tell you of an elephant, as I want to shoot that myself." "As you please, Sir," said the willing Smart, "but I will keep my gun ready in case you misses him."

The point we were aiming for was the highest part of the island; hitherto we had great difficulty in forcing our way, though we all used our hatchets without remorse, Gatty bestowing much unnecessary labour in the matter. We were beginning to think our adventure rather stupid; not a sign of any animal had we seen, great or small, no dragons, no griffins, no snakes, no anything. Our dissatisfaction might soon have found words, had not Oscar, from his elevated seat, called vehemently on Smart to stop. "What is it, Sir, a beere or a helephant?" "Go back, Smart, just under that tree. Now then stop, stand steady, while I scramble up here. I thought so, look! look! did you ever see anything so droll." So saying, he pulled out from the branches of a huge tree two quiet, wise-looking parrots, not quite fledged, that were seated side by side in a hole in the tree. They did not seem in the least discomposed, but gazed on us with great gravity. "They are neither blue nor

yellow, but dear mother, they will just do for the little girls. Pray let me take them home." I was very loathe to give leave, I could not help thinking somebody might be only in the next bush, ready to take away my nestlings. Everybody added their entreaties, so it was agreed as we must return the way we came, if we found them again we would politely request their company home with us.

So that matter being settled, Smart resumed his burden, warning his young master to be more quiet in his next announcement, if he had nothing better to encounter than a nest of parrots. We found grapes in every direction. Benjie also showed us the Banana tree, gave us a perfect volume of his discovering yams, and danced with glee before a small plantation of sugar canes. Yet all this time we saw no living thing but birds. We were enchanted with the flowers, their size and colour were beyond all description, at last we came to an open glade, and through this ran the stream, which fell over the cliffs into the sea. The trees were gigantic, and Benjie in his broken English, endeavoured to describe them all to us, telling us their Indian names, and their qualifications. Here following the stream a little way, we peeped over the precipice, and by the help of glasses I saw all our belongings at dinner, our feeble shouts were of course unheard, and now for the first time, we heard a noise, a rustling in the bushes. I turned pale, Sybil, Gatty, and Serena ran to each other. Schillie raised her gun and looked at the bushes with a determined eye. We all stood breathless. It came nearer and nearer, the bushes absolutely crashed with the sound. It could be nothing but an elephant, or rather a dozen of them. At the distance of a few hundred yards was a gigantic tree. To our amazement this tree, without a breath of wind to stir a leaf, shook and trembled in every branch, sometimes it waved with a solemn and slow motion, and again it was agitated in the most violent manner. Benjie fell flat on his face, apparently in a fit, as we stood transfixed with amazement. Smart, whose courage rose with the excitement, signed to the dogs to go forward. They nothing loathe, sprang into the bushes, and made straight for the tree. It quivered no more; but a dreadful howl from one of the dogs, bespoke something horrible. The other fleeing before some enemy, for we heard him yelling with fear, and the sound gradually died away, as did the crashing and noise, we had heard before. We waited some minutes in silence, when Smart asked Oscar in a low voice if he could see anything. "Nothing" was the boy's reply. "Get

down then, Sir, and let me see what ails blacky." For a black man it was strange to see how livid Benjie was, and he trembled in every limb. "Come, come, Snow-balls," said Smart, "what are you quaking about?" "Me dead wid fear, masser Smart." "You need not tell me that, you sneak," muttered Smart, "come get up, and let's go to yon tree, and see if the old gentleman holds court there." "No, no masser Smart, please ma'am, do ma'am, I dead, I dead." "But what is it, Benjie, that frightens you so?" said I. "Oh! ma'am, dat no elephant, dat no bear. Good elephant, good bear to that. It some horrid thing, great big monkey, or worse and worse great big snake." "Well it's gone now, whatever it do be, old hero, so get up, and come along, I am going to see what's there." "I'll go too, Smart," said Schillie, "leave the boy behind." They went slowly and cautiously, but presently called on us to come. We obeyed, and after passing thro' the hedge of thick underwood that was before us, we came to a beautiful open glade, sloping down in smooth banks or terraces to a little lake, from whence flowed the stream so often mentioned. The south and west sides of this valley were closed in with precipitate rocks, and the most conspicuous object in this lovely spot, was the large tree, whose extraordinary motions, had so bewildered us. Smart and Schillie were underneath it. "Did you ever see such a glorious fellow," said Schillie, pointing to the tree. "H'd cut into a sight of timber," said Smart, whose manners were fast acquiring the familiarity and sociability consequent upon our being so intimately connected in various ways, since our misfortunes. I never saw such a tree, but we all looked at it, with awe, expecting it to begin again its mysterious movements. There was a disagreeable odour pervading the air, that made us feel sick. Nothing however was to be seen, broken branches, and the mark of some large creature might be traced all about the place. Smart whistled for his dogs, but they either did not hear him, or as he feared, they must have been killed. We soon returned to where we had left Benjie, quite amazed at the beauty of the place, but bewildered with the strangeness of this event, and the total disappearance of both enemy and dogs. Finding him still overcome, we decided to prosecute our searches no further, after we had made one excursion up to the top of the cliff, when there, we had a full and perfect view of the whole island, which appeared about three miles across, four long, and about thirteen miles round. It seemed bathed in tranquil peaceful beauty, we saw no movement, heard no sound, and but for the unseen enemy, we should have supposed that excepting birds, we were the only

living things on the island. We now began to be weary, and foot sore, so we gladly turned our faces homewards, the descent being much more speedy than the ascent, as might be supposed. We could get nothing out of Benjie, more than groans and bewailings. We picked up the two little parrots, loaded ourselves with fruit and flowers, and curiosities, and it might have been imagined that we had been absent years, from the welcome that was given us on our return. Never was such a noisy supper, or so much talking, but the captain was quite puzzled at learning that we had seen nothing alive, and he looked grave and serious at hearing the adventure about the tree. The children had been so occupied tasting all the different fruits and luxuries we had brought home, that they had forgotten the blue and yellow parrots. Oscar had said nothing about them, but now supper being over, the excitement a little quelled, the talking rather subdued, he ran to a little hole in the rock, and hiding the birds with his cap, his bright eyes and radiant smile showed he had more pleasure in store for them. How delighted they were, when they were at last allowed a peep, what earnest requests from every one, that they might have them for their own. "How can that be," said Oscar, "here you are, three girls, and there are only two parrots, and I spied them out, so I ought to have one at least." "Then may I have the other," said the three little girls at once. "No," said Felix, "I must have it. We are lords of the creation and ought to be served before you girls."

"Oh! master Felix," whispered Jenny, "for shame, sir, ladies are always served first, real gentlemen always give way to ladies." "Well! but, Jenny, how can they all three have it, I'd like to know, besides it looks so wise at me, I know it will love me best. Let mama decide," said Oscar, "yes, yes, yes," said each little girl, and each came flying with an eager petition to where we all sat. "Oh," said Schillie, "humph, so you are fighting about the parrots, for my part (peeping into the nest), I have always heard that parrots make a capital pie." "Oh, oh, oh, little mother, how cruel you are." We laughed at this dismay, and Gatty said, "yes, I'll crunch their bones like Grumbo the giant." But the captain made amends for our cruelty, and if he had had his own way, would have marched up instantly in search of three more parrots; luckily the darkness came on so quickly that we were all obliged to make preparation for retiring, Felix being fixed on as the fortunate possessor of the other parrot, partly because I did not like to single out one little girl more than another, and partly because Oscar wished it.

Besides the captain promised the little girls a perfect flock of parrots the first opportunity. So we all bid each other good night, Felix as the last thing, giving Jenny a practical proof that her lessons were not thrown away, by declaring that she must put the girls to bed before him, as ladies were to be served first.

With grateful hearts, we slept soundly and rose refreshed.

CHAPTER X.

It was so hot down on the sands that we agreed to move half way up the cliff, where a cool breeze from the sea blew morning and evening. The brook fell over a shelf of rock, about ten feet in depth, and then lay calm and quiet in a fair round pool. Two or three palms were on one side and a large Spanish chestnut on the other, giving us ample shade. We had a lovely view of the whole bay, and were, as we thought, quite secure from any dangers above, the rock being very precipitate, but the dogs never came home, which gave us very great uneasiness. While the others were busily employed running up and down to bring our goods and chattels, to the new abode, I, and the two little girls arranged them as they were brought up. They were merrily singing on one side of the brook, clearing a place for the tent to be placed, while I, on the other, was arranging seats for a dining place. Suddenly the song ceased abruptly. Looking up to see the cause, as well as that of a sudden crashing noise, I saw the little girls gazing in speechless amazement at the great chestnut tree, and again, without apparent cause, I beheld the huge branches shake and quiver like an aspen tree in the storm. I sprang across the stream, and stood before the little girls. From between the branches there appeared and disappeared a horrible head, with glittering eyes and forked tongue, and, as I gazed still more the whole tree seemed to me to be enveloped in the folds of an enormous serpent.

The little girls now began to utter shriek upon shriek, which brought Serena with the speed of a lapwing to our side. "Take the children away," I whispered, "fly, fly, quickly." "Run, little ones, run," she said, feeling there was danger, but hardly realizing the full horrors of it. They obeyed her, and, as their little forms appeared from behind us, fleeing for their lives, the monster looked out still further from the groaning tree, his diamond eyes fixed upon their receding frames.

Fold after fold seemed rapidly unwinding from the branches. In the agony of the moment Serena flung a hatchet she had in her hand at the head she

now for the first time saw. A frightful hiss, and a loathsome and deadly odour, told us it had taken effect. Again it coiled itself round the tree, which rocked and groaned with its furious movements. Faint with fear and the horrible smell, I knew not my own voice, as I said to Serena, "Fly, child, fly, and send help; and you also." She said, "Nay, one must stay, it must have one victim to save the others." "No, no, let us both go, I will not go without you, Serena, I command you go, it comes nearer and nearer." "No, no, I will die with you." She threw her arms round me, burying her face in my neck, to avoid seeing the dreadful jaws opening so near us. I flung her off, and thought would it not be better for us to be dashed to pieces over the rocks than to be grasped in those deadly coils. "We will both fly," I said; we turned and fled. I looked behind; he was not more than thirty yards from us. I tried to shout and scare him with my voice, but all sound died away in my throat. My heart seemed to stop beating; my utterance to be choked. Everything seemed to be moving with the same angry springing motion of the snake. Nothing stopped our flight; heedless of every impediment we bounded over stones, bushes, gulleys, rocks; but each glance showed him advancing. We now came to an open smooth platform of turf, from whence I knew there was a precipitous fall of twenty feet, unless we hit upon the right spot to descend. "We must throw ourselves down," I whispered. "Anywhere with you," she answered, "but, oh horrible fate, was that another monster just before us or the same?" No, there was but one, he was before us, round us, everywhere; and he knew he had us safe, for his eyes grew larger and more glowing as he bounded and leaped on every side of us, each bound and each leap bringing him nearer. Was there no escape? Yes, almost before I saw it myself the monster's quick eye has discerned two horns rising with the sloping ground, and with one bound which threw us both down, he darted forward. A rushing deadly wind seemed to blow over us, and, ere it was past, the crashing bones, and dying bellow of the cow gave us warning of the horrible fate from which she had saved us.

We helped each other to rise, and scrambling down the rock, we never stopped or spoke until we sunk breathless by the tents, where the little girls had only just arrived. But it was many minutes ere we could tell the frightful scene going on above. We clung together and all drew within the tent, while Smart went to summon the captain. The poisonous breath of the monstrous creature made Serena and myself the victims of successive

fainting fits, we had the greatest difficulty in swallowing anything, and only revived under the influence of strong salts, and constant fanning. Our features assumed the paleness of death, and a cold dew rolled in large drops from our foreheads. The moment we raised our heads dreadful sickness overcame us, and when the captain and his men arrived, we were totally unable to give any particulars beyond the creature being monstrous and the cow destroyed. The captain desired every one to keep as quiet as possible, and directed the sides of the tent to be raised to give us air and our faces and heads to be sponged with cold vinegar and water. He entreated no one to be alarmed as the serpent would not leave his prey, and might be a day or two swallowing it, during which time we were quite safe. And afterwards in his gorged state he would be an easy victim. Towards evening Benjie crept up as near the spot as he dared, and came down reporting the snake was still occupied in reducing the poor cow to a shapeless mass, and had not even begun to swallow his intended meal. Even his dark skin shewed the fear and horror he was in, his look being quite pallid, and his eyeballs livid, his teeth chattering. He declared the snake to be the most monstrous of its kind ever seen, and called it an anaconda. On the second evening the captain, Smart, and Benjie all went cautiously up. When they returned the good captain seemed unable to express his mixed feelings, amazement at its large size, horror at what might have been our fate, thankfulness at our merciful escape, all overcame him. He could only wring our hands, and loudly and earnestly thank God.

After a while he took the two little girls in his arms, and said, "Oh! my darlings, my little precious ones, had you found a horrible grave in those dreadful jaws, swallowed as if you had been two little innocent lambs, I must have laid my head on the nearest stone, and burst my heart with sorrow." Smart openly blubbered like a great school boy as he described to Oscar, "that it was the awfulest worm he ever seed, and that the poor cow was nothing but a bloody, broken mass enough to break the heart of a toad in a stone." It had only swallowed half its meal, and the tail was still so active and full of muscular movement that the captain did not deem it safe to try to destroy it till the next evening.

He particularly requested Schillie and every body that could, to come up and see the creature before the men cut it up, saying, they might live one thousand years, and never see such a sight again. So they all set off, leaving

Serena and I to the care of Hargrave, who declared that if St. George and the Dragon were fighting up above, she would not leave her mistress to see them. Schillie came back very soon, and folded me in her arms, while the tears rained down her cheeks; not a word said she, but so unusual a sight told me all she felt.

Bye and bye all came down, poor Madame clasping her hands, invoking blessings and showering kisses on her pupil Serena. The little ones were in full fuss, especially the two who had first seen the snake, and who now detailed all their fears and feelings at full length. "Mama," said Felix, "I gave him a good kick with my thick nailed boots for daring to think of eating you." Gatty, from a similar feeling, had indulged herself with chopping the tail into little bits, and even the gentle and sweet Sybil had bestowed some very hard words, let alone blows, on the inanimate body. "Well! now then," said I, "captain, I wish to go on board as soon as possible." "Why? why? why?" sounded on all sides. "Because there may be more of these snakes on the island," said I, with a shudder.

"No, Madam, no, you may rest assured, the only enemy you have on this island is now dead. I can assure you I have until now been much puzzled to account for the lack of living things on this luxuriant and lonely island, save birds. The sight of this anaconda has solved the mystery; he has depopulated it (if I may so say) of every creeping or four-footed thing. Nay, I am also certain it has destroyed its own kind too. By what means it became of so monstrous a size I know not; but, having become so, it was lord or master of the island; moreover, I am certain that of late its food has run extremely short; nothing but extreme hunger could have driven it down those sharp rocks, in search of us, the prey it saw below it." In many places it was bleeding besides the wound given it by the hatchet, and three or four inches of skin had been rubbed off in various parts, evidently quite fresh, and done in descent. Also, if it had not been weakened for want of food, such an enormous creature would not have been so long demolishing the cow.

"But, captain, can you account for its making all those hideous gambols at us, and not springing at us directly as it did at poor Daisy." "Yes, Madam, it had never seen the likes of you before. Your clothes made it fearful; but they never attack people unless angry or frantic from hunger, as I am sure

he was. But, to set you at rest, Madam, to-morrow, spite of all my anxiety about the ship, every man of us will join parties, and we will go from one end of the island to another. We'll not leave a bush unexplored, or a corner unvisited, and then I know your mind will be easy." "I thank you, captain, that it will. Now, give the men each some grog, for I see them coming down, and let us all have supper and go to bed."

CHAPTER XI.

So we accordingly did, and long ere we were awake in the morning the captain and all his men, including Smart and Oscar, had departed to execute his plans. We busied ourselves in preparing them a good supper against their return; we had also all a dip in the sea, in a little natural bath in the rocks, where no sharks could get at us. Finally, not without misgivings, we all went up to look once more on the anaconda. That evening, if they returned in time, it was to be skinned; the shiny, scaly covering being to be preserved as a memorial of the event, and the loathsome remains were to be thrown to the sharks. While we were standing looking at its huge length, we heard shouts from above, and saw the exploring party coming home. They soon joined us, the captain delighted at being able to say that a large rat seemed our only wild beast while Smart grumbled, and said he "did not think there was a beere on the hisland." They had done as they promised, and not left a part of the island unvisited.

They brought us home quantities of grapes, prickly pears, yams, bananas, cocoa-nuts, with what would have been magnificent flowers but the hot tropical climate withered them almost as soon as gathered. Oscar and Smart seemed to have some great secrets between them, and, after keeping Felix and the little girls in suspense for some time, Smart put his hand into his pocket, and brought out a tiny, little, droll-looking monkey. Shrieks of delight were heard, Felix exclaiming above all, "Oh give him to me, let him be mine; oh the darling fellow." The little creature, with its wild sorrowful eyes, looked from one face to the other, and, at last, making a spring, it jumped into Felix's arms, and, nestling its little head in his pinafore, grinned at everybody, as much as to say, "Now, I don't care for you." Felix was by no means backward in returning this spontaneous affection, spite of the little girls' civil remark "that he was so like a monkey the little thing took him for his father and mother."

We went to rest all very happy and contented, and enjoyed a week of the merriest gipsy life that could be imagined. Both the parrots and the monkey were getting quite familiar, and at home with us, taking to their education comfortably.

At the end of that time, after the young ones had gone to bed, the captain asked me how we liked this life? There was not a dissentient voice. "Then," said he, "I think this a favourable opportunity to propose a plan to you; it has been in my mind for some days. I only waited until I saw whether it would be as agreeable, as it seems to me inevitable." We waited in breathless expectation. He looked round us all as he said, "How would you like staying here another six weeks?" "Very much indeed! Beyond every thing. It is just what we wanted. It would be most jolly." Schillie wound up by saying, "It is extremely stupid, and I should not like it at all." "Would you not?" said the captain, with kind concern, laying great stress on the you; "Oh but ye must, I'd never take ye to sea, and La Luna in such a leaky state." "What, captain, how! pray explain yourself." "Well, if I must tell the truth, the more we have examined the ship the more fearful are we to trust you all on board of her." Heaps of voices now interrupted the captain. "But what are we to do? How are we to get away? We don't want to stay here for ever. That would be too much of a good thing." "Silence, girls," said I, "do let us hear what the captain proposes." "This is my proposal then, Madam. Emptied of her cargo, and with as few hands in her as possible, La Luna will run nicely to St. Domingo, or some of the parts lying to the westward, and belonging to South America; and, even should she fail, we men can take to the boat, and, at all events make for some place, where we can procure a vessel to come for you." "But La Luna won't sink, surely we shall not lose her; we don't want any ship but her. Don't you know how you love her yourself, captain?" "So I do! so I do! young ladies, and I am fain to allow it's as much for her sake as yours, that I want to take her to some port to get properly repaired. She has strained so much that her ribs are quite bent, and, lying as she does, exposed to this hot sun, her seams are bursting asunder in all directions. She is too much damaged for us to repair, so as to make it safe for you to go in her. Therefore, Madam, will you let me take her empty to St. Domingo, where I will immediately charter a vessel for your use, and leave La Luna in dock to be repaired against we come for her." "But, supposing anything was to happen; supposing she was to

founder and all hands be lost, what would become of us?" "I would not have proposed such a scheme, Madam, did I not feel sure there would be no danger of such a thing happening; and, any way, it is better you should be left on this island, for the chance of a ship coming this way, than liable to go down to the bottom of the sea, without the power of man to save you." "I am not so sure of that, captain, I think I should prefer all sinking or swimming together." "At any rate, Madam," added the captain, "having unburdened my mind, I'll leave you to sleep over the matter. Tak time to consider, and let me know your wull in the morning."

CHAPTER XII.

Not all the taking time to consider, "nor all the morns" that ever came reconciled Schillie to the captain's plan. For my part I liked it, and am free to own that I entered into all the fun, and oddities the young ones proposed to themselves in living for six weeks *al fresco*. Madame had great misgivings about the matter. She did not think lessons would prosper; the cultivation of ladylike behaviour would be very difficult—manners would be at a very low ebb—music would be utterly abolished, and she was fast approaching a declaration on Schillie's side, when Serena, by a master-stroke of policy, brought her round. "We will speak any language you like, Madame," said she, "whatever we are doing, we can always speak in the language you order us." "So you can, my love," said Madame, most benignantly, "so I desire at once that you speak French, Mondays and Thursdays; Italian, Tuesdays and Fridays; German, Wednesdays and Saturdays."

"Oh come, come," said Gatty, "that's too bad, how am I ever to get all the nonsense, that is in my head, out if I am only to talk English on Sundays."

"My dear! you ought to have no nonsense in your head."

"But there it is, Madame, and you will be very angry if I break the Sabbath, by making puns and guessing jokes all Sunday."

"My dear Gertrude, your spirits carry you quite too far."

"Then think, Madame, what they will be on Sundays if my spirits are corked up all the other six days."

"I have not the least objection to your making puns either in French, Italian, or German."

"You're extremely kind, Madame, and I should feel most grateful for such kind permission, had I the least perception how I can profit by it."

"It is my wish that you all should understand those languages equally as well as your own."

"I have no doubt, Madame, that you will always be able to wish us such proficiency."

"No doubt, my dear child, no doubt, and that is the only drawback to my pleasure on the voyage, namely the number of interruptions and constant holidays you obtain."

"You are a pert young lady, Miss Gatty," said Schillie, "and had better leave the Mother to settle with Madame; come with me and let us see what fish the boys have got for supper."

I promised Madame that regular school should be held every day, and our conversation was put an end to, by the arrival of the captain. He wanted the assistance of every body, to get La Luna afloat that evening; with infinite trouble this was done, and we were all worn out with heat and fatigue by tea-time. But La Luna floated once more, and looked as lovely and graceful on the water. We were quite enchanted with her appearance. At tea, I proposed to the captain, that when he did leave us, he should take Smart and Benjie with him, instead of their remaining with us, for I had found out from the maids, and the boys, that the captain was very anxious to have them, being doubtful about managing the ship with so few men, and it was agreed that they could be of no use to us, as we were exposed to no dangers, and they would be of infinite use to the captain, and ensure his return much sooner; much therefore to Smart's disgust it was decided that he was to be exposed once more to what he called "a ship-wrecked life." Schillie grew more reconciled to our being left on hearing this idea for she immediately took upon herself the care of us all, and the responsibility put her into some spirits on the subject. I asked when they meant to leave us. "The sooner the better," said she, "for then they will be the sooner back again." The captain said nothing, but he lingered over his tea, and told us so many things that we were to do, and to guard against, and seemed so low and oppressed, that I thought he was ill, or had over-worked himself. But he declared he was quite well, though he still repeated the same things, and he kissed and wished the little girls good-bye so often that they began to joke with him about his absence of mind. We were also all so tired, we longed to get to

bed, yet he still sipped his tea, having had, as Sybil, the tea-maker whispered, eleven cups. "And horrible stuff it is without any milk," whispered Gatty back again, "I wonder at his taste." I began to be quite affected by his manner, while the others yawned, and yawned, until I thought all their jaws would be broken. Suddenly the darkness came on, as it always did, at once, and he was roused from his musings by eager good nights. His voice sounded rather strange as he returned our salutations, while the children declared his face was wet with tears. Schillie and I wondered to ourselves what could be the matter with him, as we undressed, the children noisily felicitating themselves that every body was obliged to go to bed at the same time that they were. But we were too weary to think much about it. It was not until early morning, when rising and opening the tent door, I looked out again to see the lovely scene we had admired so much the evening before. But did my eyes deceive me! Was I awake? Where was that object which had excited our admiration so much? I uttered a cry. Schillie ran to me; all awoke, and started from their beds. Every eye was strained, but what tongue could be the first to say that La Luna was gone; far away we could see her distant sails against the clear blue sky; we were alone, alone.

CHAPTER XIII.

All was explained now that had seemed to us extraordinary in our kind captain's conduct the evening before, and as we hurried down to the beach half in hopes not to find every one gone, we found at the usual dining place, a packet of papers put in a conspicuous situation, evidently meant to attract our notice. In this was a note from the captain, apologizing for departing in such a secret manner, but declaring that unless he had stolen away he could not have left us. That it was of such importance he should go and return ere the rainy season commenced, he could not even afford a day, and that he knew, however cheerful I might talk about the matter, my heart would misgive me, when the time came for him to leave, I might not probably grant him permission to go, when it was of the most vital importance he should. He was right in his last conjecture, the dread that came over me, as I read his letter, and looked at our helpless party, made me feel how truly he had judged me, tho' I so little knew it myself. The other papers consisted of directions, lists of what he had left, and where they were put. Also an account, written from Benjie's lips, as to what trees and fruits might be poisonous, what we had better avoid, and particular orders about the night air, the musquitos; in fact he seems to have left nothing for us to think of, and the papers wound up with many sweet messages to the children, and the dear young ladies, a characteristic speech to Schillie, a hope that the good old lady would not be nervous, or keep the children too long at their lessons, which was a bad thing in hot climates, and a very urgent appeal to all to be careful of her, whose heart was wrapped up in their happiness, to whom the breath of life came ebbing and flowing, according to the welfare and goodness of her precious charge.

There was a letter from Smart to the boys as follows, the spelling being corrected:—

"HONOURED YOUNG GENTS,

"I hope this will find you, as it leaves me, in good health, but very low in my spirits. I hope you will be good honourable young gentlemen, and obey that good lady, your Mama; and also I hope you will learn your lessons, as a sight of learning is a good thing, tho' I don't rightly know who speaks them lingos as Madame talks. But, chiefly, my dear young gents, I write to say, I am very low in my spirits, and I shall have no peace until I see my dear young masters again. I have been very melancholy ever since that big worm swallowed my two dogs, and I now feel it more, as I should not have left you so uneasy in mind had they been left with you. They were rale good dogs, and would mind you, master Oscar, most as well as me. I am satisfied of one thing, that there is no beere in the hisland, and you won't be eat up, and certainly there never can be another such viper as that there, as took two dogs, swallowing Daisy. But I write, young gents, to beg you to be careful, and to mind them sharks; I have heard they swallow all things, and are particular fond of bright buttons, and jackets like yours, young masters, and also I have heard they have nine rows of teeth, so there will be no escape, like Jonah in the whale's belly. Now I charge you to be careful, woe's me, that ever I be going to leave you. My heart is just broke, but do, master Oscar, be good to your little brother, and don't put on him. He has a high spirit, and it is no doubt cantankerous, but he must be honourably treated, and there's never a finer temper to be seed.

"Well, my hand is weary of this cramping, tho' I have a deal more to say. My respectful duty to the mistress and all the ladies, and my love to the little ladies and Jane. My compliments to Mrs. Hargrave. May good angels guard my dear young masters.

"Your true sorrowful servant till death,
"T. SMART."

Leaving the others still to pore over the letters and directions, I wandered away to a shady nook, to recover the shock, only now *did* it weigh upon my mind, what a responsibility rested on my shoulders, and, for a time, I was quite overcome with the fears that took possession of my heart. How long I sat I know not, but a hand was laid on my arm, interrupting my reverie. "For what reasonable purpose are you moping here?" said Schillie. "I am very melancholy," I answered. "There is such a weight on my heart, I cannot think how I ever suffered the captain to leave." "And in the name of

all that is ridiculous why did you not stop him when you could? Now that it has become impossible, like a spoilt child you are crying for them all back again."

"Don't speak so roughly, Schillie, I am sad enough without being upbraided by you."

"I don't want to upbraid you, but you were so bent on humouring the children it was no use talking common sense to you; otherwise I could have suggested plenty of notions better than leaving a pack of women and children alone on this wretched little island, dull as ditch water."

"Then pray mention one."

"Why what could be more easy, than for us all to wait together, until some vessel came by, and getting them to take us away or take a message?"

"You adjured me in the name of all that is ridiculous, pray may I ask in the name of all that's sensible why you did not mention this before?"

"Because I saw you so bent on your own plans, and because I don't particularly care what happens so long as I am with you, and lastly because it has only just come into my head."

"Well, then, don't scold me any more, but comfort, me, Schillie." "With all my heart, should anything happen to us, it will be a great comfort to think that the captain will come and take away our bones to England, and give them decent burial."

"How cruel you are, Schillie."

"But I am quite in the dark as to what you expect will happen; you are crying your eyes out for some misfortune, but, unless you tell me what you fear, how can I comfort you?"

"I fear so many things; here we are all alone, without a single efficient person amongst us." "Pray speak for yourself."

"Well! then, only you with a spark of courage amongst us; and we don't know what may be here."

"Now, that's nonsense, you know that there is scarcely a fly on the island that will do you harm."

"Well, then, those sharks!"

"And, who is going to walk into the mouth of a shark, I should be glad to know?"

"Nobody, certainly, but supposing a ship should come?"

"Then, we should have company, and a mighty good thing too. I think the society of women and children very mawkish for a continuance."

"But, then, supposing they should not be friends."

"Then that will be their own faults, we are not likely to quarrel with them."

"Stupid you are, Schillie! Don't you understand that they may take advantage of such a helpless party, and, if they are slavers may seize us, and sell us for slaves, and, if they are marauders or pirates they may murder or marry us!!!"

"Well! of those two latter fates one is as bad the other. But, I will comfort you by saying, nobody will want to marry you with that red nose. Really if you go on fretting in this manner, you'll wear yourself into an old hag. I see grey hairs and wrinkles springing up like mushrooms."

"Now, I'll return good for evil, and tell you that I never saw you looking so well; your eyes are quite dazzling, and, as for your figure, it has become slim and handsome."

"You may amuse yourself as you like about my dumpy figure, so long as you smile and are merry; but, come, wash your face in the brook, and let us join the rest. If the girls were to see you with that face they would screech beyond stopping; and, as for Madame, she would go into such a fit we should never be able to bring her round."

So I washed my face, but, in the middle of the business, said Schillie, "You never told me what we should do if pirates and slaves come?"

"Do! Why, of course we would do the best we could. Wait till they come, and then see if we don't do something. For my part I am not going to be sold for a slave, and, as for a pirate's wife, there will be two words about that matter. I don't intend to darn any one's stockings, and I hate ordering dinner, both of which events occur, I suppose, in the establishments of pirates, as well as more homely folk. Come, don't be absurd, we have only six weeks to stay here, and we'll enjoy ourselves as much as we can."

"Very well, I won't bother you any more, but we will join the others, and settle what everybody is to do to pass away the time."

"Pooh! pooh! the time will pass quick enough. Why need ye fuss? But, if we have regular habits so much the better for the girls."

"Nonsense, let the poor girls lead the life of larks for a change, they will never have such another opportunity. You and I will always be together, and you shall talk to me, and Madame may ruralize on that green terrace with her book and big parasol; depend upon it we shall be happy."

"Now, it is my turn to say pooh! pooh! Don't you know that even the larks have to work to get them food?"

"Oh certainly, that I allow. I have no objection to help myself. I can cook a beefsteak and make lobster salad against any one."

"First catch your beefsteak and lobster, saith Mrs. Glass. But here are Madame and the girls."

"We are quite lost without our Mothers," said the girls as they sprang towards us. "Here's Madame, wanting us to do lessons," said Gatty, sending her great thumb right through her handkerchief. "I never heard of gipsies saying lessons and we are now no better than gipsies," said Serena.

"Or people at a pic-nic," said Sybil. "Madame, the next six weeks must be one great pic-nic; do consent, now do; we will sketch if you like, and sing songs, and eat and drink for ever."

"Saucy girls," said Madame, smiling most kindly on them, "but I am sure your Mama would not allow such thorough waste of time," assuming a slight austerity of manner.

"Oh yes she will, Madame," said Schillie, "so betake yourselves off girls, wherever you choose, provided you don't come and bother us."

"Leave them alone, Madame," said I, in answer to her beseeching looks at me, "let them have their own way for a day or two, and you will find them come to you and beg for a dose of the multiplication table."

"Now, that's very comfortable, girls, you have leave to go to the moon if you choose, and, Madame, I'll go for your parasol and book, and you can amuse yourself on that sunny bank, watching us all," said Schillie.

But Madame was much more easily disposed of than the girls, in spite of Schillie's broad hints, and, at last, open remonstrances, that they would go about their own business, not one would stir.

"What's the use of a holiday, unless we may spend it with our Mothers?" said Sybil.

"That's all that we want a holiday for," said Serena, "that we may be with you all day."

"Yes," said Gatty, "this is most jolly, and now you may have one side of the big Mother, and Sybil shall have the other; Serena shall sit behind her, and I'll sit here," throwing herself down at our feet with such force that we both sprang up with pain.

"How do you like this lark's life?" said I, laughing.

"Good lack, girls, do you mean to say that you are going to be such geese, as to sit here all day? Have you no curiosity to examine those caves, no wish to discover figs and plums, no ambition to get on the top of that rock?"

"No," said Sybil, "our curiosity is at a low ebb, our wishes are quite fulfilled at being seated here, and we have no ambition but to remain."

"Indeed, Miss Sybil, your tongue runs very glibly, but if you think I am going to stand the bore of the company of you girls all day you are mistaken, and, good lack, look at my handkerchief, with a hole in it a dog could get through."

"Indeed, I beg your pardon, little Mother," said Gatty, reddening all over, "I thought it was mine."

"And, does that make the matter any better? Can't you employ your fingers any better than making holes in your handkerchiefs?"

"It's a way larks have," said I.

Schillie rose up in a huff.

"Come," said I, "let us all go and have a dip in the sea."

We all agreed to this, and we also agreed we would make an extensive bathing place, where we could learn to swim, and yet be out of harm from the sharks. In this matter every one helped. We rolled stones down to the water, and then, placed them so as to form a wall or pier into the sea, at twenty yards distance; from that we made another, and we sloped them so as to make their ends nearly meet. "Thus," as Oscar said, "leaving only room for a baby shark to get in."

"And we shall not mind that," said Zoë, "for it would not have cut its teeth."

It took us two or three days to do this, but that evening at tea, being heartily fatigued, we agreed to sit still and talk over all we should do.

"Oscar and I intend to fish all day," said Felix, "and you may be very much obliged to us, because it's very—"

"Very what, Felix," said his sister, who loved to tease him, "very tiresome, I suppose you mean."

"No; not tiresome exactly, but very fatiguing."

"Oh very fatiguing indeed, I dare say, and you know you would cry like a baby if any one prevented you fishing."

"Lilly, you are so aggravating, I wish Winny was my sister, that I do, for she is so kind, and it's hard the only sister I have should tease me in this manner."

The faithful Jenny was at hand to take the part of each, and please both, while she put an end to the dispute.

"But, Mama," said Lilly, "if the boys do nothing but fish all day, may we little girls pick up shells; ah you cannot think what lovely shells there are; I am going to make a collection, and I should like to class them all, and, by the time La Luna comes back, I want to have hundreds and hundreds, and I will take them to ornament my garden, or they will look lovely arranged all round the big hall; or, Mama, dear, we might make a grotto, think how lovely it would be! So let us little girls do nothing but pick up shells. Do, dear Mama, do let us?"

"What a little tongue you have, child. Do you think Zoë and Winny would like to do nothing but pick up shells?"

"I am sure I should not," said Zoë. "I must say I rather think, but I am not quite sure, that I shall not like it all day either," said Winny.

"We'll settle that important question soon, but at present I wish to propound to the company at large whether you think Hargrave and Jenny can wait on us all, without a little help?"

"Oh yes, Ma'am," said the smiling Jenny, "we can do well enough if Master Felix does not wet his feet too often, and the little ladies will do their own hair."

"I shall be happy to assist Jane, Ma'am, in any way I can after I have waited on you," said Hargrave.

"I thank you, Hargrave," said I, "but I must do without the waiting on, we must wait on each other."

"I hope not, Ma'am, I have always endeavoured to give you satisfaction, and should not like seeing any one wait on you but myself."

"Yes, yes, all that I understand, but—"

"I beg your pardon, Ma'am, but I cannot think of stopping with you, Ma'am, if any one else, Ma'am, is to be put above me, or take my place."

Hargrave was proceeding, in increased agitation and heat, when Gatty interrupted the business by repeated peals of laughter.

"Pray, pray, Gertrude, refrain, how very unladylike; you laugh like a great cow-boy," said Madame.

"I like Gatty's laughs, they are so merry," said Oscar, "but what are you laughing at?"

"Why at Hargrave to be sure, giving warning here, on this desert island."

"Who will you go to, Hargrave, if you leave your present mistress? The Duchess of Puddleduck? Lady Ape? or Baroness Shark? Ha! ha! my dear girls, did you ever hear anything so absurd?"

"Indeed, Miss Gertrude, I wonder at your manners to a poor servant like me, but I am not going to be put upon any how."

"And who was going to put upon you, my good woman? I meant nothing but that we must all help each other, and that there was no occasion for you to wait upon me as heretofore, while we are in this island."

Slightly mollified, she grumbled out "That it was certainly no use plaiting one's hair in such a place."

"Now, Schillie, what charge will you take?"

"Take! You mean do as I bid you."

"Then, if that's the case, you shall be caterer."

"No, no, that I protest against. Under no circumstances can I undertake dinner, though I fancy one has no great variety here. I'll look after your pet boys, and see that neither of them drown themselves fishing, and I'll take charge of the guns, powder, and shot, and any little odd things requiring to be done I am ready to be called on to help."

"Very good. And you, Madame?" I gave her a warning glance not to say anything about lessons, so, after a pause, she said, "I will undertake to prepare the table for meals, and collect fruit and flowers, with the help of my three little ones."

"Thank you very much, that will be very kind, and now you elder girls!"

"Oh! we'll do as we are bid, except lessons," said Gatty.

"Then, Gatty and Serena, you must always bring the water from the brook morning and evening, and you, Sybil, must see that the children are tidy and that the things all put away in the tent, and you must, all three, help Jenny to wash up the things, and put them in their places tidy. And now then we will all disperse, until eleven o'clock, when Jenny must give us dinner as usual, and then we will all take siesta, and in the evening we shall be ready for no end of fun and mischief. Our dinner may seem somewhat early, but then we were obliged to be up very early to enjoy the cool part of the day." But I will begin my next chapter with a description of our doings.

CHAPTER XIV.

The first person that awoke in the morning generally rose and opened the tent letting in the fresh sea breeze. This might be between two and three in the morning, and always the most refreshing part of the whole day. The first bathing party then went down to the sea, consisting of Schillie, the three girls, Madame, and myself. Before we were well out of the water, and finishing our toilettes under the tent, the boys used to come rushing down with Jenny in attendance, who was always fearing her heedless Master Felix would get into danger. Finally the three little girls, with both the maids, habited in readiness to dip the unwilling ones, finished the morning ablutions.

Afterwards we all proceeded to the great chestnut tree, where we had prayers, the morning psalms, and lessons, and sung a hymn, which sounded in that lone but lovely spot so soft and beautiful that it used to bring tears to my eyes. So many young voices, gave a peculiar flute-like sound to the music, and as each cadence rose swelling through the branches of the great tree above us, so did the birds rise in clouds above us, returning nearer and nearer, as the soft voices died away, at the end of each verse. And to look at each young face uplifted with fresh sweet feelings of piety and love to me seemed a picture of what we might see hereafter in that other and brighter world, "which eye hath not seen, neither hath it entered into the heart of man to conceive." The fair blooming face of Sybil contrasted well with the brilliant dark eyes and fine countenance of Gertrude, while the slight statue-like form of the graceful Serena, with her small head and beautiful throat bent over her book, completed their picture. And a smaller group stood beside them equally pretty to look at, equally wrapt up in the solemn duty they were performing. The taller Zoë in the middle, her black hair drawn from her fair and lovely profile, one little hand resting, on the pretty sparkling Winifred whose arch look was sobered into childish gravity, a pretty demureness hiding the merry blue eyes, and leaving long curling dark eyelashes to veil her cheeks; while on the other side, hanging or leaning, or

both, stood Lilly, her long black curls swept in every direction, and falling in rich masses over all three as the wind listed to blow them, the prettiest face in the world, peeping from between the dishevelled locks, with rosy mouth parted, and violet eyes upraised to heaven, as she sang with bird-like clearness above the rest.

The bright sun, the glowing sky, the brilliant flowers, the rich shade of the dark chestnut tree, all cast their lights and shadows on these two pretty groups as they stood before us, adding beauty to both.

The last verse being sung, all dispersed to their different duties, and the birds were now startled by the bursts of merry laughter that came from each group. Madame, with Sybil and her three little maidens, prepared the breakfast. Gatty and Serena ran for water, the maids put the tents to rights, the boys lighted the fire. Schillie and I sat looking on, acting company. I with admiring eyes, on the lovely scenery and pretty figures, she with inquisitive looks, scanning each unknown plant, moss, bird, or stone, and conjecturing their names and qualities. A little clamouring below, as to who was to blow a great shell that Benjie had taught them how to use, prepared us two idle ones for the summons to breakfast, of which we all partook with great hilarity and content, the grumblings for want of milk, having ceased partly because they were not attended to, and partly because all the grumbling in the world obtained none. After breakfast, I settled with Jenny the difficult question of dinner, which generally consisted of fish, potatoes, and pudding, sometimes a little salt meat, sometimes a little fresh meat, out of the tin cases we had brought. But invariably we had a magnificent dessert, so that the children could eat nothing for thinking of what was coming. That important matter done, I joined the rest. Madame betook herself to her green parasol and terrace, with a dignified but compassionate air, as if the young ones did not know what they were losing, in preferring play to lessons. The three little girls in high delight went to collect that indispensable quantity of shells, that was deemed necessary to ornament all they wished at home. The two good boys prepared with the gravity necessary for so important a business, to fish for our dinner, speculating upon what bait the fish would take that particular morning, and what they would not. To which we listened in solemn propriety, though well aware all the time they jumped at a bit of red worsted, as much as any other thing.

But the three elder ones did not care for picking up shells, and could not abide fishing. It was too hot to work, too sunny to read. They wanted to sit all day long in the pockets of the two Mothers, the elder one telling them stories, and the younger one making quaint remarks thereon, thereby spoiling many a sentimental speech, and upsetting many a romantic idea, but causing plenty of fun and merriment. But that could not last all day. Though we dined at eleven, it still wanted two good hours thereto. The big Mother was tired of telling tales; the little Mother was weary with doing nothing. All this time the green parasol meandered up and down, now and then sitting down to rest, and bending towards the girls with an unmistakeable look, that seemed to say, "come to your lessons, pray come to your lessons." But, the green parasol nodded in vain. At last after a fit of yawning, we all went botanizing, but that was very provoking work, for we could not tell the names of the lovely flowers and trees we found. Sybil suggested giving them our own names. Serena nearly broke her neck, climbing an almost inaccessible crag, and Gatty tore her frock every five minutes.

By this time the conch-shell sounded for dinner, in doing which Jenny blew her cheeks into the colour of a peony, we were all hot and tired and not in a very good humour.

The more we shewed this, the more gracious and cheerful Madame became, the little girls had been quite happy, the boys had wonders to relate as to the strange creatures that came peeping up at them from the deep as they were fishing. Lilly hopes they were not mermaids, for she had heard they were very cruel, and enticed men down into the dark sea weed caverns, from whence they never more appeared.

Felix.—"They will never catch me doing anything so silly. I like Mama better than twenty thousand mermaids, and so I won't be ticed, Lilly."

Lilly.—"Enticed, my dear boy, you mean, and that signifies that you cannot help yourself. They will carry you down into the sea, full of great polypuses, with a hundred blood red arms."

Oscar.—"Lilly, you are talking great stuff, no mermaids shall ever catch Felix or me, I shall shoot them first. And besides I won't believe there are any mermaids."

Gatty.—"And also besides, if they did come up from the sea, and look at Otty and Felix, I don't think they would steal them away from us, without a great battle on our parts."

"But," said Lilly, who always stuck pertinaciously to her text, "I have read it in a book, that they comb their long, sea-green hair, and sing all the time so beautifully, that men jump into the sea after them."

Felix.—"Well! I shall not do that, for green hair must be very ugly."

Oscar.—"And you need not bother about it any more, Lilly, for I hate singing."

Felix.—"And we must take care of ourselves, because we are the only two men you have got to take care of you all."

Sybil.—"Ah! indeed that is very true, you must be very careful, because what should we do without our protectors."

Felix.—"Yes, but, Aunt Sib, don't you think it is very wrong of Lilly to frighten us. Pray tell us, do mermaids really steal men away?"

Schillie.—"What is all this nonsense about mermaids, eh? Felix." She was told; then added, "Don't alarm yourselves, if an army of mermaids were to come, they would not take either of you for men; so comfort yourself, my boys, with that notion."

As most of the party agreed with her the subject dropped. After dinner we all took a siesta for two or three hours, a necessary rest during the heat of the day. Afterwards the same scene occurred as before dinner the "green parasol" meandered up and down, the little ones ran about, being now assisted by the boys, the elder ones hung about us two until tea-time, when all had some employment again. Afterwards we chatted and worked until the sun went down. This sometimes occurred so suddenly that we had to run like lapwings, from the great chestnut down to the tents, in order to scramble into bed before it was quite dark. So passed the first few days, I purposely proposing neither work nor any employment that the girls might be thoroughly sickened of idleness. Each day, however, the "green parasol" became more elevated, the measured tread more majestic. Madame was getting seriously angry, having no idea that their love of idleness would last

so long. Even to me monosyllables only were vouchsafed, and matters assumed a lowering aspect. Schillie's temper had been gone two days, and she was at open war with the three girls, extremely cross with me that I did not order them away, though too proud to acknowledge it. Sybil had taken refuge in books, and was always so deeply immersed in her stories and novels, that she could think of nothing else. Her wits were anywhere but where they ought to have been, and she was of no use to any one. Serena was making a child of herself, with the little ones, which pleased them very much, and gave her some employment for her useless activity. As for Gatty, having nothing else to do, she was in every boy's way. When every handkerchief she had was full of holes, she proceeded to destroy other people's private property. The "green parasol" having been inadvertently left alone for a short time, was used as a mark to throw stones at, and, ere its owner appeared to rescue it, had several great holes in it. An offer to assist the boys in their fishing tackle caused inextricable confusion amongst their work. The necessity of making some use of such restless activity occasioned Jenny to be gratuitously assisted in cooking the dinner, which ended in there being nothing eatable that day. Cross with Serena because she would make a baby of herself with the little ones, angry with Sybil because she was buried in silly stories, irate with the little Mother because she had called her a great plague, afraid of the big Mother because she looked so gravely at her, not on speaking terms with any of the little ones for various misdemeanours, the poor Gatty wandered up and down on a particular evening (the fourth day) like a perturbed young elephant shut up in a cage. She wanted something to do, and she glanced around each party to see which she might venture to join. The "green parasol" was to be avoided at all rates, the two Mothers had forbidden her approach for an hour. Jenny had declined a kitchen maid's help with a stammering apology that clearly told why. She was too proud to join those who had called her cross. Sybil sat alone; her feet almost in the stream, her head buried in her book, so absorbed that she saw and heard nothing. Gatty approached her from above, and, being obliged to do something, saw at one glance a most beautiful opportunity of startling Sybil out of her studies, and became quite exhilarated with the work. With a little trouble she moved some stones, made a channel in the sand, and in a few minutes a rippling stream ran down it, gathering force as it went, and, stopping for neither stick nor stone, dashed upon Sybil, as if animated with Gatty's own spirit of mischief. Up

she jumped, her cry of surprise being in chorus with Gatty's shriek of delight. Thoroughly roused, her usual meek spirit gave way, she threw down her book, sprang towards the aggressor, her fair face blushed with anger, her dark eyes flashing indignantly. So nimble was she, that she was almost upon the delighted culprit ere she restrained her laughter. In endeavouring to avoid the injured one her foot slipped, over she rolled just as Sybil reached her, and down they both went into the brook, rolling over and over several times.

Having watched the whole business from our resting place, we were down at the spot, ere they had recovered themselves, and risen from the water.

The conch-shell sounded for tea, at the same moment, and in a high state of excitement, every body talking their loudest we all adjourned. Then every body opened their hearts. I confessed I had let them be so idle, in order to make them resume their lessons with pleasure and zest. Schillie allowed she was very wrong to take them from their books, which were much better for them than idling about and bothering her. Madame had wondered at my permitting such disorderly doings, as had been going on from day to day, but would excuse it as I seemed to have a motive, and the young ladies were penitent. Sybil confessed she was tired of reading so much, and would much prefer doing something rational. Serena said she and the little ones had been privately learning something, just to employ themselves. Gatty alone still declared it was a great shame to do lessons in this hot climate, but she would not mind music and summing. Zoë and Winny joyfully agreed to learn anything, so that they might have something to do. Lilly made a stipulation about having time to pick up shells, before she finally capitulated; and the boys having been very good up to this minute, neither troublesome or quarrelsome, but on the contrary very useful, turned round completely, became naughty and rude, declaring that lessons were humbug, French a bore, German a nuisance, and almost openly declaring a complete rebellion.

This mutiny of course was quelled, we retired to bed in harmony and good humour, and rose the next morning determined to do our best, to be industrious and useful. Madame was in high spirits. Schillie most benign. The boys happy in the privilege of not having to go to their studies until an hour after the girls, and to do part of them with the Mothers. The girls all in

high spirits, so that when the conch-shell sounded twice as indicative that school time had commenced, great alacrity was shown on all sides, and good humour reigned supreme.

CHAPTER XV.

"Now then," said I to the little Mother, "what are you and I to do with ourselves."

Schillie.—"Oh, I am perfectly comfortable, now that we are not to be plagued with those girls. Let us sit down here, and now you shall talk to me."

Mother.—"I don't intend to do anything of the sort; I said, 'What shall we do?' merely to know if you had any private business on hand. Because if you have not, I have."

Schillie.—"I have nothing in the world to do, and I have not the least inclination to exert myself, and I won't allow you to do anything either, in spite of your private business."

Mother.—"Nevertheless, whether you help me or not, I am going to build a little hut."

Schillie.—"Good lack! if you are not mad to think of such a thing! I am gasping with heat, and really melt away so fast, on the slightest exertion, and have such indifferent dinners to make amends, that if the captain does not arrive precisely to his date, my skin will be a bag containing nothing but rattling bones."

Mother.—"Don't distress yourself, you look very jolly yet, and if those cannibals come, of whom Madame is so afraid, you will be the first delicate morsel chosen, I am certain. But about this hut."

Schillie.—"Don't, June, you will kill me outright if you mention such hard work again. Let us go and botanize a bit. Did you ever see such a fellow as this! He must be a plantain I think."

Mother.—"Yes! these are the broad leaves that will roof our hut!"

Schillie.—"You will drive me mad with your hut, who wants a hut? and what is the good of putting ourselves into a fever, spoiling our hands, and such like, merely for your whims. Let us go round that point, and see if any turtle land on this island. I am sure it will be a blessing to have something decent to eat."

Mother.—"I shall be delighted to go, but I think we shall dirty our hands much more slaughtering a great turtle than building a nice little hut."

Schillie.—"Now, Mrs. June, if you bother me any more about that hut, I won't stir one finger to help you."

Mother.—"Oh, so you will help me, well! that's all I want, so sit down here while I tell you all about my hut."

She made some ineffectual efforts to escape, was very indignant, stormed, and spluttered, and wound up by saying, "Well! now, my Mistress, what do you wish me to do?" which was exactly the state into which I had intended to bully her. "You know how hot we are in the tent every night," said I. "Good me! and those horrid girls snoring and talking, one worse than another, to say nothing of someone who shall be nameless snoring like ten pigs." "That snorer is not me, I flatter myself, so make no more remarks, but listen, you see I have brought you to a very pretty little spot on the cliffs, and here are six or seven nice little trees, that look so pliant and slender we can bend them into any shape, but you are not listening."

Schillie.—"I wonder what trees these are. They all seem to proceed from the same mass of roots, and yet they are nearly in the form of a square; leaves, shiny, dark, green, pinnated, I cannot make them out."

Mother.—"What does it matter to us about their names and property, if they will do for us to make our hut."

Schillie.—"And how can you imagine that I can make a hut or live in it, until I have found out the name of these trees."

So we were nearly coming to a rupture again, but waiting patiently until she had exhausted every idea on the subject we set to work once more. "You see these trees are in the form of a square already, and will just mark out the size of our hut."

"Yes very well for me, but if our hut has a window you will have to lay with your head out of it, or if a door with your feet ditto."

Mother.—"Come don't be rude about my length of limb. The square is quite seven feet this way, and we may make it double that the other way by cutting down this one tree."

Schillie.—"I wish I knew what those two trees are."

Mother.—"Then we can twist these pliant sort of reeds in and out."

Schillie.—"Reeds, June! those are not reeds, I wonder what these are? They must be all of the same family, only these are young ones. Something of the willow sort, I imagine."

Mother.—"Well! we can twist them in and out between the stems."

Schillie.—"Or perhaps they are a species of gigantic rush, but that we shall know by the flower."

Mother.—"Twist them in and out like basket work."

Schillie.—"I wish you would cease with your twistings in and out, and help me to guess what these things are."

Mother.—"My dear, I have guessed long ago, and think I am quite right too in my guess."

Schillie.—"And why are you so unkind as not to tell me? you know how anxious I am."

Mother.—"I am quite surprised that you did not see at once, they are only gigantic 'fighting cocks,' as we used to call plantain in our youth."

Schillie.—"You are the greatest——, well! I won't say what with your fighting cocks. Come, go on about your blessed old hut."

Mother.—"But it is not an old hut, inasmuch as it is not built yet, or even begun, nor does it seem likely to be begun, as we have quarrelled three times over merely of what it is to be made."

Schillie.—"Then now I won't trouble you any more, I will think of nothing but this hut, and will do whatever you bid me. But you must promise me, that if I help you, that no one else is to share it with us. I won't have any fidgety girls, or sick boys to come and wear one to death with their nonsense."

Mother.—"Pooh, pooh, you know who will be the first to invite them in, however, I only mean it for us two."

So to work we set, and in a short time had so changed our relative positions, that I was scolded for not working hard enough, and having entered thoroughly into the business, she took the command, and I willingly obeyed her sage orders. She had a capital head for contrivance, and consequently treated some of my suggestions with scorn and indifference. In fact, my notion of "twisting in and out" so often mentioned, was immediately pronounced as a trap for musquitos, scorpions, and such like. We were to have our hut made partly of boughs, partly of sods, partly of mud. This was to keep it cool. Over all we placed the large smooth plantain leaves and it really did not look amiss, but something like the little round mushroom huts of the charcoal burners. It took us four days to complete it. We told nobody until it was finished; then, of course everybody wanted to sleep in it. The size of the hut spoke the best answer. At each end we had nailed a strip of sail-cloth, which served for the bed on which to lie, and, wrapped up in a sheet, it was very cool and comfortable. Though Schillie was very uneasy for the first hour, and, upon my remonstrating, muttered, half asleep, "I wish I knew what these trees were."

We satisfied the eager wishers, by promising to help to make huts for all who liked it, and, for the next week, as soon as school hours were over, every minute was employed in this new business. Madame alone preferred the tent, and soon had it to herself. From the sand the little colony of huts looked quite picturesque, perched upon little green knolls or terraces, and great improvements were made, so that ours looked quite a little vulgar affair in comparison to the ornamented mansions which soon appeared. The little ones had now good use for their shells, and the tasteful Sybil and Serena ornamented theirs with fresh flowers every day, and transplanted creepers and other things to train all over their abode.

We found amongst our stores a packet of garden seeds, I having desired the gardener before we left home to put some up, for I had heard that we could grow mustard and cress, endive and parsley, and even lettuces on board, and that it would be a very good thing for the children. Not having specified what I really wanted, on opening the packet we found every species of seed that a kitchen garden would require, and though we laughed at the parcels of beans and peas, and other things impossible to be grown on board, also carrots and turnips, yet they were most opportune in amusing the young ones, for every one must have a garden round their abode, and it was quite surprising to see how quickly the seeds sprang up. In fact, we had so much to amuse us, that a month passed ere we thought one week had gone, and the life we were leading seemed to agree with us all, especially the children. Oscar's fine open countenance bloomed with health, and he grew so manly and tall that we treated him with great respect as the King of the Island, while the small little delicate features of Felix were getting embrowned, fast losing their delicacy; his beautiful starlike eyes were radiant with health, and through the long dark eyelashes, so peculiar to that species of deep grey eye, the pretty pink colour seemed to be fixing its residence there at last.

CHAPTER XVI.

The girls being very much absorbed in their gardens, Schillie and I took a scramble one day round the point she had wished to go when we commenced building our hut. We privately told the servants if we were not at home to dinner, to explain the cause, and not to expect us until tea-time.

It was very hard work, but when we had accomplished it, we came to another bay, not so pretty as ours, but much more extensive. There were scarcely any cliffs, but the great trees came bending down to the water's edge in many places. Here Schillie gave full scope to her enquiring mind, and we progressed at the rate of twenty yards every half hour, while she exhausted herself in vain conjectures without end. Going over the rocks, among the caverns and crevices we found a curious creeping plant, the stems trailing two or three feet long, the leaves were rather oval, of a bright green, and the flowers large beautiful white ones, each composed of four petals tinged with red. At last from the unopened buds being so like capers, we tasted them, and they were so sharp and as acid as we could wish. So we decided they were, or rather it was the caper plant, and while Schillie felicitated herself upon having settled that matter satisfactorily, she groaned over the notion of our having no boiled mutton.

The next thing we discovered was a bright green shrub, apparently an evergreen, with bunches of white flowers, which were sweet scented. There being no seeds formed, we were sometime in making it out to be the coffee tree, but Schillie remembered once seeing a coffee plant at Chatsworth. So she was in high spirits until we came to another shrub with purple and white flowers. Some of the green leaves were exceedingly light, and some nearly black, and they almost seemed to be turning colour, as we looked at them.

We wasted a whole hour over this shrub and a tree close by rather small with foliage like a birch. It had fruit somewhat like a hop, only very much larger.

We now came to an immense Banana tree, out of which flew a cloud of blueish pigeons. The leaves of this Banana looked six or seven feet long and about one wide; the fruit was hanging in every direction, looking like large misshapen cucumbers. Benjie had taught us not to cut it crossways, but from end to end, as it tasted better when cut wrong. But it was curious when cut wrong what an exact cross was pictured in the middle. Twined in the Banana tree was an immense gourd plant. At this minute I shuddered with horror. We had been so secure, so careless, so utterly unmindful of any danger that I was quite unnerved at seeing a huge thing three or four feet long drop from the Banana, close between us. "Keep back, keep back," said Schillie, "I have got my hatchet." But she never could bear to kill anything, so we looked on the creature, and it on us. It was very ugly and formidable to look at, but it had a quiet eye, and after a little while it crawled gently away, and commenced trying to get up the tree again. "I think it must be an iguana," said I at last.

"Whatever it is I admire its civility," said Schillie.

"If it is they are quite harmless, though he looks very horrible," said I.

"He does not intend to harm us, it appears, so we will go on," said Schillie, "because I begin to feel very hungry, and we had better look out for a comfortable spot on which to dine."

"I have been hungry more than an hour, but you were so absorbed in your discoveries you would not listen to my hints. I should like to go to that little knoll, in which those four cocoa-nut trees stand, we shall have a little air then, and can see any danger all round, and, perchance find a cocoa-nut."

"Which you may have all to yourself, June, for I think them unwholesome things."

After a dinner and a successful nutting, I proposed a siesta, as it was impossible to move during the sultry noon, which Schillie agreed to provided I went to sleep first, whilst she watched for an hour, then she was to waken me, and I was to watch in my turn.

After a profound sleep of some duration I awoke, and found my guard in a helpless state of somnambulism, which was so very deep I did not like to disturb her; neither could I move, as the better to guard me she was lying

half over me, I, therefore, though anxious about the time we had been sleeping, decided to sit still and wait until she showed some signs of waking. She had the watch round her neck, and I could not look at it without disturbing her, so I amused myself with watching the curious and strange things around me. I noticed some black things in the water, which came nearer and nearer, and I gave a start of pleasure when I perceived that they must be turtle; at last one landed and crawled in the most extraordinary manner some way up the sands. After spending what I thought was half an hour in the oddest movements and vagaries for such an unwieldy thing as a turtle to indulge in, it returned to the sea, and was the only one that landed. The sleeper at last moved, and I roused her up. At first she declared she had not been asleep at all, but when time and circumstances made that assertion untenable, she fell back upon the excuse that it was so dull sitting there with no one to talk to, and nothing to do, and, besides, her thoughts were very melancholy.

June.—"Your thoughts melancholy! That's the first time, then, since I have known you."

Schillie.—"I was thinking of my poor little children, and how wrong I was to go and leave them all."

June.—"But you have not yet been away from them half the time, or, indeed, one-third of what was originally intended, when we left England."

Schillie.—"I know that quite well, but, if you will go to sleep, and leave me to my own dull thoughts, how can I help thinking of my being so ill-behaved as to leave them for such a period."

June.—"It was you that made me go to sleep first. But, however, I must comfort you, and remind you how kind your father is to them, and how your mother's sole business in life is to see that they have double as much as they ought to have. And how your sister, that best of Kittie's, is more than a mother to them; indeed most strangers take her for their mother, and you for an unnatural sort of aunt."

Schillie.—"Well, that may be true, June, but you should not upbraid me with it now I am so sad; I don't pretend to be a fond mother, but I hope I am a good one."

June.—"Come! don't be so horribly pathetic; it does not suit you at all, but, if you are really very unhappy, the captain will be here in ten days or so, and then we will all go home."

Schillie.—"But, how do I know if we may not all be drowned in going home, or have a fire at sea, or something should occur which will prevent me ever seeing my little chicks again," and the great tears rolled one by one down her round blooming cheeks.

This was getting a most serious business, so I said in an angry manner as it were, "You are too absurd! just as if every day when at home you don't put your life into imminent danger, riding that frangy beast, who every ten yards has either his heels or his toes in the air."

Schillie.—"Heels and toes! Whoever heard a horse spoken of in such terms? And after all the pains I have taken with your equine education, to talk in such terms of a little playfulness! I would not give two-pence to ride a horse that goes straight along."

June.—"I should not call that playful riding to come home with one's hands all blistered from holding the animal in. For my part, I never saw you go down the carriage road, on that beast Staunton, with his tail flying and his legs anywhere but on the road, without preparing my nerves for seeing your mangled remains brought home on a shutter."

Schillie.—"Mangled fiddlesticks! Did you ever see such a butterfly? Don't catch it; you'll hurt it. There, it is settled now. I wonder what his name is?"

So her thoughts being diverted we wandered on, the heat dried the big tears, and we made many grand discoveries; amongst others, that the rocks were wholly composed of coral.

But, before we left the spot, without telling her that I had seen the turtle, we went to the place I had seen it throwing up the sand, and, upon examination, found a great quantity of eggs. For some time Schillie would not believe that I had seen a turtle, or that these were turtle's eggs. However we kept our eyes on the black specks on the water, and, turning a corner of the bay, we came upon a whole colony of turtles, all on shore. I was afraid at first to run after them and turn them, and Schillie could not manage it by herself, so that ere I had conquered my reluctance they all got away from her but one,

which we turned over all right, and nothing was more ridiculous than to see the poor hideous creature sprawling and straggling with ineffectual efforts. But we could not lift it by any means, and Schillie felt half inclined to let it go again, as it would be exposed so many hours to the broiling sun, ere we could come back with the others to despatch it. So we covered it over with Banana leaves, fastening them safe over the poor beast with bits of wood stuck through the leaves into the sand; and there we left it, making our way homewards over the rocks. The moment we appeared on the top seemed the signal for a general commotion amongst our people, and they all came running round the bay to meet us; Gatty reached us first, followed closely by Serena. They could not speak, they were so completely out of breath; but the first thing Gatty could say was a vehement reproach for leaving them all day. They had been so dull, and, coming out of school they had rushed immediately to join the two Mothers, and had found none; and the dinner was so stupid, and the lessons had been so tiresome, and Madame had been so particular, and it had been so hot; in fact, all had gone wrong.

But we were soon very merry at tea, all except Madame, who looked a little stately; and, after tea, she said she had a complaint to make against a certain person, for misconduct during my absence.

She was interrupted by Gatty's jumping up, and saying. "Oh yes! yes! such a glorious thing happened, it was so killing!—"

"Gertrude, you shock me," said Madame, "to talk of so grave a misdemeanour, in such terms."

"Indeed! Madame, I cannot help it. I never laughed so much in my life. Did you, Sib? Did you, Serena?"

Whereupon all the girls, big and little, tittered and laughed according to their different natures, and I felt relieved. But I was convinced that Felix was the culprit he was so red, and, while his brother rolled on the sand with merriment, he said nothing.

But Madame was so very grave, and seemed really so annoyed, that the laughing ceased, except when Gatty burst into a fresh fit, though she was cramming her handkerchief into her mouth, and that set Oscar off too.

"The young gentlemen came to their lessons in very good time," proceeded Madame, "and Master Oscar immediately proceeded to learn his Latin declensions and to little Felix I gave a short lesson in French, out of that small book which, as you know, Madam, contained a page or two of first French lessons for young beginners." I nodded as much as to say I knew the book. "And then, Madam, as he was so giddy and volatile, I put him under the table to learn it, with the cloth all round him, that his attention might be distracted by nothing that he saw."

Here the tittering was vehement. "He was I must acknowledge, very quiet and good, so much so, that perhaps it was half an hour ere I called him to say it." Here Gatty became convulsed. Oscar in a similar state, and not all Madame's gravity could restrain the others.

"You may imagine my surprise, Madam, when I found the book gone, he had it not. In vain I made him look for it, nay, I acknowledge that I went down on my knees under the table to look for it also, thinking he must be telling an untruth, in saying it was not there. I could find it nowhere, neither can I find it now, and though I have made him confess what he did with it, yet, I assure you, Madam, the matter seems so extraordinary to me, I beg you will ask him yourself." In spite of the laughter, I called Felix, and with a half impudent air, emboldened by his companion's merriment, half frightened at what I might say. He said in a low clear voice, "Mama, I ate it!"

Mother.—"Ate it, child!"

Felix.—"Yes, Mama, I ate it every bit."

Madame sat down in triumph; the young ones made the air sound with their laughter; Jenny looked appealingly to me. Schillie said, "What a nasty boy." I exclaimed in horror and wonder, "Good heavens! suppose it disagrees with him." This frightful notion spread; Jenny took to tears—Madame was quite affected—Schillie recommended an emetic—Hargrave rushed to put it in force—and Felix was overwhelmed with questions as to what he felt; had he a pain?—where was his pain?—did he feel odd?—was he sure he felt nothing?—and it was nearly an hour ere he was suffered to go to bed, with no other remedy than a good fright, and the next day he appeared as pert as

ever, recommending those that did not like certain lesson books to eat them up, for, after all, he added, "books are not so nasty to eat as to learn."

CHAPTER XVII.

The time passed, to use Gatty's phrase, "fatally fast," in fact, we heard distant murmurs and fears expressed lest our dear old captain should return too soon. There was something so novel and unrestrained in our present life, and we all seemed to feel we never should again have such an opportunity of imitating the gipsies, and we were so happy and merry, that, excepting Madame, we were none of us willing to be restored too soon to civilized life.

Was our future fate a punishment or not, for thus presuming to decide our own destiny? A fortnight passed. On whose heart fell first the dread thought that something was pending over us, too horrible to be put into words? In the dead of night, I whispered low in Schillie's ear, "Do you think anything can have happened to the ship?" "Nonsense, who but you would think anything so ridiculous. Do you know I think I have discovered what these trees are. I am sure they are a species of Banyan." "Yes," said I absently. "Yes," said she, "yes, did you say? Then why did you not tell me before. I have never been able to sleep a wink when I first came to bed for wondering what they could be. Just like you." So she sulkily went off to sleep.

Another fortnight passed. No word yet was spoken, no voice had even uttered where was the Captain, Smart, La Luna? But the Mother's face was pale. She spent her days on the cliffs, looking out until her eyes ached, and bade the little Mother, who sat so silent and quiet beside her, to look for her through the telescope. And the merry voices were hushed, no laughter was heard, the meals passed in silence, the little ones played at a distance speaking in whispers, on every face you could trace a hidden fear, a secret dread, a mysterious foreboding, but not a word was spoken on the thought of each heart. As evening after evening stole by, the Mothers came down from their watch on the cliff, and though every eye asked, "Have you seen

nothing?" yet no tongue had courage to say, "Where was the Captain, Smart, La Luna?"

One day, it was hotter than usual, the sun was going down with a red glare, a low moaning wind came every now and then suddenly through the trees. As Schillie and I came down the cliffs, our knees knocked together with heat and lassitude. We had not spoken for several hours until I had said, "Come, let us go." She mutely assented, and, supporting each other, we wearily and slowly clambered down. Suddenly stopping at a smooth place on the cliff, on which had been spread by Smart the skin of the Anaconda to dry, and which still remained as he had left it, she said to me, "Which fate do you prefer, June, would you rather now be a corpse within that skin, or yet alive with your present feelings and fears." "O, Schillie, Schillie," I exclaimed, "it is not for myself I fear, but think of all these young ones, can it really be possible or true that we are likely to spend our lives in this place."

Schillie.—"At present it seems true enough, not that you will have long to fret about it, for we shall have to bury you soon, grieving in this manner; I shall go as soon as I can after you; Madame is already gasping; and then I should like to know what will become of all the young ones."

Mother.—"I do my best, I try to think about it as little as possible. But what are your thoughts, Schillie? What do you think about them not returning for us? Is it accident, or——"

Schillie.—"Come, say no more at present, here are the girls coming to meet us. To-morrow we must settle something, it is due to them for the patience with which they have acted in the last fortnight, to take them into our councils. Give us all until to-morrow, before we finally doom ourselves to consider this island our living grave."

Mother.—"But have you no hope, Schillie, speak quickly ere they come, have you no hope?"

Schillie.—"Hope! hope for Aladdin's Lamp, Prince Hassan's Carpet, Green's Balloon, a Railway over the Sea. Hope nothing, and you won't be disappointed."

Mother.—"You are cruel, Schillie."

Schillie.—"Face the worst at once, it will save you much sorrow hereafter. Now say no more, but scrape up a smile for those poor girls if you can."

Even this uncomfortable conversation proved of so much relief to us two that we were more cheerful that evening at tea, and consequently the poor children took courage to be also a little more lively. But we were hurried to our different shelters by a clap of thunder and flash of lightning, unlike anything we had ever seen before, and the rain fell in large splashing drops. In the middle of the night, we were awakened by repeated peals of thunder crashing over our heads, while the lightning played incessantly, beautiful but most awful to behold. The rain at first came in gusts, but after a while, such a deluge poured down upon us, that in half an hour our little frail huts were beaten down over our heads. One minute's exposure to the sheets of water that were descending drenched us through. With difficulty we crawled to a little cavern, which just held us, and also permitted the servants to change the children's dripping clothes, and thus passed the whole night; but the sun arose as bright as ever, rendering the scene more brilliant and lovely, from the innumerable rain-drops bespangling everything. Not all the cold, misery, and discomfort we had undergone, besides losing our rest, prevented us exclaiming at the fresh beauty of the verdure and trees, and the sweet smell of the thirsty earth as we emerged from our cavern.

We had first to light a great fire, and then to spread all the bedding on the rocks to dry in the sun. We soon warmed some water, and drank hot tea and coffee; but Madame showed symptoms of a violent cold, and little Felix and Winny shivered and shook as if in an ague fit. The poor little huts were entirely ruined, and what was worse still, all our stores and the different things belonging to La Luna, though carefully covered with sail cloth and other things, were yet evidently much damaged by the wet; in fact, it was not this day only that we had to deplore the effect of the night storms catching us so unprepared. We suffered for it, as will be seen hereafter, the whole time we were on the island. However, we could now only think of making ourselves comfortable again. Of course the tents had been beaten down even before the huts; we could not shelter under the great chestnut tree, as the stream had swollen so as to surround it on all sides, washing away all our seats, a great many dinner things, books, and various other matters which we had left there, and which of course had been carried down into the sea, so that we never recovered them again. Fresh disasters were

being discovered every minute, and so much were we taken up by them, that it was not until late in the evening, when tired and exhausted we sat down to tea, that the much greater weight and dread on our minds returned in full force.

After a silence, Schillie looked at me and nodded. I tried to speak, but the words would not come, they died away in whispers. All waited in anxious expectation, not knowing what was coming; at last, Sybil and Serena both rose, and coming to me, clasped their arms round me, and said, "Dear Sister, if the ship does not come back for us, we do not care so long as you are well and happy. Do not grieve on our account, everything will end well, you will see. Do you not always bid us trust in God. Let us pray then for his help, but do not grieve, do not weep thus."

But their sweet voices, and comforting words were lost amidst the wailing and weeping that arose on all sides, now that we had given voice to our sad fears. Words fail me when I think of describing this mournful and affecting scene, for one and all seemed equally certain that hope was gone, we had now been three months here, and the captain told us all, not once, but many times, that in six weeks for certain he should return. Something therefore must have happened. Either the vessel must have foundered, or they had failed in getting another vessel for us, or they had met with some accident, or worse than all from the instruments being destroyed on deck during the storm Captain MacNab had not been able to take any observations so as to settle whereabouts this island was, and he was perhaps now sailing about unable to find us. For it was a most singular thing which we had several times noticed, that during the whole time we had been there we had never seen a vessel on the horizon. That was a mournful evening, so sad and painful that I am sure none of those who participated in it could forget it as long as life lasted. And in the midst of the fears that assailed us regarding our future lot, many were the sorrowful thoughts we had as to what could have become of the kind good Captain, the faithful and attached Smart, and all those worthy companions, so lately forming a part of ourselves. Darkness had long wrapped the little island in her dull mantle, but sobs were heard in different parts of the little cavern in which we had all been obliged to congregate for the night, and gentle whispers of prayer to the giver of all good rose now and then in the stillness of the night, shewing that some hearts felt too deeply to sleep; the overwrought minds sought

comfort from the bountiful fountain of love and compassion, that increaseth as it is poured forth. And full well can we say, our trust hath not been in vain, deeply as we suffered then and since. But on looking back to that time, and all the subsequent trials that have befallen us, I think this period was the most painful we ever endured. Not only were we in miserable uncertainty about ourselves, but we lost and bewildered ourselves in painful conjectures as to what could have become of our companions.

To have been told that they were really destroyed, that we should never see them more, that we must depend upon ourselves for every thing, and upon chance that we might be taken from the island, would I think have been less painful to bear than the state in which we found ourselves. At any rate then we should have known what to do, and would in all probability have exerted ourselves to better our condition as best we could.

But at present we were like people suddenly left in the dark, with the additional feeling of not knowing when it would be light again, or what we could do to free ourselves. Say that we were to sit still, and wait with patience, hoping the best, believing it impossible that we could be alone and deserted, this could not last, we could not sit still for ever. Say that we immediately made up our minds to the worst; that we were alone, and to be so for an indefinite, perhaps final period; that we must shift for ourselves; that our welfare, peace, comfort, food, clothing, solely depended on our own exertions; then, perhaps, after making these exertions, after using every effort, and they would be no slight ones, but must commence immediately with great toil, and anxious thought, they would arrive, we should be saved, and thus have undergone unnecessary labour and fatigue for nothing.

Yet we were at present fitted for neither of these fates. The life of ease and enjoyment without care or thought, that we had indulged in for two months; the indolent habits we had contracted from the, to us, unusual hot climate; the strangeness and suddenness of our fate, all combined to unnerve us, and for the present overwhelm the energy and strength of character necessary for such emergency.

That was a memorable night, calm and serene, as it was after the great storm of the preceding one. Troubled and tempest-tost was each heart as it awakened scared by its own dreams, through which ran wild visions of the

beloved faces, perhaps never more to be seen. Yearnings after the homes we had so thoughtlessly left, the scenes we might never more behold, the voices perchance we should never hear again. Every thing we loved and valued and had left! seemed on this memorable night to come vividly before us. Was it therefore to be wondered that with subdued and chastened feelings we all met the next day, the elder ones steeling their hearts, and recovering their minds to enter into a regular discussion and investigation of the fate destined for them; the younger ones meek and sorrowful but most loving and engaging in their simple reliance on our words, and their quiet, but watchful anticipations of our looks and wishes, and this day happened to be a Sunday.

We generally performed the church service on an elevated, but small platform above the dining place, looking down upon the great chestnut tree, and indeed upon all our possessions. Thus endeavouring to realize the scenes so often seen in England, where the pretty simple church, with its graceful spire, is seen on an elevated place, while the humble cottages, and rose-covered houses clustered round its base.

To make the resemblance more perfect, one single large cocoa-nut tree, with its tall stem and fan-like head, was the only tree growing near the spot, and the children were wont to call this tree when its solitary condition caught their eye, the church spire.

The cliff shelved over some feet, making a natural shade and cover, and here we placed the proper seats, two only being at the foot of the tree whose occupants read and responded to the church service.

Sometimes a sermon was read after the prayers, but more often it was my habit to give each of the young ones a text from the Holy Bible, and from that they made small sermons, or rather remarks of their own which were meant only for the Mother's eye, and sacredly respected by her in that particular.

On this Sunday, the prayers being over, the psalm sung, they waited a short space for me to give them their texts as usual, but seeing how sorrowful and weak I was, and so slow in finding them out, they asked to choose their own texts for this time, which I willingly granted.

They separated to perform their own tasks until dinner time, after which Schillie and I intended between us to enter into a full discussion of our present state, and future lot, assisted by Madame, before them all. "In the multitude of councillors there is knowledge," and tho' many of our party were so young, yet I have often noticed happy thoughts, and very sage ideas rise in little heads, and amongst so many might not some brilliant conception arise, some fresh thought be promulgated which had escaped the harassed minds, and jaded spirits of the older heads. My readers shall judge of this in the next chapter.

CHAPTER XVIII.

The meal was finished, everything was cleared away, the two maids were bid come and form part of the conclave, we were all equal now, and every one was to have a voice in this council.

Madame began by saying that she thought I was unnaturally hasty in concluding that we were really left on this island for life. "So many things, dear Madam, may have occurred to prevent their coming, of which we know nothing. Besides, Captain MacNab knew that we had provisions for six months, and he might not like to trust the vessel to the hurricanes that often precede the rainy season."

Mother.—"That is very true, Madame, but I don't think the Captain would willingly put us to such anxiety; besides, he knows that we have no shelter to screen us from the violent effects of the rain."

Madame.—"But I think, Madam, we should not so immediately conclude that he is not coming at all, and that we are inevitably left alone here."

Mother.—"I do not conclude so inevitably, but it is better to come to some decision than to spend our time as we have done the last six weeks. Had we not spent our days in hoping instead of doing we should not be in such an uncomfortable situation as we are now. Two children have certainly got symptoms of ague, and you have a wretched cold and cough, half our worldly possessions are more or less damaged by the rain, and should it return, where are we to look for shelter, what can we do to preserve the goods left us?"

Madame.—"I have no doubt that the storm of the other night was only the precursor of the rainy season, which lasts from fifteen to twenty-five days in the climate to which I have been accustomed."

Mother.—"Then there is the more necessity for our exerting ourselves. Tell me, Schillie, what do you think?"

Schillie.—"I think nothing. If we are to be drowned, it's the same to me whether it is by rain or sea."

Mother.—"Nay, you are unkind. It is at moments like these when clear heads and quick wits are most invaluable. You surely don't intend to burden me with the sole arrangement of this painful and arduous undertaking."

Schillie.—"I don't see what you have got to bother yourself about. You would build a hut spite of all I could say, and the first shower drove it down on your ears."

Several voices exclaimed, "Oh, cousin Schillie, a shower! did you call that dreadful storm a shower!" while Madame lifted up her hands and eyes, and said, "it was a fearful deluge."

Schillie.—"Yes, yes, I dare say it was rather heavy; but it is nothing to what we shall have."

"Heaven forbid," again exclaimed Madame, while the little ones seemed equally aghast at the idea.

Mother.—"I grant that building more huts is out of the question, and, besides, we have not time, I suppose, but we must do something to save what we have left of our property. Come, girls, what can you suggest?"

Sybil.—"I can only think of covering everything with those great big plantain leaves."

Serena.—"And we can put stones on them to keep them down; and by putting a great many layers, I don't think it is possible the rain can get through."

Mother.—"And you, Gatty."

"Oh," said Gatty, getting very red, and twisting her pocket handkerchief into a series of knots, "I don't know much about such things, but," seeing she must speak out, "perhaps stowing them away under a big tree would do."

Zoë.—"I think the same as Gatty, Mother, for it must be impossible for the heaviest rain to get through some of the thick trees out there."

Winny.—"I am not certain which plan I think best; but I will wait and hear what Mother thinks before I quite decide."

Lilly.—"I think digging a deep hole, and burying them in the sand would be the best."

Oscar.—"Just as if the rain would not go through the sand. You always think of such out-of-the-way things, Lilly."

Mother.—"But I do not think hers's such a bad idea, I think it a very good one for such a little girl; but what do you think best yourself?"

Oscar.—"I think we had much better put them all safe in the cavern in which we sleep, especially the powder and shot, because if that gets wet it is done for, and we can dry ourselves by a fire, and yet not be hurt."

Madame.—"Oh, my dear boy, you do not know how dangerous it is to get wet in this climate, and as for sleeping out all night, you would not be alive for one week."

Oscar.—"But it is of very great consequence, Madame, that we should preserve the guns, and powder, and shot. Supposing your friends, the savages, should come, how are we to kill them if I have no powder and shot, I should like to know."

Felix warmly supported Oscar, merely saying, "If Mama's plan is a better one, I will choose that, but I suppose you won't mind, Oscar!" Oscar set him at rest on this subject.

Hargrave vehemently protested against the powder and shot being placed any where near, what she considered her property, namely all our clothes, trinkets, bonnets, and caps, and bitterly bewailed the mischief the storm had done amongst various silk dresses, and pretty smart caps. Nearly all the young ladies' bonnets were more or less hurt, and not finding her wits capable of discussing any other subject, we released her from the obligation placed on every one else, namely to give their opinion on what we should do.

Jenny sided with her dear Miss Lilly, partly because she had been snubbed by Oscar, and partly because she had a great opinion of her sense and quickness.

Having gone the round of the family, nothing remained but to sum up the whole, and make the most of it. That most was so little, we were soon all in high discussion again. Madame and Oscar being the principal talkers, and carrying on their dispute to some length, she declaring the cavern must not be given up, he vociferating that the powder and shot must be saved. They at length arrived at a pitch, so as to extract an observation from Schillie, which was one reason why I had allowed the boy to argue so much.

Schillie.—"Madame, it is too hot to get into such a stew. Do you imagine there is only one cavern in the island?"

Oscar.—"And so I wanted to tell Madame, but she would not hear me out. I did not want your old cavern, Madame, I only wanted to put all the things safe in some cavern."

Schillie.—"I think, instead of making all this noise, we had better go and search for some more caverns."

Madame.—"But it is Sunday."

Schillie.—"Necessity has no law, Madame, besides the heavens are at work, see!"

As she spoke, the lightning played before us, and the heavy thunder broke over our heads. We crouched beneath the rock, but the cloud passed away, the sun came out again, brilliantly lighting up the rain-drops which fell sharply and heavily for ten minutes.

"Now then," said Schillie, "we will all go and search for caverns. You had better lie down, as you look done up. We will be absent an hour, or you may sound the conch-shell to bring us home in time for evening church. And, Hargrave, have something ready to drink when we return. I shall be dying of thirst, I know."

Every one followed her, Madame and Hargrave only making short searchings near at hand. In the meantime, I lay down and looked at all the

texts the young ones had brought to me, as was their custom before the Sunday dinner, and which on this day they had chosen for themselves. How profoundly was I affected at the selection they had made, and the simple trustful observations accompanying each, while the wish to comfort pervaded them all, mixed with hopeful anticipations that all would end well, and earnest protestations that they would be very good, and I had only to speak to be obeyed. But I think their own papers will better show the comfort and consolation they gave me than all I can say on the subject, and I will therefore give them verbatim:—

SYBIL'S SERMON.

Psalm 107, verses 4, 5, 6.—"They went astray in the wilderness out of the way, and found no city to dwell in. Their soul fainted within them. So they cried unto the Lord in their trouble, and He delivered them out of their distress."

How good is our great Father in giving such consolation to us. We cannot believe He will forsake us, when in almost every page of His Holy Book we find promises of help and deliverance to those who trust in Him; and how happy should we feel in believing that the greater our sorrow and desolation the nearer we are to Him who afflicts those whom he loveth. Let us think also what comfort he has left us still—that we are not solitary in this lonely island—that our Mothers and dear companions are with us; and let us show our gratitude for such mercies left us by becoming more obedient, loving, and dutiful to those whose sorrow for our forlorn state is so deep. May we be a comfort to our Mother, and always think that in this small island, as in the great world, our thoughts and actions are known, our prayers are listened to by One who has promised never to leave or forsake us. How happy it is to think that on this Holy day numbers of our fellow creatures are in our own dear country praying "for all those in danger, necessity, and tribulation," and whose voices in earnest prayer meet ours, and join with those of the choir of angels above. We may hope that He who supports and sends us comfort in our despair may console our sorrowing ones at home, and give them hopes, as He does us, of meeting them again in this world. For our Saviour, Jesus Christ's sake, whose loving words "It is I, be not afraid," follow us and comfort us far from home. We will ask him to look

down and guard our little island, which He brought from the depths of the sea, to be our refuge from storms and winds. To Him whose care is over us we commit ourselves, and those near and dear to us, and we will believe "that those who cry unto the Lord in their trouble He delivereth them from their distress."

SERENA'S SERMON.

"Then they that feared the Lord spake often one to another, and the Lord hearkened."—*Malachi* iii. 16.

We beseech Thee, O Lord, to hear us, for we fear Thee and love Thee. We are separated from those we love; we cannot speak to them, or they to us; we have little prospect before us of ever seeing them again; but we have the gracious Lord to speak to, and we have His gracious promise that He will hear us. Through our Father in Heaven we can hold intercourse with our Father on earth. We pray for him, and we know God heareth the prayer that goeth not out of feigned lips. He prays for us, and God heareth him, as we see daily, hourly, in the lovely place allotted to us, in the fruits that rise before us, in the flowers that spring up to our hands, in the love we bear each other, and, oh, more than all, in the privilege that we may speak to each other of the Lord's mercies and loving kindnesses, and know that he heareth us, for Jesus Christ's sake. Then let us remember, should despondency overwhelm us, or sorrow cast her gloomy mantle upon us, that this land is not our "abiding place," that here we have no "continuing city," but that beyond the tomb we have an house prepared, not made with hands, where we shall not only meet those from whom we have been torn in this life, but such things "as eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither hath it entered into the heart of man to conceive."

GERTRUDE'S SERMON.

"But they that wait upon the Lord shall renew their strength. They shall mount up with wings as eagles; they shall run and not be weary; and they shall walk and not faint."—*Isaiah* xl. 31.

It is a very happy thing for us that the great God has mercifully promised in such numerous places in the Bible health and strength in our hour of need, for, indeed, we require it now more than ever I remember before; for, though we have everything we could want in this wretched little island, we seem doomed to pass our days here, never more to see everything we loved at home. But there is a heaven above, where there is to be no sorrow, where "tears shall be wiped away from every eye," and to this we must raise our hearts, trusting that God will renew our strength and make us strong to fulfil our duties until the time comes for us to meet them. We must pray to Him that we be not weary or faint in doing the work He has set before us, that we may be worthy of going to that place where "the wicked cease from troubling, and the weary are at rest."

ZOË'S SERMON.

"Oh! what great troubles and adversities hast Thou showed me, and yet didst Thou turn and refresh me."—*Psalms* lxxi. 8.

Ever since we left our happy home we have been troubled and tossed about. Many adversities have fallen upon us that we never thought could have happened. But God has willed it so, and for wise purposes. Perhaps He thought us too happy; perhaps it was necessary to do us good that we should be thus afflicted. Let us then not grieve, but look into our hearts to see our faults, and then we shall have so much to do that time will pass quickly, and we shall have peace and comfort in our minds beyond all other pleasure, the peace that our Heavenly Father gives to those who strive to please Him. This will make our little island like a paradise, preparing us for the happy and beautiful paradise where we shall meet all those we love so much.

WINNY'S SERMON.

"But God shall deliver the island of the innocent."—*Job* xxii. 30.

I think this is an island in which we now live, and I think that we who are in it are innocent people; therefore God will love us, and take care of us, for He tells us so in His Holy Book. Look at my text, and study it; there is a

great promise, and nobody in the world, I am sure, wants such a promise so much as we poor lonely people do. Let us then be very innocent and good, and then we shall be certain that God means that holy promise, which I have written down as my text for us, and just as much as if He spoke it to us. And, though we are all alone here, we have our Bibles to teach us to be innocent people, and that's what no savages or heathen people have, and, therefore, we should rejoice and be glad, and sing a song of thankfulness. And now I think I have explained my text, and have only to say that we must often pray to our Heavenly Father, through Jesus Christ, because without His help we cannot be innocent people.

LILLY'S SERMON.

"Comfort ye, comfort ye my people."

When we look into the Holy Book of God, at every page we read something that does us good; that is, if our hearts are rightly turned towards God, so that we wish to do His will and not our own. Lo I opened my Bible at this place, and found my text, and think it very proper for us, for we do comfort each other, and God comforts us, and we have nothing to wish for, and nothing to want, except to see our homes once more. And, if God wills that we should return home, how happy and grateful shall we be, and if He does not, we have much to do here, especially in comforting each other, and, if we work cheerfully, without sorrow and grief, great shall be our reward in heaven.

END OF THE SERMONS.

CHAPTER XIX.

While I was thus thinking my dear companions returned from their search which had been very successful. I kissed and thanked them all for their pretty thoughts and comforting words, and told them how much good they had done me, and how, for this once I must show them all to Madame and Schillie, that they might derive the same pleasure from them that I did, to which Sybil, as spokeswoman for all, gave a smiling blushing consent, and, though they did not read them just then, yet I may as well say that Madame could not sufficiently express her admiration of these innocent Sermons, and got leave from me and them to copy them into a book of her own; and, whenever she was ill or out of spirits, we always saw the little marble-covered book, containing them, brought out and regularly studied.

Schillie, in a more characteristic manner, expressed her approbation, saying that they were all good worthy children, and they wrote much better Sermons than most she had heard, for, besides being greatly to the point, they were extremely short.

And, now to return to the caverns. They had found a perfect series of comfortable places, as they called them, some being connected with others, so that we could go from one to the other without being exposed to the wet.

We had another severe storm that night, but the next day we worked and stowed everything away as well as we could. The old original cavern, being to Oscar's great delight the receptacle for the gunpowder and ammunition, more because it was the furthest from the others than from any particular wish to oblige him. Every now and then in the midst of our arrangements we had a severe storm, generally accompanied with thunder and lightning. To be exposed to one for only a few minutes wetted us quite through, therefore not wishing to lose a moment of such precious time, it was not until late in the evening that we changed or rested. At the end of three days we had done wonders, but had nearly done ourselves up also. That morning

there was no sun; nothing but continual pouring down of rain all day, and so it continued for a fortnight. During this time we made ourselves more comfortable in the three caverns, which communicated with each other; one of which was very dark and close. The lighter ones we used all day, but they smelt damp and unwholesome, and the children began to grow pale, and become restless. Besides our food was but indifferent; no fruit or vegetables, or fish. Eggs we had in abundance from the chickens and ducks we had brought with us, and which had scarcely ceased laying since we arrived, so much did they thrive in this luxuriant island. The evenings were very tedious, and we had to invent all sorts of games which would at once amuse them, and yet be exercise also.

Felix and Winny were both attacked with ague, and Madame had so bad a cough no lessons could be done. I wondered at first, on hearing Gatty's eager enquiries every morning after Madame, until I accidentally heard in answer by Hargrave that Madame had not slept during the night, "All right, girls, the cough is delightfully bad." This put me and Schillie upon employing our spare time in teaching them ourselves, which announcement was at first received rather coldly; but they derived such infinite amusement from our inaptness to the business that they were quite impatient if anything prevented us performing this office. With the utmost gravity and demureness Gatty would bring me the same lesson to repeat every day; and though I must, in justice to myself, allow that I thought it must be the easiest book in the world, it seemed all the same thing, I was too innocent to imagine she was amusing herself at my expense. How long I should have gone on I know not, but her exquisite delight at my simplicity was too great to be kept in, she told her own secret amidst the laughter of all, her dupe being one of the most amused. Sybil and Serena took equal liberties, all more from the love of fun than real delinquency, so that during our reign lessons were at a premium. Schillie undertook writing and summing, and as she was always mending pens and cutting pencils, holding one or other between her lips, she was often not in a condition to reprimand by words, consequently a tap on the head, a blow on the cheek, a pinch on the arm, generally expressed her disapprobation. Moreover, she was very impatient if the sums were done wrong, and exclaiming, "Good lack, what young noodles," would do the sums again herself, instead of making the delinquents correct them. This plan I pronounced with great dignity as

highly improper; she, in dudgeon, said I was a noodle too, and we came to high words, much to the delight and gratification of our pupils.

But Sybil and Serena delighted in drawing her out while they were all three reading aloud to her in turns their English History. Then warmed with her subject, delighting in all the political and historical details, she would take the book from their hands, and enter into long discussions, her strong whig principles startling the two bred and born tory girls into sufficient argument and opposition to give piquancy and eloquence to her words as they flowed rapidly from her lips. During these periods, Gatty, who only cared to get done as quick as possible what she was obliged to do, and thought all these digressions a great bore, employed her idle fingers in whatever mischief lay within her reach. If she had no pocket handkerchief to twist into holes, it took her but a few minutes to dog-ear a whole book; or, probably, the energetic discussion and the attentive listeners would be interrupted by a sudden crash, proclaiming the tearing of something, and each would instinctively look round for their handkerchiefs; or she would collect little animals, like ants, spiders, or flies, and, having got a handful, would empty them over one of the three; in fact, she would do anything to put an end to the discussion, that they might finish their allotted task and get it over. Then in wrath Schillie would turn round and exclaim, "You idle young monkey, why don't you go on with your reading?"

Gatty (demurely).—"If you please, little Mother, we can't."

Schillie.—"Cannot! What stops you, I should like to know? Nothing but your own laziness, keeping me waiting here all day."

Gatty (still more meekly).—"If you please, little Mother, you have got the book."

Schillie.—"Got the book! Who wants to keep your book? I am sure I don't; I only wish to have done with you as soon as possible."

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, you stopped us to talk about those people."

Schillie.—"Those people indeed! You who ought to be more interested in such characters than the other girls, because your Father's name will be

handed down to posterity in the same manner. I am quite done up with you being such an owlet, Gatty."

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, I don't care about them at all. They are all dead, and they are nothing to me, and I only wish they had not lived, and then we should not have had such a long History of England to read through."

Such speeches were too much for Schillie's fortitude, and Gatty's sparkling eyes showed how successful her manœuvres were in being dismissed at once, "as too stupid to be borne with."

Sometimes I handed over the little girls to her to say their lessons, and they were invariably dismissed before they could have said half of them. And when I enquired the reason thereof, "Poor little victims," she answered, "what is the use of addling their brains with such a cart load of lessons, one more silly than another. As if they could not order a much better dinner than is mentioned in this French phrase book, and all that trumpery poetry; and their geography book is the stupidest I ever saw, as if they did not all know what an island is. It's my opinion they will know too well what an island is, without learning it in a book."

With the boys she got on pretty well, except hurting Felix's feelings now and then by saying, "Now learn your book, and don't eat it this time," which allusion generally caused a tear or two, he having a well very near his eyes.

None of the young ones were anxious to give up their new governesses, but they, on the contrary, hailed the return of fine weather with great joy.

CHAPTER XX.

I fancied we all looked quite mouldy, when we emerged from our dusky dark caverns. But the weather was so delicious, so cool and refreshing; everything was so green and beautiful that we soon revived. I thought it necessary to take an inventory of all our possessions, that we might husband them as much as possible. We also attended greatly to our gardens, and the few remaining potatoes that we had were planted that we might not be totally bereft of such a useful vegetable. I never saw anything like the growth of the English vegetables we had brought with us. They were almost too luxuriant, approaching to rankness.

Day after day passed by and we were still alone. No ardently-desired vessel hove in sight, nothing met our longing gaze as we daily scanned the horizon. Fearing the inevitable lowness of spirits that such constant hoping and longing, followed by as constant disappointment, must end in, I, one evening, said that I should not at all like being cooped up in those caverns again the next rainy season.

Schillie.—"Now if you mention one word about building one of your old huts, you shall be whipt."

Mother.—"Oh no, no! I have had quite enough of the huts. I have not the smallest intention of building such another flimsy affair."

Schillie.—"Then if you are going to talk common sense, I am quite willing to listen. Those caverns certainly put one rather in mind of one's grave, and I cannot get the nasty dead smell of them out of my nose. Now then, June, be speedy, and let us hear your intentions. Shall we build a boat, and betake ourselves off or shall we live *al fresco*, despite Madame's fears, or what? Come, speak up."

Mother.—"I don't fancy building a boat at all, much less trusting myself in it; but, agreeing with you in your horror of huts, I think we must now make

a good substantial house."

"Your horror!" said Schillie. "Delightful," exclaimed all the others. "What splendid fun. How very charming. Where shall it be? Let us begin immediately."

Spite of all her opposition, Schillie knew very well we must have a house, and the more she grumbled I knew the harder she would work. So everybody was ordered to use their best wits, and give their opinions as to the kind, size, situation, and other things belonging to the intended mansion, and at tea-time the sense of the company was to be taken. In the meantime I compared our list of goods, with what the captain had made out for us, and found that we had suffered considerably by the rain. Out of seven barrels of flour four were nearly spoilt; a cask of cheese and ship's biscuit was all that remained of those commodities; not a bit of the salted beef and pork could be touched, we had to throw it all away, but some bacon and hams were quite good. We had four or five cases of preserved meats, but, as Jenny observed, we could eat those up in a week, and then what were we to do for meat. I gave her clearly to understand that we must do without meat for the future, which caused her to drop one of our saucepans in surprise and dismay, while she exclaimed, "Whatever, Ma'am, shall we do about Master Felix if he has no meat, and he growing so fast?" "Whatever, Jenny, shall we do if you knock holes in the saucepans in such a careless way?" said I. Jenny apologised as best she could, but it was evident all the saucepans in the world might get punched into holes provided her little master had meat for his dinner every day; she comforted herself very much, however, thinking of the ducks and chickens, though she bewailed over his great affection for mutton chops and beef steaks, and now for the future that weakness of his would run no chance of being gratified.

The potatoes were nearly all gone, as before mentioned, but that was to be only a temporary deprivation. We had stores sufficient to last for six months of rice, sago, tapioca, tea, coffee, sugar, raisins, and all those kind of things; but the ship's provisions, which had been mostly left behind to lighten the vessel (the Captain having only taken what was just necessary) were greatly damaged by the rain; they had not been in good tin cases like ours, and eventually were of little use. The packets of seeds became now our most valuable possessions. We had a great quantity of ropes, spars, sails, and

other things belonging to the vessel, carpenters' tools, nails, screws, &c., all of which became invaluable to us, though we afterwards discovered a good substitute for nails in the thick sharp thorns of a species of Cactus. We had a great deal of furniture, sofas, bedding, hammocks, tables, chairs, bookcases, a great deal of pantry furniture, of which we were now most careful, knowing we could never replace the china or glass; also, we had a plate chest, in which we had silver to the value of £200. Of kitchen utensils we were greatly in want, almost everything having been lost in the caboose when it was washed away. We had two kettles and a small boiler. The men had constructed a sort of fire-place and oven for Jenny before they left, but it was so far from the dining place that we had everything generally cold. We had about six dozen bottles of various sorts of wine, a large cask of rum and another of brandy, which belonged to the ship's company, plenty of beer, ale, and porter, which, however, being in casks, spoilt long before we could drink it, from the heat of the climate. But such details must be tedious, as it can be easily imagined what our possessions would be out of a vessel victualled, furnished, and prepared for a twelve months' voyage. The result of the investigation, however, proved that of civilized food we had but little, and that we must soon set about preparing to live upon what the island would afford us. And when I looked round on the fertility and richness surrounding us, and the vast variety of food we could indulge in, I could not help thanking the Giver of all good for so much mercy showered upon us in the midst of such extraordinary events.

We had one cock and eleven hens and about seven ducks, all of whom seemed to provide themselves with food, without any assistance from us.

Every one knows that in preparing for a sea voyage quantities of linen are necessary; we were therefore most fortunate in that particular. I had also pieces of muslin, white and coloured, which I brought to make frocks for the young ones in the hot climates, knowing how fast they would grow. I left the arrangement of the clothes to Hargrave, who grumbled and put away, and put away and grumbled to her heart's content. She arranged all the best dresses and also the fine things, laces and trinkets, in such a manner that she could constantly look at them, as she could not have the satisfaction of seeing us wear them, and to each person was given out a certain quantity of wearing apparel that was to last a given time. But these are such dry

details, that I will proceed at once to tea, at which such an important subject as building a house was to be discussed.

CHAPTER XXI.

While I and the two maids had been undergoing the dull labour mentioned in the preceding chapter, all the others had been attending to their gardens, and they all flocked to tea, laden with fruit and decorated with flowers, looking so pretty and happy that I could not but think, whatever our lot, we should retain our spirits and cheerfulness to the end. Schillie came last, dragging with her a heap of unknown lichens, creepers, and mosses, on all of which she wanted me to hold a consultation as to what they could be.

Having made some highly-satisfactory guesses, and also having discovered amongst our books one on Botany, and another on Natural History of all kinds, and also the Travels of a Gentleman in the West Indies, that gave a very accurate account of all the productions natural to the climate we were in, she was in an especial good humour.

Sybil begged earnestly that the house might be in the gothic style, which upset Schillie a little, but she pooh, poohed it off, until Serena came out with a vehement hope that it might be a Swiss cottage. "Swiss fiddlestick," retorted Schillie, "my dear girls, if you think I shall break my back and spoil my hands ornamenting a house for you, you will find yourselves wonderfully deceived." She had very pretty small white hands. Gatty thought it would be delightful to cut down a tree, and muttered something about the impossibility of learning lessons and building a house at the same time. In this she was unanimously supported by several youthful voices, and Madame was already appealing to me by looks of a most pathetic kind (she had the most extraordinary horror of a holiday that I ever saw), and Schillie, on seeing her look, exclaimed, "Well, Madame, you are certainly not of the same species as I am. I should be only too willing to give them holidays every day if I were their governess." "Yes, Madame," said Sybil, "and she acts up to it; for when you were ill, I heard her say to the little girls that she would give them a whole holiday that day because they had had only half a

one the day before." Madame looked horror-stricken, and mournfully shook her head at Schillie.

Mother.—"Come, come, now, about this house. Where shall we put it up!"

Many places were suggested, and at last, partly because there were so many trees there, partly because we fancied it more sheltered, and partly because it was such a lovely spot, we fixed upon the little valley or glade which was sheltered by the cliffs on one side and by a thick wood on the other. In the centre was the great tree which had bewildered us so by its strange movements while under the influence of the great Anaconda. Inland, beyond the tree, was the pretty peaceful lake, and a sloping terrace took us down to it.

Great impatience was now manifested on all sides to begin; Madame alone was in low spirits. It had been decreed by the higher powers that, until we could see how we got on in this new and unusual work for feminine fingers, it was as well to employ the whole force of the island; besides, after being screwed up in the caverns, where lessons and Madame were met at every corner, and there was no escape, a little holiday would be a great boon. The piano had been sadly damaged by the wet, so we begged her to set it right, that it might be ready for the new drawing room.

We all drew plans of the house first, and, to the surprise of everybody, Schillie's was undoubtedly the best. So the little Mother was well bullied for being so disgusted at having to build a house, and yet taking the trouble of making such a good plan. She was made clerk of the works on the spot. Gatty's plan had consisted of merely one square. "On one side we can sleep," she said, "and on the other sit and do all we have to do." "But where are we to eat?" said Sybil. "Oh, I think nothing so stupid as having regular meals," said Gatty. "When I have a house of my own, I never intend to order anything, but I shall go to the cupboard and eat when I am hungry." "But," said Winny, "I don't see a cupboard in your plan, Gatty." "Oh, we will stick one up somewhere, little one," returned Gatty.

The high spirits with which every one began their allotted tasks rather gave way under the fatigue and hard work, so unusual to delicate fingers. Gatty had earnestly begged to cut down the tree, with Jenny, Oscar, and Schillie to help. Sybil's hands were too slight and small to hold the hatchet, so she had

to collect grass and moss with the young ones. The first tree that was cut down, how often it was anathematized, it seemed determined not to come down. Hot and panting we sat down one after another to rest, and a sort of vague notion kept running in our heads, if one tree is such a trouble, what shall we do having to cut down so many. But Schillie was not to be daunted by a tree; taking a great glassful of porter, she called on us all to set to work again, partly laughing at us, partly praising us, and especially animating us by her energetic example; at length down came our first tree with a delightful crash. And happy were the boys, sitting astride on the branches, and sawing away as if they received wages for all they did. The next tree was more civil, and came down in half the time; the fact is, we grew more expert, and at last it was but one hour's task among us all to fell one. In a week we had cleared a good space, sawn and chopped a vast quantity of wood, and then the clerk of the works ordered me to get a great feast ready, as the next day she was going to lay, not the first stone, but the first tree of our house. So we went in great state to the ceremony, and we took a bottle of wine with us to drink success to the new house, and the clerk of the works made a very neat and appropriate speech, in which, however, she showed herself on rather too familiar terms with her workpeople; and I, in return, proposed, "health and long life to the clerk of the works," which was received with great cheering and applause. Madame became quite merry, and having settled the well-being of the piano, actually offered her services to assist in the building, and never mentioned lessons the whole day. We had a superb feast. A magnificent dish of fish, the last piece of beef in our possession, peas, bacon and beans, roasted yams, a glorious plum-pudding, with brandy blazing up in the middle, fruit, beautiful to behold and delicious to taste. Then, after dinner, we sang songs, and Madame told us some stories, and we went to bed extremely happy, but nearly as weary of our day's pleasure as we were of our daily work, we had laughed and talked so much. It was quite a month before the clerk of the works would allow us to consider our house fit to be looked at, and I cannot say it was ever quite finished, as we always found something to alter and arrange in it. It consisted of one hall in the middle, thirty feet long, twenty feet wide, the walls of which were composed of the trees we had cut down, a double row of them, the intermediate space being filled up with everything we could collect in the shape of grass and moss; the inside was plastered with clay, which, after a while, we painted, as we had a good store of oils and

turpentine and other things, which had been designed for the ship. On both sides of the hall, we had what we called lean-tos, the roofs of which began where the roof of the hall ended, and they sloped down to within four feet of the ground. The other side, or point of the hall, was the entrance. The sheds on each side opened into the hall, but had no other outlet. There were two on each side and one at the end opposite the entrance, which was a kitchen and scullery. Of the four little side rooms, Schillie and I occupied the one on the right hand of the door, Madame and the three little girls the next one, the two maids and two boys opposite us, and the three girls opposite Madame. The little girls used our room to dress and wash in, so that Madame's was not intruded upon except at night, and she could keep it quiet for herself when she wanted to lie down and rest. The bed places were put just where the roof was lowest, so that, in fact, when lying down, our faces were within two feet of the roof, but, by this means, we had more room in which to stand upright and move about. The kitchen had an outlet at the side. The reason we made our side roofs slope down so much was to allow the rain to fall off quicker, and to let hurricanes blow over us, if possible, without finding any resisting substance the wind could blow away. Then all round our house we planted the prickly pear, which grew like a weed, so that nothing could attack our dwelling from the outside, excepting by the door, and that makes me remember to remark that we had no door at all, and we often laughed at ourselves for taking such care to guard the sides of the house when we left open the only place where there was an entrance. However, then we were under no alarm regarding thieves and robbers. But we had a sail-cloth curtain, which at night we fastened with bars of wood across, as much to prevent the wind flapping it to and fro as to hinder anything getting in; also, each bed-room had a curtain before its door or entrance. We had a great deal of trouble with the roof it must be acknowledged, even the clerk of the works stamped her foot, and went so far as to say, "Hang the roof," to which Sybil demurely replied, "That's just what we want to do."

We took three spars, one for the middle and two each side, these latter being placed two feet lower; on these we nailed a strip of sail-cloth each side, which we tarred and painted very often, especially the inside, which, at the children's request, was painted in blue, to make our roof or ceiling look pretty; above the sail-cloth outside we laid a smooth layer of leaves, and

then across we nailed shingles of wood lapped one over the other, which again were seamed by cross pieces very strongly fastened. Lucky it was that the walls were so thick, otherwise such an elaborate roof could never have been supported. When finished, we all had an argument as to whether it really would resist water, and Gatty offered, with Serena to help her, to go up and empty buckets of water on it to try. This handsome offer was declined, as we thought the rain would do that soon enough, and we were at present too much in love with our work to bear the shock of finding all our labour was thrown away. I am afraid of appearing tedious in describing our many mistakes, our frequent mishaps, and the many blundering contrivances we had. Certain it is that to the clerk of the works we owed most of our neatness, to the quick wits of the girls many of our ideas, and one and all worked with a will. Nevertheless, I have no doubt that the commonest carpenter in the smallest village would have laughed at the house we built, and how we rectified gaps with grass and moss, how things warped one way and others shrunk the contrary, how nails stuck out their points and their heads were utterly lost, how screws were such a time before they would ever screw for us, how, animated by the clerk of the works, few thought of chopped fingers and hammered hands, how others ceased to shriek at the monstrous spiders, centipedes, lizards and small snakes, appearing every minute in the grass and moss; and now one and all agreed, that, in spite of every impediment, we should have the housewarming dinner and the first usage of our new mansion on the first Christmas-day we had ever spent on this unknown but lonely island.

CHAPTER XXII.

And so it was quite ready, and with what pride and satisfaction we viewed it. We took little private excursions around it; we made innumerable drives into it; we gave it affectionate little pattings, as if it was a child; we smoothed down little inequalities; we utterly denied the existence of a smell of paint, an idea hazarded by Madame. Schillie had a doubt it was rather on one side, which doubt was driven to the winds. Sybil suggested a wish that it had been made higher, for which she was scouted by the older ones, and nearly tickled to death by the younger ones. Not even the remembrance of our home put us out of conceit of our new, but certainly most clumsy mansion. Oh home! That lovely home? Are we to see it again, or is it only to be seen in a dream of the past; and our kith and kin, our kind good neighbours, all that we loved so much, were we to see them no more? But this was Christmas-day.

The young ones had swept and decorated our church, as well as they could in imitation of the churches at home. Certainly nothing could be more gorgeous than the long trailing creepers that hung suspended all round, some with scarlet flowers, some bright blue, the magnificent hibiscus, the beautiful bell-shaped datura, with innumerable others, to which we could give no names.

This was to be a complete holiday. We dressed in silks and satins, we exchanged gifts, we offered to each other the proper Christmas greeting. Can I say that no heart was sad, that no remembrance of past Christmases haunted the celebration of this day? It is but too true that sad thoughts arose, but they were not for ourselves.

I must, however, proceed with the opening of the new house, which was also to have a name given it. After church we all helped to get dinner ready. Schillie cooked with Jenny, being determined to have some superb turtle soup. I made by her orders some lime punch, Hargrave boiled vegetables of

all kinds, the girls got fruit and flowers, Madame arranged them, and the boys were getting the fish. I went into the kitchen to ask Schillie some question relative to the punch, and was sent out with a word and a blow almost. Her face was blazing like a warming pan, the soup was at its most important crisis. Gatty hearing the explosion of wrath, came as was her usual custom to join in the *mêlée*, also got a shower of invectives, but, knowing the soup-pot could not be left, she stood her ground, and occupied herself in various petty acts of mischief. For instance, the new cook had a perfect series of cloths and such like articles pinned to her when she made her appearance. Hargrave found all the gourds and pipkins into which she had put the vegetables changed, and, not being naturally sweet tempered, she declared, "Miss Gertrude was the most aggravatingest creature she ever met, and she would not serve her for a pound a day." But all ended well, and the dinner was served. We had boiled chickens at the top, and roast chickens at the bottom, and we had roast ducks on both sides, and the great bowl of turtle soup was in the middle, with two jugs of lime punch each side, and we had guava jelly in two places, and a pumpkin pie, and roasted yams, and rice and fruit mixed together of all kinds. In fact, it was a perfect Lord Mayor's feast. Schillie had insisted on dining like Christians, as she called it, with dinner napkins and finger glasses. The rest of the dinner table was covered with fruits and flowers, such as I am sure no Lord Mayor ever saw at his table. Grace was said. Schillie, with the dinner napkin spread out with an air, her face still glowing, but bland in the extreme knowing that she had achieved a triumph of cookery, proceeded to serve the soup. I being the first to taste it pronounced it delicious. Madame thought it the best she had ever tasted! when we heard an exclamation from Schillie, "In the name of all that's ridiculous what's in the soup?" said she, turning wrathfully to Jenny. "Indeed, Madam, you poured it out of the pan yourself, and I only brought it in." "What can it be, here is something hard at the bottom rolling about, and I declare everything was stewed to a sponge when I last stirred it," continued she in rising choler.

Gatty (rising with great alacrity).—"If you please, little Mother, shall I try to fish it out?"

Schillie.—"Fish fiddlesticks out, indeed, Miss Gatty. Ah you may look as demure as you like, I'll be bound you are at the bottom of this mischief. I remember now, when I was taking off these rags you pinned on me, my

back was turned. Now, tell me this instant, you young crocodile, what have you been putting in the soup?"

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, don't be so angry, it's only a stone, and I washed it quite clean."

Schillie.—"Then take that stone for your dinner, Miss, and nothing else shall you have."

This threat of course went for nothing, and Gatty had as much dinner as any of us, and, perhaps, rather more, considering that she was nearly the biggest of us all, and also never being still, she required more nourishment to keep up the demand upon the constitution.

We made Jenny and Hargrave dine with us. Hargrave mincing her words, looking dignified, and eating next to nothing, because she thought it more ladylike; while Jenny sat between her two dear boys, and made nearly as much noise as they did, swallowing all they made her taste out of their own plates, though she was helped out of the same dishes they were. The chattering on all sides could only equal the eating. I proposed the health of the new house with the first glass of lime punch. This was drank with great applause, and a discussion ensued as to what we should call it.

Schillie (with her mouth full of turtle).—"Pooh, pooh, use your brains for some other purpose. It's a house, is it not? Then why not call it a house!"

Sybil.—"But all houses have names to distinguish them."

Schillie.—"Alack, if you are not a young noodle. Pray, who has got a house here besides? A great boon it would be to have some neighbours to whom one could talk common sense."

Serena.—"Oh, we will talk as much common sense as you like, little Mother; and the first thing I shall say is, though there is but one house in the island, we may just as well make it as like home as we can, and call it the same name."

I nodded approvingly to the dear girl for her nice thought. Madame's pocket handkerchief was in requisition, while Schillie, who seemed to favour Serena's remarks with more attention than any of the others, said, "Call it

any name you like, my dear child, if it gives you the smallest pleasure; only you will see house it is, and house it will be called, until a hurricane blows it down."

"Oh don't, my dear Madam," murmured Madame. "Hurricanes will come," repeated Schillie. "I would oblige you if I could, but in this particular I am not clerk of the works, and have no control."

"Then," said Sybil, "we will call it Maescelyn."

"No," said Oscar, "I won't have it called that. The real Maescelyn is a castle, very large, airy, and handsome to look at, and this is a dingy little house, with no windows in it."

What a start we all gave. It was too true. Even the clerk of the works looked quite silly. The house that had cost us such infinite labour, on which we looked with such pride and affection, had no windows of any kind or sort in its principal room. It is true the door was very wide, it is true that floods of light poured in through it, but, suppose we had to shut the door (that is when we had made one) what could we do then? It is true the little bedrooms had each their little pigeon holes for light and ventilation, and that the back kitchen was very airy, but our hall, dining-room, drawing-room, school-room (the pride of our hearts and delight of our eyes) had no windows whatever. No wonder we all felt the remark was true. Felix spoke first, but only in a whisper, which whisper passed round among the young ones, and marvellously restored their equanimity. "There was no possibility of doing lessons in the dark." As Madame became aware of this telegraphic dispatch, and saw its effect, she grew quite nervous, which always caused her to lose her voice. In vain she attempted an expostulation, and, what between her efforts and the rising exultation, I began to apprehend she would have a fit, so I comforted her, and said, "Never mind, Madame, we will have a window without doubt somewhere, and at present you see we don't want one, for the door throws in so much light, that we never found out we ought to have windows." I don't think the clerk of the works spoke for the next half hour, she was so annoyed; but, what we thought a great misfortune proved afterwards a very desirable thing, for it was most refreshing in the glaring sunshine and hot baking air to come into the dark

cool house, the walls of which being so thick, and filled up with clay, preventing the heat penetrating into it.

So we carried on the discussion about the name; Madame, Sybil, Serena, and Winifred all for calling it Maescelyn. Oscar, Felix, Lilly, and Jenny all against it. The little Mother, not having recovered herself gave no name, Gatty was waiting for her opinion before she gave any, for, though in constant warfare, their similarity of tastes made them in reality sworn friends. Hargrave also would give no name, principally because she said, "It was a 'orrifying place, and very outrageous," by which we suppose she meant outlandish. Though urged by the little ones, whom she suspected were laughing at her, to explain, she would not, but went off into a discussion upon dress, and, bidding the young ladies to look at her Mistress dressed in Christmas robes, with her hair so beautifully plaited in a basket plait, and her curls so smooth and bright, and her black satin gown sitting and hanging so becomingly and well. "And then to think she could like such a 'ole of an hisland, where no one could see how she 'ad hattired her Mistress, and to give such a 'eathen place a name too, was more than she could bear." So the girls who loved to tease her, declared her Mistress did not look one bit better than the rest of the party, and that Madame's neat plain white cap was the prettiest thing at the dinner table, or Jenny's smart blue one, with bows and ends all over it. As she was too-matter-of-fact to see any joke in this, and as her Mistress's hair was her weak point, she waxed wrath, and began a splendid description, misplacing all the h's, and making such a sad havoc amongst her parts of speech, that it was difficult to make out what she wished us must to admire, whether her Mistress, or diamonds, or black velvet, herself or hair. I had the casting vote in giving a name to the house, but, previously, I thought it as well that we should give a name to our island. "Certainly, certainly," was said on all sides, and also most voices decided it should be a Welsh name; therefore, in a glass of lime punch, after a long discussion, we christened our island "YR YNYS UNYG," the last word, Unyg, being pronounced as inig. This in English signified "The Lonely Island." Much as I wished all my dear companions to feel happy, and to be as much at home in our painful situation as circumstances would allow, and, much also as I liked the notion of our calling everything about us by home names, I yet shrunk from giving the name of our beloved home to the hut in which we now seemed doomed to pass our days. Several

times I attempted to begin upon the subject, but it was too painful and I dared not trust my voice, lest its faltering should show my companions that this Christmas-day was not one of unmixed pleasure, and I was the more anxious to restrain my feelings as I could easily perceive that a little was only wanting to turn our day of feasting into one of mourning. It was not, therefore, until repeated entreaties had been urged, that, at last, I said somewhat shortly, and with an effort of hilarity, "I think we will call our house 'Cartref Pellenig,' or 'The Distant Home,' because—because—"

Schillie.—"Well, why, because."

"Oh hush, hush, cousin Schillie," said Lilly, who was always impetuous, and, throwing her arms round me, she continued, "Don't, dear Mama, my own Mother, don't cry, I cannot bear it. We shall see home again, we shall not always live here, we will be so good, we will do everything to please you. Oh Mother, my own darling Mother, don't cry so."

And so all my efforts were in vain, we were all upset, and the little house, so late the scene of merriment, now was filled with the voices of lamentation and woe. Each in their different way mourned and wept, but, as I said before, it was not so much for ourselves as for others.

We had been so busy, and had so much on our minds that we had thought of little else than mending our own condition, and doing all we could to make ourselves comfortable. To the olden heads it had been a time of great anxiety and trouble, while the younger ones had been forced out of their proper sphere of dependance, into that of companions, helpers, and advisers. We had, therefore, but little time to think of those who, it now struck us, on this Christmas-day, for the first time, would be suffering under fear and anxiety for our fate.

The same feelings that were so forcibly striking us of the relations, friends, and neighbours with whom we had always exchanged the happy Christmas greetings, would, we now began to feel, also strike them. In our family what gaps would be seen in the heretofore merry Christmas party. I looked round, Schillie was separated from her children, Gatty, Zoë, Winifred, Madame, even the poor servants, how many mourning households would there be? Not because we were missing from the Christmas party, as that was expected, but because they must be aware that something had occurred.

They must now be suffering under that worst of all fears, doubt and apprehension. Eight months had passed since we had seen them, and six must have gone by since they had heard from us. There could be no doubt that, painful as our feelings were, they were now most to be pitied. Oh how we longed for the wings of a bird to fly over, and set them at rest. How the more we wept and talked about them, the more unbearable and painful grew this feeling. All that we had undergone; all that we seemed likely to undergo, appeared but as a drop on the ocean compared to the mourning and sorrow which we knew were filling the hearts of so many households, weeping, as they would be at the mysterious and unknown fate of those they loved so much. We were safe, we were well, we were comparatively happy, yet we could not tell this, and, perhaps at the time, the very time, we were celebrating our housewarming and Christmas dinner, they were lamenting us as dead.

Will it be wondered at that our Christmas-day ended in sorrow, and that we wept for those weeping for us. We talked over all they might be thinking and doing. Every speech, every sentence ending, "Oh if we could only tell them, if they could only peep into the rude hut, and see the healthy blooming faces contained therein, albeit each face was bedewed with tears, each voice was choking with sorrow." This picture would they see. The rustic rough house, with its wide open entrance, showing the table strewn with the wrecks of our feast, but brilliant with flowers and fruit. Lying on a rude grass cushion was the Mother, her hair all dishevelled with sorrow, her face lengthened with woe; close by her, with her face hidden from sight, was the little Mother; Madame leaning far back in her chair, with a handkerchief over her face, was weeping bitterly behind it; the six girls, in various groups, about the two Mothers, were each, though deeply sorrowful, trying in their own sweet ways, to speak of hope and comfort; the two boys, at a little distance, were sitting on the ground, Oscar grave and sorrowful, Felix weeping and crying while he fed his monkey to keep it quiet; the servants had retired. Beyond, through the door, was seen the deep blue quiet sea, over which we were so anxious to fly, while the rich dark foliage of the trees appeared cool and refreshing against the glowing sky. But this sadness could not last long in a party animated by christian hopes, sustained by christian faith; ere the hour for evening service arrived our sorrow grew lighter, each seemed to feel in the stored words an individual

comfort, and we retired to rest committing the consolation of all near and dear to us to Him who had preserved *us* through so many and great dangers, for the sake of His Son Jesus Christ. Thus we sat for hours on this Christmas-day, but what was going on at home?

CHAPTER XXIII.

In a distant county, in the North of England, there was situated in a quiet country parish a rural rectory, surrounded by a garden, and adorned with the only good trees in the neighbourhood; it stood sheltered at the foot of a hill, the only rising ground to be seen amidst a flat and smoke-dried country. Within that rectory lived a venerable and venerated father, with a loving and adored mother, who had hitherto been surrounded at Christmas by the happy faces and smiling countenances of thirteen children, with their numerous offsprings.

A bright blazing fire is sending a gloomy tint all over the pretty drawing room, hung with green, and adorned with bright flowers, worked by skilful fingers. Various beautiful and rare specimens of Foreign workmanship ornament every part of the room, chairs and sofas of ease and luxury pervade the apartment, nothing seems wanting to render this room the beau ideal of an English home at Christmas time, for the bright green holly with its scarlet berries is hung in every direction. It is well inhabited too. In the high-backed old-fashioned chair sits a sweet and dignified lady, but her face had a painful expression, her eyes were fixed on nothing, her delicate white fingers were half clasped together, her thoughts seemed far away. On the opposite side of the fire sat a girl writing, whose pretty figure bent over the paper until the long chestnut curls lay resting on the table, but they quite concealed the face. A tall slim figure was busily winding silk, with her back to the fire, her dark hair, beautifully plaited in a thick Grecian plait, shewing her small head to great advantage. In full front of the fire sat another girl, whose pretty sweet face was bedewed with tears, which every now and then she wiped away. A step was heard on the stairs, the sweet Mother's eyes recovered their animation, the winder stopped from her occupation, the writer raised a pale and care-worn face, each advanced to the door as it opened to admit the grey-headed Father. He bore a packet of letters, but his face was mournful as he said, "No, none from them." "Alas, alas," said the sorrowful Mother, sinking back into her chair, "what are we to think? I see,

I see, all this heap of letters, and not one contains the news we pine for. They are only repetitions of what we have already had; anxious enquiries from still more anxious parents, painful to read, still more painful to answer. I cannot read them, I cannot bear them in my sight." As they tried to comfort her, rapid wheels and fast-trotting horses' feet were heard, and the next minute a carriage with four breathless and smoking horses turned into the drive, and stood at the front door. Before they had stopped, a gentleman sprung from the carriage and bounded up stairs in a minute, his figure being concealed in a travelling cloak. As he raised his hat, he shewed the fine bald head and handsome countenance of Sir Walter Mayton. The aged father raised one hand, the sorrowful mother clasped the other, as they exclaimed, "What news, what news. Have you heard of our lost ones?" He could not bring himself to speak the negative that his sorrowful shake of the hand indicated, but another person was behind him, having come in the same carriage. Who could mistake that kind and loving face, the noble features so handsome in their regularity, so beneficent, so benign, the snow-white hair, the merry kind blue eye, the upright figure. The weeping Mother threw herself into his arms. "Don't cry, don't cry, my dear Emily," said he, the tears rolling down his rich ruddy cheek, "we shall find them again. We will go in search of them. Remember, I too am a sufferer. Have I not lost my right hand, the sunbeam of my house, my sweet, little, mischievous, pretty, fidgety Gatty," and he raised his eyes reverently to heaven, as if to invoke a blessing on his lost child; and this was Gatty's Father, who had left his court, and had come down purposely with Sir Walter Mayton to consult on the best mode of discovering the lost party, and taking the advice of all those nearly and dearly interested in them.

"Now," said Sir Walter Mayton, seeing that the painfulness of the meeting was nearly over, "now let us proceed to business. First of all, will you allow me to ring the bell for some dinner, as I can tell my story while it is getting ready, and we must leave immediately after." That matter being arranged, he proceeded, "You are aware that I, according to directions that I received from our lost party, dated Madeira, followed them to Rio Janeiro by the next packet. I had a capital voyage, and was so speedy in my movements that I was not surprised at finding La Luna not in port when I arrived. I waited patiently for a week during which time I hired a house and made preparations for their seeing all that was worth seeing in the country. At the

end of that time your son's ship came into port, and she had not reported herself five minutes ere I was on board. He, with me, expressed great disappointment at the non-arrival of our party, and, from being rather fidgety before, I became doubly so at seeing his anxiety. Accordingly, we left orders and persons ready to receive them should they arrive by any means unknown to us; and I, at his request, accompanied him on his cruise up and down the coast, thinking, in my impatience, that I should hear of them sooner; and at all events, it was some employment, for, I frankly own, I could not have waited another week doing nothing, and suffering such anxiety.

"We were out a fortnight, and all we heard was that there had been a tremendous gale, for those vessels that were only in the tail of it suffered considerably. But, your son had no fear of La Luna riding it out, knowing what a good sea-boat she was; except, indeed, she had by some misfortune got into the circle of the storm, by which she would not only have the worst of it, but be violently exposed for many more days than otherwise. Our anxiety grew with the weeks, so at the end of the fortnight we put into Rio again, and consulted the best authorities. We all agreed on one subject, namely, that having good sea-room, which we calculated she must have had when the storm overtook her, she could not have foundered or been lost. We had then to think what else could have occurred, and in making up our minds to wait patiently another fortnight, we calculated that ladies do sometimes change their minds, and that they might have been seduced into landing on some of the numerous and lonely islands with which the Atlantic abounds.

"But, it was sorry work this waiting, I determined to make them pay dearly for breaking their promise, should it be the case, and for putting me into such a painful state."

"I can well believe it, Sir, I can well believe it," said the grey-headed Father. "Thank you, thank you for all your kind interest."

"Nay, Sir, thank me not. I own I have neither chick nor child, and so may not be expected to feel as much as a parent would do on such an occasion; but, Sir, I feel for my wards as tenderly as any Father can, I would rather a thousand ills occurred to me than that a hair of their heads should be

injured." His strong voice faltered, "But, enough, I came here to tell my tale, and not to indulge in unavailing sorrow. Let it suffice to tell you I left not a port unexplored on the coast of America; I left not a stone unturned to learn their fate; I rested not day or night; your son had permission from the admiral to devote as much time to the same search, as his duties would permit. I mentally resolved I would not leave the spot until I heard something of them."

"How kind, how good you are," said the listeners.

"And I should have kept my promise, had it not been for a letter from Mr. M., who you know is co-trustee and joint guardian with me of your grandchildren. Of course the loss of such a party soon became known, in fact our anxiety, and all we did, and the sympathy we met with, and the help we obtained, would detain you much too long were I to tell you. But you will not be surprised to hear that the next heir to my wards' estates has intimated his knowledge that some dire misfortune has occurred to the three children on whom the property is entailed, your grandchildren. I, therefore, came home at once. I have consulted Mr. M., I have taken the ablest advice, and where could I have better than from him who is so interested in the matter, and so high in his profession?" Bowing to Gatty's Father. "Also I have seen the once-hasty heir, and settled his business, I have put everything into the hands of Mr. M. regarding the property, and in such training that nothing can be done for a year or two by the next heir, and now I am come down to see you, and take your orders and wishes, and tomorrow I sail for America to prosecute my search, and not leave it until I find them dead or alive."

"You are too kind, too good, one might expect such devotion in one of their relations, but not in one barely connected with them. We know not how to thank you."

With such speeches the whole party were proceeding, but Sir Walter interrupted them, saying, "Nay, nay, say no more, I am not acting so disinterestedly as you think, my conscience would not suffer me to rest easy did I not do my duty to the children of one of my oldest and dearest friends. At his dying request I undertook the charge, and only with life do I mean to relinquish my care over them. Besides, look round amongst all who are now

mourning the loss of those I am about to seek; have they not ties of home, children, professions? I have none. I had but to guard the property of my wards, superintend their education, and prevent their mother spoiling them, and, by this sad event that business is over. It is my duty to seek for them; as a military man and acquainted with the world, I am fitted for adventure and all its consequences. I go with a cheerful heart and hopeful expectations. I have but one sorrow, and that is the mad permission I gave them to go without me." Thus saying, he arose and paced the room rapidly. Gatty's Father rose also, and, taking his hand, solemnly thanked him for what he was about to do as regarded the welfare of his lost child, continuing in this strain, "Your language and energy, Sir Walter, make me wish I could accompany you, but that you know is impossible, serving her Majesty in the capacity I do. But my heart and prayers go with you, and remember that as I cannot indulge my wish to join you in your search, you must command my purse. Ah my Gatty, my pretty darling, did your Father reckon your value by his purse, what worlds could contain the treasure I would give for thee? The merciful God preserve my dear child, and restore her to my arms." All were too much affected to speak for some little time, but the meal being announced as ready, they entered once more into conversation as they ate it.

Emily, the active winder, asked if they had escaped the tempest, what probable fate could have detained them so long? Sir Walter looked up, quickly laid down his knife and fork, and was about to say something, when he corrected himself, and said instead, "You shall know all I can learn when I get to America."

"But," said Charlotte, looking up from between her long curls, with great anxiety, "you do know more only you are afraid to tell us. Pray be kind to us, and tell us all you know." "Why should I tell you what would add to your sorrow, when there may be nothing but conjecture in the idea?" "Oh," said the eager Mother, "tell us all, we are so bewildered and lost in conjectures, that nothing you can tell us could add to the anxiety we are in. Moreover, I think I know what you mean. I have already hinted such a thing to my husband. Are you not afraid they have been captured by the pirates, whose depredations my son has been ordered to subdue?" "Just so, my dear Madam, it was the common opinion of every one, when I left Rio, that they had fallen into the hands of the gang of pirates now infesting those seas. This knowledge has added an additional spur to your son's exertions,

though he did not want it, for the Admiral had been laughing at him, and calling his ship a 'Will o' the Wisp,' she seemed to be in every port every day. I can assure you, Sir," turning to the Father, "you may, amidst all your sorrow, congratulate yourself on having for a son one of the most promising officers in Her Majesty's service, and it is well known too." The dear beloved parents needed such a balm to their harassed minds. "But, can you," said Gatty's Father, "form any conjecture as to what would be their fate, say they were in the hands of the pirates?" "I took good care, Sir, before I left Rio, to offer very tempting ransoms, and to publish them in all quarters, and it is well known they are a very needy set, and that so much money will be too difficult for them to refuse. So I have every hope, and now I must be off."

Amidst the prayers, tears, blessings, and good wishes of the whole party he departed, leaving the loving Mother comfortable, the christian Father resigned, the sweet anxious sisters hopeful. But the weary months flew by; the distant parents came to talk over the fate of the lost ones; the letters from America grew brief and desponding; hope died totally away in the breasts of some; Sir Walter again visited England, and again returned to pursue his search; H.M.S. C—— was on the eve of being ordered home; some went into deep mourning, as if their nearest and dearest were but just dead; the over-hasty heir was beginning to threaten; the letters home ceased, as if it were better not to write at all than to write disappointment.

Had years gone by since that pretty drawing room had disclosed the affectionate family mourning their lost ones on Christmas-day? Had not Christmas come and gone, and yet they were still mourning? Time will show. It takes the sick couch, the dying words, the quivering breath, the last sigh, the solemn funeral pomp, to make death seem reality, to be assured we have lost "the light of our eyes," to be certain that one from amongst us has gone, and that we shall see his face no more.

Without all this, was it possible to feel that so large a gap was made in the family circle, such a rent was torn from the flourishing tree, and yet no sign was given to show how it was done?

Weep on, beloved mourners, weep on, but not for ever. Have we not a home, where no such ties can be severed, no such grief felt? This is but a

passage to a better world; why should we grieve at what occurs to us herein, when we have the home of the blessed before us, the rest of the faithful awaiting us. In such words spake the pious, humble, consistent Father to his family, and they were comforted; and as months flew by, they whispered and talked of their lost ones, as if they were already denizens of the bright world beyond the tomb, and peace was restored to the family.

CHAPTER XXIV.

It fortunately happened that we had so much to do we could not weep all day; moreover, Jenny, who was very methodical, thought if we went on crying all the evening, how was she to get the tea ready. Accordingly, with some hesitation, having shewn her face several times before, she ventured to enquire if she might take away the remains of our feast. On this we all roused up, and bestirred ourselves; the girls helped to wash up; the little ones ran out to amuse themselves; I swept the floor, while Schillie put the room tidy; Madame having gone to lay down to cure her sad headache. We then all went down to the sea to bathe and enjoy the cool breeze, and at night we went to bed sorrowful but thankful for the many mercies above, around, about us.

On the morrow, lessons were to begin seriously, and some seemed to think it almost a hanging matter, so doleful did they look. They were to have that part of the room nearest the door, as being lighter and more airy. The maids had the rest of the room for laying the meals, while Schillie and I had to dispose of ourselves any way we could, so it was out of the way.

We had a long conversation on this particular morning, which I began by saying, "We must now begin to think of making discoveries, and storing food against the rainy weather."

Schillie.—"Good woman, how fidgety you are. I do think you might allow me a little rest after building that horrid house and labouring so hard."

Mother.—"But we shall look so silly if we have nothing to eat, and it is impossible to get out during the wet weather."

Schillie.—"That's granted, I cannot abide wet weather."

Mother.—"Then making discoveries is your principal delight; and you may combine amusement and use together."

Schillie.—"A thing I abominate. I hate joining two things, and I cannot be amused when all the time I am thinking I am so useful."

Mother.—"Then sit down here, while I go and perpetrate this horrid crime!"

Schillie.—"Now, June, you are going too far, as if I would suffer you to stir a yard without me; you will be tumbling over some precipice, get eaten up by a huge turtle, or light on another great snake. Now, come along, what's the first discovery we are to make?"

Mother.—"That's more than I can settle, because I am quite in the dark at present about what we require. But, if you must have a decided answer, pray discover some shoes and boots."

Schillie.—"Now you must talk common sense if you mean me to help you. I heard that little demure Jenny, who thinks of nothing but the children, coming to you this morning with a complaint about the number of holes in her darling's only pair of shoes."

Mother.—"Oh but she brought in her apron the whole establishment of young boots and shoes, that I might see the dilapidated condition in which they were."

Schillie.—"And what did you say to that?"

Mother.—"I looked at her gravely and said, 'Then Jenny, order the carriage, and tell Goode I shall go to H—— this evening to buy boots and shoes for the young ones.' I was sorry after I had indulged in this joke, for first of all she looked perplexed, then she looked sorrowful, and finally she bundled up her miserable cargo, and fled in a burst of tears."

Schillie.—"Then she is a greater goose than I imagined. She would have been more sensible had she devised some means of repairing them, without bothering you."

Mother.—"But they are past repair."

Schillie.—"Then she might have tried to concoct new ones."

Mother.—"Perhaps she does not like combining amusement and business together."

Schillie.—"Now, June, you are too bad, and to punish you I'll not help you a bit with your boots and shoes."

Mother.—"Suppose we take to going without any."

Schillie.—"Yes, and get bitten to death with these horrid scorpions, or, look here, see how pleasant to put one's naked foot on these black ants."

Mother.—"Then it seems clear we must have boots and shoes."

Schillie.—"Of course, who doubted it?"

Mother.—"Then let us go and discover something that will somehow do for them."

Schillie.—"You always come round me in such a manner, that I begin to think if you told me to do so I should be creeping out of my skin some day."

Mother.—"Pray don't disturb yourself with that idea, as I rather want to clothe you than disrobe you. For our next discovery must be something of which to make dresses."

Schillie.—"Are you gone mad; who wants dresses, have we not enough to last us for a year at least?"

Mother.—"Yes, that I know, but I want to make the discovery, and get expert in the business before our own clothes are quite gone. It will be so awkward to have no clothes at all."

Schillie.—"Very much so."

Mother.—"Now do you know I have already had a great idea that this is the palm tree, out of which they make sago. Here you see are the young ones, small prickly shrubs, and here they are growing up into trees, and this one that I first pointed out is covered with a whitish dust, which I have read is an indication that the sago is ready to be taken."

Schillie.—"You seem very learned on the subject, but are you going to make boots and shoes out of sago?"

Mother (laughing).—"No, no, I don't want to confine my discoveries only to boots and shoes, I am for discovering everything, and I meant to have

told you of this discovery before, for I conjectured it when you used to make me lie down to rest in this spot while you did my work."

Schillie.—"And very lucky it is that you have some one with an ounce of sense near you to make you rest. You don't work race horses like carters, but a Suffolk Punch is made for use, and all the better for it."

Mother.—"You don't compliment yourself, Mrs. Suffolk Punch, though I agree you do the work of the animal you liken yourself to. But I beg you won't compare me to anything so useless as a racer, who is only required for a few days hard labour, and then may die, having fulfilled the purpose of filling the owner's pockets."

Schillie.—"You know nothing about the matter. You don't suppose that horses are bred so highly merely for running races. It is to improve the breed of horses, and you may go to the moon and never——"

Mother.—"Look, look, what a lovely tree!"

Schillie.—"So it is. Let us sit down, while I fish out my book, and discover what it is. Now then for characteristics. Why here is a picture of it. What a nice book this is. It's a nutmeg tree. Then it may go to the dogs, for I hate nutmegs."

Mother.—"I don't like them either, but I have heard they are very good preserved, and, besides, some of the others may like them, so let us see if any are ripe. No! none at all, so it's lucky we are indifferent about nutmegs at present."

Schillie.—"All this shrubby stuff about here, looking something like Jerusalem artichoke, is ginger I think."

Mother.—"Yes, it is, so we will take some home, as it is very good for Madame. What nice large roots it has, but I don't call it a shrub. Shrubs are bushy things."

Schillie.—"Call it what you like, so we may have some preserved. I could eat it for breakfast, dinner, and tea. Now, here are your boots and shoes growing on this Ita palm. Look, my knowing little book says the leaves are enclosed in cases, which serve for shoes, and this is the exact description of

these tall fellows. Now, June, if we can only take some home to Jenny she will be as pleased as Punch, and so shall I, for I did not think your fidgetiness would end in such a fine encouraging manner."

Mother.—"But, good lack, as you say, how are we ever to get at them; this tree must be at least a hundred feet high, and all the others seem bigger, and all the leaves are at the top; almost sky-high they look."

Schillie.—"We must cut one down, there is no help for it. I will run home for a couple of hatchets, and mind you don't stir from hence until I return, and don't get eaten up, for your life, by anything."

Mother.—"Suppose you bring the girls with you; we shall never cut it down ourselves without aching all over, and they will be so glad to get out of school."

Schillie.—"I'll be bound they will. But first I shall say only those are to come out who have been good, for the pleasure of seeing Miss Gatty screw up her countenance into ineffable disgust, for I know she will have been naughty."

Mother.—"You know you will do nothing of the sort, but, on the contrary, say that Gatty is more wanted than the others."

Schillie.—"I confess I have a weakness for that child, she is so preposterously mischievous."

Mother.—"Now I have a weakness for her, because she is like the knights of old, 'the soul of honour.' Now she fires up, and now she ruins her pocket handkerchiefs if anything is said derogatory to her own country or to her Queen. Did you hear or rather see her this morning while they were reading their history, when Madame praised Napoleon Buonaparte at the expense of the Duke of Wellington?"

Schillie.—"Yes. I misdoubt me that I shall find her in sad disgrace. She will have endeavoured to soothe her wounded feelings by putting spiders on Sybil, changing Serena's book, mislaying Madame's alderman, which is neither more nor less than the name Gatty has given that great fat pencil with which Madame marks their books, and rat-ta-tals them up when they are looking dull and stupid."

Mother.—"Don't come without her, however, for she is the strongest. It's a pity Sybil is so good as never to be in disgrace, for her little delicate fingers are of no use in such a case."

Schillie.—"Indeed Sybil and Serena are too stupid for anything. They learn all their books, they like all their lessons, they agree to all Madame's crinkums crankums, and they are so horridly good, it quite puts me out."

Mother.—"Pooh, nonsense. If we had three Gattys here we should find the island too hot to hold us. Be content at having two of the best girls in the world to deal with."

Schillie.—"I must say Serena is a tip-top girl, she makes Miss Gatty look about her; but I must be off."

During her absence, I sat down upon an old stump of a tree, and by and by I heard a little rustling in the bushes, out of which came a sort of animal like a large rat, but it had a flat tail, and each side of this tail was adorned with hair like fringe. It looked at me steadily, and, except its tail, was not an ugly creature. I did not choose to be frightened; but still as another and another came, and all stood steadily gazing at me, I had a sort of qualm that some rats fly at one's throat, and, though not really injured, I might perhaps get severely bitten if they attacked me. I was therefore glad to hear the merry voices in the distance coming nearer and nearer; and, as the rats heard the unusual sounds, they slunk away as if by magic, for I could hardly perceive the movement by which they disappeared.

Schillie (quite breathless).—"Well, here you are quite safe. I am always so afraid when I leave you that you get into some mischief. But you have seen something, I know by your face."

Mother.—"Then don't look as if I was injured. I have only seen some odd-looking sorts of rats with flat tails."

Schillie.—"Then Otty must come with his gun and shoot them, for I dare say now that snake is dead the animals of all kinds will increase very much. I only wish there was a snake among the gnat tribe. Anything like the way in which I am teased by things biting me is not to be described."

The girls were delighted with the business set before them, and even Madame appeared with a hatchet in her delicate fingers, but without being able to make even an apology of a stroke.

When the tree was down, we proceeded to shoe ourselves, intent upon delighting and surprising Jenny. But we never regarded a gummy substance exuding from all parts of the tree, which plagued us for some time afterwards, destroying the stockings, and very, very difficult to get off, also blistering the skin a little, but these sheathes for the leaves of the Ita palm really made capital shoes. We had only to dry them a little in the sun. They did not however last very long, and it was no uncommon thing for the boys to want a new pair every day. Notwithstanding there being such an abundance of these naturally-growing ready-made shoes, we were not sorry at the ingenious invention of Sybil and Serena, who, after repeated efforts, contrived to plait most excellent shoes out of grass.

One day, penetrating a little farther than usual, we came to a rich little glen, running down to the sea. Here, digging up some plants, as was our usual custom, to make fresh discoveries, we found the mould of a beautiful bright red colour; this shaded off into deep chocolate or bright yellow. We could not discover any metallic substance in it, or that it tasted of anything, but it painted our fingers whenever we touched it, and when first turned up was glossy and shining. Near this place grew some sugar canes, curiously striped, and a tree or shrub, seven or eight feet high, with an oblong hairy pod; something like a chestnut, hanging to it; inside were about thirty or forty seeds, buried in a pulp of bright red colour, smelling rather fragrant. We found out afterwards that these seeds were good for fevers, and the pulp made very good red paint.

The tobacco plant we all knew very well. It grew in the most rank manner here. But one of the most lovely trees we had yet discovered was one twenty feet high, with a grey, smooth, shining trunk, apparently destitute of bark. It had beautiful dark green leaves, with an astonishing profusion of white flowers, so deliciously fragrant, that we sat to the wind side of it with the greatest delight. It had berries on it, out of which squeezed a sweet oil smelling of cloves.

We did not like the situation of our house nearly so much as on the cliffs; we had so little air, and were so much tormented by insects of all kinds. Some of the ant hills were at least three feet high; and upon merely walking near them, the angry little inhabitants came swarming out in multitudes to resent the supposed injury.

On the cactuses, which grew very large, and in a most luxuriant manner, we discovered what we supposed were the insects for making cochineal, but we did not think that a grand discovery, but, on the contrary, thought the cotton plant a much greater gift.

I had been used to spin when in Scotland, having taken a fancy to the thing. But, not all the wishes in the world could produce a spinning wheel, so I kept my desires secret until I saw some hope of accomplishment. Every day each person had to bring in their quota of discoveries and additions to our larder and stores, for, though we knew nothing about the climate we imagined ourselves looking remarkably silly, should bad weather come on, and find us unprovided.

Taking one day as a specimen for all the rest, after three hours exploring, in different parties, we produced our treasures, as follows:—Madame had gathered a number of small reeds or rushes, out of which she had concocted two very pretty and useful baskets, one of which had been immediately appropriated by a hen. For, while she was busy with the other, this hen thought she had never beheld so cosy a nest, and, therefore, laid an egg in it. This was of course given to Madame, for her supper, as a reward for her ingenuity. Schillie came dragging with her, besides innumerable other plants and curiosities, an enormous root, as thick as her waist.

Schillie.—"Now then, young ones, come round and see what this is. You see when I cut it what milky stuff flows from it."

"Yes," said they, "we see; may we not have some to put into our own tea? It is so nasty without milk."

Schillie.—"For goodness sake, brats, don't be so rash, it's rank poison."

Mother, Madame, and a whole Chorus.—"Then, what good is it to us?"

Schillie.—"Well! don't make such a row, and you shall see. Here, Jenny, you and some of the young ladies help me to rasp or scrape it up, but, for your life don't let it touch the skin, or you may die, but, at all events, you may get blisters on your hands."

Mother (very cross).—"How can you be so absurd, Schillie, as to bring such a dangerous thing amongst the children?"

Schillie.—"Now, pray, keep yourself quiet until I have hurt one of them. You told me to make discoveries, and this is a superb one. Now, we have got a good heap. Fetch a cloth, Jenny, pop it in; now hold one while I hold the other, and twist and squeeze as if Master Felix's life depended thereon. And now behold."

So opening the cloth we discovered some nice white flowery-looking stuff, which she declared was tapioca, and which we discovered made most excellent bread. We really voted this discovery of the cassada root quite a grand discovery, though I was always very fidgety about the poisonous milk in it. But the loaves made from the flower were delicious. She, of course, had many more things to show us, but I will only take one from each of us. Sybil had been indefatigable in her search for hemp, and had found a species of grass, which she had beaten between two stones in the water, and it had spread into innumerable fine threads, so that hers was a most valuable discovery. Serena had found a perfect horde of turtle's eggs, besides eggs innumerable of all kinds of birds. Gatty, we all knew, could not have discovered much, for she had been running from one Mother to another, flying off again to the girls, helping the little ones in innumerable difficulties, and doing anything but minding her own duties. However, nothing undaunted, she opened an apology for a handkerchief, and out waddled a large odd crab, for which Schillie greatly applauded her, and said she would have him boiled for supper. "But I have discovered something else," said Gatty, with a mischievous twinkling of her eyes, and opening a paper box, out sprang a horrible spider, three inches round I am sure, black and hairy, faintly spotted. Madame and Sybil fled, the little ones shrieked, Schillie scolded, and in the midst of the uproar the spider bolted, and peace was restored. Zoë had discovered a beautiful species of jessamine tree, most fragrant in smell, and on which, for a wonder, there were no insects whatever, and she therefore supposed it must be something good.

We found out that no ants would touch the wood, so it proved very useful to us. Winny bent and quivered under the weight of an enormous curiously-shaped gourd, and triumphantly declared her discovery was nearly as big as the little Mother's. "But it is no discovery, little one," said Serena, "for we have had gourds before." "But it is a discovery," persisted the little one, "for it is such a big fellow, and it has a growing in and a growing out, quite unlike the others." So we thanked her warmly, and Jenny said she was and had been undone to possess a gourd of that very particular shape. Lilly had discovered so many wonderful things (upon supposition) that we contented ourselves with thanking her for some large and useful shells which would serve for many purposes. The boys had been so intent on manufacturing fishing lines that they had spent their time wandering vaguely about, hoping fishing lines would fall from the skies for them, but as no such thing happened, they had pulled long hairy lines from the cactuses, and they had also brought in their pockets a fruit like an apple outside, but it was full of an insipid kind of custard. Jenny had got some sand for scouring her floors and kettles, also she said she had got a plant that looked like one in an old book she had, from which they made soap. This we found correct, and it proved a most valuable discovery; it was called the soap-wort. Hargrave had contented herself with gathering the most beautiful flowers she could see, at the same time bewailing over their rapid destruction, only wishing that they were artificial ones that she might ornament the young ladies' dresses. It was on this day that my discovery consisted of the cinnamon tree. But all this will appear tedious, so I will go on to the time when we were roused from our discoveries, pretty walks, out-door amusements, and healthy exercise, by a terrific thunder storm.

CHAPTER XXV.

We had become somewhat accustomed to the storms, and, though this one was terrific, and also followed by no interval of sunshine to break us in for the wet weather, yet our condition was so greatly ameliorated, we thought but little of it. Our house was waterproof even when the rain came down like the sea itself pouring over us. The wind was furious, but the nook we had selected was most sheltered, and, but for the uproar it made among the trees, we should have hardly known the real extent of the hurricane. Sometimes the thunder cracking over our heads awoke us in the night, and we congregated together for companionship and comfort. In the day-time we were very busy; I was inventing a spinning wheel; Schillie and the girls concocting chessmen; the boys knocking up shelves, seats, and boxes; the maids labouring through a perfect haycock of rent clothes and damaged stockings; somebody always singing, and sometimes that somebody was everybody. In the evening, Madame played, and everybody danced for an hour by the light of one candle; when breathless and tired, stories were told, each taking it in turn. A quick and pleasant three weeks passed, for which we daily thanked the Giver of all good.

When the sun shone once more our occupations were innumerable, leaving us no leisure from early morn, until the darkness came. What with gardening, lessons, manufacturing food and clothes, we had our hands full. It was astonishing to see how active the young ones were in turning everything to use; how quick and clever they became in all sorts of ways that belonged more to older heads. It is true there were some symptoms of fine ladyism that grumbled at washing clothes, grinding sand, and cleaning up dirty dishes; the latter was carried to so great a height that Zoë and Lilly came to me with a flat refusal to wash the breakfast plates. "Why?" said I. "Because they are so dirty," said they. "Very well," said I, "you need not do it." But they never objected again to any work, for their dirty plates were put before them, without any remark, each day, until they washed them of their own accord; and the elder girls let slip no opportunity of commenting

upon fine ladies, who expressed great anxiety to help others, but must have the plates cleaned before they could wash or wipe them, and supposed they must have people to sweep the way before them, others to hand their food to their mouths. In fact, the irony ran so high, and was felt so sorely, that a private petition was sent in to have it stopped. This I was most glad to do, for our meals had been rendered a little unpleasant by mortified tears bedewing the face of the gentle Zoë, while indignant sobs and haughty looks betokened the harassed feelings of the high-spirited Lilly.

As may be supposed, we had many conversations regarding our future fate, and the probability of passing our days in this island.

Mother.—"It is the idea which always makes me so anxious, Schillie, to retain every possible memorial of our civilized life. Should our children and their descendants remain on this island, they will live to thank the Mother who worries you so with all the spinning, weaving, and other inventions that tease you."

Schillie.—"So you expect the children to marry, do you? Well, there will be plenty of old maids left to keep up the civilized art of scandal, seeing there are but two husbands for these six girls."

Felix.—"Don't call me a husband, cousin Schillie, for I don't intend to marry."

Oscar.—"I don't mind marrying Gatty, because she will go out shooting with me."

Schillie.—"And what has set you against matrimony, you imp of mischief?"

Felix.—"Why I don't like being called grandfather, and so I won't marry and have grandchildren."

This unfortunate announcement drew upon him the fate he wished to avoid, and, spite of his indignation, and tears, "grandfather" became his *sobriquet* until they were tired of the joke.

But we renewed our conversation, and, though I used my best arguments, and had Madame on my side, and though the battle waxed hot and loud, and was oft renewed between us, I never could get Schillie to allow that it was

of the slightest use our thus exerting ourselves. This surprised me a good deal, for she had so much plain good sense, and was so naturally clever, and gifted with such brains for invention and concoction, that I expected to find her the champion of my plans, instead of the damper she proved. The hot and relaxing climate might have had some effect on her constitution, or the good hope she always carried about with her that we were not to remain here for ever, might make her reluctant to take trouble for nothing.

But it proved always in the end, the more busy and interested we were in our occupations the quicker time went, and less of it was spent in those vain regrets and idle wishes that left wounds on the heart which nothing could heal.

In justice, I must say, when fairly roused, none worked so hard or so well and the little workpeople had to look sharply about them when she was in superintendence.

She was in a cross mood one day, when she discovered me writing.

Schillie.—"What can you be doing, June?"

Mother (hesitating a little).—"I am writing a journal."

Schillie.—"Now, pray, tell me for what purpose."

Mother.—"It will be interesting to us to recur to some day; or it will serve to enlighten our own descendants, should we never leave this place."

Schillie.—"Well, I could not think you would be so absurd. Who wants to recall this horrible time; or what possible interest can you put into the details of such a life as ours."

Mother.—"I grant it's very difficult, but you are at liberty to look at it."

Schillie (reading).—"Ha! a thunderstorm (very interesting). Another (truly pathetic). Felix ill (the dear pet, how sorry his grandchildren will be to hear it). Gatty in mischief (when is she ever out of it?) Schillie worked the most of all (and what has she got to do besides?) Very merry tea (what a fib, when we have had no tea this month). Sybil so amiable (yes, quite mawkishly so). Our dear captain (good me! what a monody). The good

Smart (perfect epitaphs over them all, pity they are not in rhyme). Well, June, of all the nonsense I ever read your journal seems the crown thereof."

Mother.—"I don't pretend to write anything amusing, for how can I with so few incidents; only I wished to keep a sort of journal."

Schillie.—"It seems to me nothing but about the children, how they were naughty and how they got good again. Why don't you write the geological structure of the island, the botanical history, and a whole account of the birds and beasts."

Mother.—"That I leave for your abler head and pen."

Schillie.—"Then it will never be done. I hate the place so much, I would not record a single thing about it."

Mother.—"If that is the case, leave my poor journal alone. I grant it is everything you say, dull, stupid, and monotonous, nevertheless, I have a fancy to keep it."

Schillie.—"Then, pray, indulge your fancy, and, in addition to keeping your journal, keep it locked up, for it is quite enough to endure all the children's twaddle, without writing it down."

My spinning-wheel answered remarkably well; but all my spinning was of little avail, as we had no idea of weaving. Schillie promised if she was not bothered by having to build more houses, she would try her hand at inventing a weaving machine the next rainy season. Luckily my yarn or thread was as coarse as needs be, and answered very well for crocheting and knitting. In both these arts we became wonderfully skilful; sewed crochet boots and shoes, while others knitted petticoats and jackets, so that we were in no particular fear that when our present clothes failed we should become a tribe of white savages. The children grew like the vegetation, and Gatty stalked over the ground like a young Patagonian. We had no lack of food, though we had neither beef or mutton, but poultry, birds, fish, eggs, and turtle, with innumerable vegetables and fruits, were surely enough for our simple party. In the midst of our many avocations, sighs and tears would arise for those we loved; neither could the the affection we bore each other, and the peaceful, useful, and happy lives we led, obliterate from our minds all we had lost. It was no uncommon thing, especially on Sunday, for

us to collect round a favourite tree, and talk of and picture to ourselves what was passing at each home. In remembering the simple steadfast faith of my Father, the hopeful, sweet, loving nature of my Mother, I could not but think that through their virtues we might hope for a restoration to home. As the sins of the parents are visited on the children, so are their virtues means of showering blessings to the third and fourth generation. Was it possible that we were to be finally severed from the world for ever? all the comforts of civilized life fresh in our minds and thoughts. And here I sometimes paused, thinking to myself should we be restored in a few years, in what sort of state and condition should I deliver up each of my precious charges to their parents. I could not disguise from myself that their present mode of life was not suited for the highly-bred and polished youth of the nineteenth century. Madame, I must say, whatever employment they were about, from cutting down a tree to washing and peeling potatoes, never failed to inculcate a ladylike way of doing either employment, and spared no pains to make them as accomplished and graceful as our limited means afforded her.

Sybil was naturally so feminine and elegant that no rough work could spoil her. Serena had a bounding springing freedom of action that befitted a graceful young savage, and was too healthful and pretty to make any act one not suiting to her; while that dear young leviathan, Gatty, could have been graceful nowhere, though beaming with health and strength; how she did grow, and how she found out she was stronger than the little Mother, and how she teased her in consequence, enticing her upon little shelves of rock, under pretence of having discovered a new plant, and then keeping her there, though I might be calling for my lost companion until I was hoarse. Mischievous Gatty, and yet good and loving as she was mischievous. Serena managed her admirably, and could make her do whatever she liked; and it was pretty to see the sylph-like girl holding the great strong powerful Gatty in awe, lecturing her in a gentle, grave, simple way, with a sweet low voice, that murmured like a stream. Sybil might talk of duty, and "you ought" and "you ought not," until her fair face was flushed with talking, but she either found herself showered over with insects, or laid gently on the greensward, or swung up into a branch of a tree, from which she feared to jump down. No mercy had Gatty upon the gentle soft Sybil. The only one among the children who did not seem happy was Oscar. He had no boy of his own age to associate with in boyish

pastimes; he was brought prematurely forward, from being the eldest male of our company; he had been passionately attached to his home, and he could bear no allusion to it, or the probability of not seeing it again, without being seriously unhappy for the day. Fond as they were of each other, his brother was too young to enter into the feelings that were unnaturally old, because forced on him.

If Schillie and Gatty devoted themselves to him for a day, he seemed more happy, but he loved to mope about by himself with his gun; and while he grew tall and strong, his face was pale, and his brow thoughtful beyond his years. Many were my anxious thoughts about him, and I lamented a thousand times having suffered Smart to leave, for he would at all events have been some sort of companion to him. Of all our party, he certainly was the only one who invariably remained grave and quiet, whatever might be the pleasantries in which we indulged.

Madame talked for an hour upon the dreadful fact of having no new music for the girls, and used the same phrases and words concerning there being no shop to buy a new cap as she did to the anxieties we had endured and the fears that others must be enduring for us.

Her horror at having no chemist near to make up her tonic mixture equalled the horror she felt at what had become of our companions, or seeing the girls do anything inconsistent to her notions as befitting young ladies caused her as dreadful a shock as the thunder. She was afflicted with fits of dying perpetually, which we remedied the best way we could, generally finding out that a long confidential talk about her sorrows, making her will, and confiding her last wishes to us, restored her as soon as any other recipe. But she was so good, and so fond of the children, that Madame had but to speak to have us all her messengers; even Schillie succumbed to her when the dying fit came on, matter of fact as she was, and scolding me as she did for giving in to it. I had exhausted all my efforts at consolation in one fit, and sent in Schillie to take my place.

"Well, Madame," began Schillie, in a great, stout, hearty, anti-invalidish voice, "better, of course, you are, I see."

Madame (in a faint whisper).—"Ah, my dear Madam, my dear kind friend, I may say now I am going to leave you."

The great Voice.—"I am proud to be your friend always, Madame, but it's all nonsense talking of leaving us. Why you look as well and rosy——"

Madame (a little hysterical).—"Fever, dear Mrs. E., all fever; my poor frame cannot support this long."

The Voice.—"Fever, is it? Let me count your pulse. Very good pulse, rather weak I should say. Take a glass of port wine and you will be all right."

Madame.—"Dear friend, your robust frame knows not what it is to suffer. Ah, the agonies I endure, the insupportable suffering!"

Schillie (a little softer).—"Rheumatism, I dare say; I have it sometimes in my knees, and it is very aggravating."

Madame.—"Alas, alas, would that it were; but I must not lose my precious moments, I must try to speak while I am able."

Schillie.—"Don't hurry, don't hurry, dear Madame. I have nothing to do at present, I can wait as long as you like."

Madame.—"Dear Mrs. E., thanks, but it is I, it is my time that is so short."

Schillie.—"Oh, come, come, that's all nonsense. I see no symptoms of dying about you. Indeed you look better than I have seen you for ages."

Madame.—"It's all deception. My time has come, dear friend, and to you I wish to confide my last wishes."

Schillie.—"But I never can keep a secret. Don't confide anything to me."

Madame.—"They are not secrets. I only wish to confide my beloved little ones to your care after I am gone."

Schillie.—"But I hate children, Madame. June will take care of them."

Madame.—"Ah, I know she will; but she is so fond, so tender a Mother, she sees no faults in them. There is my darling Sybil, she is certainly, if a human being can be, faultless."

Schillie.—"She is a very good soul in her way, Madame, but shockingly untidy."

Madame.—"But her lovely smile, her sweet engaging manners. My Serena is something like her, but, being so much with Gertrude, she is a little less ladylike in manners than I could wish. Could you, dear Mrs. E., just hint to her when I am gone——"

Schillie.—"Oh, good lack! no, Madame, I can hint nothing. I'll tell her you thought her unladylike if you wish; but I think both she and Gatty are first-rate Girls. They are afraid of nothing, and your pattern, Sybil, jumps at a spider."

Madame.—"Dear angel! I must go on. My lovely Zoë will certainly have a poke if she is not watched."

Schillie.—"I'll poke her up always, Madame, I promise you, for your sake."

Madame.—"Thank you, thank you, and my pretty Winifred. Have you not observed how she turns in her right foot?"

Schillie.—"No indeed, Madame, I never observed either right or left foot, but I'll look out, if I remember, for the future."

Madame.—"Thanks, dear friend, I think that is all about my darlings, save Lilly's eyes."

Schillie.—"They are very good eyes, Madame, and neither poke or turn in, which would be a squint I suppose."

Madame.—"They are lovely eyes, of heaven's own blue, but she ruins them by reading no much."

Schillie.—"Well, I'll stop her reading. Anything more Madame?"

Madame.—"Yes, I should like to be buried under trees near our church."

Schillie.—"Very well, I can safely promise that, as I suppose I shall help to dig your grave myself."

Madame then wound up in such a pathetic manner that Schillie was obliged to have recourse to her pocket handkerchief, and came blubbering out of the room, muttering that though she believed she was only an old humbug she would be very sorry if the old lady really died.

She was only just recovering this fit one very sultry day when we carried her to the edge of the cliff to catch a breath of air if she could. It was so extremely hot we could do nothing, and therefore lay beside her, instead of leaving a little girl in attendance as usual. We fancied something must be about to occur, for every breath seemed as if drawing in hot air. I, with what Schillie called my usual fidgetiness, was imagining horror upon horrors, when, suddenly looking at the sea, we beheld it rise and fall as if one tremendous wave passed over it. Almost immediately the whole island seemed to tremble under our feet, a rumbling and at the same time crashing sound quite surrounded us. "An earthquake," cried some, while all sprang to their feet. A breathless silence ensued, but all nature seemed as if nothing had occurred. "The house," said Schillie. "The boys!" I exclaimed. We flew down headlong towards the rocks from which they usually fished. Not a trace of them or the rocks, the sea was boiling beyond what we had never seen covered before. I sat stupidly down on the sands, as if waiting for the waves to cast my sons up at my feet.

"They may not have been fishing," said Schillie. I did not heed her until the sharp cry of a child in pain struck on my ear. We rushed towards the place, and found Oscar supporting his brother, who was screaming violently. They were alive; all other things seemed to me as nothing. As I took him in my arms, Oscar told me that, finding the fish would not bite, and feeling excessively tired, they had agreed to go to a shady ledge on the rocks, and sleep for an hour. He was awakened by a strange noise, as well as being thrown rather violently from the place where he lay; opening his eyes, he beheld Felix some feet below him, lying apparently dead. He ran and picked him up, and throwing some water on his face from the brook near which they had lain down, in the course of some minutes he opened his eyes and knew his brother, but on moving he shrieked with pain. Oscar wrung his hands, and cried as he said, "Oh, Mother, Mother, what is the matter, will he die? Who has hurt him? What has happened? Oh my brother, my brother, I should die for my Felix." The sight of Oscar's distress caused a cessation in Felix's screams. He put out one little hand, and said, "Don't cry, Otty, I'll bear it, only don't cry so." "Bear what, my darling," said I, "where are you hurt?" "I am hurted all about, Mama; but is it a snake that has eaten me, or who killed me? I'll be a man, dear Otty. I'll not scream any more, if you will only not cry so, because I shall cry, I know I shall, I must

cry just a little, but it is not the pain." As he tried thus to comfort his brother, the colour fled from his cheeks, his eyes closed, the rosy lips paled, he fell back in my arms motionless. I thought he was dead, but he was in my arms, the wild waves had him not for their prey; could it be possible that I felt comforted as I clasped him closer? Wine was brought, water poured on his face; and, as we laid him on the sward, his right arm fell in an unnatural position. It was broken. Stripping off his clothes, and carefully examining, we found him bruised in various places, but no other bones injured save the collar bone. Schillie set both arm and collar bone. We bandaged them as well as we could, and then carefully carrying him to the old tent place, we did our best to restore him to consciousness. In this we succeeded; and, though for many days he lay in a dangerous fever, once that was subdued he grew well astonishingly fast. The arm reunited perfectly, but the collar bone retains a lump on it to this day.

The first symptom he gave us of returning health and strength was in a conversation he had with his beloved Jenny, who was so occupied in nursing him her attentions to us were of the most scanty kind. Imagine a little figure, clothed in a little white gown, his arm and shoulder bandaged up, lying on a lot of cushions. The smallest little white face peeped out from a mass of hair, and a little brown monkey, with a face about the same size, watches the different clouds of restlessness or pleasure that passed over the little white face with a curious mixture of wonder and curiosity. Jenny appears with a dish and exposes it to view. The little invalid, with a lordly air, surveys his dinner.

Felix.—"A nasty chicken again, Jenny."

Jenny.—"Oh, Sir, I have roasted it to a turn, and here is egg sauce."

Felix.—"Then give me the egg sauce, and you may have the chicken. I wish chickens were never invented."

Jenny.—"Would you like a duck, Sir?"

Felix.—"No, duck is nastier. I want a mutton chop, Jenny."

Jenny.—"But I have not got one, Sir."

Felix.—"Then a beefsteak."

Jenny.—"Indeed, I wish I could get one for you, Sir."

Felix.—"Well, I don't mind, just for once, eating some boiled leg of mutton."

Jenny.—"Oh, my darling, then you must want mutton very bad, and you know there is not such a thing on the island."

Felix.—"Then it's a bad place, and I wish we were away, having nothing but chickens and chickens, ducks and ducks, until we shall all crow and quack."

Jenny.—"Oh, don't, Sir, don't go for to move, and get in such a passion, you'll displace the bones, and make your Mama so unhappy."

Felix.—"I am sure nobody is so unhappy as me; and as for your chicken, there——"

And with a kick of the little impudent foot away went the chicken out of its dish into Jenny's face, who forgave her darling on the spot; nay, even came to us for congratulations on his recovery. "For," says she, "he is as impudent as ever he was when well, and is that not a good sign, Ma'am."

Schillie.—"Wash the remains of the chicken off your face, Jenny, and then I'll tell you my opinion."

CHAPTER XXVI.

The fact that our beloved island was subject to earthquakes disturbed us considerably. Storms we began to think quite common, hurricanes nothing, rain but another mode for enjoyment; but to be swallowed up by the earth, by the very land that had proved a haven to us when storm-beset and wave-tossed, seemed an infliction not to be got over.

For some time we imagined every noise a rumbling earthquake, the swift running feet of the children as if the house was coming down, the noisy thumping of the washing stones as indicative of the rocks falling over us. This induced us to think, much to Schillie's horror, of seeking a new abode during the very hot weather on a smooth plain where no rocks could cover us, nor trees fall on us, though we could not prevent the earth opening her mouth and swallowing us up.

In one of our exploring parties for this purpose we came upon the site and signs of an old habitation, evidently having been a substantial and large dwelling, with remains of garden and palisade. We know not how it escaped the observation of our kind captain, unless from the fact that it lay on the open plain, and just before it was a plantation of trees, so that, unless you walked across the plain, and went behind the trees, you would see nothing of it; and they being able to see all across, doubtless thought it labour lost to investigate what seemed open before them.

Here we fancied had been the lair of the great serpent, from the close smell and other circumstances about the place; but it was with feelings rather akin to awe that we investigated a place built by other hands than our own. Feeling so assured, as we did, that no mortal was on the island, or apparently had been, but ourselves, we had begun to think really that it was our own, risen out of the sea for us alone, so that Schillie was for a time the only one who took a matter-of-fact view of this appearance to us "Robinson Crusoes" of "Friday's foot." She declared it had been deserted twenty years

and more, and that the roof was a very bad one at the very beginning of it, and not on such a good plan as ours; that certainly she descried a new lichen on the walls, which she went to fetch, and proved herself correct; finally, that there might be some lock-up place within, giving us a clue to the former inhabitants. We accordingly searched, and found various articles of clothing and furniture, evidently of foreign manufacture. Everything was covered some inches thick with a fine sand, which caused insufferable choking and sneezing to those who were heedless. It seemed very apparent that the house had been quitted suddenly, or that something had caused great disorder and confusion. After wasting a great deal of time, talking, thinking, and conjecturing, we at last came to the conclusion that, with some trouble, we might make it a very tidy house, and that we would proceed systematically to clean it, and make it fit for the use of such august people as we were; and, being governed by the soul of honour, every article looking like private property was carefully put away, in case the real owners should arrive, though there was many a thing that would have been rather useful to us. Some books in the Spanish language we kept, as the girls and I thought to amuse ourselves during the next rainy season in teaching ourselves Spanish. "Mighty silly," says Schillie, "taking such unnecessary trouble, as who knows but that there may be nobody to talk to ere long even in English." This old house was very low, and full of rents and holes; also, we discovered that, though on a plain, it was so contrived nobody could perceive it was a habitation unless close to it. From two sides it was quite hidden by trees, though not close to them, from the third side it looked like part of the plantation, and from the fourth side it seemed to be part and parcel of a mound and clump of rocks close by. It had five rooms in it, two not much bigger than closets. Altogether we agreed our new abode had not the open, frank, handsome air of our own home, with its wide-spread doorless entrance, but looked rather like the covered den of people wishing to keep themselves concealed and out of sight. However, we used it in all openness and fairness, and whatever might have been the character of its last inhabitants, we kept open house, never closing the great iron-plated door or the barred shutters; also, we misdoubted they could have been good people, as there was nothing feminine to be found about the place. Nevertheless, we lived in great comfort, and every evening somebody told a new romance as to what had been the fate of the lost and gone, until we wove a history about them, equal to any fairy story ever told, winding up

with one from Felix, who, after giving various touching descriptions as to their numerous qualities and perfections, declared that they died one by one. "How?" said the little girls, looking aghast at such an abrupt conclusion. "They disappeared," said Felix, "one every night." "But that's no story, how did they disappear?" "Oh, you must guess, my story is a riddle." So they guessed and guessed, but, becoming no wiser, they clamourously called on him to tell. "But if you don't guess," said Felix, "how can I tell, for not one of them was left alive." "You are a stupid boy," said Lilly, "and tell a very bad story." "Yours was a much badderer, and you are a stupid girl not to guess that the big snake eat them all up." "Well done, well done," said everybody, "a very good idea. I dare say it did happen." So then we fell upon conjecturing what we should have done to save ourselves under similar circumstances, which gave rise to so many bloody-minded schemes and horrible intentions of torture, that no respectable snake would have ventured near us.

CHAPTER XXVII.

What! has a year gone? Are we celebrating the day of our arrival at Y_R Y_{NYS} U_{NYG}? More, much more, days flee away, weeks speed on, months glide by us. Has hope gone? Are the cheerful strong hearts weary and low? The elastic young spirits, the energetic wills, the high courage and strong energies, could not always last on the full stretch. But why detail the fits of despondency, the listless hopeless state into which we sometimes fell? Suffice it that nature sometimes asserted her rights, while religion kept us from open despair. Many events occurred, wearisome to the reader, though interesting to ourselves. Sometimes we divided, and half lived in one house and half in the other. We then paid each other visits of ceremony, expending much labour, even if no cost, on the feasts we prepared for our company. Also we established a post, in which we wrote imaginary news from England. The girls became very expert in drawing. We spoke all kinds of languages. We invented stories and told them, many of the children's I have preserved, being very clever and amusing. Also we had another earthquake, which led to a great discovery. No less than that the cliffs behind our house, and reaching down to the beach, were one continuous range of caverns, all apparently formed of old coral. Serena was the fortunate discoverer, for, excited by curiosity one day, she insinuated her slender figure in a fissure which had been rent in the rock by the last earthquake. Her exclamations of delight and pleasure caused all those who could follow her to do so; but, alas for the stout Schillie, and the gigantic Gatty, they were compelled to hear the shouts of joy and yet could bear no part; a discovery was made and no Schillie to give her opinion thereon; a new adventure and no Gatty to lend a helping hand. They chafed like lions in a cage, until Madame happily came to their rescue, by suggesting an enlargement of the fissure. But this was not the work of a moment, more especially as every two minutes they were interrupted by the little ones rushing out with fresh wonders to detail, while the big ones shouted more and more.

Gatty squeezed herself through with the loss of half her garments, fully prepared to prove the new discovery nothing, while Schillie, Madame, and I worked for another half hour, and went through like ladies to see a sight which enchanted us. A most magnificent cavern, cool and dark, though some light penetrated in from above somewhere, the ground was covered with fine dry sand, the numerous grotesque shapes and oddities all around the cavern seemed almost made on purpose for little private habitations and snug corners. It was so large in size that it had nothing of the musty feeling of the little caverns below, but was airy, and even bright with sunshine during part of the day. Every body seemed to find a nook or place in it so suited to their minds, that we called it the "Cavern of Content." We nearly deserted our houses during the hot weather, and lived almost entirely in the cavern, everybody choosing their own private apartment, and fitting up according to their own fashion. Schillie grumbled a good deal at the perversity of the cavern in not having suffered itself to be discovered before, and saved her the trouble of building a house. "I declare," said she, "my hands have never been fit to look at since." These hands were her weak point, as I said before, but, as they were just as white and pretty as ever, I would not nibble at her fish for a compliment, and she held them up without a remark from any of us until Gatty pinched them.

The only thing I did not like about the cavern was that it had innumerable passages and windings about, and odd places, with dark holes, and ghostly-looking corners. I was not satisfied until I had explored them all, blocking up narrow little slits, and doing all I could to rout out anything that might be harbouring there. There was one passage very long and steep, the entrance to it out of the cavern was so narrow we did not notice it at first; but, when once through, we had every here and there light, and it led in one or two instances to other caverns, though none so large as ours, but it always led downwards. At last we came to a place utterly dark, and, as we stopped for a moment, we heard the rushing of water. Of course I thought we should all be drowned, and commanded every one to return, but, somehow, we could not rest without finding out what dangers we might be exposing ourselves to. So, after a couple of day's doubt, we took candles and torches, and the whole family set out, not being willing to leave one survivor to tell the tale of what might befall us. At the dark place we lighted our torches and proceeded towards a glimmering light. The rushing of water sounded nearer

and nearer, our steps became slower and more slow, the light brighter and better, at last what should we see but the sea shining through a fall of waters that hung like a gauze curtain between us and the open air. We were able to creep out with but a slight sprinkling, and then found ourselves not far from the great chestnut tree, at the place before mentioned, where the rocks had a precipitate fall of twenty feet, over which the stream fell; in fact, the entrance into the cavern was immediately under the fall, and, with very little trouble, we could make egress and ingress without getting wet.

It is impossible to do justice to the beauty of the scene looking at it through the sparkling veil of waters, or to describe our pleasure at this singular discovery. Not only did the outside of the island belong to us, but now we had the secrets of the interior exposed to us, and the right of making what we liked of them.

Mother.—"Now, Schillie, this is one of the most charming discoveries in the world, for if pirates and marauders come here, we shall be able to hide for weeks without their discovering us."

Schillie.—"I had hoped your head was cleared of those piratical notions. For my part, I wish someone would come. The King of the Pirates would be welcome so that we could have a little variety."

Mother.—"I think you are ungrateful. We have been eighteen months here now, and can you say that we have had one privation or serious trouble?"

Schillie.—"June, you have your children near you, you see nothing else and care for nothing else. I own the sight of my Willie, and the long sunny curls of my Puss, would, were it but for one moment, ease my heart, and make me bear hunger, thirst, privations of every kind, without a murmur. We have everything here we can possibly want, and that without having to slave for it. We have food growing up to our mouths, the trees shed clothes for us, the sea, the sky, the air, the island, more lovely than angels' dreams; the young ones grow and thrive; Madame has become a new creature; you are regaining your youth and spirits. So what have I to do, but eat, drink, and sleep, and think of what I have left behind, and what I may never see again. I tell you, June, I am moped to death. I welcome the thunder storms as a variety, I look upon the earthquakes as a desirable change in something, I

watch the hurricanes with a sort of insane desire that they would blow us all away!"

Mother.—"My darling! I am vexed for you. I trust that God will look upon your present state with compassion and mercy, restoring you once more to your children. But remember yours are with the best and kindest friends, in the midst of civilisation and religious advantages. Look at mine. Though I have them with me, and they are healthy and strong, yet is this the sort of education I intended for them? Is this the life I had hoped to see them lead? Should they not soon be restored to their homes and country will they not be rendered unfit for mixing with civilised society? or too old to change; or, even if we remain here, will not that be worse for them?"

Schillie.—"Well, I grant our troubles are equal, but I wish, I wish, oh how I wish to see my children once more. But here are the girls, and they must not see me thus. Upon my word Gatty is too stupid. She has grown almost as good as Sybil and Serena. I don't think she has been in a bit of mischief these three months."

Mother.—"Don't make yourself unhappy about that, lest you find reason to eat your words, and have to sit in repentance once for some act against you. Now girls, don't you think this one of your best discoveries?"

"Yes," said Sybil, "because during the rainy season we can come here every day and have a shower bath."

"And," said Serena, "we can get fresh water every day without being half-drowned."

"And," said Gatty, "we can sit here and look out for ships all day long."

Mother.—"What, Gatty, are you tired of being here?"

Gatty.—"Tired, tired does not express what I think about this place. There is nothing to do. Nothing frightens Sybil now, and Serena is so busy learning Spanish, she won't listen to a word I say in English. Oscar makes me talk of home and Wales until I am ready to cry my eyes out at my own descriptions. And the three little girls are all so wise and womanly that they seem to reprove me if I do anything the least like play or fun. I have not had

a bit of fun since Felix tried to teach his monkey to fish, that he might lazily read himself. I am quite done up with dullness" (heaving a sort of groan).

Mother.—"Indeed, I think you are badly used, especially since Madame has found out you really can be a good girl if you like."

Gatty.—"I could be as mischievous as ever, only nobody cares for it or scolds me."

Schillie.—"Mischievous! I should think so, you sphinx of plagues, I declare I am dripping, and you know I have a horror of being over damp."

Gatty.—"It is quite clean water, little Mother, and it is but a little stream, and has not been running long to you."

Schillie.—"But you know if it had not been for your great clumsy fingers making a channel, that stream would never have come to where I am sitting; and you did it on purpose you know, so that it should just dribble to my seat and not June's."

Gatty.—"Yes, I know I did, little Mother, because you know I would never have done so to her."

Schillie.—"Did any one ever hear such impudence. Now, I insist on it that you go back, and bring me some dry things. But it's no use, I must go myself. I am wet through and through. Well, you shall never catch me complaining again of Miss Gatty being stupidly good; and she knows so well I hate anything like damp."

Gatty (with her demure face).—"Yes, little Mother, I know that so well, that I sent sufficient water to wet you thoroughly instead of damping you."

Schillie went off muttering horrible imprecations.

CHAPTER XXVIII.

We employed the next rainy season in making the passage through the cavern wider and better, so that we could run up and down without torches or fears. The rainy season had commenced with what Felix called a very savage storm, and it seemed likely to end with one equally fierce. The thunder pealed so loud that many large pieces of rock were shaken down in the cavern by the concussion, and it became dangerous to live in it. Schillie turned us all out, therefore, one day, and taking Oscar and Gatty, she placed them in different safe corners with guns, and they all three fired their guns in the cavern for half an hour, thereby bringing down any loose rocks or dangerous parts of the cavern. When we were re-admitted, we were nearly all choked with the smell of the gunpowder, which did not go off for a good while. The cavern was so dry, healthy, and large, and being able to run down to the brook was so delicious, that we scarcely thought of the danger we incurred in living in it. But this storm was tremendous. We ran to the narrow part, close by the waterfall, to flee out at a minute's warning. As we sat huddled together, all silent and awe-struck, what was that we saw in the flash of lightning? Some uttered a hurried exclamation, all started, but none said a word. The thunder crashed louder; we longed for the lightning. It came, one long, bright flash, and every mouth uttered "a ship! a ship!"

How unaccountable were our feelings. Fear for the ship predominated. Then the wild conjectures, the hopes, the fears. Suppose it was the beloved La Luna, or some stranger. We heeded not the storm for ourselves now. We longed for the flashes of lightning to reveal to us the strange, the welcome, the bewildering sight. She was apparently riding at anchor, endeavouring to weather the storm under the shelter of the great rock, for each flash showed her in the same place, but each flash also took away from the most sanguine the hope that it was La Luna; yet still we clung to the idea that it might be the dear captain come in another vessel. To leave the spot was impossible; the maids brought cloaks and wrappers for the children, who slept at our feet, but the older watchers remained with their eyes fixed on the one spot,

waiting for the coming dawn. The wind lulled, the rain ceased, the thunder was silent, and the impenetrable darkness remained unrelieved by the lightning. Thus we sat through that dark night, waiting for the coming hour so important to our fate.

Over the wide-spread sea streamed the first light of morning. As it spread from one end of heaven to the other our hearts beat, our eyes ached to penetrate still quicker the fast-receding gloom. It was then that Madame spoke, beseeching me earnestly to suffer no signs of our being on the island to show themselves until we had carefully scanned and examined the strangers. To this I silently agreed. Schillie and Gatty, with the three girls, were so absorbed in their watch that Madame went to each and gave them the caution she had given me. In a few minutes the world was in a blaze of light, and conspicuous on the troubled but brilliant sea was the long, low, black hull of a schooner-rigged vessel. There seemed no signs of life on board, which sent a chill to our hearts. If our dear captain had been there, would he not have been watching for the daylight as we had been? Would he not have been landing at this moment, and we rushing down to meet him? Many sobbed aloud, half overcome at the sight of human beings again, half overwhelmed at the fatal fear that they came not for us. Madame alone seemed to have her senses about her. Silently beckoning the maids to follow, she left us, but what to do we neither asked or cared to know. The little ones still slumbered, we still watched, no life, no signs of humanity to be seen on board the object of our fond wishes, our deep anxiety. An hour passed, and, as the little sleepers each awoke, Madame had them carried off. Presently the maids brought us each some coffee, but we hardly cared to drink it.

At last a man is seen. We grasped each other's hands and withdrew, clinging closer together, though the veil of waters effectually screened us, well as we could see through it. Another half hour, and the vessel was alive with human beings. Finally, about a dozen, all armed, got into a boat and came to land. They, one and all, anxiously gazed on the cliffs and rocks, while some used their telescopes. When landed, they examined with wonder and curiosity the remains of our tent; we had left but few signs there, as nothing could remain out in the wet weather without being damaged. But still there was enough to show them that human beings had been there, and that within a month or so. They sat down, and talked vehemently, always

looking with great earnestness on the island. We supposed them to be alarmed, for they did not venture one hundred yards from their boat. How little did they think what a helpless party was watching them, and that, too, with greater fear than interest. Not that I was not already feeling the wisdom of Madame's advice, for, as far as we could judge, they seemed a black strange wild-looking set of men. But our suspense was soon ended. We heard one shouting, the others all ran, and he pointed to something on the cliffs we could not see. I trembled as I looked round for the children, but Gatty, whose curiosity and excitement took her beyond the bounds of prudence, exclaimed it is the snake's skin, they are wondering at it. She was quite right. Two got into the boat and rowed back to the ship, the rest ran without apparent fear to the rock on which our captain had nailed the great skin, and which we had never removed, and which neither time or storms had apparently injured. The boat brought back another load, who also ran to the place, and all seemed in a great state of excitement.

"June," said Schillie to me, "they are not alarmed about us, you see. They must have known of this island, and the great snake, and been afraid of it; now they see its skin you'll see they'll be all over the island. I misdoubt me, that big fellow is the King of the Pirates, whom fate has wafted hither in compliance with my mad wishes; and that house we found on the plain is his castle, and now he'll go and take possession, and find out that somebody has been beforehand. I don't like their looks, June, we must keep close at present. But what infatuated geese we are to sit here, when we must run to Tir-y-hir, and do away with as much of our whereabouts as we can."

Leaving the children to watch, with Sybil in charge of them, we ran for our lives. Here we found the wise and thoughtful Madame beforehand with us, she and the maids had been moving everything, and it required but willing hands and quick work to pile up stones, and remove all vestiges of the cavern. Of course our house would speak for itself. Luckily we had been living in the cavern for a month, so that no very recent traces of us could be discovered. Gatty grumbled a little, indeed I don't think she would have worked had she not anticipated some amusement in watching the new arrivals, whilst they must be utterly ignorant of our existence. Schillie worked with a will; from the first I think she had a foreboding that all was not right about these people. We now went back, and found the watchers full of news, and also full of squabbles amongst themselves. More people

had come from the ship; fires had been lighted. Every one had gone to look at the big snake's skin. Working was going on; symptoms of a tent had been commenced. The squabbles amongst the little ones arose because of their different opinions of the new comers. Oscar voted them pirates, and declared he would shoot the first one that came near us. The little girls declared they must be friends, and would be sure to take them home if they gave them money. Felix was most anxious to be amongst them and get on board, and go home, and every other variety of scheme, but the promise from Oscar that he should have the first chance of shooting the first pirate completely turned him, and he became perfectly convinced that they were horrible robbers, perhaps slave-stealers, and did he not shoot them he and his Mother would be stolen and sold for slaves to different masters. A climax of fate that seemed to him would settle the period of his life.

We took little food that day, and the strangers never imagined that throughout the whole time at least four pairs of eyes were constantly watching them; nay, even when night arrived two of us kept watch, though we had most of us fits of impatience, not to say remorse, at thus welcoming strangers so long desired. In fact, if it had not been for Schillie and Madame we should certainly have rushed upon our fate in our anxiety to find out whether they were friends or foes. Gatty chafed like a young lion, every handkerchief that came near her was soon in tatters. Sybil glowed with animation as she said, "They never could harm us, they will be only too glad to help us, they will pity us so much for our sad fate; we have only to tell them our story and they would take us all away; oh I am sure, quite sure they would. It seems so unkind and ungracious to be thus suspicious of the first human beings we have seen so long."

Schillie.—"Pooh, pooh, child, it is better to leave them in ignorance of our unkindness, for fear you should find out when too late that they will be equally unkind in chopping you up into beefsteaks, at least you had better make up your mind which of the two acts will be the most unkind."

Sybil.—"But, surely they are not cannibals; I don't think there is a sailor in the world who could be a cannibal, they are all such good fellows."

Schillie.—"Humph! Think as you like my dear. I honour your innocence and applaud your approbation of sailors. But you are such a noodle, and,

being the stoutest of the party, ought to have more compassion on yourself."

Serena.—"But I agree with Sybil in thinking it very ungracious, not giving them the option of being kind to us, if they like it. They can but leave us behind if they don't like us."

Schillie.—"If they would promise to leave us behind in case they don't like us, I am ready to go and meet them now."

Gatty.—"Then do come, for I do think this most horrid work, peeping and watching, and imagining every evil thing against them. Besides, supposing they do turn out uncivil, what is to prevent us when they are all asleep rising and taking possession of their vessel, and sailing off with it, leaving them a note to say we will pay them for it as soon as ever we arrive in England."

Schillie.—"And I trust you are prepared to act captain to the vessel, as well as mate and crew. I promise you that I am not going to sea without some experienced hands to guide the ship."

Sybil.—"Perhaps we can bribe some of them to come with us. For if they are wicked people there are sure to be some unfortunate good ones among them, who will be glad to get away."

Mother.—"Well! between us we shall weave a romantic story about them. In the meantime don't let us be impatient."

Serena.—"But, dear sister, won't they think it unkind of us hiding ourselves from them in this suspicious way, supposing they turn out to be good friendly people."

Madame.—"My sweet child, let them think us anything rather than we should get into their power. Once in their hands we should never get out again so helpless as we are. Indeed they look so ferocious that two of them would be quite enough to kill us all."

Oscar.—"I should like to see two dare to do it."

Felix.—"And so would I, we would soon settle their business, would we not Otty? You should take the left fellow, and I would knock down the right one."

Gatty.—"Yes! indeed; two! Why I could settle two myself! But this is such sorry work; peeping like brats. We might be even now making preparations to go away, they having promised to take us by this time. I can't stand waiting another day, I know I cannot."

Serena.—"Then you must sit, and be patient, meanwhile let me tell you _____"

Schillie.—"I think you are very childish. Think if these people turn out to be enemies what an advantage we have in being able to see and watch all they do, and yet they not being able to find out anything about us."

Sybil.—"But I don't like to think they are enemies or that they would be so to us."

Gatty.—"Of course not, Syb. For once I agree with you, and I think it a great shame to behave like this to them; so like Madame fearing an elephant behind a straw."

This last sentence was muttered between her teeth, but Schillie caught it, and turning round said, "I'll tell you what Miss Gatty, if you say another word on the subject, or favour us with any more of your remarkably silly ideas, I'll have you locked up."

"Where, little Mother?" said Gatty, winding her great arms round Schillie, who struggled in vain to release herself from the potent grasp. "June, June, con—— no, I don't mean that, hang—— no nor that, you horrid—— Well! I am in a vice, June, I say June, make her release me. What arms the wretch has, will you let me out you good-for-nothing, I'll give it you well, Miss; come release me, June, I'll never speak to you again, if you don't let me free instead of laughing in that absurd manner."

Truly it was very ridiculous; Gatty so cool and quiet, but holding her fast; Schillie in a red hot rage, and utterly unable to release herself. But we were getting too noisy, so peace was proclaimed, and harmony restored.

The next morning we found it a true prophecy that the strangers would be all over the island. First of all they examined all our remains and marks of habitation on the cliffs, especially the church, where our foot-marks would be more recent than anywhere else. But we trusted to the great rains that

had fallen to obliterate them as much as possible. In examining the cliffs they came so near us that we could distinguish their voices, and even found that they spoke a sort of Spanish. The nearer they came the less prepossessing they appeared, and even Gatty retreated with a shudder as two wild fierce-looking hairy faces showed themselves just above a ledge of rocks within fifty yards of our hiding place.

Some of us remained under the waterfall, the noise of which prevented us hearing anything distinctly, while the remainder ran up and watched at the other entrance. There, through chinks and crevices we could watch them, as they gradually came in different parties towards the little valley in which our house was built. It was quite inevitable their discovering it, so we made up our minds to that matter; and it was not long ere the shouts of those who did so drew all the others to the place.

How rejoiced we were on a nearer view of them that Madame had been so provident in advising us to keep close until we could learn something of them. Even Sybil was obliged to allow that she did not recognise a single good face amongst them. So wild and fierce a set I never saw, and their looks made me shudder. From our small knowledge of Spanish we could make out that they were greatly surprised, and evidently guessed some one was on the island. Also they said a great deal about the snake, and their rejoicings it was dead, making evident allusions to the island as if they knew it quite well. After satisfying their curiosity some sat down to smoke, as if intending to wait patiently for the arrival of the inhabitants, others pursued their researches and we had no doubt went to the other house, while all examined their arms and primed their guns, as if preparing for an engagement with the warlike people who had slaughtered so great a monster as the snake.

We made all these remarks amongst ourselves, and were greatly amused at our conjectures and interpretations of all they said.

But we could not thus calmly give up all our fond hopes and wishes. We had still some struggles, frightened as we were at the sight of our new companions. It was necessary, however, that we should come to some regular arrangement of our time and work, as we were in danger of starving to death in our eagerness to watch these people. Unluckily a great part of

our store of food was in the house they were now so busily smoking in. We had enough with us for a few days, but we generally kept our stores there, as they seemed to do better there than in the cavern. Also it was useless the whole set of us watching; accordingly we took it turn about, two at each entrance for two hours at each time, a little one and a big one always together. The remainder went about their usual occupations, all except lessons, about which Madame seemed to have tasted the waters of Lethe. We suffered rather in point of meals, as we dared not light a fire for fear of the smoke discovering us. Besides our kitchen apparatus was all in the house, so that altogether, what with fatigue, worry, and discomfort, we were getting unanimous in abusing our new neighbours. We came to one agreement, namely, that the next day being Sunday we should observe how they spent it. If, in anything like a christian manner we would open negotiations with them by some means yet to be discussed, but, if in a heathen manner, then we should consider them as savages, cannibals, and no one knows what; and, hiding close, we should quietly endure our privations as best we could, until the ill-omened, disappointing black vessel should leave us once more to our fate.

In the security of darkness and secrecy we slept that night, Madame and Jenny moving their mattresses to the waterfall side, Schillie and I to the side where Tir-y-hir was, that, at all events we might have the first intimation of any discovery they might make. Before we went to sleep, however, we assured ourselves that they had been to the other house, and, if anything could have completed our disgust it was the fact that they returned dragging with them all our summer clothes, with which they covered themselves. The pretty white hats belonging to the girls, which they had learned to plait themselves, were thrust on the great, dirty, greasy heads of these horrid men. All the pretty silk Sunday frocks, the shawls, the scarfs, the caps, the bonnets, the carefully hoarded remains of our civilized attire, alas! alas! did they not also tell these wretches what a helpless party were on the island? Everything was recklessly thrown about, torn, and trodden under foot. Hargrave flew from the sight, and hid her tears and stifled her sobs in the darkest corner of the cavern. From that hour they were doomed in her estimation as the acme of wickedness and vice.

Many times during the night were we awakened by their noise and drunken revelry, and alas for the hopes we had formed of the Sabbath-day none ever

were less fulfilled.

The scenes of riot, quarrelling, drinking, and imprecation were so dreadful we could not keep watch any more, but hurried as far we were able from the sight and sounds of life so abhorrent to our nature, so horrid to witness. With pale faces and tearful eyes, and ears yet filled with oaths and bitter words, we proceeded to gain courage and implore help from the throne of grace, feeling how we stood in need of such aid. For not even when about to be a prey to the stormy elements, or the desolate feeling when left alone in a solitary island, or the sudden death which appeared inevitable in the jaws of the horrid snake, not even in all these did we feel our helplessness as we did now. And it was our own species we feared, for whose coming we had so often prayed. It was man, once created in the image of God, that sent this pang of horror through us.

But, enough of this; suffice it to say we were a set of miserable, trembling, quaking women, but God in his mercy calmed and comforted us, so that after the morning prayers we proceeded to make our hiding place still more secure.

As I said before, the waterfall was a most effectual screen, especially now that there was so much water in the brook. The more water that fell of course the more liable we were to get wet as we passed in and out, but, owing to the height from which it fell, the water cleared the rock by some feet, and thus gave us a passage underneath. The tall ones had always to stoop, but the little ones ran out and in like rabbits in a burrow. At the other entrance it was almost as well concealed. Now we got in and out, for the rock projected some ten feet out, and then just round the corner appeared a sort of recess. This seemed exactly smooth with the rock, but, by edging round and squeezing a little, you came to a sort of slit or cleft in the rock and that led to the cavern. But even when there we had innumerable holes and hiding places, and it would have been a good week's work to ferret us all out from thence. In case, however, of discovery, we organised a plan and arranged our places of retreat, and we practised ourselves in quick hiding, and, to get our lesson perfect, in every now and then calling out "The pirates are coming." Whereupon, as a matter of course, every one ran for their lives to their appointed place. Each place had a communication with another, so that we could telegraph all round. The place from whence we

made our observations was on a ledge up in the cavern, from whence some of the light came in; it might be about twenty feet from the ground, and we looked down on them. Dreadful wretches.

CHAPTER XXIX.

We were up, had had our shower bath after careful examination, had breakfasted, and yet there lay our enemies in stupid and heavy sleep still.

"Now then," said Gatty, "now is our time."

"Yes," said Otty, "I'll engage to kill them all."

"With my help," said Master Felix consequentially.

"No, no, children, don't be so absurd," said I, "drunken people are not so helpless as you imagine, and, besides, they may not be all so. Some may be watching elsewhere, some others may still be in the ship; they will soon be tired of looking for us, and leave us in peaceable possession of our dear little island."

Schillie.—"I am not quite sure if it would not be a good plan to pick them off one by one, when we can find them at an advantage."

Mother.—"For heaven's sake don't be mad. The report of a gun would bring them all on us, and the smoke betray us."

Sybil.—"Besides, little Mother, they may after all be good people, and we have no right to kill them until they have tried to hurt us."

Hargrave.—"Oh Miss Sybil, whatever can you go for to say they 'ave not 'armed hus. I never, no never saw such wickedness! My mistress's best lace dress! I shall never forget it to my dying day, no nor never forgive it. The 'eathens, the monsters, I am willing to 'old any hinstrument for my young master while he shoots the dreadful scrummagers."

Gatty.—"You don't say so! Hargrave, then take hold of this."

Hargrave shuddered as she grasped the gun, but she resolutely held it at arms length. Gatty having put her to the proof, applauded her, and we went

on with our conversation.

Mother.—"I can never feel sufficiently grateful to you, Madame, for your forethoughts and wisdom. We are now at all events our own mistresses and masters, but no one knows what would have become of us, had we gone open-armed to meet these people."

Madame.—"They look capable of any wickedness, Madam, and I really begin to think from all I can make out that they are pirates, and then they would have had no scruples in carrying us all off, and selling us for slaves."

Schillie.—"Or worse, they might have turned us into wives, a thing I could by no means consent to, even to be Queen of the Pirates."

Serena (our best Spanish Scholar).—"I heard them talking a great deal about the snake, and it seemed they were afraid to land at first for fear of it, but wanted water very much. And it was only on discovering its skin that they ceased to feel any alarm, and have wandered all about since."

Gatty.—"What owls we were to leave the skin there. However I think it great fun to dodge them in this way."

Madame.—"Fun did you say, my dear child? Poor deceived child."

Gatty.—"Not deceived at all, Madame, and, besides, we all think it fun."

Sybil.—"Yes, Madame, I think it very amusing to feel so safe and secure, and yet to be able to watch them so well."

Serena.—"And you know, Madame, it gives us such advantage; we know all about them, and they know nothing about us."

Schillie.—"Also, Madame, we have now something to do, and June cannot thrust any more of her inventions upon us for want of some other amusement."

Zoë.—"And you know, Madame, we cannot have any lessons while we are so busy watching."

Winny.—"Yes, Madame, and it is so nice to feel so useful, and have you all running up to ask us, 'Well! what do we see now? What's going on at

present?"

Lilly.—"And to see them all running about here and there looking for us, and all too in the wrong places."

Oscar.—"And what fun it will be to shoot them."

Felix.—"Yes! right and left shots."

Jenny.—"Oh, Master Felix, how pleased I should be to see you do that."

Hargrave.—"Nobody more so than hi, I make bold to say."

Madame turned from one to another in sad dismay, and then looked at me.

"Well! Madame, it is better they should all think thus than be as wretched as we were yesterday," returned I. "So let us make the best of it, hope the best, and ardently pray for it."

"I should like just to kill a few before they leave," said Gatty.

Mother.—"For what possible reason, my dear child?"

Gatty.—"Because, because, it will be then a real good downright adventure, and we shall be able——"

Here we were interrupted by a great noise. Every heart jumped into every mouth, at least mine did, so I suppose every other person's did. We flew to our hiding places. By and by there was a great smell of smoke. I telegraphed Schillie, and we crept from our corners, and went to the spy place. Oh sight of horror, what did we see but our beloved house, that matchless building, all in flames! Not being able to speak, Schillie shook her fists at them, until I thought she would shake them off. The dear little house, our pride and delight, built with such labour, inhabited with such pleasure, was fast consuming under the hands of these robbers. It seems that having guessed all our stores were there, and having made every effort to find us, and not succeeding, they had resorted to this method in the hope of forcing us to appear. But, such a base act only made us think much more badly of them, and we could hardly tell the news as we went sorrowfully back to the others.

In the meantime they shouted and called to us in every part of the island, offered us every inducement they could think of to make us appear. But, not even the bribe of a promise to take us away from the island moved us one bit. We kept closer and more quiet the more furious they became. This lasted two days. We had not much more food left, and it was absolutely necessary we should get to the gardens to obtain something, or to the other house. This was a dreadful idea. At one time I half thought it would be better to starve altogether. But, could I bear to see the little ones die before my face?

It makes me shiver when I think of that hour, and the settling who was to go. It must be Schillie or I, one to go, one to stay for fear of accidents. The lot fell on her. I would not let her have her way, but would draw lots. I did not know which was the worst fate of two, to go or stay. Jenny offered to go, Otty would go, and the lot fell on Serena of the three girls. Gatty groaned aloud in disappointment. The hour fixed on was just before night, when they would all be carousing. Well! we let them out. Ah! how horrible it was to see them withdrawn from the shelter of the secret cavern. I sprang to recall them my feelings were so dreadful. But they disappeared like lapwings. On our knees we waited for them, Sybil laying her head in the dust for sorrow, her Serena in such danger, Gatty tearing at the rocks and stones until her hands bled. And we could not see them if they were in danger. The suspense was too dreadful to be borne. With a few hasty words to Madame we seized as much rope and cordage as we could carry, and, slipping out expeditiously, we made our way, with the dexterity of long practice, up the side of the cliffs, among the brushwood, to the top of the cavern. Here we could see half over the island. But first we tied two stout ropes strongly to two trees, and let them down into the cavern through one of the apertures which lighted it. This told them inside that we had safely arrived at the top, and the ropes were strong enough to let us down in case we could not safely get back. Sybil, Gatty, and I were these three impatient ones. Having done that, we looked out for our beloved ones. They would be under cover all but the plain. We saw them! They were just going to cross it. How they ran! How we wept and prayed for them. How endless appeared the time when we once more lost them in the plantation by the house. It is beginning to grow dark. They are coming! yes, all four of them, heavily laden evidently. Now they are across the plain! Now the friendly trees

receive them! In ten minutes more they will be here! How we shall welcome them, though I cannot think how I am ever to touch the food they have gained at such a risk. Now we must go down to meet them, and help the dear beloved creatures in with their precious loads. The trees crack, "let us make haste," the brushwood opens. Ah! the dreadful sight! Six great pirates appear just as our dear ones burst through the trees, hurrying all the more from being so near home, half-blinded with the weights they carried. It is over! They are surrounded, the pirates shout, they scream, and I fall to the ground with those sounds ringing in my ears.

CHAPTER XXX.

But not a minute did I stay there. We must be up and doing. Despair made us calm and cool. Everything seemed to depend on our judgment and caution. How my heart was wrung with those cries. Poor Sybil, the dear child seemed frantic, almost beside herself; she became resolute, almost fierce; she seemed ready to dare the whole band. But they are carrying them off. Can we resist flying after them? Yes, we must, we must. They are going to take them down the cliffs. But where is Oscar? He is not among them. They go. Now then, now is our time; we must get quickly down, and run to the waterfall to see what is done to our heart's treasures. We got down safely. As we emerge, one by one, we hear a slight sound, and, looking round, perceive Otty hiding in the brushwood. Being a quick sharp boy, he had seen the pirates in a minute, and, falling down among the bushes, had escaped notice.

I clasped him in my arms, Gatty seized his bundle. We rushed into the cavern, and told our tale; not that Sybil stopped or stayed, she made her way to the waterfall at once, and arrived long before she could see them coming down the cliffs. But the ever-provident Gatty, calling on the little girls, ran out, and collected the dearly-bought food; and, taking the little girls, she went boldly to the gardens, and between them they brought in a plentiful supply of everything. She knew she could not help them, neither could we watchers. Night came on, and left us in despair and darkness.

Poor Sybil! the morning sun showed her in despair. We could not recognise the soft smiling girl in the wild, excited, agitated being before us. What were we to do? What could we do? We were ready to do anything. We came to one agreement, that separated we would not be. If we could not rescue them, we should join them in their captivity. Now all the men collect together; we see nothing of their prisoners, but imagine that they are on board the ship. We count twenty-two, the number of all we had seen. They talk earnestly. Eight go on board, and, after some bustle, return with the

boat laden with empty casks. These are rolled by the rest to the stream. Now all day the whole party fill the casks, roll them back, and take them on board; they don't rest one hour. We must do something. "Then," said Madame, "let me go out boldly among them. I will find out what they mean to do. They may take me prisoner; but, old and grey-headed, it is more likely they may not think it worth while. I will write what I find out, and put it under a stone near the old tent, if they don't allow me to return." So Madame goes, taking care to appear from quite a different side to our entrance. They surround her, she is bound to a tree, and they proceed with their watering. At last it seems done, and they all appear tired and exhausted, having worked hard, without food or rest, for eight hours. A consultation is held about Madame, and finally she is left loose and unbound, while they all run eagerly to the place where the meal is now being prepared for them. She watches her opportunity, and gradually steals up the cliff; when near the top, she is overtaken, and brought back. Dear old lady, what incredible exertions had she made; we had watched her scrambling up spots we knew she almost fainted to look at. But that was nothing to her dauntless courage and energy. When they were all safe at their meal, Gatty ran from the upper opening to the top of the cliff, from whence they had taken her back, and, sure enough, under a stone, close by which she had dropped her handkerchief, we found a note.

This told us that the pirates intended sailing the next morning, that they were delighted at having made these prisoners, that they had done them no harm at present, but, being on board the ship, they certainly intended carrying them off, that all the men intended sleeping on shore but two, that Madame, if kept a prisoner, would stay near the boat, and bear a light to direct us to it in case we thought we could rescue them. (Of course we could and would rescue them, who doubted it?) The rest she would leave to us, she could advise nothing. "Glorious," said Gatty, "now we have something to do. Would that night was come."

Mother.—"Now here is something to amuse us until night comes on. Suppose we write as many letters as we can, and when we go on board for the dear prisoners, let us leave them there. If these people are real pirates, their vessel may be captured, and our letters found and forwarded by the vessel that takes them. And even if no such event happens, and they are not

pirates, compassion may make them forward them to their proper destination by some ship or opportunity."

A capital notion, and we proceeded to put it into execution, and altogether accomplished about a dozen letters, each directed to different members of our beloved family. All being ready, the darkness impenetrable, we looked out and saw two lights burning. One we supposed to be the ship light, the other Madame's, which she was to light when all were asleep. With the utmost expedition, but the greatest caution and silence, we slid down the rocks in a different direction from the lights, that no rolling stone or slipping feet might be heard. Once on the sand, our noiseless feet flew, as well as they could consistent with the caution necessary in such darkness, and the way in which a bright light, under such circumstances, deceives you. We kept by the moving waves in part to guide us. We came to the bathing place. Now we must creep on our hands and knees, we are so near. We touch Madame—happiness inexpressible. Silently, Gatty, Oscar, and I creep into the boat; we tie handkerchiefs and towels round the two oars; nevertheless, what a noise we make, but we are very nearly reckless. Madame wraps her arms round Sybil, lest her impatience should make her throw herself into the water, in her wish to get to her second self. Now we touch the ship. Gatty and I are on deck like cats. We have taken off our shoes that our footsteps may not be heard. Otty keeps to the boat. We creep to the lamp and get a light, and then go down stairs. We try a door, but it is locked. Gatty goes back to Otty, and tells him to move under the cabin windows, to see if he can find them out there. I try to push some of my long hair through the key-hole to attract their attention, but the key is in. I then thrust some letters under the door. I hear their voices, but am just frantic at not being able to make them hear, but Oscar has. It is all right; they know him, and speak to him. I hear Schillie say, "Where is June?" How can we be so rash, and make such a noise. I can only account for their not hearing us by the fact that they were completely knocked up with the heat and work of the day, and had no idea there were any more people on the island; and, as the boat was on shore, their prisoners could not escape by themselves; so that in all security they sleep profoundly. Now then, at last, the door opens, and we see them, but not a word is spoken, and, merely squeezing our fingers, they pass out. I hide the letters in different parts of the cabin, and, finding them all ready in the boat, we push off, and in a few minutes,

guided by the friendly light, Serena is in Sybil's arms. They hurry off the same way we came, only treading in the waves that their footsteps may not be traced. I remain behind but to fasten up the boat in the same way we found it; and then, after some difficulty, many falls, and constant losing our way, owing to the darkness, we hear the welcome sounds of the waterfall. Heedless of a wetting, we rush in, we are safe, we are in the cavern, and then what a scene takes place. But no pen can describe it. Mine cannot.

CHAPTER XXXI.

Exhausted by our many emotions, and the agony of the last twenty-four hours, we slept until very late. But our first words on awaking were, "Is the ship gone?"

Yes! she was gone from her mooring; nevertheless she was lying to, and the boat came off to shore with about ten men in it. They lost no time, but hurried about in every direction to find what we were certainly not going to lose sight of again. We heard them wrangling and grumbling as they searched all about Cartref Pellenig. A gun recalled them to the ship after they had spent many fruitless hours in the search. Ere sunset arrived, the low black hull of the evil ship was hardly to be traced on the horizon. Then we questioned the three heroines as to their adventures.

Schillie.—"Odious beasts."

Mother.—"Is that all you have to say about them?"

Schillie.—"Wretches."

Mother.—"But, Serena, what do you say?"

Serena.—"They are shocking people."

Mother.—"Well, I must try Jenny, for you did only tell us what we guessed before."

Jenny.—"Oh, Ma'am, they are such a wicked lot!"

Finding we could not get any news out of them, we waited until they had sufficiently relieved their feelings by abusing them, and then gleaned the following information by fits and starts. To use Schillie's words they were audibly and horribly elated at having captured such notable prisoners. Also they were questioned very much about themselves, and Schillie's friend, the

King of the Pirates, asked if they belonged to a party of ladies and children supposed to be lost in a yacht about two years ago. To this she replied in the affirmative, hoping to hear news from home. Then they told her that many people were employed in the search after them, and that very large rewards were offered to any one who could give information. "Then," said Schillie, "if you take us all home you shall receive rewards beyond your greatest wishes."

This conversation was held in French. He went and retailed it to his companions in Spanish, not deeming that Serena understood them. They then had a dispute amongst themselves as to whether they would retain possession of the prisoners or claim the promised reward. The dispute ran so high that they all agreed to defer it till they got to sea, having too much to do to waste the time at present. When Serena interpreted this to Schillie she was wrath beyond expression, and vowed she would jump overboard and be swallowed by a shark ere she went to sea and leave it undecided as to what their future fate must be. Then the captain asked her where all the others were? And in a fit of disgust and horror she said to him he should not take her from the island unless it was to restore them to their friends. Giving her a ferocious look he said her fate should be decided according as she behaved, and they were in no particular want of money at present, having been very successful in their late excursion. He also told her that they had been on the look out for us a long time, and wanted to know if we had not great riches, plate, and diamonds with us; he, in fact, asked so many questions, we could not but perceive they knew a great deal about us. Finding Schillie grew more and more reserved and angry, he separated the three, and proceeded to question them. Jenny declared point blank, as well as she could by signs, that all the rest of us were dead! and only those three left. Serena pretended not to understand, and fell into such hysterical tears at being separated from Schillie, that after awhile they restored them together.

"Well, Schillie," said I, "I don't think I should have objected to go with them so much, for they are generally such needy people these pirates that money would surely have tempted them to give you up."

Schillie.—"Brutes!"

Mother.—"And then you could have made arrangements to come for us."

Schillie.—"Villains!"

Mother.—"Now do be rational, why don't you listen to what I say, instead of vituperating in this manner?"

Schillie.—"It is you that want reason. I tell you what, June, I had rather stay here all the days of my life, and live to be the last person on it, burying you every one, than be a week at sea with such a set of rascally, vile, audacious, drunken robbers as they were. Now if you love me let me hear their names no more. Let me enjoy the fact that I am with you all again. Let me do anything to drive away the horrors that beset me when in their power. I don't mean to say they were uncivil, or rude, or that they treated us unnecessarily roughly. I had a knife ready if they had done so to either of us."

So the subject was dropped, and, though we might have had some misgivings that we had not acted with great courage, and that we had lost an opportunity of being restored to the world which we might not have again, yet we were not worse off than we had been ten days ago. Moreover, we had escaped a great and serious misfortune, namely, being separated. Also we knew the extent of what we had suffered, and we could not tell what we might have had to endure. Also we had the heartfelt satisfaction of knowing that we were not given up as lost, that kind hearts and active energies were being employed in our behalf. Were we wrong to be so hopeful that these exertions would meet with a due reward?

These thoughts gave us food for many a conversation, though we made very few allusions to the pirates themselves. Once, indeed, on remarking a few cooking utensils, and a great big bottle that were now in use among us, and which I had never seen before, "Oh," said Gatty composedly, "they had no business to burn down our house, so Otty and I cleared their caboose while you were down in the cabin, and Jenny helped us, and she allows we have now a tidy set of cooking things, and Goodness knows they have arrived just in the nick of time as ours were done up."

Jenny.—"Indeed, Ma'am, it is quite true. Look at our old saucepans. Past mending, even if there was a tinker next door."

Schillie.—"Very sensible brat! I did not think she had such *nous* in her."

Mother.—"Really I think we ought to give you a vote of thanks, Gatty."

Madame.—"But surely, my dear Madam, the want of principle Gertrude has shewn ought to be reprov'd. It was (pray do not think me unkind) but I am afraid I can call it nothing but a theft on her part."

Hargrave (bursting into the conversation *nolens volens*).—"I beg pardon, ladies, but I must say Miss Gertrude has hacted in a manner surprisingly delightful. Them 'orrifying hannimals 'as destroyed 'eaps of our best dresses and millineries; and hif Miss could but 'ave tossed their best suits hoverboard my mind would be hat rest, and my 'eart heased."

So Gatty got applauded on all sides, for Madame was reminded if it had not been for her thieving propensities she would never have had the nice quantities of warm water we could now heat for her bath. Therefore she pocketed her principles at the shrine of her baths, at least to a certain extent.

CHAPTER XXXII.

Quiet prevailed, lessons predominated, we were all getting very stupid again. Schillie was very much subdued after her sojourn with the pirates, and took to following me everywhere, as the faithful dog follows his master. Also, she was very amenable to all my wishes and worked like a horse in the gardens and potatoe grounds, because I thought we had better lay in great stores of food, for fear the pirates should come again. Besides this work, we plaited grass into ropes, and made a ladder or two, with which we practised running up and down into the cavern from the opening at the top. It was something to do, and might be useful. The children were like cats at last, and used to frighten me out of my wits by their feats of agility.

So many of our clothes had been destroyed that it became necessary to do something towards replacing them; and, after various attempts, Schillie and I constructed two rude weaving machines, in which, with hard work, we made a coarse kind of cloth. This was dyed any colour we fancied, and then made into a long loose dress, with hanging sleeves, capable of being tucked up, and a broad belt to confine them round the waist. We found them very convenient and cool, only it was incessant work, spinning, weaving, and making them. We certainly did not eat the bread of idleness, and many a day's holiday was asked from Madame, only to work the poor girls harder at spinning, weaving, or gardening. But they enjoyed it, and grew like palm trees, looking so pretty and lively, that it was quite a sight to look at them: Sybil fair as a lily, and bright as a rose; Gatty glowing like the bright hibiscus; the pale and graceful Serena, faultless in form and action; while the little ones seemed to be growing up into what the elder girls had been when we first landed on the island.

The rainy season came and went. God blessed us in our house and field, and in the hearts content that filled every mind.

Intuitively we all seemed to feel that a good time was coming for us, and we prepared for the fine weather with fresh energies and renewed hopes, not unmixed with the notion that we should have dangers and difficulties to encounter, ere we should be finally restored to all we loved.

We encouraged each other in every way. We relied on some of our letters reaching their proper destination, we assured each other that another six months would not pass without our friends coming to look for us.

We made every preparation, stores of food for a full year were stowed away in the cavern. We concocted a kitchen, from whence the smoke could never betray us, and we sat down in patient expectation, and full trust in our Almighty Father, that should the pirates come again we were quite prepared; therefore, without fear, though with a little palpitation of heart, we received the news one brilliant morning that a sail was to be seen on the horizon.

It came nearer and nearer and yet kept off the island. We might have thought, for a time, that perchance it was our friends, but one after another allowed the mournful fact to escape from our lips, that it was indeed the pirates' vessel.

Supposing us to be inexperienced in vessels, and not likely to know one again, after seeing it once, we imagined they kept dodging on and off the island to deceive us, and that they would do this until dark, and then landing as best they might, they would thus take us by surprise. They little knew how sharp was the watch we kept, as much prompted by affection as fear.

But we understood their manœuvres very well, and were quite prepared. We had long ceased to need the Cartref Pellenig entrance, letting everything down by the aperture above, where the rock and brushwood would tell no tales of our footsteps. We had made some more places of observation, and we went to rest that night feeling prepared for everything. It happened as we expected. The whole island seemed alive with pirates as the sun arose. We had taken care to leave their works of destruction as much like what they had left them as possible. They spent a whole week in diligently searching the island, yet were no restraint upon us whatever. We had our shower baths, and even our exercise up and down the rope ladders, peeping out upon them from the top, for we had smoothed the sides of the cliff so

well, there was not a place for a cat to get up, and besides it seeming only to be bare rock and brushwood, they thought they saw all over it without deeming that anything could be hidden down in it.

We got rather rash, they got very vexed, we were delighted, they were disappointed. At last at the end of ten days, they began to unload the vessel. Now! thought we, "what is going to happen, surely they are not going to stay here." Our ill-timed hilarity received a sudden check, for our fears were confirmed, they unloaded the vessel completely, and after ballasting her with sand and shingle, they set sail, and departed. But alas! for us they left ten of their people behind them, who commenced to our horror and disgust building a house very near Cartref Pellenig, but so placed that they could look down the cliffs and over the sea. By this arrangement we had certainly one-half of the island entirely to ourselves, and as they were extremely busy, evidently trying to get their house completed ere the second rains came on, and as what time they had to spare they spent entirely in carousing and sleeping, we ran little danger of being discovered, though out for hours together. One precaution we took which was always to have a watcher on their movements, and never to leave the cavern, without settling where we were to be found in case of warning. Also they seemed quite to have made up their own minds that they were the sole inhabitants of the island. Little dreaming what a home she gave in her friendly bosom to the weak and helpless, and how many eyes watched their every movement.

We gathered the fruits of roots, enjoyed the turtle, collected eggs, and accustomed our hens to lay in the cavern, giving them a remote egress, through which nothing but fowls could get. We were not therefore in danger of starving, supposing they did take up their abode on the island with us. So we sat down on the carpet of contentment.

During the ensuing wet weather we saw nothing of our visitors, and we beguiled the time with writing stories and romances, and reciting them in the evening while we knitted, spun, and weaved. Part of the girls' lessons consisted in learning French Plays by heart, and Schillie and I as spectators saw more than poor Madame, who innocently left them to select their own lessons. Sometimes they would repeat the same lessons three days running, making grimaces at us to say nothing. Sometimes Gatty managed so to arrange it, that, during four or five long pages of dialogue, all she had to say

was, "*Et Tartuffe*" "*Le Pauvre-homme*" two or three times, and then she received the good jeton necessary for such a long lesson.

Schillie.—"You will be hanged some day, Miss Gatty, if you go on in this deceptive manner."

Gatty.—"Oh, Sib likes the fun, and Serena is so fond of languages, she does not care how much she says, provided it is not in her mother tongue, and I love them both so much, I always like to oblige them."

Schillie.—"I dare say you do, you young sinner. Now see if I don't expose you to Madame, and then in addition to the crime of stealing, you will have fibbing added."

Gatty.—"I am quite ready to go and restore the kettle and other things, if you like it, little Mother. Perhaps you would not mind coming with me to do this act of justice."

Schillie.—"Mention such a thing again, and see how I will punch you, Miss, just as if I would walk one yard nearer those wretches, than the horrid narrow limits of this island oblige me. No, if they were dying by inches for want of their kettle I would not stir one step to give it them."

Serena.—"How severe you are upon them, little Mother, I hate the sight of them, but I don't think I could see them starve."

Sybil.—"Indeed I should not care what became of them, or what fate happened to them so that they were all dead."

Gatty.—"There, Madame, there, hear what your pattern of gentleness and goodness says. Don't talk to me any more about being more like a boy than a girl. Here Syb declares she would like to see the pirates roasted alive."

Sybil.—"Now, Gatty, how can you?"

Gatty.—"You said you did not care what became of them; perhaps flayed alive will suit you better."

Sybil.—"Horrid girl, how you make me shudder."

Madame.—"I feel perfectly correct in saying, Gertrude, that you are merely giving voice to your own ideas, and not to my gentle Sybil's."

Sybil.—"Then, dear Madame, I must undeceive you, for, when I look at Serena, I don't think I should care whether they were roasted or not."

Madame.—"My child, my dear child, since when have you adopted these notions, so foreign to your mild nature?"

Sybil.—"I don't know, indeed, Madame; but I am ready to fire off a gun if it is necessary to drive them away."

Madame.—"You see, Madam, what an effect it has had upon our household already, the visit of these pirates."

Mother.—"Then, Madame, we must hope no worse effects will ensue. At present I admire Sybil's spirit and energy, and think she wanted but that to make her almost what you think her, perfection."

Gatty.—"I don't like the change at all. Nothing I can do to her now frightens her. I found the most frightful old bloated toad yesterday, and put it on her fat white arm, saying 'there's a pirate for you, Syb,' and, would you believe it, she neither shrieked or screamed, but said quite savagely, 'I only wish it was, and that I could make away with him as quickly as I could this poor toad.' It is quite provoking, all my fun is gone."

Oscar.—"Perhaps, aunt Sib, you won't mind learning to fire a gun now."

Sybil.—"Not at all, dear boy, but (adding quickly) you know we must not shoot at present for fear of discovering ourselves."

Felix.—"Oh, she's a coward yet, she most certainly is."

Lilly.—"She was no coward when she went to the ship that dark night, boy" (indignantly).

Zoë.—"I am sure she is as brave as any of us when occasion requires" (more indignantly).

Winny.—"Yes, indeed, all her stories are full of brave people, and they are such pretty stories."

Schillie.—"Well, children, don't let us have any more of this mawkish dispute. Aunt Sib is agreed to be nearly perfection by you all, and when I see her looking steadily at a spider without a wink I'll think her so too. It is lucky she has turned out so brave, as we may want her services, and I trust you will all follow her worthy example. I intend organizing an army, and making myself field-marshal thereof; and if you make good soldiers, and obey the word of command, I'll tell you the story of the little jack-daws."

The house the men built, which we called Pirate Hall, was magnificent compared to our poor dear Cartref Pellenig, and was made with such rapidity, speed, and neatness, our clerk of the works fell into fits of envy and jealousy. We had visited it very often without being discovered; but the children, from sheer mischief, used to carry off things of all kinds back to our cavern, and we were unable to prevent them, as they almost considered it an act of duty to do so. I would not let them go; besides, we might have been discovered, as, through the loss of different things in such a strange manner, they must suspect some other people were on the island. Schillie, Madame, and I had many private conversations regarding these pirates and their settling on the island; for we were not so hopeful as to think if they settled here permanently we could always escape notice. Some inadvertence on our part, some chance on theirs, an earthquake, any of these things might discover us.

Schillie imagined, from the peculiar way in which Pirate Hall was built, they meant to use it as a storehouse, and that probably the vessel would return, take off the ten men, now our neighbours, and only visit the island when they had to store away their ill-gotten gains, or from bad weather. I agreed with her, and further added, that probably the old house had been built for the same purpose, but that their rendezvous had been disturbed by the extraordinary snake which had been so nearly fatal to us. Now that it was dead they were again making use of the island, and we must be prepared for this and any other disagreeable occurrence that their proximity to us would cause.

Madame hoped that if they really took permanent possession of the island, we might in some manner contrive to quit it, either through their ships and boats, or from my brother's ship, which we knew had been stationed on the South American Coast, for the purpose of exterminating the pirates, and

discovering their hordes. And if he ever pursued one, in endeavouring to reach this island, he might be led on after them, and so discover us.

I doubted their permitting so safe and convenient a spot being discovered. However time would show, and without any event occurring, that could be interesting to others than ourselves, time brought the pirate's vessel back again. Henceforward its visits were at all times and all hours, never staying above a day when it did come, then all hands worked hard to unload and refit again. Sometimes everybody went in it. Sometimes two or three remained behind. And it was on one of these occasions we had a most dreadful fright. Hearing a noise amongst the brushwood at the top of the cavern, we found out in a minute, one or all of the pirates were up there. Almost before the thought rushed through us, there was a crash, a whizzing through the air, and the large heavy body of one of the men fell into the midst of us, and lay there a shapeless bloody mass. Voices were immediately heard, calling to the man, and cautioning each other to beware. We heard the axe cutting away the brushwood, which fell in the cavern amongst us, and fancied faces were peeping down upon us, to see what had occurred to their companion. We stood and sat motionless. They called to him, and speculated on his fate, and wondered that they heard nothing from him. What should we do, if they discovered our ladders. It seemed however that they were too much alarmed at the unknown fate of their companion, to hazard their lives in search of him, but left the place, saying something about ropes and a further search.

And now what were we to do? Here we were with the great body of a pirate in the midst of us, who, though dead, inspired us with almost as much horror and terror, as if alive. What could we do with the crushed and horrid remains. This seemed to oppress us the most, and in thinking who was to touch and move it, we lost sight of the danger we incurred from the other pirates coming back to look for the body.

Mother.—"Well! Schillie, what must we do?"

Schillie.—"I shall not touch the beast!"

Madame.—"The sight is frightful, I really must retire."

The three girls hung aloof, the little ones had hidden themselves out of sight. Though I said nothing, I looked at Hargrave and Jenny.

Hargrave (very mysteriously).—"I assure you, Ma'am, I am not accustomed, that is, Ma'am, it is no business of mine. I have not in the 'abits of touching corpses and excuse me, Ma'am, this is so very—oh dear me whatever 'as come over me. I shall faint, I know."

Jenny (very pale and *resolute*).—"I think, Ma'am, if I rolled it up in a sheet, we might drag it between us to some distant cavern, and bury it in the sand."

Oscar.—"No, Jenny, we must cut him in pieces, and carry him out bit by bit into the sea."

Felix.—"Yes, here is his own saw, that I took away the last time we were at his house. He is only a pirate, Jenny, and quite dead; so, saw away!"

Jenny.—"Oh, Master Felix, I did not think you had the heart to be so cruel."

Oscar.—"Cruel! don't be absurd, Jenny. You don't care a bit for cutting off the heads of the chickens so why should you mind cutting up this great brute."

Jenny.—"Oh! Sir, you really must excuse me, I cannot do it, even to please you."

Our dilemma was really growing most painful. "Can one bury him here, as he is, without touching him?" said I. "Oh no, Mother," said Oscar. "We could never endure the place knowing this body was buried in it. Besides, see where he has fallen just where we dine. At all events, if you will none of you touch him, and he must be buried here, let us seek another cavern to live in, one nearer the waterfall."

"Shall we follow Otty's advice," said I to the others, "it seems the only thing we can do, but it is horrible."

"Cover up those unsightly remains, and let us begone," said Schillie, "the place is getting horrible even now."

We ran for every sort of thing we could find to shovel the sand over him, and though very soon out of sight, we worked harder and harder, as if the more sand we put over him, the more we drove from us the horrible sight. We then recollected the ladders, and Gatty and Serena ran up, and let them down, and then swung themselves down by a rope, which we fastened at the side of the cavern, in such a manner as to be hardly apparent, and certainly of no use.

For a full hour after we had done, the children were throwing more sand on the great Tumulus now before us, while we moved as many of our things as we could to another cavern, smaller, less convenient, and darker. We were so busy, that we forgot the pirates might come back, and were therefore electrified at the sound of their voices above. They called once or twice to the dead man, now buried many feet in sand, and of course receiving no answer, we found they were preparing to let a man down.

"Oh! Mother," said Oscar, "let us stone him well as he comes down, and that will frighten him." "And let us hiss like snakes," said Felix, "and he'll think he has got into a nest of big snakes." "Capital," said Gatty, "it will be glorious fun." "No, we must shoot him," said Schillie. "No, no, little Mother, do let us stone him, and hiss him out," said all the little ones, and they ran to collect stones.

"Indeed, Schillie, I think the children's idea a very good one. If he is well stoned he won't come down, and if we hiss they will certainly think us snakes and, being already fearful about them, who knows but the fear of their being in the caverns of the island may drive them all away."

Schillie.—"Did ever any one hear of anything so silly. As if a man with an ounce of brains would be taken in by such a child's trick as this."

Oscar.—"Then keep the guns ready, cousin, and you and I will have a shot at him if necessary."

"Agreed," said she. "Now make haste, every one hide in different corners; he is coming down."

Most of this conversation was, of course, in whispers. Gatty was to give the signal for the stoning operations by her most accomplished hiss.

A sudden burst of daylight; he was cutting the brushwood away to investigate as far as he could before descending. We were all like silent mice. Three hairy faces peered down. We shivered, and picked up the biggest stones. Now then he is coming, they say all right in Spanish, and he requests they will let him down very slowly. Now we see his legs, now his body, now the whole of him. Why does not Gatty give the signal? Lower and lower, I must hiss in a minute if she does not; at last he is fairly half way down. A great hiss, a perfect hurricane of hisses ensues, and a shower of stones aimed with such right goodwill that the man roared again. In their start and alarm above they had let him slip down suddenly a few feet, but his violent cries and entreaties to be drawn up were quickly attended to, and, amidst incessant hitting, and such a volley of stones that I do not think one inch of his body escaped a bruise, he disappeared from our sight.

We heard him groaning and moaning above, while the others questioned him. He was too much stunned however to say anything as far as we could make it out, and presently we found they were lowering him down from the cliffs near Cartref Pellenig, as the easiest way of getting him home.

From our peep-holes we had the satisfaction of seeing our enemy in a deplorable state, and apparently insensible, which Gatty averred was her performance, as she aimed particularly at his head.

As Madame observed, a most unladylike proceeding!

CHAPTER XXXIII.

We were some time in learning what effect our stratagem had had upon the pirates. On our parts we were delighted at the scheme succeeding so wonderfully, and dubbed the hero of it "The Knight of the Descending Ladder." They kept very close, and we saw but little of them until the ship returned. Then, indeed, there was a great row, and we saw the unfortunate "Knight" brought out on a sort of board, apparently to tell his tale, which must have been very wonderful to judge by their amazement. He seemed very ill indeed, and while some of us expressed a little sorrow for him, there were a few who wondered how he dare be still alive after their incredible exertions to kill him.

Schillie declared she had a great contempt now for the pirates, since they had been deceived and frightened by such children's play, and began to speculate upon getting rid of them all by degrees through working on their fears, and a sparing use of the gun.

Mother.—"Nothing surprises me so much as the change in your character. Formerly you scolded me for even killing a wasp (that allowed enemy to man and fruit), and yet now you coolly talk of shooting pirates as if it was a common morning's amusement."

Schillie.—"I shall not be happy as long as these wretches remain, especially as it only requires an earthquake to expose us to view. And now that they have got some notion (fools as they are) that the island is not without its dangers, we may as well follow it up, and, whoever they leave behind this time we must take care they never see again."

Mother.—"What! you mean to kill and bury them before the others return. I think it a very good plan, and it will effectually frighten them away if they come back two or three times, and on each return find those they have left here gone, without a trace of their disappearance. But I can never persuade

myself that there is one amongst our party who can deliberately go and shoot a man in cold blood who has never done them any harm."

Schillie.—"Pooh! pooh! just put yourself into their power for a day, and I'll be bound you come back quite ready to do anything to get rid of them. Such a set of wretches I never saw."

Jenny (smiling and smirking to me).—"And yet, Ma'am, they thought so much of Mrs. E. that time we were with them. The captain could not take his eyes off her."

We all laughed heartily at this, and congratulated Schillie on her conquest, while I added that I could easily perceive now why she was irritated against the pirates.

This put her into a great fit of the sulks, and I do not know with whom she would not have quarrelled if our conversation had not been put an end to by Oscar and Felix.

Oscar.—"Oh Mother, they are unloading the ship, and they have got some prisoners."

Felix.—"And, oh Mother, one poor prisoner is so wounded he is lame."

Oscar.—"And, Mother, we saw them bound, carried out of the boat."

Felix.—"And, oh Mother, they beat their poor prisoners, and one is lame."

Oscar.—"And, Mother, they are driving them up to Pirate Hall, and, Mother, we must——"

Felix.—"Oh Mother, we must——"

Oscar.—"Yes, yes, we must——"

Felix.—"Oh Mother, say yes, say yes."

Gatty.—"Release them! of course, glorious boys, we will. Have I not often released you two when playing at 'Prisoners base.'"

Sybil.—"Poor, poor fellows, we must try to help them."

Mother.—"This is news indeed! and I quite agree with all your feelings. But, children, you must let us think. Imagine what dangers you run."

Oscar.—"But, Mother, the poor prisoners!"

Felix.—"And, oh Mother, perhaps they will eat them, as Friday was going to be eaten."

Gatty.—"Pray, pray, do let us try to release them."

Sybil.—"Once they were safe in here we could soon make them well."

Serena.—"And then, being men, they will help us to fight against the pirates, and kill them all."

Mother.—"That will be very nice indeed. Schillie, these prisoners seem just sent in the nick of time to do the work I doubted our accomplishing."

Schillie.—"I think you and the children all a little cracked together, and have no doubt you will instantly march out in a body, give battle, and return victorious, carrying the prisoners in triumph, and decorated with the bloody heads of your enemies."

Gatty.—"You don't mean to say, little Mother, you would not help to get those two poor prisoners out of the murderous hands of these pirates?"

Felix.—"And one quite lame!"

Oscar.—"And perhaps they will eat them up."

Schillie.—"Pooh! pooh! brats, don't set up such a howling. Who said I was not ready to go to the rescue? Am I not your commander-in-chief? and are you not bound to obey your general? I only beg simply for the same grace your Mother asked for, namely, a little thought to settle our plans."

Madame.—"Oh, my dear Mrs. E., I had hoped from your knowledge of the world, and general good sense, that you would have calmed the young people's excited minds. Consider what risks we should run in releasing these people, and the inconvenience of having strangers and men attached to our party, living in the strange way we do."

Schillie.—"Madame, I consider but one thing; these two poor men are in the hands of the pirates and, rescued from their jaws they shall be, if I can do it."

Such a clapping of hands, and shouts of approbation arose on this speech that I was in mortal fear lest we should be heard.

Leaving the girls and children to argue the point with Madame, who had only Hargrave on her side, Schillie and I retired to talk over the matter, for it was really too grave a subject to be discussed with the same publicity that every other thing underwent in our community.

And it did require great deliberation, for, after all, it was a mad thing, a parcel of weak women and children thinking they could out-do thirty-two ruffian pirates. To be sure we had some great advantages, but, after all, what we should lose in the event of this act of philanthropy failing was everything, and for two strangers! who might turn out to be what Schillie called very uncomfortable people. And, besides, we had every prospect before us of out-witting the pirates, and finally getting rid of them. I own I began to be dubious, but my companion was firm, and wound-up by saying, "Mind I expect a solemn promise if we fail that you put a pistol to my head rather than let me fall into the hands of that fellow." I smiled maliciously, saying, "What the King of the Pirates?" "King of Horrors," said she, "don't forget now." "Then Jenny's story was true about his admiration of you," returned I. "Jenny's a goose, and you are another. If you mention him again I'll leave you, and go and settle in another part of the island."

In settling our plans for the release of the prisoners we were very much fettered by not being able to let them know what schemes we were making for their benefit. Also of what language and nation they were.

So it was agreed, greatly to the little boys' disgust, that we must try some experiments to make them know they had friends on the island. They declared that if we lost so much time they might both be eaten up before they could rescue them, and that it ought to be tried to-night. Not being so alarmed as the boys about the eating part of the business, the commander-in-chief merely ordered out a couple of scouts, who, from their practical knowledge of the country, knew the best places to drop little bits of paper, on which was written in English the following Notice:—

"If the prisoners would like to hear of something to their advantage, let them burn a light some night when communication can be uninterrupted and convenient, and to shew that they and only they have got this notice, let them tie something white round each arm."

We wrote in English, because we knew that the pirates understood French.

Gatty and Jenny were the two scouts, and we were very uneasy until they returned, which they did after two hours absence in the night. We diligently watched all that day, but saw no signs of the white mark on the prisoners' arms, though one was kept working hard in the very course where some of the billet doux were placed. The other we supposed was ill, as he did not appear until evening, when supported by the one we had seen all day. They retired together to a ledge of rocks by themselves, and seemed to hold earnest communion. One wrung his hands and seemed in the greatest grief, which made the children half-wild to get at them, to whisper comfort and release. Three days passed and no white sign, though every day they sat in the evening by themselves in this spot, and always secured in the utmost sorrow. We agreed we must put a billet doux there, if another day passed without the sign, though it was dangerously near Pirate Hall. In the meantime they were villainously used and ill-treated by the pirates, besides very hardly worked, so that they sometimes staggered and fell down from the weights they had to carry. Our indignation was great, and, like an impatient army as we were, we implored the commander in chief to give the word of march. We longed to hear him say "Up, guards, and at them." But that very evening surely we saw the white sign. It was true, indeed; how pleased we were. And then the delightful hope that they must be English was nearly confirmed, and showed how all our secret hopes and wishes had been in unison. This added to our zest in a wonderful manner. But now such a row, everybody wanted to go to the rescue, and it became a matter of difficulty to quell the military ardour of the army.

It was arranged that Schillie was to go first, with a rope in her hand, I was to follow holding the end of hers and the beginning of another, Oscar ditto, Jenny ditto, Gatty, Serena, Felix, Sybil, Zoë, Madame, Winny, Lilly, Hargrave the last. So that we were all linked together, and had a regular chain of communication. Any danger in front was indicated by pull of the ropes. And then it was to be "*Sauve qui pent*." Thus the whole army was

employed, and we were not likely to lose our way home, as the line extended so far that Hargrave would be close at home. The only risk we ran was, that, to enable us to perform this manœuvre, we had to go out at the Cartref Pellenig entrance, which we had in consequence to pull down and open for the first time in four months. However, we trusted to our good cause, and the fact that the entrance was at all times difficult to find, and would not take half an hour to put to rights again. But this notable plan was to depend in a great measure whereabouts the signal light would be placed.

When it was quite dark, we looked out with beating hearts. No light. We watched and waited half an hour; suddenly a light shone for a minute or so, and then darkness again. "That must certainly be a signal," said we, "however, we will wait another half hour." In less than half an hour, again a light shone for only a few minutes, and, as far as we could judge, just in the usual spot where they went every evening to talk by themselves. In fact, the spot where the before-mentioned manœuvre of our great army was to be executed. So we rushed up the caverns in a most disorderly manner, and were all ready to obey the word of command in less than ten minutes at the Cartref Pellenig entrance. To our honour be it spoken, as an army composed of so many females, not a word was spoken, and we emerged from the entrance as noiselessly as bats out of an old chimney.

Cautiously we proceeded, keeping close to the rock, so as to feel our way, but had to pass dangerously near Pirate Hall. We could hear them snoring in sleep; but there were watchers also, for they were talking noisily in one of the rooms. Now we must pause a moment, in hopes the light will again shine, and also to still our hearts, if possible, they are beating so loud. Five minutes passed, Schillie was then going slowly on, when her rope jumped with a start, so did mine, so I suppose did all the others, and I was sure I recognised the faintest little scream from Madame. The light shone out all of a sudden, not ten yards from us; it was that which made us start so. We noted the two men distinctly, and, waiting until the light was out again, we then advanced, and Schillie touching one and I the other, we took hold of some hard horny hands, and made the signal by shaking the ropes to return.

Back we went, in rather a hurry-scurry I must allow. As everybody got into the cavern, the others came rushing in quicker and quicker; Schillie and I alone kept a stately march, holding the hard horny hands, not a word

passing between the delivered and the deliverers; but if gratitude could be expressed by a grasp, it was done by the hand I held in mine. I had the lame prisoner, and while the hand trembled in mine like the hand of a timid woman, I felt his hairy mouth touching it, and the other hand trying in a gentle but earnest manner to feel the arm and as much of me as he could. He seemed to shake like an aspen leaf, and almost choked with suppressed emotion. But we are nearer, Gatty is in, Jenny, Oscar, the General slipped by me, and unhandsomely got in first. Now we were all safe. Jenny, Hargrave, and the girls flew for the torches to do up the entrance again. We silently led the rescued prisoners to a little cavern, which was somewhat remote from the others.

Madame brought us a torch, and with acknowledged curiosity we proceeded to examine what were now our prisoners. Two great hairy men. Why did we start? A deep groan, and an English "God be thanked" burst from the lips of one as he fell senseless to the ground. The other rushed to the boys with vehement gesture, and catching both in his arms, uttered a shout that made the cavern ring again. "Oh, Smart, Smart," said they, "our dear, dear Tom Smart, is it really you? are you come back for us? are you alive?"

Could this be real? It was indeed too true. The prisoners about whom we had been so anxious, the poor fellows we had so intuitively been interested in, and determined to risk our lives to save, were no other than our dear lamented captain and equally beloved Smart. Surely we could now tell why, from the first, we had been so anxious about them. There yet remained a trace in their sadly-altered appearance of something we had loved and lost. But the news spread like lightning, the entrance was left to its fate, every one flocked with their own eyes to behold that it was really true. The little ones flew into Smart's arms, and kissed his great face, and welcomed him as a father. The dear captain still remains insensible on the ground. We poured water over him, we chafed his hands, we called him by every tender name, but his insensibility remained deep and profound. It was necessary that something should check our joy, otherwise we should have been too elated for safety and prudence.

Two of us watched by the captain, and the others, accompanied by the not-to-be-lost-sight-of Smart, went to fill up the entrance. It was now daylight, and in this little instance we saw what it was to have our dear Smart back

again. In ten minutes he secured the entrance far more safely than we could do in an hour; and all being now right, we adjourned to our breakfasts, though it was only to ask questions and give answers, for nobody could eat; but his important communications must be kept for another chapter.

CHAPTER XXXIV.

With a little girl on each knee, Felix hanging with arms round his neck, Oscar sitting into his pocket, and we all ranged in a circle before him, we forgot the pirates, we forgot everything but the present moment. We almost fancied ourselves once more at home; and thus we sat for hours, heedless of meals and dangers, listening to and retailing again all that had occurred since our sad and fatal parting.

The only interruptions were our occasional visits to the dear captain, whose insensibility had given place to an attack of fever and delirium, through which Madame had engaged to bring him, if we left her in peace and quiet to fulfil her own prescriptions. We could not avoid, however, spite our deep interest in all Smart said, running to enquire every ten minutes if he was better. And painful was it to hear his broken exclamations, his cries after us, the mournful repetition of each little pet name, his agonies for their fancied danger, his remorse and sorrow choking the prayers and petitions he mixed with all he said. Dear kind captain, if all you said in your delirium had been running through your brain once you had parted from us, no wonder that it had at last given way, and that you now lay before us a wreck of what you once were, a broken-down, miserable-looking, white-headed man. But now for Smart's story, which I think it best to give in his own words, as well as how we questioned it all out of him.

Felix.—"Ah, Tommy, dear Tommy, how could you run away and leave us in that bad manner?"

Oscar.—"Yes, Smart, I don't think we have ever been happy since, until to-day."

Smart (blowing his nose and wiping his eyes).—"My dear young 'squire, my darling Mr. Felix, was it not the mistress's orders? But I will never leave you again, no, not if I am pounded to death by those scums of the earth, and live to see them rewarded for their trouble."

The three little girls (all in piteous voices).—"And could they hurt you, dear Smart, so good and kind as you are, and our darling captain? Oh, make haste, make haste, and tell us all about it."

Smart.—"I will make every haste, dear young ladies, but I don't rightly know where to begin. The sight of all your beautiful faces and my young gentlemen grown into men, and looking so proud and handsome, makes me in a manner beside myself; and me and the old captain was but a-saying last night no longer could we bear the trouble, but must do ourselves a mischief."

Felix.—"You, a mischief! No, no, Smart, you were always a very good boy. It's only me was a mischief."

Smart.—"You are a very fine young gentleman, and be growed; dear me, Sir, how you be growed. I would not a known you but for them eyes, and that bit of mischief they have in them. Give me leave, Ma'am, just to take one good look of you all. My heart, how the young ladies have sprung up, like lilies on a stalk. Miss Gatty no doubt as free as ever, only quite a woman; and you, Ma'am, be a sight stouter. Oh, what a sight this is. Little did we think, ould captain and I, when we seed this onlucky island agin, little did we think as you was still here. When they brought us up out of the hold, I knowed the spot in a minute. Says I to the cap'in, 'Not content with murdering us they mean to cut our hearts in two. Here's the very blessed place as I saw them all last time as ever I laid eyes on them.' With that he gave a great shout and has never rightly been himself since. And, truly, with my own heart nigh bursting, his'n was a mighty heavy one to bear up. Spite of all our hard work, we did our best to examine every spot to find traces of you, and we came to the notion, as you were all gone, through good whiles, maybees safe, unknowst of our fate, maybees dead; any way, we thought you had escaped our sad hap."

Schillie.—"But, Smart, that's the end of your story, begin at the beginning."

Smart.—"Where's that, Ma'am? I know neither beginning or end of anything since that unlucky morn we slipped away."

Schillie.—"Where did you go to then?"

Smart.—"Why we sailed away some few days; the vessel was but a cockle on the water, she was so light, so that we were noways comfortable in the matter of steadiness and good walking ground. Anyways, however, we had plenty to do spelling at the pumps, and so we went on, I won't say with hearts as light as the vessel, until a shot struck the big stick as stands in the middle of the ship. Well, we looked about, and saw an evil-disposed, black-looking, hang-dog of a vessel, that sent shot upon shot into us. Well, the smell of powder did me good, and we gave it them back right well with them two brass guns, Master. I beg your pardon, Sir, you being so growed, Mr. Oscar. And so we should ha' gone on peppering them to this minute, until they were all dead or gave in, had it not been for them same guns getting so hot, they were next to no use at all. Howsumdever, when they came aboard, we gave it them in a manner as some will carry to their dying day. And though that never mended the matter, it's a poor heart that does not rejoice over something, and that something was the settling of a round dozen of them rascally pirates by my own hand."

The boys (together).—"Twelve pirates! Did you really kill twelve?"

Smart.—"Kill or drown 'em, you may reckon on that, Sirs, and many more would I have served out in like manner, but four great brutes came behind me, and cracked my skull to that degree as neither sight to my eyes or sense to my tongue came for a length of weeks. And, maybe, but for the good old captain, it's in heaven only (if God in his goodness will grant me to go there) that I ever thought to see your sweet faces again."

Lilly.—"Now, dear Smart, go on."

Smart.—"Yes, Miss Lilly, but what a head o' hair you have, my pretty young lady; why here are curls enough to hang a score of pirates, but never a hair shall go near them, mark my words. They shall hew me into mince-meat ere they look on the sight that makes me strong as lions."

Lilly.—"But go on, dear Smart."

Smart.—"The breadth and length of them shall pass over my body ere they touch even Mrs. Hargrave. My heart sings with joy. I feel as a giant refreshed, now I know thee to be all safe and well, and growed so beautiful. I wants nothing, I cares for nothing. It's enough that I see you once more."

All the little girls and boys.—"But, dear Smart, go on. What did the pirates do to you?"

Smart.—"They did that to me as I never thought living man would do. They marked my back with stripes, but I never felt them, for the wound in my heart. They worked me worse than any horse; yet I was glad to be druv from my thoughts. And when I would fall from weakness, want, and hard treatment, I would sink with pleasure, trusting my time was come, and that they would have nothing but senseless clay to kick. Howsumdever, God has been good to me. May I never forget this hour. All things will prosper now. The good time is coming, and the worst is over. Could we but build a bridge now to bonnie ould England, I would desire nothing else in this world, save one good fight with those d——. I humbly beg pardon, ladies, but excuse poor Smart, he has almost forgot his manners in the bad company he has been keeping."

The boys.—"Never mind, Smart, we will help you to kill them. Mother and cousin Schillie were going to set about it as soon as ever the pirate vessel was gone, and we were to help."

Felix.—"And I was going to have a right and left shot, Tommy."

Smart.—"And you would ha' settled 'em, I'll be bound, Sir. What a stout fine fellow you be growed, Sir, and I hope as good too, and very sensible too; and I dare say, Sir, quite the gentleman to the little ladies."

Felix (looking down).—"Yes, yes, I dare say, perhaps, Smart, but we are not able to be ladies and gentlemen here you know. We are obliged to be servants and everything, and Otty and I are the gamekeepers."

Smart.—"Well, I do suppose, Sir, that does not prevent your behaving in a civil like way to the little ladies."

Felix.—"Oh yes, we are very civil to them when they are kind to us. But once we could not have any fish, because Lilly would not give us one of her curls to make lines."

Smart.—"Oh, my heart alive, take one of these pretty curls to make fishing lines? Indeed, Master Felix, I always thought you were very oudacious, Sir, begging your pardon."

Felix.—"But she had such a many of them, Smart."

Mother.—"There you need say no more on that sore subject. You know Lilly repented afterwards, and you ought to be ashamed of mentioning the matter."

Felix.—"But I must just tell Smart she did give us two at last, her two longest and best; and, my stars, how angry Jenny was, I really thought she would whip me."

Jenny.—"Indeed, Sir, you was very aggravating. See how shocked Smart is that ever you should have wanted or taken Miss Lilly's curls."

Felix.—"Well, Smart, don't be angry, we will never do it any more, only they did make such good lines, and Mama was nearly as vexed as Jenny."

Big and little girls.—"Now, Smart, go on."

Smart.—"I ha' a'most done, ladies; them times is too shocking to remember; but it's true gospel, as we all remained servants and slaves to them——scums. They took the ship, and painted and fitted her out until her own sister would not ha' known her. And they came and went just as suited 'em, always a-leaving us with sum on 'em, and their wives, and houses, and children, in a outlandish place, hot as the place I trust they'll all go to."

Oscar.—"Sailors and all, Benjie and Mr. ——"

Smart.—"He, poor fellow, was done for at the first, and a good many of the sailors were likewise done up and made away with, so that, maybees, there was not six left on us. The cap'in and I have stuck to each other through fair and foul, though it's precious little of the former as has blessed our heads, and there be sum few yet remaining at that place I was telling you was so hot."

The Quixotic little girls and boys all exclaim, "Then we must go and save them, especially Benjie."

Smart.—"Hi, Benjie, he was doing very well, but, being a good decent sort of chap, it's my wonder he never poisoned them——ramscallions when cooking for them."

Smart always, when mentioning the pirates, seemed half choked in preventing himself saying some word that he did not deem proper for our ears. Sometimes it half slipped out, when he made an apologetical bow; sometimes he swallowed it whole; but he always paused, as if to give himself time to say it privately as a relief to his feelings.

But this conversation will be wearisome, so I will say no more than that Smart imagines they were brought to this island to help to look after the stores and gardens, and to be servants, the pirates not knowing the important interest they had in the island, or that they had ever seen it before. Also, that they intended to make it their regular colony, and by degrees bring their whole establishment there; for the island was very well known, and always shunned by vessels on account of the great snake, whom it seemed impossible to destroy. This accounted for our never seeing any vessels all this time; and the pirates would not have ventured there had it not been for the storm we had thought so unlucky, and which now seemed to be the crowning providence of our eventful lives.

In the meantime, Smart was never tired in listening to the children's tales, and whatever he was doing, he had the whole five clinging about him.

CHAPTER XXXV.

Madame fulfilled her promise, and in a few days we had the inexpressible satisfaction of sitting by the rude couch of the captain, and hearing his broken exclamations of happiness and delight. It seemed sufficient pleasure to him to watch us as we went about our various duties, and smiles mixed with tears often covered his poor thin face as the little ones vied with each other in nursing him. But he was too weak yet to enter into much conversation, and his nurse was very careful not to let him over-exert himself, for fear of a relapse. In fact, nature seemed to speak for him, as in reply to our anxious queries whether we could do anything for him, he would reply, "Nothing, nothing, but let me look at you, God be praised."

In these few days of exquisite happiness we forgot all about the pirates. Nobody watched them, nobody thought of them, though we have reason to suppose that they made a diligent search for their prisoners, and even persevered in it to the top of the large cavern. This we had deserted for some time on account of the dead body, and we now lived in the smaller ones lower down, one of which was so near the waterfall we had nearly as much light as above, and also heard the murmuring sound of the water in a very pleasing and cooling manner. Here, close by the waterfall, the little ones led their dear captain, that he might inhale as much of the fresh sea air as we could get, and from thence we, of course, watched our enemies. They seemed very busy indeed, and it was no small satisfaction to the children to watch them working so hard, and pointing them out to Smart, saying, "See, dear Smart, you would have been doing that if our great army had not come and saved you."

By degrees the captain told us a more coherent story than Smart had been able to give us, and said within a fortnight of their leaving us they were made prisoners by the pirates; that they dragged out lengthened days of misery, want, and ill-usage, only held up by the knowledge that our future deliverance depended upon their escape. And when time went on, and he

thought it was almost impossible such a helpless party of women and children could survive and bear up under such an unhappy fate, he was almost reduced to despair, and they were both determined to do something desperate when they were put on board the pirates' vessel and brought here. And when brought up on deck, and Smart's exclamation awoke his mind to the fact that he was looking upon the lovely bay in which he had left us with hopes of a speedy and happy return, his brain turned with inward emotion, his heart seemed to turn to stone, he became a moving body without soul or sense, save an eager looking for traces of us.

These could, as we knew, be only so very faint they could leave no clue to our destiny. The first ray of hope that shot through him was finding one of our little notes, though, for some time, they thought it was but the writing of ancient days, and not meant for them now. But when they found another, and when the pirates picked more up, and turned them round and round to make out their meaning, a conviction shot through them they had some kind person interested in their fate on the island. But they had some difficulty in managing about the light, as burning it steady would have been forbidden by the pirates. A wild hope had now and then crossed their minds, but had each time been driven away as impossible, and it was not until they felt the soft smooth female hands in that dark but happy night that they gave up their minds to hopeful anticipations, mixed with some fears. How their fondest wishes were realized almost in the first flash of the torch had been already detailed, and while the weakened frame and overwrought mind of the captain sunk under the weight of so much happiness the buoyant Smart recovered his own character at once, and became all and everything he had ever been to us, with a double portion of strength, energy, and sense to assist and help us.

And now a fortnight had passed, and we found the pirates making great preparations to sail. This they soon did, and, counting their members as they went on board, we had the inexpressible happiness of finding that not one was left behind. Once more we had our dear little island to ourselves, and thoroughly did we enjoy the open air and brilliant sunshine, for, with all thankfulness for their kind shelter, it must be acknowledged the caverns were a little gloomy and musty. We wandered over every well-known place, shewed our dear house, now such a ruin, and expatiated upon all its beauties and conveniences, until the captain declared it must have been the most

perfect house in the world, while Smart vowed he would settle a score of pirates for daring to burn it down.

And now we found out what the pirates had been so busy about during the last fortnight, namely, building a perfect village of huts at the old house by the plantation. The captain shook his head as he mournfully said, "the whole colony are coming to settle here," while Smart coolly declared, "he was mighty glad thereat, as he would not die happy unless he could settle 'em all, big and little." And forthwith persuaded everybody but Madame and Hargrave to take to ball practice as he called it, that the army might be ready in case of any emergency. We thought it no harm to practice with our neighbours' goods, though we meant to turn them against themselves. But Smart knew where their magazine was, and in a most unprincipled manner we abstracted whatever we could that would not be immediately discovered.

Smart, who always had had a secret admiration for Schillie's *sang froid* and man-like propensities, treated her as his favourite pupil; and after she had hit the mark seventeen times running, held her up to us as worthy of imitation.

Smart.—"I used to always be a-telling our cap'in they'll do well if they mind Mrs. E, she has the soul of a man and the wits of a king; and it's my belief even if they hadna gotten us back, she'd a outwitted them ere——rascallion divildims."

Nothing delighted the boys so much as to put Smart into a rage, talking about the pirates. The dooms they were all to meet with, if once he got them into his power, would have done for Foxe's book of Martyrs. But much as we enjoyed this time we were not idle; we were making constant preparations for the great struggle that must, we knew, inevitably take place between us and the pirates. And, calculating that they would arrive with their colony a short time before the wet weather, to get settled in their houses before it commenced, we should have that time to mature our plans, besides settling what had best be done.

CHAPTER XXXVI.

The sight of two sail in the horizon one evening prepared us for seeing them in harbour the next day. But conceive our indignation when the captain told us that the other dirty, dingy, ill-looking, black vessel was no other than our darling La Luna. To be sure she had not lost her elegant shape, but in every other respect she was so altered not one of us knew her. The little girls sat down and cried like fishes (if they do cry), and Madame helped to swell the stream by a copious flow of tears; while the indignation of the elder girls vented itself in anathemas and threats against the pirates, that showed they had profited pretty considerably by Smart's conversation and opinions. We were now obliged to take to our burrows, and watched, with immense wrath and disgust, the debarkation of the female pirates from the pretty cabins and berths of our La Luna.

In appearance and manners they matched the men, but we agreed amongst ourselves, tall and fierce as they looked, we were not afraid of them, and had no objection to "settle them," as Smart called it. There were fifteen women and about eleven children, while the pirates themselves now amounted to forty-five. Fearful odds against us. Nevertheless, the courage and determination of the army rose higher and higher. They had only just time to get themselves into their houses and huts, and the ships into winter quarters; ere the bad weather commenced. How they spent their time on the island we never enquired. It was enough that we were very happy within her friendly bosom, indulging in all sorts of merriment and fun, knowing they were a good way off, close prisoners like ourselves. And while in the pretty, elegant, and spacious drawing-room once before mentioned, so replete with luxury, beauty, and every comfort, mourners still sat and thought of and wept for the long-lost, the mysteriously-doomed members of that once happy family; each kind face bearing the traces of the anxious fear and thoughts months but added to and time could not heal: how looked the little party in the coral caverns of the Pacific? We will look at them once more, ere we take our leave of them for good. Lying on a rude grass couch

is an elderly lady, her hair snow-white, and covered with a cambric handkerchief to serve as a cap; she is reading. Not far from her are two servants, in long blue rough dresses; they seem preparing a meal. On the other side of them is seated, on a rude bench, a weather-beaten white-haired man; a pretty graceful girl of twelve is watching him concocting a pair of shoes, and as they are for herself, she diligently assists. A little sparkling bright face peeps behind, and mischievously adorns the captain's head with Hargrave's sad remains of a cap, which she always carefully puts aside when doing anything likely to hurt it. Not far from them is the fine, tall, athletic frame of the keeper, both boys intently watching him making fishing lines, they dressed in loose white shirts, open in front, and full white trousers; the elder boy imitating the art of making lines, the little one exciting his parrot to abstract Smart's apparatus, as fast as he puts one thing down after another, which leads to sundry threats on Smart's part that he will "settle" both young Master and parrot if they are not quiet. As this "settling" never takes place, of course the delinquents go on, even to abstracting all the treasures out of Smart's pockets. But you can see by Smart's eye a day of reckoning is coming for those two. There are no less than nine parrots making more or less noise in the cavern, who have each a different owner, and whose voices they distinguish with wonderful sagacity, and hop, crawl, and climb in their quaint manner whenever they are called.

Two little, quiet, serious-looking monkeys are busily watching the preparations for dinner, appropriating what they can to themselves in so secret and sly a manner that Hargrave is totally ignorant of the real thieves, and accuses Jenny wrathfully of misplacing her things. Jenny laughs and shows her pretty white teeth, enjoying the joke as much as we do.

Three fine, tall, becoming girls, each above the middle size, one fair and bright-looking as the sun, another graceful as the fawn with eyes and mouth the perfection of sweet gentle beauty, and the last a sort of female Smart, strong as a young elephant, with mouth like rosebuds, teeth like almonds, and eyes so bright in their dark beauty you could hardly gaze into them; such were the dear girls, a sight, as the captain said, such as he only thought to see in heaven. They are grouped together over two weaving machines, and while one is employed removing the broken threads that invariably occur in our clumsy machines, the other two throw the shuttle to and fro. Not with much diligence though for that ever-mischievous Gatty throws one

impediment after another in their way, so that I foresee the two sisters will suddenly set upon her, and there will be a regular scuffle.

And who is that lying her full length on the ground, the flushed cheek resting on one hand, the violet eyes closed, and the knitted stocking that requires finishing that day has fallen from the little listless hand? Oh Lilly, Lilly, idle Lilly, here are you soundly sleeping, and there is your parrot conceitedly thinking he can do the work of his lazy little mistress, and in another minute it will be all destroyed. Wake up, little sleeper, wake up, and collect those long curls floating like a raven curtain about you. Think what Madame will say if she catches but a glimpse of you. A little apart from all stands one tall figure, taller than all the rest, her dark hair folded back from her forehead, her dark eyes watching each beloved group, while she spins unceasingly. Close at her feet sits her shadow, clothed in the same sort of long white dress, with the open sleeves disclosing the prettiest ivory arms in the world. Short curling hair of a rich dark colour hangs round the white neck and broad forehead of the sitter, and what are those little pink and white fingers doing? Must I tell? A faithful historian must recite plain facts, and, therefore, provided the secret goes no further, I will allow she was cleaning pistols! And, according to Smart's opinion, "she did 'em a sight better than many a man he had had under him."

Now and then those clear dark eyes look up, and she says, "Now, June, stop that everlasting wheel or I shall have you fainting with fatigue."

Mother.—"Take my place then."

Schillie.—"Good lack, spinning is such dull work. Let me finish my pistols first."

And of course dinner is announced ere the pistols are pronounced complete. A solemn grace said by the dear captain, whose "God be thanked" comes slowly from the lips as if the heart was with it. Then a merry dinner, Smart, and the maidens waiting on us, for nothing will persuade Smart to sit down with us, and Jenny keeps him company, and Hargrave, with a little hauteur condescends to do the same. All sorts of pranks go on between Smart and the boys during dinner. Felix trying to upset his solemn gravity, while Oscar sends him with preserved ginger to Schillie's duck, roasted potatoes to Madame's tapioca pudding, whereby he gets very shamefaced, as Schillie,

with blunt sincerity, points out his mistake. Then behind us he shakes his fist at the boys, while they invent fresh nonsense to tease him. In the meantime the dispute runs hot and high between the little girls as to who is to sit next to their beloved captain, Gatty and Serena making believe that they will assert their rights as Signori Priori, and take the coveted seats.

However dinner is over, and we all adjourned to the lowest cavern while the servants eat theirs. Then we sing songs and tell stories.

Felix.—"Cousin Schillie, you promised to tell us the story of the jack-daws if we behaved well and obeyed our general."

Schillie.—"Pooh! pooh! you have heard it a hundred times, boy."

Felix.—"But the captain has not."

"I should like to hear it very much," said he.

Mother.—"Then, Schillie, you will have to tell it again for the hundred and first time, and you, captain, must not think that you are to hear a very wonderful story, but, as it is the only one she was ever known to tell, we are obliged to make her repeat it again and again. If she would kindly tell us a fresh one we should be obliged, but, as she won't, we will prepare ourselves to listen once more to the tale of

THE JACK-DAWS.

Once upon a time (this is too bad of you June) there stood an old church in the middle of a village (making me tell this old story), and this church had a very fine old tower (I wish you up in it now), and in this tower lived a fine pair of jack-daws (fine company for you). Well! you must know these jack-daws had a large family of greedy young children (just like you). Now there lived in the village, (besides many other brats) two boys, a big boy and a little boy. The big boy was a great big stout hulking fellow, with a snubby nose and green eyes; and the little fellow was a nice active chap, about the size of Tom Thumb, quick and sharp as a needle. So one day these two boys sat in the church-yard, and watched the jack-daws as they flew hither and thither and everywhere. Says the little fellow, 'Them jack-daws must have a nest up there.' Says the big chap, 'No doubt, and I would like to have the

young ones,' (mind children it's a wicked thing taking birds from their nests; look at all of you away from your nests; go on, cousin, go on, the captain is quite impatient). Well! so they agreed they would climb up the old church tower, and get the young ones, which accordingly they did. Now you must know the old jack-daws, being very knowing, had built their nest so that it was outside the tower, just out of their reach, and there they could see almost within grasp seven little jack-daws, all with their mouths wide open, waiting for their father to pop in a delicious fat worm! ('Oh, cousin, how nasty,' says Winny). So the two boys were much puzzled, but at last the big one takes hold of a plank, and, putting it out of the little window, 'Now,' says he, 'go you and sit at that end and I will push the plank out of the window, and you will just be able to reach the nest.' 'Very well,' says the little fellow, 'but mind you sit at the other end, lest the plank tilts up with me, and I go down.' 'All right,' says the big fellow, and away goes the little boy. 'I have got them all seven,' says he, 'and very fine ones they are.' 'Very well,' says the big boy, 'mind four are mine, and three are yours.' 'No such thing,' says the little one, 'I underwent the danger, so I'll have the four, and you shall have the three.' 'No you shall not,' says big bully. 'Yes I will,' says the little sturdy fellow. 'I will let you down if you don't give me the four,' says the big rascal. 'Let away,' says the small boy, 'I won't give them up.' So the young villain let go the plank, and away went the little fellow, holding stoutly on by his little birds. Well the seven jack-daws spread their wings and fluttered, and the wind being high, it filled a great stout pinafore that he had on, so that between the two, he was borne safely to the ground, when, looking up at the window, out of which the big bully was watching his flight, he shouted out, 'Now you shall have none of them.'

CHAPTER XXXVII.

Felix.—"Now, captain, if you had seen that big boy, would you not have walloped him?"

"Most certainly," said the captain, "but now we must be thinking of more important matters." And as the hot weather set in with more than ordinary vigour, it was very clear that we should not be safe in our caverns, subjected to the earthquakes that generally accompany the heat.

Besides we were getting restless and impatient. If all alone by ourselves, we had meditated getting the better of the pirates—think what wild schemes we now had, with Smart and the captain to help us.

But we must wait until some of them went away in the ships after their usual avocations, as even the bravest amongst us did not hope to conquer them all. They seemed however bent upon making their homes more comfortable before they went, and it was somewhat late in the season when they started in their own vessel, leaving La Luna and half their men behind. These latter were employed in sowing seeds and preparing the ground for fruits and vegetables. We saw but little of the women, as they hardly ever left their side of the island. We now discussed the possibility of dispatching those parties who were left behind, thinking though there were many more than we expected, yet we might get rid of them, and taking possession of La Luna, get off the island at once. A mad scheme it certainly was and nothing but the ardent longing we had to escape made us think of it so confidently.

In the meantime, Smart gained the captain's permission, to "settle" any of the men he might catch in a convenient position, so as to shoot them, without exposing himself or us to risk of discovery. So highly did he appreciate this permission, that he never ceased day or night dodging about and watching these people, and three times he came in with ill-concealed triumph, though he respected our feelings too much to do more than insinuate he had "settled" some one or more. We, in the meanwhile,

occupied ourselves in making sacks and putting food into them, ready to start at a moment's warning should a favourable time arrive.

The pirates, we suppose, now began to suspect, from the extraordinary death of three of their men, that the two prisoners were concealed somewhere in the island, and not being able to discover them, or to account for deaths taking place in such different parts of the island, they kept altogether, close to the plantation side, and left the bay entirely to us.

This gave Smart an opportunity of getting to the ship and bringing off a boat, which we concealed by day in a cleft of the rock, but nightly we employed ourselves in running down to the shore with everything we had collected, which Smart and the captain stowed in the ship. We had been at this work about a week, in full confidence and in the highest spirits, our hopes were great, the dangers of the voyage appeared as nothing, all our plans seemed succeeding, when one night, just as we were all creeping up, tired and worn out with our night's work, we heard shriek upon shriek from one of our party.

The strong sonorous voice of the captain shouted to us to get to cover. Smart followed, huddling us all in like sheep, but, dark as it was, we could not see who was missing, and I could not trust my voice to ask. We ran to the inner cavern, and there, by the light of the torch, we missed the darling child, Zoë, and both the maids.

Smart.—"Don't fret, Ma'am, don't fret, no harm is done. We'll have 'em back by the morn. The cap'in and I will just take a step out and look about us, and you, Madam, will be ready to help us, no doubt," turning to Schillie.

Schillie.—"Yes, yes, Smart, I am quite willing. As for you, June, mind what Smart says, and don't fret. If we could rescue those two from all of them, think how much more likely we are to succeed now. I am only afraid that fool Hargrave will do us a mischief. I wish it had been any other person than her in the scrape."

Captain.—"Now then, Madam, send them all to rest, and don't fear anything. Smart and I are not likely to sit still while our brave deliverers are in danger. And as for my pretty flower, I'll cut through a wall of pirates to get at her."

Mother.—"Then, Madame, take them all away. I assure you I cannot sleep. I am ready to help with Schillie. Let us settle at once what is best to be done."

They all went off most unwillingly, while we arranged that getting up through the big cavern by the rope still concealed there, Smart should go to the pirates' village, in as secret a manner as he could, and find out what was best to be done, and where the prisoners were placed. No time was to be lost. He was guided immediately to the place, not only by the glare of the torches, but by the screams of Hargrave, and following them cautiously, he concealed himself close by one of the windows where they were put, and heard all that took place.

Jenny was recognised immediately, and the innocent child was frightened almost into a fainting fit by the rough and horrid manners of these dreadful people. But, according to Smart's account, Mrs. Hargrave was in a mort of tantrums. He got back in safety, though with much difficulty, and then detailed to us the following facts:

They were, as before, questioned all about themselves, and Jenny, as before, stoutly maintained all were dead. They pointed to the child, and smiled in scorn, but Zoë, like a brave little girl, positively refused to say more than Jenny did, making the tears run down Smart's face as he described the little white lips, so firm and decided; and each time, by way of puzzling her, they put the question in a different manner, each time she pointed to the three as if they were all.

Smart.—"I beant one bit afeard of them two, but I am of that Mrs. Hargrave; and it crossed my mind, when I heerd her shrieking and squalling for you all, if I had not better put a bullet in her head just to silence her, only I did not for ould acquaintance sake, and I seed, by the sniggling of them oudacious monsters, as they meant to get some'at out of her. I gave Jenny to understand as I was near at hand, and the brave little thing, I could see by her eye, knowed the sound, but never a sign gave she."

Captain.—"I am afraid, Smart, it is of no use trying to deceive them any longer, as they must be now aware that there is some place of concealment on the island unknown to them; and, from my knowledge of their character, I know their cunning and devilry is so great they will leave no stone unturned to find it out."

Smart.—"Cap'n, you and I agree, and it's through that weak fool Mrs. Hargrave as they'll sarcumvent us. I never thought she had much brains, and now I reckon she has worse nor none. Jenny and Miss Zoë would ha' got clear off, had it not been for her skriking and pulling at 'hem, for I heerd Jenny a giving it her handsome, saying she must ha' had the heart of a savage to keep such hold of Miss Zoë when the pirates took her, instead of letting the little innocent lady escape as she could; and, though she did not say so, I am partly sure Jenny might ha' got off well, only she was a-trying to get Miss Zoë free from that weak woman, a-holding on like grim death, and, finding she wasn't capable, she bided with the child to be a help and comfort to her."

Mother.—"Ah, how like that good Jenny."

Schillie.—"She certainly is a little trump, and never thinks of herself."

Madame.—"If I fold my darling Zoë in my arms once more, I shall never be able sufficiently to show my gratitude to Jane."

Captain.—"She shall never want for bite nor sup, once we get her free, as long as I live."

Felix.—"She is not your Jenny, captain, she is mine, she is always to live with me, and, when I am married, she is to be my children's nurse."

Sybil and Serena and Gatty all expressed their admiration, while Gatty added, "I wish Smart had sent his bullet where he said, for if there is an owl in the world it is that Hargrave."

The captain proceeded to state that there seemed no likelihood of the prisoners being harmed at present. I had visions before my eyes of the old stories where innocent children are brought forward with bloody swords held over their heads, ready to be sacrificed if they did not confess and capitulate, and while all agreed they would sacrifice themselves for Zoë and Jenny, Smart and the captain declared we were not allowed the choice, for our lives were in their keeping, and all must not be sacrificed for two. We none of us seemed to have the least pity or care for poor Hargrave.

"It was mighty lucky," said Smart, "she could speak nothing but her mother tongue, and that but badly clipping and mincing it, for she was letting out

everything in such a way I could ha' shook her well; and I'll be bound to do it when I next see her. I hopes as they did not understand, but I ha' my doubts."

The captain now set them all to work watching at different posts, with orders to run and tell him all that occurred every half hour. Turning to Schillie and me he said, "Ladies I would advise you to prepare for the worst. They will work on the fears of that silly woman I doubt. We must be prepared, and while I can defend the entrance for a good hour, you must make your retreat, and where that is to be the Lord only knows."

Mother.—"If we could get to the top of that big rock standing out this side the bay, we can keep them off for some time there."

Captain.—"That rock is but changing one desperate hope for another. However we must trust in God. I'll try and believe that poor woman will not utterly forget herself and us."

Schillie.—"Why! my good captain, this island is like a rabbit warren, they can never unearth us if we choose to be moderately careful."

Captain.—"I have no doubt we could hide here for some time, but, with such a lot of young ones all the care in the world on our parts may be upset in a moment by thoughtlessness on theirs. Besides, they won't leave a corner unvisited I feel sure, partly out of revenge, for they are a most spiteful race, and partly from feeling persuaded you are the people so long lost, and for whose recovery such large rewards are offered."

Schillie.—"In that case I imagine they won't harm us."

Captain.—"They might not perhaps have done so at first, but 'they will cut off their nose to spite their face' I am certain; by which I mean they will be so savage at losing their men, and so angered at having been deceived all this time by such a helpless party, that they might murder us all in cold blood on the spur of the moment."

Schillie.—"And that will be very unpleasant as far as I can judge."

Mother.—"I should think we could make some hiding places amongst the caverns, captain."

Captain.—"So we could, Madam, had we time, and if I live but an hour, or for one hundred years, my regret at not having taken the precaution will be the same."

Schillie.—"Give me any orders you like, captain, and they shall be done if possible."

Captain.—"I know they will, I know for certain they will, so now I will tell you all I think, and you shall decide for yourselves. In the first place, have you any doubt but that if the pirates let Mrs. Hargrave go as to where she will come?"

Schillie.—"Like any wild bull she will of course rush to these caverns and expose our hiding places."

Captain.—"Then we agree, Madam, and without doubt the pirates will watch her and discover all. Now are we to run the chance of finding safe hiding places in these numerous caverns, or show ourselves at once and give fair fight?"

Mother (shaking and shivering).—"That I hold to be impossible, for there must be twelve pirates left, besides all the women and children, and look at us."

Captain.—"We have but a poor chance indeed, Ma'am, but remember, Madam, Smart and I have the hearts of a dozen strong men in our bosoms, ready to sacrifice all for those we love so much, and who risked their lives to save us. I feel, yes, I feel as if a wall of pirates must fall before such a spirit as is within me fails."

Mother.—"But in the fight, supposing any of the children should get hurt, supposing one of the party were killed, I think, I really think I would rather all went at one blow than that we should have to mourn the loss of one."

Captain.—"I can understand your feelings well, Madam, and——"

Schillie.—"Come, captain, don't let her talk any more nonsense, crying her eyes out, let you and I go and take as quick a view of the caverns as we can, and leave her to watch, there is no danger for an hour or so. And here is a pencil and a bit of paper for you to keep you quiet until we come back."

Write a page for that beautiful journal, for you have got something rather more interesting to detail than heretofore."

Mother.—"Schillie, I shall really begin to think you quite heartless."

Schillie.—"Pray do. I only wish it was the case, for I doubt our hearts will be sadly torn to bits the next few days."

They returned in less than an hour with rather less hope than they had before of our being able to hide in the caverns. One thing was certain we could not hide altogether, and the notion of being in different places, and not knowing whether one set might not be discovered and the others looking on, not daring to help for fear of discovering more, quite upset me. I began to think any fate was better than playing bo-peep in the caverns, and so I said, "We will take our chance on the rock, for we have many things ready by the waterfall which were meant for the ship, and we need but snatch up a bundle a-piece."

Schillie.—"When up there, too, we can look down upon our enemies, and take good aim. I shall not fire at random, but pick out my man."

Mother.—"Don't be so bloody-minded. Hark! there is a scream!"

The captain looked out, applying an epithet to Mrs. Hargrave that only the exigency of the case could excuse. He said, "Here she comes, and I make no doubt the whole body of them after her. You'll find lots of bottles and kegs on the right hand side within the waterfall. Whatever you do think of water. Hang that woman she is coming straight away. I see those rascals close behind her, she'll be here in five minutes. Come, gang, oh gang yer ways, oh aye here she is, sailing like a mad woman."

Mother.—"Then you think we had better go at once to the rock."

Captain.—"Yes, yes, without a doubt. Ye'll get up without a soul seeing ye, and ye can kick in the brushwood weel. Now gang, gang yer ways, and when aince up, keep close as mice."

Schillie.—"I begin to think you have some *nous* in your head, June, thinking of that rock. It's so near the ship we may, perhaps, get off in the night."

Mother.—"Heaven grant it. How that woman screams."

Schillie.—"I should like to give her something to scream about, but you are loading yourself like a pack horse. Well done, Sybil; now, girls, scuttle about, take what's useful; whoever carries up anything not wanted will have to bring it back again in the teeth of the enemy."

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, may I stop behind for one minute, just to speak my mind to Hargrave."

Schillie.—"She won't be let in this hour, you ape. Now is our only time for getting up to the top of that rock; where we shall have a full view of the enemy all round."

Madame.—"Gracious heaven, preserve us all. What dangers have we not to endure from the frightful weakness of one woman."

Schillie.—"It's no use moralizing, Madame, pick up something useful, and be off."

Gatty.—"Here is the green parasol, Madame."

Serena.—"And here is your warm shawl."

Sybil.—"And here is my arm to help you along."

Madame (murmuring).—"May God help us, may the Almighty look down upon us in our hour of need, and preserve my beloved ones."

Sybil.—"Come, Madame, come, see how active the little ones are. Think how charming to be safe up there, think how lucky we are to have Smart and the dear captain to help us. Look at Otty with all the guns running like a hare, and all the little girls flying like lapwings. Come, Madame, come quickly."

So we ran about in every direction, and, collecting everything that was useful, we left our friendly shelter and took refuge on the isolated rock before-mentioned.

There was some brushwood at the top, and two or three old weather-beaten palm trees, these afforded us most welcome shelter.

It was weary work getting to the top, but when once there we hauled up many of our things by ropes, and some of us had time to return to the cavern and bring away a rope ladder, with several other valuable acquisitions that, had we been hurried, we should not have recollected them, also quantities of water.

To our surprise, we saw nothing of Smart after Hargrave's first scream; he disappeared, and we were all upon the rock but Madame when we missed him, requiring his strong arm to help her up.

Not all the assistance we could give her seemed likely to get her to the top, she was in so nervous a state. In vain she implored us to leave her to her fate. Nothing but seeing us all begin to scramble down again to share it with her made her at last, in a fit of desperation, reach the top. When there, she sunk on the ground helpless, and we laid her at the foot of one of the palm trees, where she declared she would breathe her last sigh. The three elder girls now collected all the precious drops of water, putting them under bushes, covering them with sand, to prevent the powerful sun from evaporating the smallest quantity of such precious liquid.

Schillie and the boys prepared the guns and pistols, putting everything "handy," as they called it, for a siege. We snatched a hasty meal, not knowing when we might have another opportunity; then laying ourselves down, we hid snugly in the brushwood, seeing everything, yet utterly unseen ourselves.

Gatty.—"It's jolly fun being perched up here seeing all the country round. But what is the reason we have come up?"

Schillie (shortly).—"You were ordered to, that's enough."

Gatty (half whispering to the girls).—"The bear is out to-day. If I don't mind I shall get a scratch from its claws."

Schillie (overhearing).—"Bear or not, Miss Gatty, you will be so good as to keep a silent tongue in your head."

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, why?"

Mother.—"Why, Gatty, don't you perceive that if we continue to hide ourselves as we do now the enemy will never guess where we are. But if you chatter like any magpie, of course they will find us out."

Gatty.—"Well, I am ready to do anything reasonable and now that I have had a good reason given me, I'll be as mute as any mole."

Schillie.—"Who deems a mole like you worth a reason."

Sybil.—"Oh, little Mother, Gatty has a capital head when she is trusted."

Schillie.—"Filled with your notions, I suppose, Miss Sybil."

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, cannot we get off to the ship to-night; it's quite close, and no sharks to speak of."

Schillie.—"When your advice is asked, then you may give us your sage opinions."

Mother.—"Come, Schillie, don't be so cross to the poor girls. You know Gatty has given your own advice in almost your own words."

Schillie.—"Why don't you and those two magpies follow the example of that good child Serena, and hold your tongues, as she does."

Mother.—"We shall not be disturbed yet awhile. But what makes you so cross?"

Schillie.—"I wonder you don't see what a predicament we are in; and it is no very pleasant prospect being sea-sick for the next month, let alone going to sea in this mad way, with only the captain for crew."

Mother.—"Indeed it is very hazardous. I almost think we had better not trust ourselves to the sea, but run our chance with the pirates."

"Oh, no, no," said all the girls and boys.

"Now if you make such a noise again, children, down you shall all go into the mouths of those sharks," said Schillie.

"Then promise not to give up," said they in return.

"I promise nothing," said she.

"Then the king of the pirates will come and take you away, cousin," said Felix.

Schillie uttered something between a sigh and a groan, and then said, "You are an impudent boy, Master Felix, and I always tell your Mother you'll come to no good. But whether she will live to see you hanged or not I cannot say, for our fate is horrible every way. Just too as we were getting so comfortable, and having everything so nice and snug about us. I do not think there is a plant on the island of which I have not discovered the name and property, and everything grows so beautifully, and such bathing, besides, such delicious fish, and I am so fond of fish, really it is too bad. I am just beginning to think the island a very nice sort of little place, and here we are sent to the right about in this horrid fashion."

Gatty.—"Cannot we somehow contrive to kill all the pirates, and get rid of them altogether."

Sybil.—"Yes, we could shoot them from here, taking good aim."

Gatty.—"Ha! ha! just listen to Sybil. Could any one ever have thought she would have been so bloody-minded."

Serena.—"I wish Zoë and Jenny were safely with us, then we should be quite happy, having only the captain and Smart to wait for."

Sybil.—"I dare say that is the reason Smart left us in such a hurry."

Gatty.—"I hope it is as you say, old Syb, and I hope still more that they will join us soon, and I hope most of all that they will leave Hargrave behind."

Sybil.—"Poor thing, but what will they do with her?"

Gatty.—"Eat her, I dare say, and very tough——"

Lilly.—"Oh, Mother, look there! Oh, look! look! Here is Zoë coming, and Smart, and Jenny."

Up we all jumped, and saw the three stealing round the rocks, not two hundred yards from the shore. Run, we all shouted, waving everything we

could lay our hands on. They saw us in a moment, and quitting the shelter of the rocks, ran down towards us.

At this moment a noise of yelling and screaming was heard, and the whole body of pirates, men, women, and children, came rushing out from underneath the waterfall.

Smart heard them first, and catching up Zoë in his arms, giving Jenny some directions, he plunged into the sea, while Jenny kept running to that point of the rock where was the only accessible point for scrambling up. The tide was half flow, which favoured Smart but would impede Jenny, unless she dashed through the waves without regarding a wetting. By the care that Smart took of his little charge, and by Jenny's deliberate proceedings, we saw the servants both meant to sacrifice themselves for the sake of the child.

We, on our parts, were bewildered for a moment with the coming strife, but the thoughtful boys, rolling stones down to startle away the sharks before their dear Smart's way, recalled us to our senses. We let down the rope ladder, and the ready Smart swam to it. Placing his precious charge on it, he watched her run nimbly up it and we receive her with rapture in safety, when he wiped his streaming brow, and plunged into the sea again.

Leaving the little ones all to kiss and embrace the lost and found, we ran to the other side to watch Jenny, and help her if we could. She is flying now, and dashes through the water, heedless of the coming waves. She does not intend to be taken prisoner again without a struggle. But there is one horrid pirate outstripping all the others. "Oh, Jenny, Jenny, run, he is gaining on you." What shall we do to help her? How shall we bear to see her taken before our eyes? She touches the rock. "A few more steps, Jenny, and you can seize the rope we have let down to assist you. Oh, horrid fellow, did ever any one run so fast. Ah, it is of no use, dear, dear Jenny; one more effort." "Mother, Mother," said Oscar, "cannot I shoot him?" "No, dear boy," said Schillie, "you cannot without hurting Jenny." "But let me try, do let me try. Oh dear, oh dear, it is too late, he has hold of her." Throwing away his gun, the boy swung down by the rope before we could prevent him. In vain Jenny called on him not to come, he was down in a moment, and attacked the pirate, who had both arms round Jenny, with his cutlass.

She struggled, and turning round aided his efforts by buffeting the pirate in the face with her hands and nails. At this moment Smart appeared, emerging from the sea, having swam round the rock. One blow from his powerful fist settled the matter. The pirate fell down stunned upon the rocks. Oscar gave him a parting kick, and then all three assisting each other, scrambled up the rock in no time, where we most joyfully received them, and where they did not arrive a minute too soon, for the whole body of pirates were close at hand.

CHAPTER XXXVIII.

And now how silly we looked, all exposed to the wondering gaze of the pirates. I heard Schillie muttering, "What a pack of fools we have been," while Oscar said, "Cousin, we have gone and done it now. We shall have to fight for it, and we shall have a good rowing from the captain. I had better go and see after the guns." This he did, shaking them one by one at the pirates as he examined them, while he and Felix kept appearing and disappearing from behind the trees, sometimes with hats and sometimes without, as if to make believe there were half a dozen boys. Smart lay his full length on the ground, endeavouring to recover his breath, after his late exertions.

It was of no use disguising the fact, we had discovered ourselves and our hiding place, and though no one certainly could get to us without leave, our helplessness would be fully apparent, and our identity with the lost party well known. All the advantages we had gained from our concealment were now over. We had nothing to do but wait in patience for what fate had yet in store for us.

All this time, while these thoughts were rapidly running through our heads, the whole colony of pirates were staring in undisguised amazement at us.

Sybil.—"What a frightful set of wretches."

Gatty.—"Horrid. We will never capitulate to them."

Serena.—"The women look as fierce as the men. How they do stare, just as if they never saw human beings before."

Oscar.—"I could pick off a fellow or two from this distance, Mother, if you like."

Smart (from his lair in the bushes).—"Ha' done, if you please, Sir, with any such notion. Let me get a breath or two afore we come to a fight; and

anyways let them strike the first blow."

Oscar and Felix (together).—"Then do make haste, Smart, and get your breath. If the captain was but here, we could easily fight those wretches."

Smart.—"Breath or no breath, I ben't agoing to fight them devildoms with no better helps than you two, young masters. Bide quiet like brave boys, and do as the Duke of Wellington does."

Felix.—"How is that, Tommy?"

Smart.—"Why he waits until the enemy gives him a reason to get his blood up, and when that's done it's all up with them."

Felix.—"But my blood is up, Tom."

Smart.—"Then let it cool a bit, Sir; any way the tide is rising, and them rascals is sufficiently knowledgeable to see that the sharks is a guarding of us now. When it gets dark it will be ebbing and I'll be off to see after cap'n, and you'll have enew to do, Sir, to keep watch until we get back."

Gatty.—"Don't bring Hargrave back if you can help it, Smart."

Smart.—"I ben't much inclined that way myself, Miss, but I have heerd we are bound to be merciful."

Gatty.—"She has not been merciful to us, I am sure."

Smart.—"I do partly think as she ben't quite answerable for her ways. Any how I shanna put myself out of the way to look after her."

Mother.—"Oh yes, Smart, you must try your best."

Smart.—"To be sure, Ma'am, if so be you wishes it. But I be thinking there is a power of mischief in her yet."

Mother.—"I think it must all have been frightened out of her by this time. Did you see anything of her when you went in search of the others?"

Smart.—"No, Madam, I went straight away for Miss Zoë and Jenny, the cap'n having given me my orders so to do, let alone me ordering myself that way also. I had to knock over a couple of women-kind, which went agin my

conscience: not knowing how people might act towards my poor dear woman, and my two pretty boys, all these years that I have been from them."

Here Smart showed symptoms of a pathetic nature, for which Felix tried to comfort him saying, "I am sure they are doing very well, for Mrs. Smart will have taken in some washing, and Jem is I dare say a gamekeeper by now, and perhaps little Tom too."

From Jenny we further learnt that they had come round the way they did to avoid the pirates. As they passed the upper caverns they heard what Jenny called a great "scremmage," but saw nothing of Hargrave or the captain. Had they been ten minutes sooner round the rock they might have reached us in safety, and without discovery.

The pirates having given full scope to their curiosity regarding us, now separated, and, while some remained as watchers, the others went off to examine the waterfall and caverns, and look, as we supposed, for our two companions.

"Ha, ha," said Smart, as he saw them emerging in and out from beneath the waterfall, "if it had not been for that demented woman you would never have speered that place, I'll go bail. Mighty pretty it is too as well as uncommon convanient."

Oscar.—"Is it not like the waterfall at Cil Hepste in Glamorganshire."

Smart.—"Just such another, Sir, and if I have the luck to see that ere waterfall again, it's a pity if I don't look o' the inside of it."

Felix.—"What, do you think we shall find caverns and pirates in it, like this one, Tommy?"

Smart.—"No, Sir, I'se warrant there is neer a pirate there, but it's an uncommon curious place, and like this 'un as one pea to another. The ould lady seems but baddish I consate."

This was but too true. Whether from the fright or the heat, or the unusual exertions, Madame was anything but well, and fell from one fit of hysterics to another. We could do but little to mend her, for even supposing we had

had smelling salts on the island we should not have deemed it one of the necessities to bring upon the rock. We put Zoë beside her with orders to talk to her, and tell her as many of her adventures as she could to amuse and divert her mind.

And then Jenny told us how good and brave Miss Zoë had been, and how neither of them would have been taken prisoners had it not been for that "squawking" Hargrave. Upon which Gatty and the boys declared they wished her no worse fate than to be married to one of the pirates.

Schillie (with gravity).—"I will make over to her my interest with the King."

Gatty.—"We might actually have been on board sailing away at this moment instead of frying up here, with these frightful pirates blinking and grinning at us, as if they never saw Christians before."

Sybil.—"Perhaps they never did, Gatty."

Serena.—"Jenny, did you know that we were discovered in the caverns through Hargrave? They made her a trap to catch us."

Jenny.—"Miss Zoë told me, Miss, she was afraid from what she could make out that they were going to make something out of Mrs. Hargrave. But I could not understand them at all. Nevertheless we both cautioned her as much as possible, though she was in such a sad way I doubt if she heard us. After awhile she was taken away from us, and, though I told her the last thing to be sure to be careful, and do her duty by her mistress, she screamed so I don't think she minded me one bit. The women were pretty civil, but very wild and bad looking, and I would not bear them to touch Miss Zoë, which they were trying to do all the while. And, oh, Miss Zoë was so brave, and, whenever I said you were all dead she said so too."

Gatty.—"How could you tell such fibs, Zoë? Madame will give you that odious Theresa Tidy's Nineteen Maxims of Neatness and Order, to do into German, for being so naughty."

"Angel child, never, never could I punish her after her agonizing sufferings," murmured the good kind Madame.

The strict watch kept over us began to be so wearisome we were glad when night veiled us in her dark mantle.

It was astonishing with what composure we laid down to rest, secure in the sharks' guard for some few hours yet, while the morrow, with all its probable horrors, seemed not to present itself to any mind. "We trusted in God that he would deliver us."

CHAPTER XXXIX.

The morning's light brought us no change either for worse or better, excepting that under cover of the night Smart had gone to search for our other companions. He gave us orders what to do, in case of an attack, and departed with these comforting words "Let a score on 'em attack ye, and I'll be bound the young gentlemen, if they be but steady, can keep 'em off. Any ways Mrs. E. can, and if we hear shots cap'in and I will just come in the rear in nick o' time."

We sat composedly down to such breakfast as we had, which led to an examination as to what had been brought up. We had plenty of water, bread, yams, and potatoes. No little girl had forgotten her parrot, or the boys their monkeys; in fact Felix declared his had been very useful, as he made him carry two great potatoes. "But," said Lilly, "you had to carry him, so it made no great difference."

"Moreover," says Felix, "I brought my two hens, because they lay eggs, and Tommy is so fond of eggs."

Lilly.—"I do think you love Smart more than any of us, more than your Mother."

Felix.—"Oh! any body may have the other egg, but I must keep one for my Tommy. He has never been quite well since he was with those brutes. And I am his doctor he says, so I order him eggs. And if I bid him do it, I know he would eat twenty, one after another."

Mother.—"How odd it seems to Schillie, our laughing at all this nonsense of the children, when we certainly are in a very uncomfortable position. We seem to think we are in no danger, now we have got the captain and Smart to help us, and I doubt if we were ever in a worse predicament than now."

Schillie.—"Predicament or not, it's extremely nasty not being allowed any water to wash with, and I shall owe Hargrave a grudge all my life. Here we have been accustomed to bathe two or three times a-day, now stewed to death we are only allowed sufficient water to send bread down our throats, that would otherwise stick there."

Mother.—"I wish that may be our greatest inconvenience; it's all very well for Smart to say that we are in no danger, but if these people keep staring at us and watching us all day as they did yesterday what are we to do? They'll stare us out, let alone the chance of our being broiled to death. I feel quite sure Madame will have a brain fever if we don't take care."

Schillie.—"Well don't fuss. We can last out a week of this work, perhaps, and then we shall at all events be less fat for the fishes. I intend to try the depths of those caverns before I put myself in the power of that pirate captain."

I shuddered as she pointed down to the blue waters, through whose depths we could see endless caverns of fantastically shaped coral.

"Oh! Ma'am, Ma'am," cried Jenny, "they are coming up." We ran for our weapons, concealing them as well as we could, and then stood on the defensive, Schillie on one side of the path and I on the other, the rest all ready to hand us the guns. "Shoot, Schillie, shoot," I said, "hit the foremost man, and he'll tumble over the others."

"I am trying, I am indeed, but don't you know I cannot even kill a wasp! Hang me if I can do it," said Schillie, turning white as a sheet, and letting her gun drop. Steadily Otty raises his gun, fires, and the foremost man falls, knocking over two others, and causing great confusion. Felix, by way of calming it, fires his gun right into the middle of them.

Their imprecations were loud and deep, and their rage seemed boundless as they looked up at their two little antagonists. One man dead, two hurt. "Very good boys," say we. But the pirates were not to be driven back in this manner. It was too humiliating to be repulsed by two boys. They seemed speculating as to what had become of Smart, he was evidently not with us. So once more they essayed the ascent, sheltering themselves as well as they could from the guns, by creeping under cover of the ledges of rock. "Now

let's all be firm this time," we whispered, "for shoot them we must." Schillie took a great gulp of water, seized her gun, and once more we all stood ready. "Let them come quite close," said Oscar.

But a fresh person appeared on the scene of action, whose shrill screams told her name better than anything. Not that anybody seemed hurting or molesting her, but attracted, I suppose, by the sound of the guns, she had ventured forth from her hiding place, and discovered us all roosting at the top of the rock. Not being able to entertain more than one idea at a time, and that idea being since her separation from us solely how she could rejoin, it was not a matter of wonder, that to see us, was to make her rush down towards us. It never entered her limited capacity to think that the pirates might object to the re-union. However they showed themselves most civil and polite towards Mrs. Hargrave, though we on the rock did not give them credit for acting entirely from disinterested motives.

Schillie.—"Upon my life! if they are not going to let that mad woman come up here. You may be sure, June, they have some motive for this gratuitous kindness. I dare say they think such an ass of a woman will be more likely to do us harm than good by her presence. Well! any body may help her up that likes, I won't."

"Nor I, nor I," sounded on all sides.

But there was no need for us to offer, for the amiable pirates were kindly assisting her up themselves. Little did Mrs. Hargrave dream that they were making a convenient shield of her most precious self and that if we hoped to execute our former manœuvre we should have to send our bullets through her first. She thought of nothing but being again amongst us, and scrambled and struggled towards us, screaming the whole time.

Oscar.—"Mother, I must shoot her, there is no help for it. If one of those fellows gets footing on here, we may as well give ourselves up. You see he is close behind her."

Mother.—"We will just make one effort. Wait till she is so near that I can grasp hold of her, and then shoot; she must take her chance."

With the greatest coolness the brave boy did as he was bid; and I had no sooner grasped the woman than he fired. With a squall that no one could

think proceeded out of human lips, she lost her footing and held on by me, and if Schillie had not had firm hold of me, Serena and Sybil of her, I must have gone over with Hargrave and the pirate. As it was, he fell dead, and we dragged her up, and, pulling her to some distance, we never stayed to enquire if she was wounded or not, but ran back to our posts. They were swarming up, just under a ledge, ready to make a bolt out upon us if we looked off one moment. "Get stones, little ones," whispered Serena, "they will help us, perhaps." Now they bolt. We all fire simultaneously. They retreat again, some wounded, but none dead. We took up the second relay of guns, Schillie carrying off the others to reload.

"In the name of all that's horrible," we heard her say, in a loud angry voice, "what are you doing here?"

Hargrave.—"I am not going to be shot at and killed by those dreadful guns any more, and, besides, the pirates gave me to understand down there as the sun would soon set the powder in a blaze, and we should all be blown up. Look at me, bleeding like a pig, and half my ear and one of my best earrings gone. No, no, though I was dead, as I thought, I was determined to throw the powder and shot over the rock, that you might be safe, if I died the next minute."

"Bring me that rope, Lilly," said Schillie, in a voice of concentrated rage. Gatty sprung to help her, and in two minutes the foolish woman was tied, with her hands behind her back, to one of the palm trees, and they returned to help us, as best we could be helped. We trusted that Smart would hear the firing, and come to our assistance before all hope was gone. But the pirates themselves ceased their warfare against us, finding the stones quite as destructive as the guns; besides, they seemed to be in a great state of uncertainty and trouble among themselves, and had so many consultations, and talked at such a rate, that we lost ourselves in conjectures as to what it could be all about. "They are in a mighty rage against us, I think, for killing the two men," said Oscar. "They don't want to hurt us, apparently," said Serena, "as they never fixed their guns at us." "Why, my dear child, don't you see that is against their interests to hurt any of us," said Schillie, "they want to sell us, or some such blessed thing."

Gatty (demurely).—"I don't think the king will sell you, little Mother."

Schillie.—"None of your nonsense. Miss. I'll marry you to him if you don't mind, and a regular dun ducky mud-coloured spouse you will have."

Gatty.—"If you please, little Mother, you are and have been so cross to me since we came up here."

Schillie.—"And no wonder, you young noodle, talking such nonsense, and behaving like a young ape when we are in such danger; and June is just as bad, encouraging you in all this stuff."

Mother.—"Come, don't let us quarrel, night is coming on. Go to bed, children. You and I must watch, Schillie."

Schillie.—"And I, feeling like a dead dog, wanting a week's sleep at least."

Mother.—"Then Hargrave shall help me."

Schillie.—"Help the pirates you mean; but who has looked after that female lately?"

We went to see her, and luckily she was unable to have her feelings wounded by any remark that might have been bottling up against her, for through her nose she gave audible demonstrations that she considered her troubles and sorrows over, and that any remonstrances on our parts would only be regarded as an unpleasant dream of the night.

"What a dirty draggled thing she looks," said Schillie, "in all that worn-out old finery. Why cannot she dress like us and Jenny in these serviceable dresses?"

"Oh, she made a particular request to me," I answered, "not to dress in our island costume, and asked leave to use all our old things to make herself, what she called, respectable. But are you really so tired you cannot watch?"

Schillie.—"To be sure not; you don't think I am going to let you watch without me, only I am regularly done up, and think it would be rather a good plan to get shot that I might have some rest."

Mother.—"Fie, Schillie, you forget what you are saying."

Schillie.—"I dare say I am very wicked, but don't bother me now; keep your scolding until we get out of this mess, if we ever do."

CHAPTER XL.

Towards midnight, a sound in the water made our hearts beat. Either the pirates meant to storm us at night, or Smart and the captain were attempting to join us. Calling the girls, we set them to watch the rope ladder, which we let down on the one side, while we watched the pathway on the other.

The tide was ebbing, though our rock was still wholly surrounded by water, yet not sufficient to make the sharks any protection to us. It was this which made us so anxious, for there were such a few hours in the day during which the pirates could attack us, and they had been so unexpectedly repulsed, we had but little doubt they would attempt a night assault if possible, and for this the tide now suited very well, and we could not hope that they would be ignorant of the advantage.

The sounds advanced on one side, though still so faint and designedly smothered we could distinguish nothing to lead us to know whether friends or foes were coming. Now, whoever they were, they certainly had landed at the foot of the rock. We instinctively each grasped a stone.

"The Lord be thankit, captain; I do consate as we have found the pathway," in Smart's tones, rose up to our delighted ears, and we grasped their hands with heartfelt pleasure as they severally reached the top. We had, however, a drawback to our pleasure, for Smart had been wounded looking for Mrs. Hargrave. The necessity of binding his wound and restoring his exhausted strength, prevented us from thinking of getting off to the ship then; besides, we had little more than an hour's darkness left us, and it would have taken that time to move Madame alone. So, after making Smart as comfortable as we could, Schillie and I ran off to take some rest, in the full assurance that half our cares were over, now that we had got our two able-bodied defenders among us again. Besides, no further responsibility rested on our shoulders, and that was so great a relief we were asleep almost before we laid down.

CHAPTER XLI.

The imperturbable Hargrave presented herself the next morning as perfectly rested, and ready to dress her mistress, and put her hair (now for so long neglected) into proper order. A piece of coolness and effrontery that so surprised me I remained quite dumb.

Not so the young ones; but I am ashamed to repeat all that was said, for, though they had right on their side, the unfortunate woman was set upon by all, and if tongues could sting, she would not have been alive now. At last she sat down in a remote corner of the rock, to weep and bewail herself, thinking, I dare say, that she had escaped from one set of savages into another. And, though she derived some consolation part of the time in what she called "tidying herself," she shed many a tear over her torn garments and battered appearance, declaring that she had had her clothes ruined by the rough way in which the captain and Smart had dragged her about. "Say that again," said Felix, "and I must spit at you to show my contempt."

That the captain and Smart had joined us soon became known among the pirates, and if they had been so severely repulsed before by two boys, it was madness attempting another assault.

So they set about means of devising how they could dislodge us, without endangering their own lives. Madame's increasing illness became our great care now, she was becoming delirious, and there was no possibility of subduing the fever upon this baking rock.

"A little cooling lime juice, Ma'am, I would venture to advise," said Hargrave.

"And who has put a stop to our having that?" was uttered on various sides, in various indignant tones.

Hargrave shrunk back into her corner again, while the captain said, "I will draw up some sea water, with which you must bathe her head. Smart's wound will fester I doubt; we have nothing here to ease that, I am grieved to say."

Middle day came, when the heat was greatest. We lay gasping, half dead with fatigue, heat, and fears as to what would be our fate. Suddenly we were roused by Smart's voice, who could not rest for the pain of his wound. "Be sharp, be sharp," he cried, "they are throwing lighted brands up here, we shall be on fire in a minute, and roast meat in ten." We flew in every direction, and threw them off as fast as they could throw them on. It was hotter work for them than us and, seeing us so active, they ceased for awhile. The captain then cut away great square plots of brushwood as best he could, to prevent much harm accruing in case they tried their brands again.

While thus occupied, Sybil came running to me, all in tears, and wringing her hands. "Oh, I have killed him, I am afraid he is dead," she cried.

"How? who?" we exclaimed.

"I only meant to frighten him, I would not hurt anybody. Oh, what shall I do?"

We ran with her to the extreme end of the rock, and, looking down, we saw on a ledge below, a large stone with a man beneath it.

"I was running here," continued the weeping Sybil, "to see if any brands were thrown in this direction, and, peeping down, I saw a man scrambling up, very near the top. He did not see me, but I had no time to lose, so I just pushed that great stone with all my might. You know we had remarked this stone before as being just in the position to roll down, if it was only on the other side. I do not know how I managed, but over it went, and fell directly on him; and, oh, I am afraid it has killed him. What shall I do, I shall never be happy again."

Gatty.—"Not happy again, Sib, I only wish I had done it."

Sybil.—"But, sister, do you think he is really dead? Can we not go down and save him, or take that great stone off him? Oh dear, oh dear, how could

I do such a cruel thing."

Gatty.—"Oh, Sib, Sib, what a goose you are. You have done a glorious thing. I only wish it had been me. Think, Serena, of Sib having killed a pirate all by herself and we have not even cut off the little finger of one. It is too provoking."

We were obliged to take the poor tender-hearted girl away from the spot, and she shook and shivered with remorse all the rest of the day. We comforted her as well as we could by saying he must have died immediately (for dead he was without any doubt), and he had fallen on a spot where the sea would carry away all remains of him before morning.

The little ones looked at poor trembling aunt Sib with the greatest admiration, Gatty with envy and jealousy, while Serena, like a true tender-hearted little sister, comforted and kissed her, telling her how gentle, good, and kind she was to everybody, and what a good thing she had done for us, and how, perhaps, this was the identical pirate who had stolen her, and that she was not to be unhappy at what perhaps we might all have to do ere long. And this set us talking upon our plans.

"Don't you think, captain," said Schillie, "we may get off to the ship to-night?"

Captain.—"We must try, Madam. If they should chance to go on board, they will find out how busy we have been there, and they will then take measures to prevent us executing any such plan. But I have lost my right hand in Smart."

Gatty and Oscar.—"Oh, captain, send me for the boat. I can swim like a duck, and it's not a hundred yards from here."

Mother.—"My dear children, the sharks."

Oscar.—"I don't mind them, Mother."

Gatty.—"They will have a good mouthful if they swallow me; and if I am as troublesome inside a shark as you, little Mother, say I sometimes am here, I shall not agree with him at all."

Schillie.—"Now, Gatty, I won't have you running into any danger. I don't mean to say you are not extremely troublesome, but still I have got used to you, and I won't have you expose yourself to any danger."

Captain.—"I think I can manage to make them both of use, and yet without much danger, I trust. I would not have a hair of their precious heads lost."

Gatty flushed up like the setting sun with pleasure; Oscar nodded in approbation, while I said, "Then it is decided, at all events, we get off to-night, if we can."

"Man proposes, and God disposes."

"Sister, look," said Serena, in a low sorrowful voice. Ah me, did I see rightly? With every sail set, that ominous, black, hateful vessel, the pirate ship, hove in sight, and ere we could collect our senses, or believe our eyes, she was anchoring in the bay.

CHAPTER XLII.

We sat down on the carpet of desperation and the stools of despair.

The pirates on shore seemed as bewildered as we were. The pirates on board seemed in a great state of confusion and uproar. A general running, hurrying, and scurrying took place among them all.

While those of the ship pointed vehemently to the sea, they of the land gesticulated violently towards the caverns, and both were equally eccentric in their observations regarding us. At last regular parties were organized, who began systematically, at the same time with the utmost rapidity, to unload their vessel; while the pirate king, hoisting a white flag, and attended by a few ferocious-looking followers, advanced towards our rock. By the captain's advice we hoisted a white rag of some sort, as a token of friendship, and in silence waited the result.

In bad French the pirate captain offered us terms for capitulation. He pointed out how useless it was for us now to think of repelling such numbers. That if we would come down quietly, we should be received with open arms ("and cut throats," murmured some one behind me); that they would engage their most sacred word of honour they would do us no harm ("much honour in a pirate," murmured the same voice); that there was plenty of room on the island for us all, and that we might choose which side we pleased, and they would take the other. All they wanted was peace and our friendship.

Our dear captain shook his head at all this civility, and fairly laughed at the offer of friendship. But he turned, as in duty bound, being spokesman, to take our opinion.

Simultaneously we all rose together, and letting the pirates have a full and perfect view of our whole party (save the two invalids) for the first time, with one voice we all exclaimed, "No! no!" Though evidently surprised at

seeing what a helpless party we were, it yet seemed to give him but greater zest to persuade us to come down.

His offers became more generous, his civilities greater, his promises most profuse and tempting, but, invariably and simultaneously, without waiting for our captain's appeal, rose the decided "No! no!"

With subdued oaths and imprecations he left us, having been several times interrupted by urgent entreaties from his companions. Leaving some young boys to watch us, he repaired to his companions, and they now seemed wholly occupied in emptying the ship and stowing everything away in the caverns. The bay was one scene of activity and bustle.

We sat quiet, knowing that night was drawing on, when our last effort for escape must be made.

Oscar.—"Captain, you never told us what happened to you in the caverns, and how Smart found you."

Captain.—"I found him, Sir, instead of his finding me. I kept the entrance blocked up as long as I could, but I could not get a good shot at any of the enemy on account of that demented woman, who was always in the way. It was enough that as fast as they took out one stone I piled up another, until, finding that they were getting too many for me, and knowing that you had had ample time to place yourselves in safety, I swung myself up by the rope to the top of the cavern, and, drawing it up, I lay there concealed, watching their movements. Such a pandemonium scene I never beheld. Luckily their eagerness, curiosity, and excitement made them forget Mrs. Hargrave, who sat down and howled like a hungry cat, not, however, before she had discovered to them every secret corner, by running madly to look for you. I suppose, for her sake, we must allow, poor woman, she is a little touched in the brain, for I found her, after everything was quiet, and the pirates had gone down to look for you, looking over some musty old caps and bonnets, and fitting up for herself a bundle of clothes. I suggested a little food and water would be more useful, but she stopped my mouth by saying it was her duty to appear decent and tidy for her mistress's sake. And such trouble I had with her besides. I am persuaded that woman would never be guided by mortal tongue. Many times I thought to leave her to her fate and to go and see after you, but she was so unfit to be left, I had not the heart to do so.

Nevertheless, after getting her out of the caverns up on the top, in a well-concealed place, where we could see nicely all round, she escaped me, for what reason neither she or any one else could tell I think, and I lay quiet until night, when, venturing down to see if I could join you all, after a while I heard a noise just nigh me, and, hiding behind a tree, I looked out, and presently spied a great big fellow, standing six feet two, before me. I knew Smart in a moment, dark as it was, but, having a mind to startle him, I took hold of his leg. Laws me, Sirs, you should have seen how he jumped. I am sure the good old lady could not have been more alarmed. The rest you know."

Felix.—"Poor Smart, I dare say you took hold of that very leg that's now wounded. Do you know, Smart, Otty and I had our right and left shots."

Smart.—"Had you so, Sir. Well, I hopes you both killed your birds."

Felix.—"No, for unluckily we both shot at the same fellow, but we knocked him over clean. We frightened them in an awful way, but cousin Schillie would not shoot."

Smart.—"How cumed that about I wonder. I reckoned her a prime one."

Felix.—"She was frightened, Smart."

Smart.—"Oh no, Sir, I'll never believe that."

Felix.—"Oh, but she was. I saw her shut her eyes when we all had to shoot together, and she did not open them for a good minute after."

Schillie.—"Good lack, captain, what is going to happen now?"

Boats were approaching La Luna. The pirates boarded her, and, after half an hour's work, her anchors were taken up, and she was towed to the other side of the bay, and there made secure.

Night set not in more darkly than the gloom that fell upon our hearts. We could but leave our fates in the hand of a good and merciful Providence.

CHAPTER XLIII.

The whole night long the pirates worked hard, doing what we could not see, neither could our captain at all understand their conduct. "If it was not too good to be true, they have been chased," said he, "and have come into harbour to hide. Did anyone look over the sea?" he continued. No, we had all been too much engaged.

Captain.—"Then the first thing I shall do on the dawn will be to scan the sea. Something unusual must have occurred to put the pirates to all this pothor."

With the first streak of day came the pirate captain with his flag of truce, and again made his offers of peace, friendship, and civility, and again met with a vehement negative, though most forlorn were now our hopes and fortunes. To our surprise we now only saw La Luna. There was not a vestige of the pirate ship.

The pirate king had now recourse to threats, which we heard in disdainful silence. After spending half an hour in oaths and threats, he waved his hand, and, stamping with anger, pointed to La Luna. "I give you one hour," he cried, "if by that time you do not come down voluntarily, I intend sweeping the top of your rock with those two guns." We looked towards the vessel; she had been brought within gun shot, and her brass cannons were placed directly before us. "I know," continued the pirate, "who you all are, and I have no wish to harm you, but rather to gain the rewards offered for your recovery. Be persuaded and be reasonable."

Mother.—"Captain, what do you think, what shall we do, he speaks fair?"

Captain.—"Madam, we must not trust him. I feel sure they have some reason for this bustle and activity all night, and I feel persuaded they have scuttled their ship and sunk her. Look round, and you will see that when they retire into the caverns, there is not a trace of human beings about save

our own vessel, and that looks weather-beaten and old enough to have been riding at anchor there for ages. No doubt they have concealed all traces of themselves in her. If they get us down they will use us as hostages for their own safety, or they may murder us at once, and thus leave no one to tell the tale of the caverns. As long as we are alive that secret cannot be kept, and, having made a settlement here, I think there is every probability that they will commit any crime sooner than suffer such a convenient and suitable stronghold for them to be discovered. I trust them not, let us trust in God."

Mother.—"And you, Schillie, tell me what do you advise?"

Schillie rose up, and drawing me to the highest part of the rock, turned her broad white forehead to the ship, while her clear eyes, darkened in their beauty by the emotions of the hour, looked steadily down into the mouths of the guns.

Schillie.—"June, do you believe that the spirits of the departed know what occurs on earth, and with unseen forms can visit those they love?"

June.—"I hold some such doctrine, my Schillie, but whether there is truth in it or not, the departed alone can tell."

Schillie.—"I'll put faith in your doctrine, my mistress, and think that in an hour I may behold my children, though unseen by them."

June.—"And is it this feeling that makes you gaze so boldly into the jaws that are so shortly to breathe forth death to us?"

Schillie.—"It may be so, or it may be the strength given from on high for such emergencies as these. In this awful hour I feel no fear; a sacred calm is filling my heart. My God, I feel Thou art near; Thou knowest this is not presumption that I bow me in humility before Thy throne, that I approach it under the shadow of my Saviour's wing."

I gazed in her face, flushed with ardour, refulgent with her inspired feelings, and thought her half way to heaven already.

June.—"My Schillie, ere you go, take my thanks take my heartfelt gratitude with you for all you have been to me."

Schillie.—"We go together, June, we shall not be separated in the happy pasture fields of our immortal shepherd. You will come with me to gaze on my children, and whisper holy dreams of goodness and truth into their childish ears to prepare them for the burdens of life, such as we have gone through. Our fates in life were thrown together, and the last act of mercy received from our gracious Father is this, that we die together."

June.—"But with my mortal lips and mortal heart receive my thanks, for, without you, what should I have done? Without your brave heart and good spirit to help me I must have given way. Without your hopeful, strong, and Godly mind I, guilty of ungrateful murmurs, should have forfeited the right of comfort from on high. Ah! my Schillie, take my thanks, for next to my Father, Saviour, God in heaven, what do I not owe to you?"

Schillie.—"Enough, enough, we give and take in this world. Our obligations to each other are mutual. We have an eternity before us to settle the debt between us. Our time on earth draws to a close. It is fit we prepare the young and weak for the fate they seem hardly to realize."

June.—"I shrink from them. Oh, my Schillie, do me a last act of kindness, and keep them from my sight."

Schillie.—"Nay, rouse yourself, and remember you take all you love with you."

June.—"But such a death! and they so young, so beloved, so lovely and gifted, to die in so horrible a manner."

Schillie.—"Then think of the fate you would have them live for. But one hour of mental agony, and they are safe in their Saviour's arms."

June.—"And, oh, Schillie, one more horrible fear I have. Suppose those dreadful guns do not fully complete their dreadful work. Think if some are left, wounded and maimed, yet more wounded in heart at the death of those they loved."

Schillie.—"Call them, and give each their choice."

They came, but it was only to group themselves in one close embrace about us. They replied not to the words we uttered, but looking as fearlessly as

Schillie did down on the brazen mouths of death, they turned their loving eyes in unutterable affection towards us. The beaming light of Schillie's countenance seemed reflected on each young face, until we thought an halo of glory already surrounded them.

The two men tenderly lifted up Madame, and laid her moaning and unconscious at our feet, and then placed themselves on each side of the group.

"See," said Schillie, half smiling and waving her hand, "your last fear is groundless, it will take but one of those cannon to deliver us all at the same moment from this mortal coil. Let us lift up our hearts to God."

CHAPTER XLIV.

The minutes fled. Ever and anon a group of pirates would advance, and, as they gazed, pity, remorse, and even admiration seemed to blend in their swarthy countenances, as they looked at the motionless helpless group. Evidently reluctant to give the fatal signal for death, the pirate captain restlessly paced to and fro, only taking his eyes from us to look hurriedly on the sea. The hour was gone. The boat shot from the shore, bearing the fatal messengers of death. The pirate captain clenched his hands, and hurried up and down, like one in despair. Sometimes he looked as if he would speak to us, then turned more quickly away.

Our hearts beat audibly to each other. "May God take us into His safe keeping this hour," murmured the low earnest voice of our dear captain. "Amen," was fervently uttered by all that could speak.

Still the pirate captain wavered and hesitated; but what made our captain start? A body of pirates came forward, and drawing their chief away, began expostulating with him, and we heard a sound behind us. "For the love of God move not," said the captain; but every ear listened.

As the sun gilds one cloud after another in rapid succession, rising higher and higher, so did one face after another illumine with hope and deliverance as the sound became more audible. We had heard it before, but, oh, so long ago, could it have been in our dreams? It seemed so familiar, yet we had never heard it on the island. It sounded so homelike, though our own home was far inland. But to British ears and British hearts could such a sound be unknown? The long, measured, steady stroke of the oars of a man-of-war's boat broke upon our happy senses; and yet we were silent, as if turned to stone. The conviction of our safety and deliverance sent the once-burthened hearts in silent thankfulness to the foot of God.

"Avast there! keep under the shelter of this rock," said a man's deep voice, in a subdued tone, "it won't do to run right into the mouths of these

blackguards without a little reconnoitering." Our captain crept silently to the side from whence the voice proceeded and hailed them. "Hollo! here's a fellow up here, we had better settle him at once, lest he gives the alarm," said the deep voice.

This made us all move quickly to the same place, and, as we caught sight of the gallant sailors, who, though strangers to us, seemed each to possess the features of dear and long-lost friends, our feelings could scarcely be restrained. An intuitive feeling that we might, by some rash movement, lose the heavenly chance just opening to our view, kept us in iron bounds. As it was, a sort of hub-bub did ensue, they not understanding who we were, and we caring for nothing on this near approach of delivery. But our captain swung himself down by the rope ladder into the boat, while we eagerly drank in every word of the precious voices and language we had thought never to hear again, while he explained our situation. "What, the missing family so long sought for, so deeply mourned? Now God be praised. Up there four days, battling it out. Well done! Those blackguards shall have it double-fold. What an innocent boy with his big hat; who is the pretty child? Is that all her own hair? I say, which is the Mother? She is tall enough for a grenadier. Poor things, poor souls; what sufferings, what privations. All by themselves. Hah! indeed, joined only the last year. Well, we are heart and soul at their service. Are they all ladies, or some servants? What rum dresses. They look very picturesque up there, and you, boatswain, must make a sketch of them for us to take home when we have settled these pirates. Is that a boy or a girl? she's a whopper if she is a female. That short one looks cool enough to face any danger. But don't let us waste more time, we are burning to be at them. How shall we manage? Blown to pieces in five minutes; I'm blowed if you shall. D——n those (ah, ladies, I beg pardon). No, no, we will attack them at once. Too few, not a bit; as if a dozen English sailors could not knock over two score of pirates, and eat them too. Well, just as you like, only be quick; as for restraining my men, I shall not be able to do that long, especially as I know I can't hold in much longer myself."

Such was the disjointed conversation that reached our ears, and which we drank in with such delight. Our captain swung himself up again, and said that another boat's crew were expected in a few minutes; and though the sailors in this boat scouted the notion of not being able to settle the pirates'

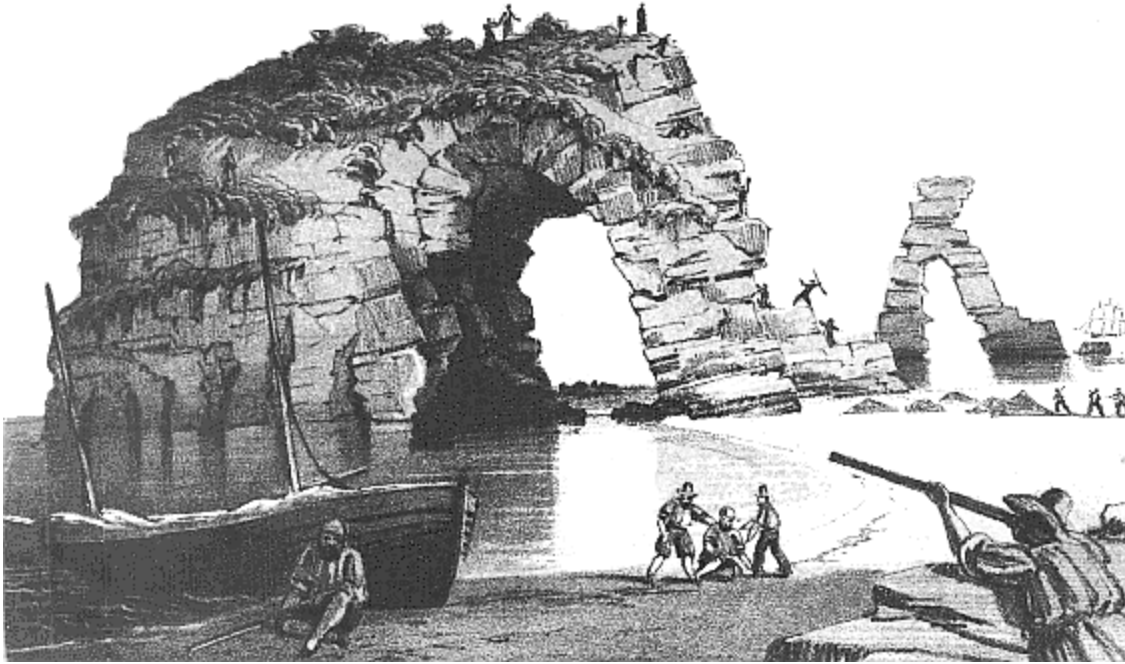
business themselves, yet it would be as well to make assurance doubly sure, on account of the savage nature of the pirates. They might be driven to desperation when they saw what succour we had received.

Schillie.—"Captain, you must make haste, they are on board the vessel and loading the guns; in a few minutes we shall be scattered into a thousand pieces."

Captain.—"What I advise is, as there is no time to lose, hold out a flag of truce, and capitulate."

"Oh no, captain," said many of us.

"You must, indeed you must; make haste. Come, begin to go down at once. Those devildoms are only too rejoiced they have got their captain's consent, and are going to lose no time. Come, don't lose your courage at the last hour, you will be in their power but a few minutes. That's a sweet brave girl, now she is down you will all go."



This latter remark was addressed to Serena, whom I tried to grasp as she lightly sprang down. We all followed, save Schillie and the two invalids. The pirates shouted with great deafening shouts, and ran towards us, rudely grasping hold of us as we each descended. We shuddered and shrieked with horror. The pirate king ran and brought Schillie down in spite of her struggles. The captain was instantly seized, and would have been roughly treated, but the sailors, unable to hear our cries and not help us, shot round the corner like a flash of lightning, and, ere the pirates were aware of their presence, mixed in the *mêlée*, cutlass in hand.

Though at first the sailors gained an instantaneous advantage, the numbers against them were so great and the pirates so desperate, that much blood must have been shed and a fierce battle fought, but another boat appeared round the rock, most vigorously propelled, another, and again another. Now we were saved, God be praised! No more doubts, no more fears. We withdrew to a sheltered place on the cliffs, thankful, oh, how thankful God alone can tell. The pirates fled in every direction, but not before our captain, raising his gun, sent a shot after the pirate king that put an end to his reign and his love for ever.

CHAPTER XLV.

An officer was sent to take our wishes, while the other sailors, with their captain and lieutenants, proceeded to pursue and exterminate the pirates. The fresh boats' crews being so eager in the chase that they knew nothing more about us than that some prisoners had been found. The captain, therefore, politely sent an officer to attend to us, with a message to say he was too busy to do so himself. We learnt from this officer that our captain's conjecture was quite true about the pirate vessel having been chased; and they knew well enough that, once seeing them, Capt. Bute would scour the sea in search of them.

They made for "YR YNYS UNYG" as a last chance, knowing that few but themselves were aware that the great Anaconda was dead, and they trusted that the fear of it would prevent any one from landing on the island.

Their intentions were all frustrated by finding us all perched upon the rock, and it became a matter of policy to get rid of us somehow. They were unwilling to harm us at first, wishing to reap a golden harvest by claiming the rewards for our recovery; but our obstinacy in refusing to come down drove the pirate captain much beyond his own wishes. Had Capt. Bute's boats been half an hour later there would have been but little of our sad remains left. To his eagerness and skill in following the pirate vessel, and anchoring the Turtle side of the island under cover of the night, we, humanly speaking, owed our lives. May God be praised for all his mercies.

Madame and Smart were first to be considered. It was agreed they must both be taken on board the man-of-war for medical advice. I was to go with them, and Felix was to accompany me to attend on Smart. The rest were to be employed in making preparations for our final departure, besides getting La Luna ready for our once more taking possession of her.

But we had never been separated before for more than a few hours, and the leave taking was quite a business. So I promised to return in the evening,

after seeing Madame and Smart comfortable and well cared for. We must talk over our joys as well as sorrows, and, hearing that there were some ladies and servants on board, I the more readily agreed to return. Madame was let down from the rock with great difficulty, utterly unconscious of anything but her own delicious thoughts.

In Turtle harbour, not a mile from our memorable bay, we found the ship, and it was with indescribable emotion that I climbed on to her deck. With the tenderness of women the kind sailors lifted up the invalids, while I was shewn down into the cabin to beseech the good offices of the ladies in it. There were two of them; one reclining on a sofa, hearing a little girl read, whose golden hair hung round her fair face, as the glory surrounds the cherubim; the other and oldest of the two was sketching from the cabin window. The lovely fair face of the recumbent one was raised as I entered.

Why did I start? Have I seen that face before, those calm clear blue eyes, the delicately-formed nose, the beautiful expression? Be calm, my heart, beat not so wildly. "Poor woman, she is ill, what is the matter with her?" said the lady at the window. I knew her too, so well, so perfectly, I wondered she could speak so calmly to me. I forgot my strange appearance, my island dress, my grizzled hair, and brow burnt by the ardent sun.

The younger lady gazed at me, but said nothing. "Pray be seated," said the sweet soft voice of the sketcher, "you look so ill, I will bring you some water." The other lady still gazed, was still silent, but she half rose from her sofa. I could not withdraw my eyes from the well-known face, but I grasped the kind hand that placed the chair for me, while my breath laboured under the convulsive swellings of my heart. "She must be one of the pirate women, and some of her people have been killed," said the elder lady. "Pray, Meta speak to her, and don't gaze at her so fixedly."

I tried to speak, it was impossible. I clung to the one sister, and held out my hand imploringly to the other. She sprang up, and rushed towards me. She pushed my hair from my forehead; her colour came and went like the evening clouds. "Oh, June, June, my sister, my beloved one, it must be you. I cannot be mistaken. I should know that face through every change. Speak to me, speak but one word, call me by my name, if only to ease my heart. My long-lost, my own sister, relieve me, relieve my bursting heart."

Faintly breathing the word "Meta," I remember no more. I sunk upon the ground, but I felt loved arms round me, and the bliss of heaven seemed to take possession of my senses. I awoke to the blessed reality my loving sisters were near me, they soothed me with sweet words, kissed me with sisters' kisses, asked nothing, said nothing but endearing sentences, and suffered my overburdened heart to relieve itself to the full.

The anxieties and cares of the past years, the fear and anguish of the last few days, rolled away like a dark cloud from my troubled brain, while peace, happiness, and rest flooded my heart to overflowing. The transition from utter misery to perfect bliss seemed too much for me at first; I had not felt until then the forlorn and hopeless state to which we had been reduced, and how death in its most dreadful form had nearly severed all I lived for from the earth they were so formed to enjoy and ornament. But, it is idle thus to write, joy does not often kill, so having seen our invalids well cared for, and introduced my lovely little savage boy to his aunts, my beloved sisters accompanied me back to my companions. We found the whole of the pirate gang secured, and going on board *La Luna*, ah! what joy. The surprise, the ecstasy, the happy welcome, the boundless joy, the innumerable questions. It is impossible to describe it.

We found we owed the meeting with our beloved relatives to the following circumstance:—After my brother's leave was up, and his ship's commission expired, instead of spending his time at home, he, with Sir Walter Mayton, chartered a vessel and determined between them to spend all the time his services were not required by his Queen in searching for us. My two sisters had begged to accompany them, one with her husband and children, and my eldest sister to be her companion. The *Esperanza*, their vessel, was something similar to *La Luna*, only larger and carrying six guns. They had been out six months, when, owing to the *Esperanza* requiring some little repairs, the party, consisting of my two sisters, Mr. J., and the children, accepted Capt. Bute's invitation to take a little cruise with him. He was in command of her Majesty's *S. H.*, which had superseded my brother's ship on the piratical coast.

Accidentally coming across the pirates' vessel, Capt. Bute had given chase, and pursued her so sharply, that, under cover of the night, he had got the *H.*

into safe anchorage on the lea side of the island without the pirates' knowledge. The rest of the tale has been told.

CHAPTER XLVI.

And now we were all on board La Luna, Capt. Bute spared us a crew; he remains behind to settle everything about the island, and to go afterwards to the other rendezvous of the pirates, there to rescue the remainder of our crew should they yet survive. Our captain gave him all particulars where to find it.

But we were not to be separated from our newly found relatives. Oh no! they came with us. We collected everything we wished to take from the island; the children's endless parrots, monkeys, shells, and pet things. Schillie took nothing, but her last act was to stoop down, and take a lengthened draught from the lovely stream. Florence, my eldest sister, made sketches of every place interesting to us, and, finally, we bade adieu to "YR YNYS UNYG." Seated on the deck we saw the lovely island fade from our sight, with mixed feelings certainly but no regret. We had none for it, because we could only think of the happiness opening before us. The lost were found, the deeply-mourned restored, the mother given back to her little ones, the fondly-loved children to their sorrowing parents. There was rapture in these thoughts. No wonder that our little home, our little haven of so many conflicting emotions, faded from our sight for ever without a tear from any eye.

We were to shape our course so as to fall in with the Esperanza, which we did in about ten days. During those days fancy alone can paint the innumerable questions asked, the pang and half fear ere they were answered. We lived a life time, it seemed, in those ten days.

We had had no opportunity of restoring our pretty La Luna to her original beauty, therefore we did not wonder (my brother being on board, and we looking so practical) that the Esperanza bore down upon us in a menacing and warlike manner.

We submissively struck our colours, and ere long were boarded by my brother and Sir Walter Mayton. At the request of my sisters we all remained below, that they might have a little amusement. But it was hardly possible for us to wait. However, my brother quickly put an end to the suspense himself; for, in his quick decisive manner, down he came into the cabin, requesting to see the ship's papers. And, what papers did he see? The whole party in the cabin! He gave but one look, he comprehended it all, and, ere I thought it could be him, he had wrapt me in his arms; he wept with joy and thankfulness, and he could not cease to gaze at us all with unutterable emotions of pleasure. We forgot Sir Walter Mayton until we heard his well-known firm tread stamping above, as if impatient at the Captain's delay. We determined to have a little amusement with him, and yet not keep him long in suspense. We sent the two boys up, and watched the effect. He started, and looked keenly at them, he threw his cigar away, and then we heard his loud cheery voice say, "Whose boys are you?" They said nothing, but each took hold of a kind hand, and smiled up in his face.

"Boys, I bid you tell me, who you are," and his voice husky, while we could see he trembled.

"It is us uncle, dear uncle, here we are all safe," and throwing their arms round his neck, they half smothered him with kisses, Lilly joining her brothers.

"But your Mother, my children, are you all safe? have I none to answer for?" "All safe, quite safe," said I, appearing immediately.

"Ready to thank you for all you have done for us, the weary years we have been away. For your kind thoughts, your indefatigable exertions, we are here to thank you, and prove our gratitude by acts as well as thanks." "Thank God, Thank God," he said. "This hour repays me for all my care."

And now what happiness, nothing to mar it, but a few gales of wind, which only blew us nearer to the homes our hearts longed for. Madame was nearly well, Smart only limped a little, and was in high spirits at hearing that not only was Mrs. Smart alive and well, but that Jem had become a young gamekeeper, and they had wanted for nothing during his absence.

"So you were right Master Felix, about the washing, she has done well at that," said Smart, "and a mighty good washer she be, sending me out with shirts as white as any Lord's."

We sailed in company, and it was hard to say which ship contained the merriest party, La Luna or the Esperanza.

We touched at St. Helena, and there picked up another brother to our great delight and pleasure.

The ships were gazetted there as the Esperanza and her consort, that the news of it getting to England before we did might prepare the beloved family in some degree for what was in store.

THE LAST CHAPTER.

Once more we will return to that pretty drawing-room, and visit the kind sisters, the grey-headed father, the loving mother.

Her sweet calm face had lost its painful expression; years have gone by; time has come with its healing wings; she is nearer the hour when a meeting with the lost ones may be promised her in heaven. One sister is married and gone. The dark-haired sister is as usual employed in making brilliant flowers grow beneath her skilful fingers, like the magic work of the fairies. The pretty face of the other beams with content and sweetness. The door opens, and the grey-headed Father appears with the newspapers.

"My dear," says he, "what can this mean? Here is the *Esperanza* mentioned on her way home to England with her consort."

The Mother.—"Oh no, that must be a mistake. She has no consort; besides we do not expect our *Esperanza* home for six months at least."

The Father.—"But you see it is in the ships' news. 'The brig *Esperanza*, Capt. C., touched at St. Helena with her consort, and brings home Capt. C. of the Royal Engineers.'"

The Mother.—"There really seems no mistake indeed, especially Bertrand's having joined his brother. I suppose Richard must have captured some pirate or slaver's vessel. You know he took out a license to do so."

The Father.—"Very likely; but still I think we should have seen some account of the exploit in the papers if he had done so."

Emily.—"Especially the *Esperanza* being a private vessel. I really think, Mama, it must be a mistake."

The door opens, and the best and kindest aunt in the world appears, who, having no children of her own, opens her large heart, and takes in those of

her only sister's.

The Aunt.—"Don't be surprised to see me, but my husband has seen in to-day's paper that the Esperanza is coming home. I thought, sister, they were to have been absent a year?"

The Mother.—"So I expected, and we are quite puzzled about it, having seen the news as well as yourself. I am almost inclined to agree with Emily that it is a mistake."

The dear Aunt.—"Then I am miserably disappointed. When I heard it I was in the greatest hope you would have some news to tell me, so I ordered Osman and the brougham, and came here so fast that I am quite in fear for the dear fellow. Cecy, pray let me ask you for a little bread to give him, and do come down and look at him, he is in such beauty that Robert is quite proud of him."

So they all went down to look at the beloved horse, and Robert the groom heard him praised to his heart's content.

The dear Aunt.—"Well, now then, sister, I will say farewell, but we will do what you so kindly wish us, and come to-morrow for the whole week; by this means we shall be on the spot to hear the earliest news if you get any, for I must own I cannot bear suspense, and my Florence being in the Esperanza doubles my anxieties."

The Mother.—"We shall be charmed to see you, dear sister, so, until then, farewell."

On the morrow, the kind aunt and uncle were not the only visitors. Little Winny's father and mother, uncle Parry, the "next heir," all came pouring in, as well as innumerable letters from kind and anxious friends; but still no news by the post.

They had all seen the report of the Esperanza, and all had flocked to B——, as head quarters, to learn what had brought her home so much sooner than was expected. However, they were invited to remain the week out at that ever open most hospitable mansion.

In the middle of the week came Gatty's beloved parents. Zoë's father and mother lived so near that they could have daily intercourse; so daily everybody met, daily everybody talked, and daily everybody agreed that it was all a mistake, and that this Esperanza was not their Esperanza.

The summer is coming on rapidly. It is the 2nd of June, the golden laburnums hang their rich pendant clusters over the fragrant lilacs, all nature seemed rejoicing, and every tree had its living chorus, for no noisy gun or treacherous snare was ever heard or seen in that pretty garden.

"I don't mean to stay in the house this lovely evening," said Gatty's father. "Come Emily, come Julie, let us sit out on the lawn, and smell the fresh wholesome scent of the earth, and hear this delightful evening hymn of the birds. But do you expect company? Here is a carriage, and surely another behind it. No! it stops. But do my eyes deceive me? Who is in this first carriage? The dear crew of the Esperanza! Welcome, welcome. Bertrand too. My dear girls how well you look. Ah, Sir Walter, welcome, welcome home."

They are clasped in the arms of everybody, and welcomed home, as those who go to B—— are generally welcomed. The new brother also, after six years' absence in New Zealand. Everybody seems overwhelmed with delight and pleasure. Whatever curiosity, whatever wonder, whatever fear might have run through the heart of each at seeing the beloved crew of the Esperanza so much sooner than was expected, all was now swallowed up in the joy of seeing them.

The old and valued servants crowded to meet them, and congratulate them on their safe return. "My goodness me," said Anne, the housekeeper, after she had made her courtesies and said her say, "if the great gates are not open and the beggars coming in. Oh, Thomas, (turning to the dear aunt's servant) whatever must we do, what a queer set. Be off, good people. I must see for some men to turn them out. I don't think really that they can be anything respectable. None of our people would peep and look in like that. I cannot make them out at all, Thomas. They have a look about them anyways but respectable."

Thomas.—"To be sure, Anne, they look Furrineers, and they never is so neat and trim as our people."

Anne.—"Furrineers, then, Thomas, help me to turn them out, we wants nothing but English here. Be off, good people, be off, we harbours no vermin here. Eh, but they're a strange set."

My brother ran to her. "Don't disturb those people, Anne, they are very good people," said he.

Anne.—"But so unmannerly, Mr. Bertrand, coming in at such a particklar time."

Mr. Bertrand.—"Never mind, Anne, they are friends of mine."

Anne.—"Friends of yours, oh, indeed, Sir; well we did not know that, Thomas, did we? and how could we guess, so queer as they look. Surely now Mr. Bernard, you have never been and gone and brought home some New Zealand savages?"

Mr. Bertrand.—"Yes, Anne, I have, and that tall woman in the hat is to be my wife."

Anne.—"Oh my goodness me, Mr. Bertrand, none of your jokes to me if you please, Sir. I don't believe a word you say, Sir, and the more I look at them people the more I am sure they are no friends of yours, Sir. Such outlandish folk, in them big hats and those long bed-gownish things, they are not respectable. I must——"

Mr. Bertrand.—"Hush, hush, Anne, they are dear friends of mine; wait, wait just a few minutes; hearken now to what my brother says to your master."

With trembling voice the dear brother was making the aged Father understand; Meta threw herself sobbing with delight into the arms of the long-mourning Mother, trying to tell her of the joy that yet remained to be told; Florence, with sweet touching voice, was preparing the dear enthusiastic aunt. Everybody was beginning to feel and know that there was something still to tell, some event yet to occur, something much beyond what they had yet felt or experienced. But who could look in the agitated faces of the travellers and not see that it was joy which so overcame them? Who could see the radiant smiles shining through the irrepressible tears and not feel a thrill of happiness shoot through them?

And the poor beggars at the great gate, why were they in tears? why so agitated? Oh, make haste, they cannot wait much longer, their impatience is boundless. Think how many years they have been deprived of the sight of those sweet faces, the hearing those dear voices, the feeling those soft kisses. Gatty, Gatty, startle not your Father so, restrain your impatience; he wonders now. Who calls, that wild and passionate "Papa, Papa." Just a few short moments to wait. See, see, my Mother's eyes; she must know now, she is prepared. Almost before the signal is given, before the arms are open, Zoë rushes to her Mother. Winny, Schillie, Gatty (the first of all, with a bound like an antelope) all fly to their own people, and we three, Sybil, Serena, and I, into whose arms we fell I know not; I remember nothing, I can tell nothing but that I heard my grey-headed Father, in a low, distinct, and solemn manner, say—

"Now, Lord, lettest Thou Thy servant depart this life in peace."

FINIS.

Transcriber's Endnotes

The original publication contained many typographical errors. Minor misprints have been corrected without note, however the following amendments deserve further note:

Chapter Titles

The original sequence skipped the numbers 10, 26, 31, 37, 38 whilst using 39 twice. With no discrepancy in the page numbers, the chapters have been renumbered to avoid confusion.

Hargrave/Havord

The character initially introduced as Hargrave is referred to as Havord from

Chapter XXIX to part-way through Chapter XXXVI. In light of the poor typography throughout the book, all instances of Havord have been changed to Hargrave.

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